The Hour of the Wolf

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A Novel

A work of fiction. The historical events are real; the people in this book are not.

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PART ONE

THE INSTRUMENT

Paris, November 1943 – February 1944

Chapter one

The Hour Between

❦

The sentry walked the gravel every eleven minutes. She had timed him in October and again in November, and he had not changed, and that was the trouble with the Germans: they did not change. Eleven minutes, the long way round the garden, past the statue of the stag with its nose broken off in some earlier, better argument, and then a pause at the gate while he worked his feet in his boots to keep them warm.

She could hear the whole house from this bed. The kitchen pipe that ticked. The clock in the hall, which was two minutes fast and which the Colonel, who had set the other five clocks in the building to the second, had left alone, because it had belonged to the previous owner of the house and he considered it a French matter.

The man beside her slept on his back with his hands open, the way a man sleeps who has never had to be afraid in a bedroom. Fifty-four years old, hard in the shoulders and hard in the hands, grey at the temples and cut close at the neck. Saddle soap and cold tobacco and, very faintly, under both, lavender water, which was the one thing in this house he did not know he smelled of.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay still beside him in the dark of a requisitioned house on the avenue Henri-Martin

and did what she had done every night for five months: she took the house in and held it.

She had never slept in this bed. That was the first rule and the last, and she had learned it in another city and paid for it in a colder currency. At three she would get up and use the water closet so that the house heard her do it; the maid would hear her, and the maid would mention it in the morning in the way servants mention things. She would come back along the corridor with her socks in her hand. She would go into the study at the end of the passage, where he worked when he could not sleep, and which was the only room in the house with a shutter that did not close all the way. And she would count to ninety and go back to bed, and at half past five she would stand up, dress in the dark, walk down the back stairs — skipping the third step from the bottom, which had told on her in July and never would again — and out into the morning with Rutz holding the gate and the whole of Paris, grey and wet and entirely occupied, on the other side of it.

Between now and then there was the rest of the night and the man in it. She lay with her forearm against his ribs because he liked that, and she kept her breathing slow because he was a light sleeper and because she had once spent a fortnight learning to breathe like a woman in love, and now it cost her nothing at all.

He woke at twenty past two the way he always woke when he wanted her, without a word and without any interval between sleep and appetite. His hand came over her hip and pulled her onto her back, and his weight came with it,

and for a while the room was only the two of them and the ticking pipe and the sentry's boots going round the garden.

She had learned him the way she had once learned irregular French verbs: by repetition, without affection, until it could be done in the dark. He was not a brutal man in the way of the men in the illustrated papers. He was worse in a smaller way: he was a man who had decided what belonged to him, and who did not consider, at any point in the twenty minutes that followed, what the thing he owned might want. His hands were the ugliest part of him, cracked across the knuckles from a boyhood spent with horses he no longer had. He used them on her the way a man uses a good tool, unhurried, thoroughly, with satisfaction at the end and none at all in the middle.

She made the sounds he had taught her to make and meant about a third of them, and even those she did not mean in the way he believed. There was a particular pleasure in being wanted by a man like this — she had stopped lying to herself about it in the second month, because a lie you tell inside your own skull is the only kind that costs. She liked his weight after the war's thin men. She liked being the one thing in a Prussian's day that he could not organise. She liked the exact moment when his breath changed and the German in him went out and left only the animal, which was the moment she could have put a knife in his throat and which she had never once, in five months, been able to fully enjoy for what it was.

When it was finished he lay on her for a moment and then rolled away and put his forearm over his eyes, which was the closest he came to tenderness.

"Sleep," he said.

"Yes," she said.

She stayed on her back and looked at the ceiling. The cornicing had been done by someone in 1890 who cared about it: plaster laurel, a hundred-odd leaves, the last four of them botched where the man's hand had tired. She counted them the way other people counted sheep. She had got to ninety-one when his breathing went long and slow and the house, which had been holding its breath, let it out.

The clock in the hall struck the half hour, two minutes fast, and she put her feet on the floor.

❦

The corridor was cold. Paris in November 1943 was cold everywhere except in German rooms, and the Germans warmed themselves with coal that came from France and would have gone to French houses in another century, and the fact of it had stopped shocking her in the summer and had not stopped being true.

She went to the bathroom first and ran the tap and washed her hands and looked at herself in the glass above the basin. Twenty-four years old. Dark blonde hair flattened on one side from the pillow. Grey eyes, her mother's, with nothing at all behind them, which was not true and did not matter. She had a good face for the work. It was the sort of face that men described as soft and women described as expensive, and both of them were wrong in the useful direction.

Then she went along the passage to the study, walking on the balls of her feet, not because she needed to but because the practice was the point.

The study was the Colonel's, but it had been somebody else's first. You could still see it: the bookshelves with the empty spaces where the books that mattered had been taken away in a hurry, the prints of horses on the wall, one of which hung crooked and had hung crooked since June because he did not notice pictures. His desk was oak and enormous and French, and on it, squared to the edges, were his blotter, his pen tray, his reading spectacles, and the file he was working on, which tonight was a brown folder with a string tie that he had tied in a particular knot because the man who tied it had tied it for the Führer and he did not care to undo another man's knot in front of a Frenchman's desk.

She had not touched the folder. She never touched the folder. The folder was the reason that other women in other houses got shot.

What she touched was the blotter.

It was a Frenchman's blotter, made of green leather, the size of a newspaper when opened out. A tidy man uses a sheet of blotting paper until it is soaked and then throws it away. The Colonel was not a tidy man. He was an orderly one, which is a different disease: he used each sheet for exactly one week, wrote the date in the corner on the Monday, and then, instead of throwing it away, laid it face down in the drawer of the table beside the desk, where a stack of a hundred and something such sheets now lived in chronolo-

gical order, going back to a Parisian winter that had been somebody else's.

The present sheet lay in the blotter. She stood beside the desk with her hands behind her back, which was the posture she had settled on after some thought, because if the door opened she would be a woman looking out of a window with her hands behind her back, and because a woman with her hands behind her back is the least suspicious object in Europe.

The window was black. The shutter did not close. And in the gap between shutter and frame there was a slice of avenue, and in the avenue there was a lamp, and by the light of that lamp, four feet away, the sheet of blotting paper was legible the way a mirror is legible.

She read it from right to left. She had been taught to do this in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement, with a girl from Lille who thought she was teaching a Belgian, and she had never once failed at it since, though it was slow and it made one's head ache behind the eyes.

Of the coastal sector works, the schedule has been reported to the Commandant. The batteries at Saint-Nazaire and La Rochelle will be inspected on the seventeenth and eighteenth by the officer of the Inspectorate, with a delegation from the Todt organisation. Requests for labour are to be submitted directly to the Feldkommandantur, not to the Kreiskommandantur, in the case of the two westernmost. The matter of the requisitioned horses at Nantes remains open.

And under it, a hand she knew better than her own: a marginal comment, in pencil, that read: Kessler again about the horses. Send him the second paragraph only.

She read the whole sheet twice, twice right to left, and then once normally to be certain of the sentence about the labour requests, because the sentence about the labour requests was the one her network would want and because it contained a number of men, which was the kind of fact that got passed to London inside another fact, and because somewhere in London at the end of a chain of such facts there were men with maps who would use it.

Ninety seconds. She gave herself ninety seconds and then she went back the way she had come, and in the corridor she heard something that stopped her heart in the way a hand stops a bell: the maid's door opening two floors below, and a voice, and footsteps going down towards the kitchen.

She stood in the dark and did not breathe and counted the plaster laurels backwards from ninety-one, and when she reached one she went into the bedroom and got into the bed as if she had never left it.

He was awake.

"You were a long time," he said, in the dark.

"The water was cold."

"It is always cold."

"Yes," she said. "And I always hope it will not be."

He did not laugh, but he moved his hand onto her wrist, which was the closest he came to laughing. The hand was heavy and dry and lay over the small bones the way a lid lies

on a pot. She had learned to keep her own hand relaxed under it, which had taken three weeks to master, and which now she could do in her sleep.

For a while there was only the sentry, and the pipe, and the clock in the hall deciding, two minutes early, that the hour could go and hang itself.

"I had a letter from my brother," the Colonel said.

She said nothing. She had learned that too. When they talk in the dark, a woman who says nothing gets more than a woman who asks, because the asking is the same as the leaving, and a man in the dark wants to keep talking to somebody who is not going anywhere.

"Kranzow is to be sold," he said. "The Pomeranian thing. My grandfather bought the land in fifty-nine, and my father planted the avenue, and the avenue is two hundred metres of linden and it will go into the ground with the man who buys the timber. My brother writes to me about the timber. He is fifty-nine years old and he writes to me about the timber."

She turned her head on the pillow towards him. The light from the street lamp came through the shutter in four bars, and in that light she could see the top of his forearm and the line where the pillow had pressed into his face and, beyond him, the photograph on the chest of drawers with its back turned towards the bed, which was the only picture in the house he kept facing away.

"Klaus would have gone back," he said. "He wanted the horses. He was a boy who liked things that were alive. His mother used to say it would be the ruin of him." A pause. "She was right about the things she was wrong about."

She knew better than to say anything about Klaus. She had said something about Klaus in September, one sentence, in the right voice, and he had got out of the bed and stood at the window for eleven minutes without speaking, and she had watched the shape of his back and understood that she was being shown something, and that being shown it was a test he was not aware of setting.

So she lay still, and after a while he did what he always did when he had come close to it: he turned away from his son and opened a file.

"You know they are stealing from us," he said.

"Who is?"

"Everyone. In this country, everyone. The French steal the coal and the clerks steal the coal the French leave behind. There is a whole department of my office that does nothing but count what is gone." He was awake now in the particular way of a man who has found something he can be busy about. "Do you know what I have spent the winter doing, Marion?"

"Seeing that the officers are properly shaved," she said.

"Ah. That is the Second Bureau." He moved onto his back and put his other hand behind his head, and the bed creaked in the place where it always creaked. "I am hunting one person."

Her body did nothing. It had been trained to do nothing, in another flat, with a girl from Lille, and it did nothing now with a completeness that would have frightened her if she had had any room in her for fear.

"A leak," he said.

"A leak of what?"

"Documents. Orders. Lists. Everything that is worth stealing and a great deal that is not." He said it with a kind of tired professional relish. "Two years, more or less. Some papers from the Kommandantur in the spring of forty-two, which we put down to a French clerk who hanged himself in Fresnes. Then the coastal material last winter. Then in the summer, three things in six weeks, which is what made them take it seriously. We have brought in the Sicherheitspolizei, which means we have brought in a number of people who cannot read a military appreciation but who can read a railway timetable, and who have been very busy arresting Frenchmen who were selling butter."

"And you are the one who catches the thief."

"I am the one who is asked, in Berlin, at intervals, whether the thief has been caught." He put his hand back on her wrist, and this time it was not a lid on a pot; it was a consideration. "It is not a Frenchman. That is what makes it interesting. A Frenchman sells what he can to whom he can and then he buys a restaurant. This one is different. This one is not selling. This one is giving, and to whom is a question with an unpleasant answer, because there is only one organisation in the west that is not selling anything, and it pays in other currencies."

She said, in the voice she had spent two years perfecting — warm, slow, a little foolish, with a shrug in it — "So it is a Communist."

"That is what the Sicherheitspolizei says. It is always what they say. It saves them a great deal of thinking."

"And what do you say?"

"That it is somebody who is very close to a great deal of paper." He said it in the way he said everything, as though the sentence had been typed. "And that if a woman came into my office and read my desk, I should not know. Which is why the desk is locked."

He waited, and she understood that she was being given an opportunity to laugh, so she laughed, and he took his hand off her wrist and put it on her hip, and the conversation was over.

Then he said, already half asleep, "The SD has given it a name. Their files are written by Romantics. They call it Fräulein."

"Fräulein?"

"It is a woman, according to a partial intercept, or a man who telephones like a woman, which is a joke the Sicherheitspolizei is not capable of making." He yawned, enormous and domestic. "Fräulein. Two years of stolen orders and a Frenchman's suicide at Fresnes and eleven arrests, and somebody in a cellar on the avenue Foch sat up one night and put Fräulein on the cover of the file. When we catch the person, I shall make a point of telling him. It is the kind of thing they write about afterwards."

She lay in the dark with her hands flat on the sheet beside her, in the posture she had learned from a girl from Lille, and she thought about the name.

Fräulein.

She thought about it the way you think about a coat you have been wearing in a photograph you did not know existed: it fits, it is hers, and there is nothing in the world to

be done about it now except to go on wearing it and to make sure the photograph is never developed.

"What do you think?" he said.

"About what?"

"About the thief. Come. You have an opinion about everything. You have spent five months hiding your opinions from me in the way of a woman who has a great many of them."

She shifted onto her side to face him. In the four bars of street light he was looking at the ceiling, magnificent and ruined, a man who had been beautiful at twenty-five and had kept the bones.

"I think," she said, "that a woman would do it better."

"You think a woman would do better than a French Communist clerk?"

"A woman would do it much better." She put one finger on his chest, in the fine dusting of hair going grey, exactly where she knew he liked it. "You have always told me that we have no head for the long game. That we cannot keep accounts. That we weep at concerts."

"I have never said that at a concert."

"You said it at the Opéra."

"I would have been right at the Opéra." He was smiling in the dark. She could hear it in his voice, which had gone down the half-tone it went down before he gave her something she did not want: a name, a compliment, a piece of his history. "Very well. You would have done better than the clerk. What would you have done?"

"I would have stolen nothing."

"Nothing?"

"Nothing at all. I would have listened. I would have lain in a bed like this one for two years and listened to a man talking about his brother's timber, and then I would have gone home at Christmas and said it all out loud to somebody in a kitchen, and no one would ever have found a single sheet of paper, and the Sicherheitspolizei would still be arresting the men who sell butter."

There was a silence of about three seconds, and in the middle of it she heard her own blood go past her ears, because the sentence had come out of her mouth whole and it was the nearest thing to the truth she had said in this house.

And then he laughed. It was a real laugh, a German laugh with the consonants falling off the end of it, and he pulled her over onto him with both hands and looked at her in the light from the shutter with an expression she had seen on him exactly twice before, and which she never once saw again.

"You are a treasure," he said. "You are my little lark."

She lay on his chest and let him stroke her hair and felt, in the middle of the satisfaction and the disgust that lived together in her chest the way they had since June, the entirely professional relief of a woman who has just been given a name she did not ask for and cannot refuse.

In the corridor, the hall clock said half past three.

"I must go," she said.

"It is the middle of the night."

"The car comes at half past six, and I have to be dressed, and your man looks at me."

"Rutz looks at nothing."

"Rutz writes it all down in a book, my dear."

He grunted, which was his way of agreeing with something he did not intend to do anything about, and she got out of the bed, and dressed in the dark, and found her gloves, and stood for a moment at the window with the four bars of street light on her hands.

By six she was on the pavement of the avenue Henri-Martin with her collar up, walking east towards the river, and the sky over Paris was the colour of a man who has been drinking all night. Rutz had held the gate for her and said Fräulein Marion — the name the house knew her by, the only name the Colonel had ever had for her — in his careful way, and she had said good morning, Emil, which he liked, because she had one time asked him the name of his village and remembered it, and because the Germans are the easiest people in the world to be cruel to by being kind.

She walked twenty-five minutes to the rue Saint-Honoré. The streets were filling: the men on bicycles with the wooden tyres, the women in their queues outside the shops, the old man who had sold horse-meat from the same cart since before the war and had graduated in the course of the war to something worse. Two German soldiers came out of a bakery eating something hot and one of them looked at her and then away, and she felt, as she always did at that hour, exactly half alive: the night done, the delivery not yet made, and every fact she was carrying in her head sitting in the middle of her skull like a stone in a shoe.

The Polish Mission on the rue Saint-Honoré had a shabby door between a shop that sold notions and a shop that had sold books and now sold nothing. Inside, in the

grey air of six forty in the morning, there were six or seven people at the early mass: three women in black, a man with one leg, a boy in a coat that had belonged to a bigger boy. She knelt in the third pew on the left, and the cold came up out of the stone into her knees, and she put her hands on the rail and waited.

The chaplain came along the side aisle at a quarter to seven, in a soutane with a scorch mark at the hem, and knelt down beside her as though he had come in for the same reason as everybody else. He was sixty and had the small, tidy hands of a man who had once taught history in Poznań. He did not look at her and she did not look at him, and they prayed side by side for three minutes, and then he said, in Latin, the words of the psalm.

She answered him in Polish, in a voice no louder than a breath, and she gave him everything in order, as it had been given to her: the sector of the works, the two batteries, the seventeenth and the eighteenth, the inspector from the Inspectorate and the delegation of the Todt organisation, the labour requests that were to go to the Feldkommandantur and not the Kreiskommando, the two westernmost. She gave it to him as a list, without verbs, the way she had been taught, because verbs are what a man under torture remembers.

He took it in without moving, and at the end of it he said one sentence.

"You are to have nothing to do with the Lubianka."

"What?"

"The Polish desk at the Lutetia has taken on a man from Warsaw." A silence, and then the priest's voice, dry as a ledger: "He is working the emigrants' lists. He is new, and he is good, and nobody in this city knows what he is. You have never met him. Avoid him."

"Who told you this?"

"The man who tells me things."

"And if I do meet him?"

"Then you have never met him," the priest said, and got up, and went away to the sacristy with his hands folded and his soutane dragging on the flags, and Krystyna stayed kneeling in the cold with her palms flat on the rail, thinking about a name on a file in a cellar on the avenue Foch, and a boy from Warsaw in the Hôtel Lutetia, and the fact that she had to be back in a bed on the avenue Henri-Martin at nine o'clock that evening, in a nightgown, in a room that smelled of saddle soap and cold tobacco, because the man she was going to lie down beside had just told her, with his hand on her hip, exactly what he was looking for.

Outside, it had begun to rain.

❦

She had a room of her own in the ninth arrondissement, three flights up, let to a widow who believed her lodger was a Viennese widow who did something in millinery and who was away a great deal. Two rooms, a window on a courtyard, a stove that smoked, and a bath that had to be filled from a copper on the ring because the geyser had given up in the second winter of the occupation and nobody would come to mend it.

She filled it to the depth of four inches and got in, in water hot enough to raise the colour on her thighs, and began the second half of the night's work, which was the part nobody had trained her for, because it could not be trained.

She washed, methodically, in the order that had become a rite: hands, face, arms to the elbow, the whole of her chest, and then, with more soap, the parts of her that had belonged to somebody else since twenty past two that morning. She did not wash him off because he disgusted her. She had examined that, in the first month, honestly, in the way you examine a wound in order to know what to tell the doctor, and she had found no disgust in it at all, or very little, or not enough to matter, and the smallness of the quantity had frightened her more than a larger one would have done.

She washed him off because she had to be at a fitting in the rue de Miromesnil at eleven, and because the woman who would be at that fitting had to have skin that smelled of nothing in particular.

Afterwards she sat on the edge of the bath and pared her nails with a small pair of scissors and thought about the sheet of blotting paper. She held the whole of it in her head, right to left, the way it had gone in: the coastal sector works, the two batteries, the inspectorate, the Todt delegation, the labour requests, the horses of Nantes and the second paragraph only. She turned it over twice more and put it away in the part of her memory she had spent two years building, which had rooms in it, and in which the paper now lived in the left-hand drawer of a desk in a house on the avenue Kléber, next to a station timetable from the spring of 1942

and a photograph of a boy in a cavalry cadet's uniform, which was the only photograph she had ever memorised by mistake.

Then she took the pearls out of the drawer of the night table and put them round her neck, and looked at herself in the mirror of the wardrobe door.

He had given them to her in July, in a box lined with grey velvet, and he had told her the price, and the name of the jeweller on the rue de la Paix, and how the man had had them from a family that was no longer permitted to live in the eighth arrondissement. A man who gives a woman pearls on the occupation's money and tells her what they cost is not giving her jewellery. He is giving her a receipt, and he wants her to have it, because a thing with a price on it can be counted, and the Colonel's one great fear in the world, which sat behind everything he did, was of a thing he could not count.

She had worn them for four months. They were warm within five minutes and they made her neck look longer than it was, and when she wore them she was treated, by waiters and shopkeepers and German wives and once, memorably, by the wife of a general at the Ritz, as the possession she was pretending to be: an expensive object, kept indoors, of no opinions.

She looked at the pearls and then at her own face above them, and it happened again; it had been happening more often; it was the only thing about the work that had frightened her since the first month, when she had stopped being frightened of the rest.

She smiled.

It was a small, private, entirely genuine smile, of the kind she had met on the face of a man in a telephone exchange in Bordeaux in 1941 when he had been given exactly what he wanted, and it had been on her face before she knew it was there.

Not for the pearls. For the names. She had been in that house for half a year with a file on a shelf in a cellar on the avenue Foch that was hunting her and did not know her name, and she had stood in a study at three in the morning with her hands behind her back and read the Reich's business off a piece of blotting paper by the light of a street lamp, and the whole business — the cold corridor, the pipe that ticked, the hands with the cracked knuckles, the smell of lavender water — the whole business was, and she had promised herself in Warsaw that she would never use the word again but it came anyway, rising up through the soap and the water and the pearls like something in a thaw, enjoyable.

She put both hands flat on the washstand and made herself look at the face in the glass for a full minute, and it looked back at her: twenty-four years old, grey eyes, her mother's, a small white scar on the left wrist from a stirrup in a summer that was four years dead, and a mouth that was very good at saying yes.

Then she got dressed, and pinned her hair, and put on the coat she had worn to the fitting last week, and went out into the rain at eight o'clock in the morning to be fitted for a dress to wear at a German Christmas party, and on the stairs she took the pearls in her left hand, once, and squeezed them, and let them go.

CHAPTER TWO

Salt and Silk

❦

Boin, Robes et Manteaux had three windows on the rue de Miromesnil and a bell over the door that rang in the key of F, and had rung in the key of F since 1926, when Madame Odile had bought the shop with the dowry of a marriage that had lasted four years and a settlement that had lasted longer.

"A little to the left," Odile said. "You are not a door. Stand like a woman."

"I am standing like a woman."

"You are standing like a soldier. There is a difference, and it is the whole difference, and it costs you nothing." Odile had a mouth full of pins, which did not affect her diction, a trick she had learned in a workshop at fourteen and had never explained to anybody. "Left. Now breathe in and hold it, and do not tell me you cannot breathe, I have seen you breathe at the Ritz with that German's hand on your back, and that requires more breath than a fitting."

There was one thing on her that no German had ever looked at, and it hung on a cord of black silk inside her dress and had hung there since the eighteenth of September 1939: a silver signet with a flat face, and on the face the head of a greyhound above three willow leaves, which is the crest of the Stankiewicz family of Mazovia. It had been her father's. He had given it to her in the hall of the flat in Warsaw on

the morning the German removals men carried the sofa out through the door and asked the family, in the manner of men doing a job, whether the piano was to go in the first lorry or the second.

Odile saw the cord at her throat on the day of the fourth fitting of that winter, when the dress came off her shoulders, and asked what it was, and Krystyna said, "My mother's."

Odile looked at it for about four seconds and then said, in the voice she used for dress alterations, which never changed: "If they find it on you, they will have your family name inside an hour, and if they have your name they will have the flat in Warsaw, and if they have the flat they will have your father and your sister. A woman in this trade who carries her own name round her neck in an occupied city is a woman who has decided to be found." And then she pinned the shoulder and said nothing else about it for the rest of the war.

The ring stayed where it was. It stayed through the fifth fitting and the sixth; through January and the arrests and the bicycle in the passage on the rue de Saint-Honoré; through a bedroom in the avenue Henri-Martin and a dance in the ballroom of the Majestic and eleven hundred questions in the office of an Oberst who would have given a year of his pay for the name of the family that crest belonged to; and the reason it stayed was not sentiment, and it was not defiance, and it was the reason that had been given to her in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement in the autumn of 1942 in a sentence she had written down in her head and had never once been able to obey: you will find

that there is one thing of your own that you will not be able to leave behind, and I am telling you now, before you find it, that it will kill you.

The atelier was cold, because coal went to the Germans and to the concierge and to the shop on the corner that had a cousin in the prefecture, and so the room was warmed by an iron stove that Odile fed with the wood of dismantled hat stands and, in the last resort, with an enormous and unsellable mahogany dresser that had been standing in the courtyard since August. The smell of the place was chalk and sizing and scorched silk and the ghost of a hundred perfumes that had been sent to be copied: Guerlain, Chanel, Lelong, L'Heure Bleue by the gallon, worn by women who came in fur in the morning and stood on the same four boards as German officers' mistresses and Jewish dressmakers and the wives of men who were in prison at Fresnes, all of them equal in the only way this particular room recognised, which was that Odile made them all stand still.

Krystyna stood still in the grey dress that was being made for the Christmas supper at the Majestic. It was the fourth dress of the winter and it would cost more than the flat on the rue Saint-Honoré in which she had first been taught to hold a pen without pressure. Odile had a theory about the dress — she always had a theory — and the theory was that a mistress who was seen in the same dress twice was a mistress with a limited budget, and a mistress with a limited budget was a mistress who might be paid for, and a mistress who might be paid for was a woman who would be asked, eventually, what she had done before the war in Vienna.

"Pin the left," Krystyna said. "The left is hanging."

"The left is perfect. You have a shoulder like a farm girl on that side. It comes from carrying things." Odile took the pins out of her mouth and looked up at her, and there it was: the small, level look that the woman used twice an hour on everyone and which was the reason the network had put an atelier at the centre of its Paris survival. "How is your mother?"

"Dead."

"I know she is dead," Odile said. "I am asking whether she is dead this week."

"This week she is dead."

"Good. Then stand still."

Two women in the back room, whose voices came through the curtain as rustling and French, were working on the evening bodice. The curtain was blue cotton and had been bought in 1937 and bleached by the sun on one side, and behind it, in a space of perhaps eight feet by ten, Madame Odile Boin kept, in a drawer under a stack of the fashion magazines of a better year, the tools of a trade she had learned at fifty from a Pole who came in one day pretending to be a client looking for mourning clothes for a cousin and who had stayed eleven hours and left at two in the morning with a rouble watch and a promise.

There was a press. There was a tin of paper of four different weights, which Odile could distinguish by touch the way another woman can distinguish children. There was a physician's stamp of the department of the Seine, four rubber stamps of the German military administration in various

states of wear, a bottle of ink that was not the ink sold in the shops, and an iron, because sometimes a document needs a crease and creases do not lie.

None of it was in the shop when she had visitors, which meant that none of it was there for about half the hours of the day.

"You are to have a new card," Odile said, in the voice she used for dress alterations, which never changed. "The one you have is August's. There is a woman at the prefecture who has started to write letters, and letters keep."

"Which woman?"

"The one whose machine you are wearing. Do not concern yourself." Odile marked a seam with chalk. "Also I have a fourth stamp. The one with the mark of the Ortskommandantur of the fifteenth of June. It is very good. It is from a German's desk. It cost a great deal of money and no one's life, which is the best one can say for it."

"Whose life did the others cost?"

"Ah," said Odile, and was silent for the length of one pin.

The bell in F rang at half past ten, and into the atelier with a draught of the street came a man in a dark green overcoat with a stick, fifty-odd, grey at the moustache, with spectacles repaired at the bridge with black thread, and a folded newspaper under the arm, which he put on the cutting table as though the table belonged to him, which in a sense it did, because he had found it.

"Madame," he said to Odile.

"Monsieur," Odile said. "You are early. You are never early."

"I am becoming old, and one of the symptoms is that one is early." Wiktor Janowski took off his hat and his spectacles and wiped them on his handkerchief with the unvarying three passes, and looked at Krystyna the way a man looks at a horse he has bought and not yet paid for. "My dear colleague. You are looking well."

"I am looking well," she said. "It is the work."

"Come," he said, and went behind the blue curtain, and she followed him, because the rules said that the fitting was for Odile and the conversation was for the curtain, and the rules were not suggestions.

There was one chair. He sat in it and hung the stick on the back and she stood, because she was in a dress that was pinned, and because he never, in three years, offered a woman his chair.

"Report," he said.

She reported. She gave him the sheet of blotting paper, right to left and left to right, with the dates and the sector numbers and the sentence about the labour requisitions, and she gave him the two facts about the household that she judged to be facts of trade rather than facts of gossip: that the Colonel had, since October, kept a locked drawer in the desk as well as the safe, and that his orderly's day book had a page for the nights she was called to the house late, which meant that somebody outside the house had asked for such a page to be kept.

Wiktor took it all in without a single question and then asked four questions, all of which were about numbers, and wrote nothing down, and at the end of it said: "The two westernmost."

"Feldkommandantur."

"Not to the Kreiskommandantur."

"Not to the Kreiskommandantur. Which means the labour is being requisitioned not for the works themselves but for the Todt people, who are outside the military chain, and who are building something the army does not want the district commands to look at."

"You have been thinking."

"I have been lying in a bed at three in the morning listening to a man talk about his brother's timber."

"Then it comes to the same thing, in your case." He took off his spectacles again and looked at the window, which was grey with rain. "It is good. It goes tonight, and it goes the long way. Do you understand what you have brought?"

"Something about a wall."

"Something about a wall," Wiktor said, with the flat distaste he kept for anything that sounded like a phrase. "You have brought the inspection schedule of two of the batteries on the Atlantic coast, and the fact that a certain organisation not under the army's command is requisitioning labour on the western coast through the Feldkommandantur, and that the army's district commands have been told not to interest themselves. In London, there is a man in a basement whose whole job is the coast of France. When he reads what you have brought, he will go upstairs and stand in front of a map for forty minutes. I know this because he is the man I used to be."

"He was taller."

"He was," Wiktor said. "And better dressed, and he had a wife, and he did not talk about walls."

He stood, and took something out of the inside pocket of the green coat, and put it on the cutting table: a woman's compact, engine-turned silver, the kind of thing a woman buys once and keeps for thirty years, with a mirror in the lid and a powder tray inside.

She knew it. He had given it to her in the summer of 1942, in a room in the fifteenth arrondissement, with the shutters closed and a fan worked by hand.

"You will not be taken alive and talking," Wiktor said, in exactly the tone in which he had said it the first time. "This is not courage. This is tradecraft. Repeat it."

"You will not be taken alive and talking."

"Louder."

"You will not be taken alive and talking."

"Good." He picked up the compact and turned it over in his hand and pressed the little catch at the hinge with his thumbnail, and the false floor came up, a quarter of an inch deep, and in it, wrapped in a scrap of tissue, was a single tablet the size of a match head and the colour of chalk. "Do not carry it loose. Do not put it in a glove. Do not sew it into anything. When they search you they will search the seams, and they have found things in worse places than the seams of a woman who has been searched before."

"You have told me this."

"I have told you this twice. When I have told you three times I shall know that I am frightened." He shut the compact and gave it to her, and she put it in the bag that was hanging on the back of the chair. "It is the same tablet as the last one. It is not a game. It is not for the day you are arres-

ted. It is for the third day, in the cellar, when you hear your own voice in the corridor saying things you have not yet decided to say."

"And Odile has one."

"Odile is a dressmaker from the eighth arrondissement and she has refused one for two years, and when they take her they will break her like a plate, and I will read about it in the German papers, and there is nothing at all to be done about it, and I do not wish to discuss it." He put his spectacles on. "Now. The papers."

She took the new Kennkarte out of the bag and looked at it, as she did every month: Marion Helene Herschlag, born in Herschlag, Lower Austria, twenty-nine years old, seat of the Austrian Red Cross's Vienna branch 1937–38, divorced from Oberleutnant Helmut Kurt Gessner, killed on the Eastern Front on 4 January 1942. A genuine Austrian woman had existed, briefly, in a hospital in Vienna, and had died of typhus in 1921 at the age of seven, alone, without a birth certificate that anybody had ever troubled to correct, and her name had cost the network four thousand francs to a clerk in a Kreisgericht in 1941.

"Say who you are," Wiktor said.

"I am Marion Herschlag."

"Where were you born?"

"At Herschlag, in Lower Austria. My father was a notary. My mother played the piano badly and taught me to sing."

"Why are you in Paris?"

"Because my husband was killed at Rostov and I could not stay in Vienna with the memories, and a friend of my

mother's had a house on the rue de Rivoli and I came in the spring of 1942 to work as a companion to her, and she died in November."

"Who was the friend?"

"Madame Rosa Berg. She is buried at Père-Lachaise. She died in November."

"And who do you sleep with?"

"I sleep with Oberst Wolfram von Hagen, of the staff of the Militärbefehlshaber in Frankreich, at 19 avenue Henri-Martin, on Tuesdays, Thursdays, Saturdays, and any other night he telephones."

"Repeat the second half of your account of the labour requisitions."

"Not to the Kreiskommandantur in the case of the two westernmost," she said. "Requests for labour to be submitted directly to the Feldkommandantur."

Wiktor nodded and put his hat on and looked at her for a moment with the expression that she had privately, in 1942, named the Ledger: the look of a man totting up a page he has written himself and found correct.

"You are not to think about the war," he said. "You are to think about the next thing. The war is a hundred and forty people in six rooms doing what I do, and if you begin to think about it you will be slow, and if you are slow you will be dead, and I will have to write a report about it, and my reports about women are always the same: capable, and lost through an error of sentiment."

"Which sentiment?"

"Whatever one it was." He turned for the door and then stopped with his hand on the curtain. "One thing. The Pol-

ish desk of the Lutetia has a new man. He has come from Warsaw through the Abwehr's own channel, which means he is either a fool or something we have not seen here, and the people who keep the emigrant lists have been asked to send their files up to the second floor. I have no more than that. Nobody in this city knows him. I do not know him. He does not know you. You will avoid him."

"His name?"

"I have given you everything I have," Wiktor said, "which is that you will avoid him," and went out through the curtain into the sound of the bell in F.

❦

She walked up the rue de Miromesnil with the new card in the lining of her bag and the dress in a box tied with string, and it began to rain in the thin, vindictive way that Paris rains in November, and she put up her umbrella, which was a German umbrella from a German shop and had cost more than the shoes of the woman who walked past her on the pavement pushing a pram made of a wooden crate and four bicycle wheels.

That woman looked at her. It lasted a fifth of a second. It was the look that Krystyna received, in this city, perhaps forty times a day, and it did not vary: from the shoes up, in one movement, and then away, with the face closed, and then, sometimes, at the end of the street, a second look back, which was the one that mattered, though not for the reasons the woman thought.

It was not a look about wealth. There were poor Frenchwomen in Paris in 1943, and there were rich Frenchwomen

in Paris in 1943, and the rich ones were eating at Maxim's and being photographed in the illustrated weeklies with their hair done by a man who had been released from a camp for the purpose. It was a look about provenance: it said, that coat came from somewhere that is not a French drawer, and it was, in its small way, an accusation, and Krystyna had learned to walk through forty of them a day the way one walks through a smoke-filled room.

The woman with the pram did not know, and could not have been expected to know, that the coat had been bought in the rue de la Paix with August's money from the Militärbefehlshaber's entertainment fund; that the shoes had belonged, before the fitting, to a girl of twenty-two from Lille who had been arrested in a bookshop in January and about whom nothing further was known; and that the woman in them, the twenty-fourth of November 1943, was at that moment carrying in her head, along with the dress and the compact and the Austrian papers, the inspection schedule of two batteries of the Atlantic Wall, which she would not be permitted to write down anywhere, and which she would have to keep safe for six more hours.

The pram-woman turned up a side street. Krystyna walked on, and something small and hard and familiar turned over in her stomach, which was not guilt — she had put guilt down somewhere in 1940 and had never been able to find the place again — but a thing for which she had no name, and which she had decided not to investigate because there was no profit in it, and which came back to her at night sometimes in the shape of her mother's coat.

Two years earlier, in Warsaw, she had been a girl who could not walk twenty metres without meeting somebody's eyes. That city had been a lit room. This one was a corridor.

She had once sat on the edge of a bed in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement with a girl from Lille and been asked, as a training exercise, to tell the story of her own life out loud in the third person while the other woman interrupted her.

She was born in Warsaw in 1919, she had begun, the middle child of a family that had money before the war and a name after it.

Why did she leave?

In September 1939 the city was bombed for three weeks and the family decided that the daughter should be sent south to relations while the son went with his regiment and the mother stayed with the father, and she went with a small case and a coat, on the fourth day of the bombing, from the Eastern station, and the train was stopped twice by the air raid and once by a rumour, and it took nineteen hours to go a hundred kilometres.

And who sent her?

Her mother. Her mother stood on the platform and put the coat on her and said, do not look back, and then held her husband's arm so that he would not call out, and she did not look back, and she has spent four years not looking back in a great many different places.

And after?

Hungary. Six months in Budapest, in the flat of a cousin of a cousin, doing a little teaching of French to the children

of a woman who had a passport and no scruples. Then Italy for four months, waiting for a passage that was bought twice and never came, and in the spring of 1940 the last of the money and a place in a group of people going to France, where the Polish army was being re-formed, and France was the road to everything else, and the road to France went through Yugoslavia and took nine weeks and cost her the last thing she owned, which was a ring.

And in France?

The army she had come for had already gone into the line and been broken, and the men she found in the second week of June 1940 were men of a country that no longer existed, sitting in a room in Toulouse with a typewriter and a set of instructions from a government in London, and a captain who looked at her for a long time and then asked her, in Polish, whether she could hold a piano tune, and she said yes, and he said, then we shall find somebody to teach you to sing.

And what does she do now?

She sings, Krystyna said, and she sleeps with a German colonel twice a week, and other things which are of no interest to you.

The girl from Lille had written something in her notebook and said nothing for a while, and then she had asked the one question the exercise was designed to produce: which part of that is true?

All of it, Krystyna had said. That is why I was chosen.

At half past three she was at the Ritz, where the Germans were, and where the hats were.

❦

The tea at the Ritz in the third winter of the occupation was an operation conducted by about forty Frenchwomen of a particular class and by the wives of German officers of a particular rank, and the two kinds of women sat at the same tables and spoke to one another in the manner of people who have agreed to consider a mutual acquaintance dead.

There were eleven Frenchwomen in the room that afternoon and five Germans. There was real cream, which had not been in a Paris shop since 1940, and there were petits fours that had been made by a chef who had been making petits fours in the Place Vendôme since 1921 and who had, in the intervening years, developed a small tremor of the left hand that could be seen by anyone who watched the trays. The fire was lit. The mirrors were polished. In the corner, a Hungarian played the piano, and played it well, and played the sort of thing that is played in hotels, and had been, in 1934, in the front rank of his profession, and knew it.

"Darling," said Céline Marchand, "come here, you have to see what the Krüger woman is wearing. Come here. Stand where I am standing, do you see, in the light, look at her back."

"I can see her back from here."

"You cannot see it from there, from there she looks almost normal. Look at the back. It is a dressmaker's crime. Do not laugh."

"I am not laughing."

"You are laughing inside. You have a laughing face, it is a curse, it is why the men watch you at the door. Have you

eaten? No, you have not eaten, you never eat, and I have eaten four of the small cakes and I am going to have to be let out of my corset with a jack." Céline Marchand had been born in Neuilly, had married a man who owned a factory at Asnières that had made agricultural machinery and now made parts for the German army, and had spent the entire occupation being delighted with herself in public, and was, in Krystyna's professional estimate, the single most dangerous Frenchwoman in the eighth arrondissement, because she noticed things about other women's clothes and other women's accents with the accuracy of an intelligence officer and the conscience of a magpie.

"The Krügers are going to Berlin for Christmas," Céline said. "She told me at least four times, in the way that means the opposite, which means he has been recalled, which means something has gone wrong at his office. Robert says the whole administration is going to be rearranged in the spring, he heard it from a man at the Majestic, and that is very good for us, because if they rearrange the administration, they will have to buy the whole thing over again, and Robert's contracts all come up for renewal in March." She sipped her tea. "We are going to do extremely well out of this war, darling, and then afterwards we are going to die of shame, and I intend to be in Biarritz when it happens."

"Then you will need a new coat."

"I have already ordered it," said Céline, delighted, "from your woman on the Miromesnil, she is too expensive and too slow and I love her, she refuses to make me anything with a pocket, she says a woman with a pocket stops thinking about her waist. Marion, may I ask you something?"

"You may ask."

"Are you all right?"

Krystyna turned her head and looked at her. Céline was forty, blonde by chemistry, with a small dark root showing that her hairdresser had been unable to obtain something, and her eyes were perfectly kind and perfectly empty, and she was the sort of friend that the operation had been built to produce: a woman who would introduce Marion Herschlag into every drawing room in Paris, who would defend her when she was not there, who would tell her everything she heard, and who would never, not once, ask a question that mattered.

"I am perfectly well."

"Because you look tired, darling. Not tired, that is the wrong word. You look — " and Céline made a gesture with her teacup, hunting for the word, and found it, as she always did — "you look elsewhere. Twice this afternoon I have been talking to you and you have been somewhere else. And your German is so good, but when you are tired it goes — here, like this — " and she put the cup down and said, in the voice of a woman quoting an old servant, with an accent laid on like paint on a wall, "'A bułka, if you please.'"

The room did not stop. The Hungarian played. The fire went on burning at the Ritz's expense.

Krystyna heard her own voice, twelve days earlier, in a room in the Hôtel Majestic, saying to an orderly with a tray: a bułka, if you please, and hearing herself do it, and covering the whole thing with a laugh and a story about a nanny from Lemberg who had taught her to curse and to pray and to ask for bread. It had been nothing. It had lasted four

seconds and the whole table had laughed with her, and she had gone home afterwards and stood under the running tap for twenty minutes, and had decided — this is what she had decided, standing there — that it had been nothing.

"You do that," Céline said. "That is a Polish word for a roll. My husband's first wife was Polish, God rest her."

"Your husband's first wife was Belgian."

"She said pumpernickel," Céline said, with immense satisfaction, "in a Polish accent, and my mother-in-law went to her grave calling her the Pole. A bułka. And where does a Viennese girl out of a notary's house get a Polish word for a roll?"

"From a nanny."

"From a nanny," Céline said, and burst out laughing, "and from nowhere else, because if it were from a husband I should have had to be jealous, and if it were from a mother I should have had to be interested, and one mustn't be interested, darling, it is the only rule of the period." She took Krystyna's hand and squeezed it, and her fingers were warm, and there was real feeling in it, which was the worst of it, and Krystyna looked at this woman with her dark root and her expensive gloves and her factory at Asnières, and thought — as she thought, more and more often that winter — you are going to be very useful to somebody, one day, and it will not be by your own choice.

❦

The concierge of the house on the rue Saint-Honoré was called Madame Roussel, and she had a lodge with a brown curtain and a stove and a cat, and she kept a ledger.

The ledger had been in the lodge since 1937 and had been kept first for the landlord, who wanted to know about unpaid rent, and then for a period of two years for nobody much, and then, from the autumn of 1942, for a purpose: a column of arrivals and departures, in the concierge's own hand, which was slow and round and had been made at a school in the twelfth arrondissement in about 1892.

It recorded what a concierge in a good building in the eighth arrondissement would record, which is everything: the coalman, the doctor for the second floor, the priest for the fifth, the Englishwoman's letters before the Englishwoman left. And, since October, it recorded — in a column that had been added at the right-hand edge, in a hand that was pressed a little harder than the rest — the hours at which Madame Herschlag, second floor left, went out in the evening, and the hours at which she came in.

Krystyna saw the column on the twenty-fourth of November, at half past six, standing in the lodge with her key in her hand, being handed her post by a woman who had been three years at the same post, who kept the stairs clean in a building that was not hers, who had a nephew in the Resistance, and who had never in her life been asked a question by a German that she could not answer with a shrug and a shrug's worth of truth.

"Madame Herschlag," the concierge said. "There is a man asking for you. Here, in the afternoon, on Tuesday, and again this morning."

"A man?"

"German," said Madame Roussel, in the voice of a woman reporting a bill. "Not a soldier. He came in a hat and he asked me who lives on the fourth floor and he asked me how long you have had your rooms, and he asked me whether there are many Poles in the building, and he asked me whether I could read, madame, if you can believe it, whether I could read, and I said yes, monsieur, I can read, and he wrote it down."

"Did he give a name?"

"No name." The concierge pushed the ledger an inch further away from the edge of the counter, and Krystyna did not look at it, not once, and never would; she had memorised the whole of the relevant spread in October in the eleven seconds it had taken the concierge to find the second-floor post.

"And the column?" she said. "The one at the edge."

"That," Madame Roussel said, "was there before the man came. It was there in October. A gentleman asked me to keep the hours of the people who go in and out at night, because of the blackout, he said, because of the thefts in the building, and he had a little list of the tenants and he ticked the ones he had spoken to, and when he had gone I looked at the list, and madame, every name on it was German or Austrian. Not one French name. Not one."

"Did you tell the man in the hat?"

"I did not," said Madame Roussel, and closed the ledger with her hand flat on it, and looked at Krystyna for the first time, straight on, which was a thing she had never done in three years. "My nephew is in the country. He writes to me

about his chickens. He writes a great deal about his chickens. If you understand me, madame, then we understand each other, and if you do not understand me, then I have said nothing about chickens and it is of no consequence."

"I understand you," Krystyna said.

"Then good evening to you," said the concierge, and took up her knitting.

She went up two flights with the dress box under her arm, and let herself into two cold rooms, and stood in the dark without putting on a light for the length of one cigarette, which she did not smoke but held, and thought about the man in the hat, who was neither a fool nor a Frenchman with a grudge, and who had asked a concierge to keep a record of the night movements of the German and Austrian tenants of a building on the rue Saint-Honoré, and about the fact that a man who starts with the German tenants is looking, precisely and patiently, for something that is German and is being used against the Germans, and that when he finishes with the German tenants he will arrive, with his notebook and his careful questions, at her.

She had five days, by her own reckoning, before the letter arrived, and she would spend all five of them doing what she always did, which was work.

Chapter three

The Ledger of Small Hours

❦

There were four chairs in the corridor outside the office of the Chef der Militärverwaltung on the third floor of the Hôtel Majestic, and three of them were occupied by Frenchmen with briefcases, and the fourth, for three hours on the second of December 1943, was occupied by a woman in a grey dress who had been told to wait and who had discovered, in the course of a great many hours of waiting in a great many buildings, that waiting was the only form of intelligence work in which a woman was never suspected of being engaged.

Nobody looks at a woman who is waiting. She is furniture with a handbag. In three hours she learned: that the corridor's second door on the left was used by the officers of the transport section, because the man who came out of it had a timetable under his arm and a pencil behind his ear; that the third door on the right was the office of the administration's legal adviser, because two lawyers and a priest went in and none came out smiling; that the courier who arrived at ten past eleven with a leather satchel and left at twenty past, twenty-four, and forty-one past, was a despatch rider from the Kommandantur, and that he was sleeping with one of the two secretaries in the typing pool, because he looked at the blonde one and the blonde one did

not look at him and both of them were very careful about the door.

That the SD's man had been in the building that morning, because he had left his card on the table for the officer of the day, and the card was picked up by a clerk who read it, looked at no one, and put it in his pocket, which is what every clerk in France did with a card from the avenue Foch.

And that at eleven o'clock, an hour and a half into her wait, an officer came down the corridor in a civilian overcoat with a hat in his hand, and glanced at the four chairs with the glancing of a man who inventories everything, and looked at her for perhaps two seconds longer than a German officer looks at a waiting woman, and went out through the main door, and she sat with her hands in her lap and her face empty and did not move until he had been gone half a minute.

At half past twelve a Hauptmann came out and said, "Fräulein Herschlag? The Colonel will see you now," in the voice of a man interrupting a holiday, and she stood up, and gathered her bag, and went in.

The office was too large for the desk. That was the first thing about it and the thing she came to understand as the man himself: it had been the sitting room of a suite built for a family that had employed nine servants, and the German administration had put a desk in the middle of it and a map on the wall and a table with four telephones, and left everything else exactly as it was, so that an Oberst in the service of the Reich sat with his back to a marble fireplace that had been carved with a hunting scene, doing his paperwork under a plaster ceiling with a naked woman in it.

He had been in there since half past ten. He looked up when she came in and did the one thing she had learned to dread in him, which was to look at her for a moment as an object of value before he remembered that she was a person.

"My dear. Sit down. Have you eaten?"

"I have eaten."

"You have not eaten, you never eat, everyone in this building tells me you never eat, they watch you at the receptions like a laboratory experiment." He pushed a plate across the desk: sandwiches of real ham on real bread, cut into triangles, with a sprig of parsley on them, in a building in a city where the ration for an adult Frenchman in that week was two hundred and fifty grams of bread a day, and children in the twentieth arrondissement were being sent to the country to drink milk that the Germans had not requisitioned because there were not enough lorries. "Sit down. I am going to dictate and you are going to be useful, which you have not been for eleven days."

She sat down, and got out her notebook, and was useful.

He dictated four letters. He dictated like a man reading a poem he did not admire: flat, accurate, with the verbs at the end, and pauses at the end of paragraphs in which he looked at the map or out of the window or at the corner of the room where the photograph was not. One letter to a quartermaster in Nancy about a requisitioned hotel; one to his brother about the Pomeranian timber, in which he wrote a fair price and an unfair sentence and crossed out the sentence; one to the wife of a colleague about the death of the colleague's brother, which was four paragraphs long and

contained no sentiment whatever, and which was, she thought, the most German document she had ever handled, because every one of the four paragraphs said in a different way that the man would be replaced; and one, the last, dictated more slowly than the others, to a schoolmaster in a village near Magdeburg.

Dear Herr Direktor, You will recall my son Klaus, who was in your school from 1931 to 1936 and who was an indifferent scholar in mathematics and a first-rate scholar on the subject of horses. I am informed that the school intends a memorial for the former pupils, and I have been asked for a photograph and a short paragraph. I send the photograph. For the paragraph I find that I have nothing to say that would not embarrass the school, and I would be grateful if you would write it yourself. If it would assist you I can tell you that he was not afraid of anything except failure, and that he was frightened of failure to the last day of his life, in January, at Stalingrad, at the age of nineteen, and that this was not a fault of the school.

He stopped. The room was quiet in the way of a very large room with a marble fireplace and two telephones and a man in it who has stopped talking.

"Read that back," he said.

She read it back, twice, and he changed one word — first-rate to good — and told her to add a sentence of condolence from himself to the Direktor's family, and she wrote it in her notebook, in her own hand, which she permitted to be a little clumsy at the ends of words because a woman who writes too well is remembered.

"Now the file," he said, and pushed a folder across the desk with his two fingers, and she took it and opened it, because this was what she was for: an officer's mistress who could type in German was worth the taking; an officer's mistress who could type in German and file was worth keeping.

Inside were the papers of an argument. She did not read them — she never read anything in his presence except what he asked her to read — but she turned them, and sorted them, and put them into the order of their dates, and in the doing she took in, through her fingers, four sheets that mattered: two memoranda from the Militärbefehlshaber's office in Warsaw about the state of the bridges on the Vistula; a copy of a report on the security situation in the Warsaw district, in the language of the office, in which the phrase these persons are to be reckoned with occurred three times; and, on the last sheet, a list of three names in a hand she did not know, in which the second was the name of a man appointed to the Warsaw garrison command, and the first was a name in the fourth line of a paragraph about a police commander who had been shot in the street in Warsaw in the winter and about the reprisals that had followed.

She had it all inside a quarter of an hour, through her fingertips, in a room with a marble fireplace, while the man who had dictated the letter about his son sat and looked at the map and drank ersatz coffee and told her, once, without looking round, that the heating in the building was a scandal.

At one o'clock the telephone rang, and he answered it, and she got out of the chair because the tone told her to.

"An hour," he said. "At four. Bring a hat. There is tea."

"But the fit—"

"The fit will wait. There is a gentleman in the building from the Sicherheitspolizei who has asked to be introduced to you, and I have agreed, because agreeing costs nothing and disagreeing costs a file." He turned back to the map, and then he stopped, and he said the last thing that happened in that room before she left it, and it was not to her, and it was as flat as everything he said. "It is the third time he has asked. First the office, then the street, and now my house, in three weeks. A man who asks three times is not curious, he is methodical, and I do not like methodical men in other people's departments. Go and be charming. Do not be interesting."

❦

The tea was in a room on the second floor with a portrait of a French banker over the fireplace, and there were eleven people at it, and by the time Krystyna sat down she had already made her assessment of the two men standing at the window, and the assessment was not comfortable, because the one she had been brought to meet was not the one who told her so.

He was perhaps thirty-seven, perhaps forty, in a grey civilian suit, medium, ordinary, with brown hair that had no grey in it and a face that had been designed, she thought, by a committee whose subject had been a bank clerk, and he was cleaning his spectacles with the corner of a handkerchief when she came in, and he put them on and stood up and bowed his head a fraction of an inch, and said, "Fräulein Herschlag. Bruno Kalbach."

"How do you do."

"I do very well. May I get you something? The tea here is not tea. There is a Frenchman at the end of the corridor who makes something he calls coffee, and which is not coffee, but which is hot."

"I should like the thing that is hot and called coffee."

"So should we all," Kalbach said, and went and got it, and brought it back himself rather than letting the orderly do it, which was the first of what she was to number, over the next ten months, as twenty-three acts of consideration.

The conversation lasted thirty-one minutes and she could have reproduced every word of it for the rest of her life from memory, and did, in other rooms, on other evenings, in the bath at the flat in the ninth, turning it over and over the way a woman turns over a stone in a stream to see what is on the underside.

He began with the weather and the price of coal, and went on to the ballet, and told her about a performance of Giselle he had seen in Vienna in 1938, in a way that made her understand that he had been in Vienna in March 1938 and that he had seen everything else that was there that month, and then he asked her the four questions he had been waiting to ask, in the right order, in the way of a man who had spent the morning arranging them:

Where had she been at school?

Vienna, at the Institute of the Sacred Heart on the Rennweg, until sixteen, and then, because her father's health had gone and the money with it, in a lycée in Lausanne for two years, where she had been very badly taught French by a woman from Bern and learned to swim.

Which of those two places did she think of as home?

Lausanne. Vienna was the city in which she had been a child, and she was not a child any longer, and to be in Vienna in 1943 was to be walked through a museum of her own mistakes.

Did she play the piano? He had heard she sang.

She sang a little, and played only well enough to accompany herself, and had been taught, oddly enough, by a Galician woman who had been in service in her mother's house and who had taught her the songs of a country she had never seen.

And her father's health?

He had a heart, she said, that was older than the rest of him, and he had died at Herschlag in 1939, and her mother had gone in 1941, and she was an only child, which was why she found herself, in Paris, in 1943, with no one to whom she had any obligation at all.

"Which is an enviable condition," Kalbach said.

"It is a lonely one."

"The two are usually the same," he said, and looked at her with his spectacles on and his hands folded round his cup, and there was nothing whatever in his face; and then he said the thing she carried home and turned over in the bath, because it was not a question, it was an observation, and observations are what hunters leave in the forest to see which animals will step over them. "We have a very peculiar sort of thief in this building, Fräulein Herschlag. I have been reading his file all afternoon. He has been at it for two years and he has never once taken a thing that could be sold, and he has never once been late, and he has never once made a mis-

take that we can see. In Vienna, in 1938, I catalogued the contents of eleven hundred flats, and every single person in them believed that they had made no mistakes either. What do you think of that?"

"I think," Krystyna said, "that you must be very good at cards."

Kalbach did not laugh. He said, "I am very bad at cards," and finished his not-coffee, and stood up, and thanked her for the conversation, and bowed again, that fraction of an inch, and left the room.

And the second man, who had been standing at the window the whole time with his back to the room and his hands behind him, turned round when the door had shut behind Kalbach, and looked at the place where Kalbach had been sitting, and said, "Well. What did the little clerk want?"

"To know where I was at school," Krystyna said.

"Everyone wants to know where you were at school," said Hauptmann Kurt Lindemann, of the counter-intelligence section, thirty-three, handsome in an over-designed way, with his hair done with a hot finger, and a laugh he use to cut things. "It is the curse of a beautiful woman in an occupied country. He has been at the building for three weeks and he has spoken to eleven people, and you are the first woman, which either means that he has eliminated the other women or that you are the first woman he has any reason to speak to. May I be candid?"

"You are always candid."

"Naturally. Then: that man is the most dangerous person in the German administration in France, not because he

is clever, though he is, and not because he is cruel, though he is that too, but because he does not enjoy any of it. Our people enjoy it. Reinhardt enjoys it, he had his office redecorated twice; I enjoy it; even the Colonel enjoys it, in the way of a man playing a long game of chess. That man in there does not enjoy anything at all, and he has no wife, no mistress, no dog, no debts, and no vices that anyone has been able to find, and he has been in the service since 1934, and when he goes home at night, Fräulein Herschlag, I believe he goes home and reads. Do you understand what that means?"

"That he is boring."

"It means that he is the only man in this building who is exactly what he appears to be," Lindemann said. "Which means that when he looks at you, he is looking at you. Be dull, madame. Be lovely and dull. You have been given a great gift: the entire German officer corps believes that you have no head for anything, and God knows they need to believe it. Do not disabuse them."

❦

The villa on the Frascati would not be requisitioned until the spring, and the villa on the avenue Henri-Martin was the house of the winter, and by eleven o'clock that night she was in it, and by half past eleven she was in the bed in it, and at midnight the Colonel came up with the smell of the office on him and the tiredness of a man of fifty-four who has been shouted at by a general on the telephone.

He lay down and put his hands behind his head and told her about Warsaw.

Not because she asked. Because there was a woman in the bed and the light was off and a man who has been shouted at by a general needs to fill a room with his own voice, and because, in the six months she had lived in his house, he had told her more about the German administration in the east than her network had been able to assemble in three years of couriers.

"There will be a new arrangement in the east," he said. "The Generalgouvernement is not an administration any longer, it is a corridor, and everything that moved into it in 1939 has to be reorganised because of what is happening on the other side of it." He said the word reorganised the way he said requisitioned: as a fact of nature. "There is a man in Warsaw who has been running the police there since the autumn, a Kutschera, an Austrian, from the SS, with the manners of a border guard and a very good record, and he has been asked to do in Warsaw what we have not done in Paris, which is to break the Underground's intelligence. Do you know what the difference is between the Underground in Poland and the Underground in France?"

"I have never been to Poland."

"No," he said. "Nobody has been to Poland. It is a country that consists of a railway station and a graveyard and a great deal of argument." He laughed, once, and it was not a laugh she had heard him use before, and she filed it. "The Poles have an army in the forest. They have a government in London with three parties in it and a division of opinion, and they have courts, and schools, and newspapers. In this country, the resistance is a hobby that the middle classes

have taken up instead of the theatre. In Poland it is a state. And the state's weapon is not the bomb, it is the file. They know, my dear, the name of every policeman in Warsaw who has ever taken a bribe. So they send an Austrian with a good record, and they give him counter-intelligence and a free hand, and the polite version of his instructions, which I have read, is that the intelligence apparatus is to be dismantled and its personnel put in the ground. That is the polite version. I have seen the impolite one, and I do not intend to repeat it in a bedroom."

She lay still in the dark with her cheek on his shoulder, which was the position she slept in when she was told to.

"In the spring," he said, "the whole Abwehr in this country will be dismantled, and I have it from a man who knows, because the Admiral has lost his argument in Berlin, and because there is a document, and because this is how the Reich does everything, by document. The sections will be divided, and the officers will be distributed. When a thing is distributed, my dear, people like me are given a new address. I have been told to expect the east."

She kept her breathing exactly as it had been.

"Warsaw," he said, and the word came out of the dark at her like a hand. "I am fifty-four years old, I am a colonel of counter-intelligence, and I have broken four networks in three years, and they are sending me to Warsaw, which is a place where I shall be given a great deal of work and no thanks, because that is what the Reich does with men like me at the end of the fourth year of a war it is not winning."

"Will you go?"

"I will go where I am sent." A pause. "There is a house there, on a street called Frascati, that was requisitioned from a Jewish lawyer and is currently occupied by a man from the administration of the ghetto who is being transferred to Lublin, which is a German euphemism, my dear, and you need not look it up. It has four rooms and a garden and a safe in the study. I have been offered it, and I have accepted it, and the requisition papers arrived at the office today."

She said, because it was a question and a question can be answered without lying, "And what am I to do with a house in Warsaw?"

"You will come with me," von Hagen said.

In the dark, with her cheek on his shoulder, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna counted to eleven, and then said, in the warm, slow, foolish voice that had taken her two years to build, "Do they have a good dressmaker in Warsaw?"

He laughed — the ordinary laugh, the man-at-home laugh, the one she could steer — and put his hand on her hair.

"They have nothing in Warsaw, my dear. That is the point of it."

❦

She was at the Mission on the rue Saint-Honoré at seven the next morning, because the Mission opened at six and the priest who mattered came to the early mass with his hands blue.

She gave him what she had in the order she had learned: the two memoranda about the bridges, the phrase these persons are to be reckoned with, the name in the second line of

the list, and the fact that the German administration in the west expected its counter-intelligence apparatus to be broken up in the spring and its officers distributed — a piece of news which was, she knew, worth more to the Polish government in London than a battery or a bridge, because a government that has been in exile for four years lives on the knowledge of who is going to be standing where.

And then she said, in Polish, without any change in her voice at all: "The Colonel has been given a house in Warsaw. He is to be posted there in the spring. He has told me I will go with him."

The priest was silent for the length of three Hail Marys.

"You will go," he said at last. "That is not a question for me. It is a question for the people in London and for the people under the ground in Warsaw, and I shall send it tonight, and you will have your answer in three weeks. Until then you will do nothing whatever, and you will do it very well."

"I know what the answer will be."

"Of course you know what the answer will be. Knowing is nothing. Doing it without sentiment is everything, and you were trained by a man who was very good at that." He crossed himself, and looked at the altar, and said, in a voice that had something in it which she had not heard from him before: "There was a girl from Warsaw in this parish in 1941. She had been at a school with a cousin of mine. She had a head for languages and a mother in a hospital at Ivry, and she worked with a group of Poles in the twentieth arrondissement, and in June the Germans took eleven of them

and shot six, and the six were the ones who had been betrayed by the eleventh. She was not one of the six. She was one of the eleven who were questioned and released, and she came to me afterwards, in this room, in that chair, and asked me what she was supposed to do with the rest of her life. And do you know what I told her?"

"What?"

"That God had not made her for this. It was the worst thing I have ever said to a living soul, and she went home that night and took the gas, and I have never once told anybody, except a woman I have never seen before and shall probably never see again, who is off to Warsaw in the spring with a German's papers in her bag." He stood up. "You will not be told that God did not make you for it. You will be told nothing at all. You will simply be told where to stand, and when, and what to bring, and you will not be thanked, and if you are lucky you will be old one day, in a country that exists, and you will have a great many bad nights, and that is the whole of the reward. Do you understand me?"

"Yes."

"Then go and have your breakfast with the enemy," the priest said, "and do not come to me on Thursdays any more. The man in the hat was at the door of the building on Wednesday and again this morning. Sundays, after the eleven o'clock, in the chapel of Our Lady, where the bell cannot be heard from the street."

❦

At eight o'clock, in the café on the corner of the rue de Rivoli, she ate two eggs and a piece of bread and drank a

bowl of something the menu called coffee, and read the morning paper, which was full of the war in Italy and of a speech by a German field marshal about the invincibility of the Atlantic defences, and which printed, on the second page, in a box, the names of eleven men who had been executed at Fresnes in the previous week for acts of sabotage against the military authority of the Reich.

She read the names the way she read everything now: once, all the way through, and then a second time in her head, in case any of them was a name she had ever heard in any room, because if it was, there was work to be done before noon.

None of them was.

Then she put the paper down, and lit a cigarette — she had four a day and the fourth was in the evening, and she smoked them like a soldier on leave — and looked out of the window at the rue de Rivoli, at the German soldiers filing past with their rifles slung and their eyes ahead, at the woman with the pram and the coal, at the two girls on bicycles, at the gendarme who was thirty and tired and standing in the doorway of the préfecture with his hands behind his back, and she let the thing she had been holding since half past midnight sit in front of her on the table for exactly as long as a cigarette lasts.

Warsaw.

She had not let herself think the word, properly, since the platform in September 1939, and now it was on the table with a German colonel's requisitioning papers behind it and a hunter's file on the avenue Foch behind that, and

she understood, with a clarity she had not asked for and did not want, that her own life had just been divided into two parts: the part in which she was a woman with a face nobody in a city knew, and the part in which she would be walking through the streets of her own childhood, in a fur coat, on the arm of the enemy, and every doorway would contain the possibility of a woman who had known her mother.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna of Warsaw had, in the four years since she left it, done the following things: crossed three countries on papers she had paid for; learned to be another woman twice, once badly and once well; memorised the coast of France; and lain in the bed of an Oberst of the Militärbefehlshaber in Frankreich and listened to him talk about the east.

She had also, in those four years, developed a rule for the moment when the fear arrived, which was this: the fear arrived, and she gave it one cigarette, and then she took it out of the room by the scruff of the neck and put it to work.

She finished her cigarette, and paid, and put on her gloves, and went out into the cold to the fitting on the rue de Miromesnil, which had been moved to nine because the dress was to be worn on the twenty-third and it was very far from finished, and to which she brought, folded in her bag and printed in her memory in its entirety, everything she had learned in the Hôtel Majestic the previous day: the bridges, the phrase, the names, and the fact that, in the spring, the whole apparatus of German counter-intelligence in the west was going to be taken to pieces like a watch and put back together in the east, and that among the parts be-

ing moved was a fifty-four-year-old Oberst with cracked knuckles and a dead son and a photograph with its back turned to the room, and a hunter with clean spectacles and no vices who read her the way a man reads a page of sums, and one man in the Polish desk of the Hôtel Lutetia whose name she did not know and whom, in twenty-nine days of absolute obedience to her own instructions, she had managed not to meet.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Christmas of the Wolves

❦

The winter of 1943 was the third cold winter and the coldest, and Paris had a way of being cold that Krystyna had not known in any other city: not the flat, honest cold of Warsaw, which came at you off the snow and got into the seams of things, but a wet, breathing, indoor cold that got into the wallpaper and the plaster and stayed there like a smell.

Coal went where coal went. The Germans had their own allocation, and the concierges had theirs, and the hospitals had a great deal less than either, and everybody else burned whatever Paris had that was made of wood and not nailed down. In the courtyard of the building on the rue Saint-Honoré a walnut escritoire had stood since the start of October slowly reverting to the elements under a tarpaulin; by December it had lost its drawers and half of one leg, and the wood of a Frenchman's desk of 1780 was keeping a linen maid of 1890 and her two granddaughters warm at night, one drawer at a time.

At half past nine in the morning the temperature in the rue de la Pompe was two degrees above freezing and the pavements had a yellow-grey glaze on them that had been frozen and trodden and frozen again, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked on it in boots made for her in a shop that had a German licence on the window, and there

were thirteen people standing still on the corner, and they were standing still because of the two cars.

The cars were French, black, with their headlamps masked down to slits, and there was a German officer sitting in the back of the first one with the window down, and he had his arm out of the window and his hand on the door, and he was not doing anything at all; he had the face of a man watching a train come in.

The police were French and they went into the building in the way of men doing an unpleasant job in front of their own neighbours, which is to say quickly and without looking at anyone. They were in the building for a quarter of an hour. At the end of the quarter of an hour they came out with a family: a man of about fifty-five in a good coat with no hat, a woman with her hair down and a fur over her nightgown, a girl of sixteen or so in a grey skirt and a cardigan, and an old man who came last, holding a clock.

The old man was the one everybody looked at. He came down the steps of the building with the clock held in both hands against his chest, a walnut clock with a brass face, and he was not being hurried and he was not being made to carry it, he was simply carrying it because it was his, and the policeman who walked behind him had his eyes on the middle distance and his mouth slightly open, and the whole street watched the clock go past.

At the car, one of the French police put out a hand to take it, and the old man said something that Krystyna did not hear from twenty metres away and heard perfectly, as the entire street did, in the pause the sentence made. The

policeman took his hand back. The old man got into the second car with the clock on his knees and the door was shut by a man who then put his hands behind his back and looked at the pavement.

The girl had begun to cry, and had stopped, and the woman's fur had come off one shoulder and nobody had put it back.

The German in the first car lifted his hand an inch off the door and the cars moved off down the rue de la Pompe towards the boulevard, and it took eleven seconds, and then the street was a street again and the traffic came round the corner, and a woman in a queue outside the baker's, three metres away from Krystyna, said to nobody in particular, in the flat voice of a person discussing a draught: "They will want the building now. They will put some office in it. There was a whole family in there on the second floor and they were here before the war, and now they will put an office in it, and my sister will not be able to get her milk."

Krystyna walked on down the rue de la Pompe.

She had had, in the five seconds after the old man said whatever he said, the following experience: her legs had decided to cross the road, and her hips had turned, and her coat was already moving, and she had put her hand out to the left in a gesture that came from nowhere and that was, she understood with a kind of clinical distance, the beginning of a movement to take the clock and put it down on the pavement and stand in front of the old man; and then the training, which had been installed in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement by a man with a stick

and no vices, had come up through the floor of her and taken hold of her by the spine and turned her the other way, and she had walked on.

There was nothing to be done. That was true, and she had spent two years learning the shape of it, and the shape was this: a woman who interferes at a round-up in the rue de la Pompe is a woman who is arrested, and a woman who is arrested is a woman whose handbag is searched, and in the handbag of Marion Herschlag on the twenty-second of December 1943 there was a compact with a false floor in it, and a scrap of paper with a telephone number on it that belonged to a hotel in Toulouse, and the names in her head of forty-one Poles in the Paris region whose names she could not say under torture even once, and if that sounds like a boast it is not: she had been given two lessons about the business of being asked, and she had learned them, and the whole of her courage, from 1940 onwards, had been converted from the sort that runs into streets into the sort that walks past.

She knew all of this. She went over all of it while walking the length of the rue de la Pompe with her hands in her pockets, and it worked, and by the corner of the avenue she was steady, and there was still, at the bottom of her, a small, cold, permanent thing the size of a fingernail that had been installed during those five seconds and that would be there for the rest of her life, and she catalogued it, too, without slowing down, the way a woman catalogues a splinter.

At Odile's, at eleven, she was fitted for a bodice and said nothing about the rue de la Pompe, and Odile did not ask, because Odile had known by nine o'clock, because every-

body in the quarter knew by nine o'clock, and there was a rule between the women in that workroom that was never written down: no news, no predictions, no list of what had happened this week to other people.

At half past eleven, while the two women in the back room sewed, Krystyna took the lid off the box under the cutting table.

It was a dressmaker's box, pasteboard, with a picture of a rose on it. Odile had begun it in 1941 as a spool box and it had become, over two years and four months, what it was now: the contents of the pockets of the people who had been taken. A tortoiseshell comb. Two rings. A child's glove, knitted, with a thumb. A photograph of a young man in a military hospital with his arm in a sling and his cap on the bed behind him, inscribed on the back à ma petite soeur, souvenir de Bar-le-Duc. A prayer book with a name in it in pencil. A key. Four letters, banded with a rubber band that had perished.

"I have had that box for two years," Odile said, without turning round, "and I have never once looked in it, and if you take one thing out of it and put it in your bag, I shall take the whole box down to the courtyard and burn it, and you will not be angry with me, because you know the rule."

"I know the rule."

"You want to."

"Of course I want to."

"Then put the lid on it and stand still, and consider this: you are the only person I have ever met who is a worse sentimentalist than I am, and you have more to lose by it." Odile

spat a pin into her hand. "Also, the shoulder is now right. Look at the shoulder."

❦

The supper at the Majestic on the evening of the twenty-third was an event in the German social calendar of Paris, which is to say that it was held in a ballroom with eleven chandeliers and a balcony, and that the Reich paid for it in an accounting sense, and France paid for it in every other sense, and that a photograph of it appeared three weeks later in a German illustrated paper under the caption Christmas Eve in Paris and was reproduced, after the Liberation, in a great many accusations.

There were two hundred and forty people at it. There was an orchestra of French musicians who were paid in money and in passes, and who played what an orchestra plays. There was a buffet with a boar's head and oysters from Brittany and a bar at which any man in a German uniform could drink anything in the world. The wine list had been requisitioned from a cellarer in the Loire; the tablecloths came from a firm that had had a Jewish proprietor in 1938 and had a German administrator now; the holly had been flown in from Norway, in an aircraft that had been scheduled to take a general to Berlin.

And there was a woman standing at the end of the room in a grey dress with a pearl necklace, who was the Colonel's Marion, and who was known, by the two hundred and sixteen people who did not know her, as the charming one, the Austrian, the one who is too good for him.

She had done the arithmetic on the way there, in the car, with the flake of cold steel in her chest that was three days old: the room would contain, by her own count, the heads of eleven German departments in France, four colonels, one general, and, at a table near the balcony, the wife of the man who had ordered the deportation of four thousand stateless Jews from the southern zone in August, who was a small woman of about fifty with a sweet face and a taste for Schubert; and she intended, in the course of the evening, to be introduced to all of them, because the whole of her work had become exactly this: the acquisition, through the medium of being delightful, of the small facts that men drop in rooms that they think are safe.

They ate. She talked to a Luftwaffe major about the acoustics of a concert hall in Dresden, and to a French contractor about the price of cement in the Seine department, which he quoted to her to the franc, because he had told her four times that a woman could not understand a business and had then explained the whole of it, and to a German clerk of the administration's food section, who was drunk, and who told her that the meat that had come to Paris in the second half of the year had been coming from a slaughterhouse in the east, and that the section had a row with the railway over the refrigerated wagons, and gave her the terminus.

At eleven o'clock the orchestra stopped for the speeches, and after the speeches, as was the custom of that year, the room sang carols.

The Colonel put his hand on her elbow and steered her through the tables the way a man steers a boat he is proud of.

"Fräulein Herschlag will sing," he said, to a general who was asking about something else; and then, to her, in a lowered voice, with a pleasure in it that was genuine and that she never afterwards managed to hate in the way she wanted to hate it: "Do the third one. The one with the roses."

The third one was Es ist ein Ros entsprungen, which is a German carol of the sixteenth century about a rose growing in the winter, and which she had learned at the Institute of the Sacred Heart on the Rennweg in Vienna, in the year when she was fifteen and enjoyed singing, and which she could now perform in a manner that made German officers of fifty put down their glasses and look at the middle distance and remember a church in a town that was not on any map any more.

She stood by the piano, in her grey dress, two hundred and forty people in the room and the chandelier lights up, and she sang it in a clear, small, tender voice, in German, for the Reich, in the ballroom of the German military administration in Paris, on the twenty-third of December 1943.

They were silent while she sang. Some of the older ones put their hands behind their backs. The wife of the general who had the sweet face and the taste for Schubert had tears in her eyes at the third verse, and looked at her afterwards with an expression of pure love, and took her hand in both of hers and said, "Child, where were you in Vienna?" and Krystyna told her the street, correctly, and the woman said,

"I know it, I know it, there was a confectioner on the corner," and there was in fact a confectioner on the corner, in the file, in a photograph, in a paragraph of a report on the parish of Rennweg written by a Polish monk in 1937, and it was this, this, that had cost four thousand francs.

Then there was applause, and a general made a small speech of thanks which did not name her, and the orchestra came back, and the Colonel, who had been standing at the piano with his hands behind his back and a look on his face of an almost unbearable satisfaction, took her by the elbow and led her out of the room through a side door into a small salon with two windows and a fire and no one in it.

"There," he said, and set her down in a chair as though she were a piece of porcelain that he had carried across a room without breaking. "You see. They will not forget that. In this country they will remember a voice for thirty years and a battle for thirty days, and when the war is over and the arguments begin, there will be men in Berlin, in important rooms, who will say, I once heard a woman sing a carol in Paris, and it will be in the record along with everything else."

He took the box out of his jacket pocket and put it on the table between them.

She knew the box. She had seen that box in the window of a jeweller on the rue de la Paix in October and had admired it in the correct way, which is to say for four seconds, in the presence of a man, and without ever mentioning it again, because mentioning a thing twice is the amateur's error and mentioning it once in the right voice is the whole of the art.

"There is a necklace in it," von Hagen said, "which belonged to the wife of a banker who is no longer in Paris, and which I have bought for you, on account of the singing."

She opened it. Twelve millimetres at the top and seven at the bottom, forty-one pearls, a clasp of white gold with a small diamond set in it, and a card inside the lid with the jeweller's name and the date and a figure written in pencil in a hand that was not the jeweller's. Nine hundred and forty thousand francs.

"Christian," she said. She used his first name three or four times a year and it cost her something every time. "I cannot take it."

"You will take it. It is bought and it is paid for and the money went to a man who is going to need it."

"It is far too much."

"It is exactly enough," said the Colonel, and took it out of the box and put it round her neck himself, standing behind her chair so that she had to hold her hair up with both hands, and his fingers were cold and a little clumsy and he was careful not to catch her hair, and the whole of it took eleven seconds. "There. Now. Some arithmetic, my dear, in the middle of the evening, because we are both of us practical people. You are twenty-nine years old—"

"I am."

"You are twenty-nine, you are an Austrian without a family, you have been kept since June by an officer of the German army at an expense that you have never once asked about, in a city that is going to be hungry in the spring and very unpleasant in the autumn. When I am posted, I shall be

posted to the east. I am not a young man and I have no illusions about the Russian winter. If anything happens to me, you will be a woman in Paris in 1945 with an Austrian passport, no money, and a great many photographs, and the pearls will be the difference between a room and no room, and you will remember, I hope, that I thought of it. That is the arithmetic. There is also the other arithmetic, which is that I do not intend to be separated from the one thing in my life that is pleasant."

She turned in the chair and looked up at him.

There he was, in the firelight, in a well-cut dinner jacket, fifty-four years old, with the duelling scar on the left cheek and the enormous ugly careful hands, and there was nothing in his face that she could safely have called love and there was certainly nothing in it that she could safely have called contempt: there was possession, and there was habit, and there was a kind of dry, formal tenderness that was the exact product of his class and his generation and his dead wife and his dead son; and she found, sitting in that chair with the pearls already warming at her throat, that she could not meet his eyes, which was a thing that happened about four times a year, and which always frightened her far more than the fear of being caught.

"Say yes," he said.

"Yes," she said.

"To Warsaw."

"To wherever you are sent," she said; and because that was not quite what he had asked, and because she understood what he had asked, she added, smiling, with her hand out for his: "You will have to buy me a coat."

"You have four coats."

"I shall need a fifth. For the east."

He laughed, and pulled her up out of the chair, and put her hand on his arm, and took her back into the ballroom, and the orchestra was playing something from the year before the war, and in the middle of the room four couples were dancing, and a general of artillery was being told something funny by a Frenchman with a red face, and the woman with the sweet face was finishing a plate of oysters with the neat, quick, terrible appetite of a small bird, and the whole room smelled of perfume and roasting and pine and cigarette smoke, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked into it on the arm of the man who had just given her the price of a house and told her, in a German drawing room in the fourth year of the war, that she was the one thing in his life that was pleasant.

She danced twice, once with him and once with a general, and then, at half past one, with a young captain of engineers called Weiler, who had been amusing her at table with the story of a bridge at Orléans that had been built nine centimetres too narrow and had needed a Frenchman to be arrested for it, which he told entirely without malice, as an engineering anecdote, and which she had found, over three courses, to be one of the more revealing things she had heard that week.

He was not a bad dancer and he was twenty-eight, and he smelled of shaving soap rather than of saddle soap, and in the middle of the last turn he said, confidentially, with his hand flat on her back in the correct position, "Every man in this room hates me at this moment. You are aware of that."

"I am aware that it is Christmas."

"That is a much kinder way of putting it than the Colonel will."

The Colonel was twenty feet away at the edge of the floor with a glass in his hand, talking to a major of the Luftwaffe, and he watched them for the length of the turn and not longer, and when the music stopped she thanked the captain and left him in the middle of the floor and came, on her own, without being fetched, back to the man whose hand on her waist was the deed to her.

"Have a good time," von Hagen said.

"I have had a good time."

"That is the third word you have used for it."

"It is the only one there is."

He put his glass down on a table without looking at the table, which was a thing he did to tell her that he was angry. "Weiler is a fool. His father made the family's money in potash in the nineties and the son builds bridges for the infantry. When he is posted to Russia, he will be dead by March, and he will spend his last week writing letters about the width of roads." He turned and looked at her with an expression of perfect courtesy. "If you would like to dance with him again, my dear, you may. Nobody in this building would think anything at all. It is a party, and you are the decoration, and the decoration is permitted to be turned."

She had learned, in six months, that the way to survive this particular move was not to apologise, since apology implies a fault, and not to defend, since defence implies an accusation; the way to survive it was to become dull.

"I am tired," she said. "If you would let me call the car."

He looked at her a moment longer with the courtesy in place, and then he took out his watch and looked at it, and said, mildly, "Rutz is at the side door. My coat is the one with the fur collar. Wait in the car."

❦

At the side door on the rue Dumont d'Urville, the car was standing with its engine running and its headlamps masked to two slits, and the breath of it went up in the cold in a long white wedge, and Emil Rutz was standing beside the rear door with his greatcoat buttoned to the chin and his cap on, holding the door open against the wind for a lady who had not yet come.

Rutz had been with the Colonel four years, and with the German army twelve, and before that he had been with a baker in a village near Bamberg whose name he said in the way other men said the name of a country. He was forty-one and heavy in the shoulder and soft in the middle, and he had a photograph of a niece behind the windscreen of the Mercedes and a wife in Bavaria who wrote to him every fortnight in a hand that got smaller each year.

"Fräulein Marion."

"Emil. It is very cold."

"It is very cold," he agreed, in the tone of a man who has said this sentence forty times since October and will say it forty times more, and he held the door and then, because she was early and there was nothing to do, he took out of his tunic the small black notebook he kept there, and licked his thumb, and wrote in it.

She had seen the notebook before. Everyone in the house had seen the notebook: the car's mileage, the hours of the sentries, the bottles of wine drawn from the cellar, the days on which the silver was counted, the days on which the laundry went out. A German orderly's day book is the most boring document in Europe and it is also, in the hands of the right reader, the most complete: it records every movement of every person in a house, in order, in a small careful hand, for four years.

He wrote the hour, and she watched him do it, from a metre and a half away, with her hands in her muff, in the light of the masked headlamps.

He wrote: Fr. Marion, abgeholt 1.35.

He looked up from the notebook while his pen was still on the paper, and his eyes came over the page and met hers, and he knew that she had read it — had watched him write it, in fact, which was worse, because it made the reading deliberate — and the two of them stood there in the cold at the side door of the Hôtel Majestic with two hundred and forty Germans and a French orchestra on the other side of the wall and the car's breath going up white between them.

Then Rutz closed the notebook and put it back in the tunic pocket over his heart, and said, "It is only the hours, Fräulein. The Colonel wishes to know when the car is used. It is the petrol."

"Of course," she said.

"Yes," said Rutz, and looked at the pavement, and then at the street, and then, at some length, at the small buckle on the car door, which did not need looking at. He had never in

four years been anything but correct with her, and he was not being incorrect now: he was being a man with a wife in Bavaria and a photograph of a niece and no politics at all, standing in a cold street, having just written down the hour at which a woman left a building, and knowing — as every servant in every occupied country in Europe knew everything and said nothing — that this hour, and the eleven other hours like it in the book, were the beginning of a document.

"Fräulein Marion," he said, "you have not got your stole."

She had not. It was inside, in the charge of a nearly blind old woman in a grey overall with a brass ticket, and the reason she had gone back into the building at all.

She went back into the building, and along the corridor, and the rest of it happened in a service corridor in the half-dark with a little brass ticket in her hand, and a man on the top step of a staircase who said her name.

❦

The side corridor at the Majestic was the corridor the waiters used and the officers used to smoke in, and at half past one in the morning it had four waiters in it, all of them sober, all of them French, all of them standing in the attitude of men who are counting the hours, and she went along it to the cloakroom to fetch her stole, which was in the charge of an old woman in a grey overall who took the ticket and looked at it for a long time because she was nearly blind, and it was while she was standing there, in the half-dark of a service corridor, with the pearls under her chin and the little

brass ticket in her hand, that she heard the boots on the marble and turned and saw the man at the top of the stairs.

He was in the uniform of a captain, and he was holding his cap in both hands in front of him in the way of a man who has just come in out of the cold, and he was standing absolutely still, and he was looking at her.

He was not looking at her the way men looked at her at the Majestic. He was not looking at the dress, or the pearls, or the mouth. He was standing on the top step of a staircase in a German administrative building in Paris with his cap in his hands and his face doing nothing at all, and he was looking at her the way a man looks at a door that he has spent four years believing was bricked up.

She had, over the previous six months, been looked at by perhaps eleven thousand German officers, and she had a system for it, and every part of the system had stopped working, all at once, like a clock that has been dropped.

The captain opened his mouth.

Somebody on the other side of the corridor said Herr Brandt, the Colonel has been asking after you, and the man at the top of the stairs did not move and did not look away and said, in a voice that was entirely level and about two degrees off the temperature of the building, one word.

"Krystyna."

CHAPTER FIVE

The Boy Who Kept Her Name

❦

The corridor was eleven metres long and had four doors in it and a mirror at the far end, and in the mirror she could see the two of them: a captain of the Abwehr on the top step with his cap in his hands, and a woman with a pearl necklace standing in front of a cloakroom counter with a brass ticket in her fingers, and between them, on the wall, a French clock of the sort that the German administration did not bother to wind.

She had exactly one second, and she used it the way she had been taught to use a second: she took in his hands, his boots, the absence of a ring, the way he stood, the way he had said the word, and she arrived at three possible answers and rejected two of them, and then she heard her own voice come out of her, warm, unhurried, with a lift at the end of it, in the accent of a woman who had been brought up in Vienna by a notary and badly educated in Lausanne by a woman from Bern.

"I beg your pardon?"

The captain did not move.

"You have the advantage of me," she said. "I am afraid I do not—" and she let the sentence trail, and smiled the specific smile that had been built for exactly this, in a room above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement, over four

days, in front of a mirror, while a girl from Lille watched her and told her when the eyes went wrong.

The man came down the two steps and stopped three metres from her, and the old woman in the grey overall, who had been listening with the total attention of the nearly blind, pushed the counter flap down and shuffled out to the far end of the corridor to be nearer to whatever was going to happen.

"My apologies," he said, in French, with an accent that had been formed in a classroom in Warsaw and corrected in Hamburg, and which she had last heard in an orchard with the flies going up off a pond in the summer of 1939. "You are extremely like someone I knew. It is a great impertinence."

"It is not the first time," she said. "I have one of those faces."

"You have not got one of those faces."

"Then I am sorry to be a disappointment."

"You are not," he said, and he looked at her for one more second, and then he did the thing that took the whole of her professional armour off her, the way a man takes a coat off a chair: he stopped. He stopped looking, and he bowed his head an inch, and he stepped back, and he said, "I hope you will forgive me. I have just come off a train."

And she stood there with her pearls and her ticket and her training, and she understood that she had walked out of the room in which she was safe. Because a man who insists is a fool, and a fool can be managed; and a man who is embarrassed is a gentleman, and a gentleman can be lied to; and

this man had stopped, not because he believed her, but because he had decided — she watched him decide it, in a corridor, at half past one in the morning — that being mistaken was a thing he could afford and being certain was not.

"Fräulein Herschlag," said a voice behind her, and there was the Colonel, come out of the ballroom with his coat over his arm and his hat in his hand, in a good humour, which was the most dangerous of his four moods, and he took in the scene in the way he took in everything, in a single pass, and drew the conclusion that any other man in his position would have drawn. "Brandt. So it is you that the whole building has been waiting for. My dear, this is Hauptmann Brandt, of the intelligence section; he has come back from Paris with the Lutetia's paperwork and a reputation, and he has been at my table three times this winter without managing to be introduced to you, which I am told is a symptom."

"Colonel."

"Herr Brandt." Von Hagen put his hat on the cloakroom counter and looked from one of them to the other with the mild, proprietary amusement of a man who has brought two things he owns into the same room. "You are the Polish speaker. My mistress has just been saying something to you in French, which means you have made a mistake already. She is Austrian and her French is a scandal and she refuses to be corrected."

"It is not the French," said Phillip Brandt. "It is the impertinence. I thought Fräulein Herschlag was someone I had known in Warsaw before the war, and I said so, and I have been apologising for it."

"You have been in Warsaw?"

"I was born in Warsaw," Phillip said. "My father is a German engineer. We left in October 1939, when the city was still burning, which is a thing one does not forget, and I have been correcting the French on their Polish place names ever since, for which they are grateful about once a year."

And von Hagen laughed, and put his hand on her back — the hand, the whole hand, the whole of the deed — and said, "There. My dear, it is the same old story. Everybody in this building came out of some city in flames, and on a good evening you can hear four different nationalities lying about their childhoods in one room. You shall dance with him, and he shall tell you about the Poles, and you shall tell him about the confectioner on the Rennweg. Come."

The band played. Three of them stood by the tall window at the end of the ballroom, where the rain had stopped and the black glass carried a yellow smear of the city on it: the Colonel with his hand on the small of her back, the captain with his cap under his arm, and herself between them; and they talked for four minutes, and she counted every one of them.

"You have been to Warsaw," von Hagen said. "Who is at the top of the building now? I have a file in the office that says Frank has too many cooks."

"Fischer has the labour section and Koppe has the police, and neither can be told anything by the other, and the two of them sit on the same telephone exchange, which is a fact the office finds interesting." Phillip said it flatly, as an inventory. "The civil administration considers Warsaw a colonisation. The security people consider it a problem of or-

der. The two positions are incompatible and the incompatibility has been allowed to run since 1940, and the reason is that both men have an ear of the Führer, in different ears."

"You see," said von Hagen, to her, with the satisfaction of a man showing off a horse. "This is what I tell you. There is no plan. There is a collection of ambitions wearing a plan."

"There is a plan," said Phillip. "It is the plan of a man who does not write it down. The Warsaw district reports every three weeks, and every report says the city is quiet. It was quiet in February and it was quiet in April and it is quiet now. That does not mean anything except that the people who write our reports are told what to see."

"Ugh," said von Hagen. "You are a pessimist. My dear, we have with us the most reliable pessimist in the Militärbefehlshaber's service, and he is on loan from the east because nobody in this building can tell a Polish address from a Czech one." He took a glass from a tray and put it into Phillip's hand without asking. "But explain something to me, Brandt, since I have never had it explained. Why is it that a Pole will salute you one day and shoot at you the next? The Czechs, the Danes, the Dutch — they are all in the business of surviving. A Pole is in the business of Poland. Where does that come from?"

"It comes from the fact that Poland has been occupied for a hundred and forty years by three countries and never once stopped being Poland," Phillip said. "A man in Kraków has been in a conspiracy since he was fourteen. His father was in a conspiracy. His mother has a hiding place behind the stove that was built in 1863." He drank. "Your question

is why he does not behave like a Dutchman. The answer is that the Dutchman's history is a different history. It is not a compliment to anybody. It is the shape of the place."

"And you have a Polish mother," said von Hagen, pleasantly.

"I have a Polish mother and a German father, and my father's firm laid the tram rails in Warsaw, and I have spent my life with one foot in each of them, and at present I am standing in a ballroom in Paris being asked by an Oberst to explain a country he has no intention of entering." Phillip said all of it with a deadpan, agreeable courtesy, and drank, and looked at her for exactly as long as the last clause took. "You will understand, Fräulein, that I am often not invited twice."

She laughed, because that was the correct response and because laughing was a labour she had performed four hundred times; and inside the laugh, behind it, in the load-bearing room of her, she was doing something else entirely.

He had said, in the course of those four minutes, three things that were checks and one thing that was not.

The checks: a street by the Vistula, an aunt who grew a lemon tree in a tub, the courtyard of the Institute of the Sacred Heart. He had put each of them into the soft places of his own sentences, where a woman who had been at school in Vienna could answer them and a woman who had been born in Warsaw could recognise them, and he had watched her face while the questions went past without changing his own expression at all. And she had answered Vienna, three times, in her Austrian voice, with charming, vague, entirely false details.

Not one of the three satisfied him. She saw that; she saw him file the fact; she understood that she had just been read, thoroughly, by a man wearing a captain's collar who was asking a colonel about the labour section, and she understood something else, which was that he had done it kindly. There had been no trap in it. He had wanted to know and had asked the only way he could ask in a room with a chandelier in it.

But the fourth thing was not a check.

Somewhere in the middle, while von Hagen was talking about the Polish character, Phillip had said half a sentence in German about his mother, and had stopped, and had finished his glass rather than finish the sentence; and she had seen, in that half-second, that he did not know whether his mother was alive or dead, and that he had been carrying the not-knowing for four years in the same way she carried hers. Then the orchestra came back up, and von Hagen put his glass on the tray of a passing waiter, and said, "There. Now. You shall dance with my Marion, Brandt, so that the whole building can watch you do it and be envious," and Phillip said, "If Fräulein Herschlag permits," and she said, "I permit everything that is permitted," which was a sentence she had used before and which nobody had ever found odd, because it sounded like coquetry and was in fact a very exact statement of policy.

❦

They danced.

In the ballroom, at ten past two in the morning, to a slow thing from The Merry Widow played by eleven

Frenchmen who had been playing it since September, a captain of the Wehrmacht and the mistress of an Oberst of the Militärbefehlshaber took one turn round a floor with two hundred and forty people on the edges of it, and the floor was crowded for the first twenty seconds and empty for the rest, because it was very late and people were leaving and because there is nothing in the world so interesting to a room full of Germans as a woman they have all assessed dancing with a man they have not.

He held her correctly: his right hand flat on her shoulder-blade, his left closed round hers, no pressure, the whole distance of four centimetres between them that is the correct distance, and he danced in the German way, which is to say extremely correctly, with the counting visible.

For eleven seconds neither of them said anything.

"You are not," he said at last, in German, quietly, with his eyes above her shoulder.

"Not what?"

"Not saying anything," Phillip Brandt said. "The Krystyna Stankiewiczówna I used to know would have had four sentences by now, and at least one of them would have been insulting."

She looked up at him. He was twenty-six, and he had a fine line at the left eye that had not been there at twenty-two, and he had shaved closely and inexpertly at the jaw, and he was holding her hand the way a man holds a document he intends to give back.

"Nine of them," she said, in Polish. "I have nine sentences. I have been keeping them for four years and they have all gone stale."

She heard his breath go, once, on the word years.

"That is not them."

"No. That is not them."

They made the turn at the end of the room and came back, past the general of artillery, who was drinking champagne and telling a Frenchman something about 1914, past the wife of the man who had ordered the deportations of August, who was eating a last marron glacé with the neat, terrible appetite of a small bird, past two majors of the Luftwaffe standing in the middle of the floor discussing a film, past the door where Emil Rutz was waiting with a coat.

"How long?" he said.

"Since when?"

"It is half past two in the morning in a German building," Phillip said, "and in four minutes the orchestra will stop. The well at Wierzbów. The one by the orchard, with the rope, where the bucket sticks at eleven metres and you have to let it down twice. Do you remember it?"

She did not answer him. They finished the dance. He let go of her, three centimetres, four, and stepped back and bowed, and she stood with her hands at her sides in a ballroom in Paris in December 1943, and he turned and walked to the door without looking back, and she went to the chair where the Colonel was putting on his coat, and stood there and said something amusing about the width of the bridge at Orléans, and got into the car, and rode home along the avenue Henri-Martin with her cheek six inches from a shoulder that she could have bitten through.

❦

At the villa the Colonel was in a good humour and wanted her, in the undemanding, proprietorial way of a man who has had a great deal of wine and a great deal of applause and considers that the evening belongs to him; and afterwards he lay on his back with his forearm over his eyes and returned to the subject of Brandt.

"A clever fellow," he said. "The kind of clever that never gets promoted. He has a Polish mother and a Polish accent in German and no party, and he will be forty-five and a Hauptmann, and he will be a very useful analyst for somebody."

"Then why is he an officer?"

"Because his father signed a paper." He yawned enormously. "The whole trick of the east, my dear, is that there is always a paper. Give a man a paper and he will sign it and then he will serve you for four years out of shame, and it costs nothing, and it is the most economical invention of the century."

She lay beside him in the dark of the avenue Henri-Martin and looked at the cornicing with the hundred leaves and the last four botched, and she thought, with the exact, hard, professional attention she had brought to a sheet of blotting paper at three o'clock in the morning three weeks earlier, about a boy in an orchard with a bucket and a rope.

The orchard had been her father's, at Wierzbów, the estate that had been in the family since 1796 and had gone to the bank in the summer of 1939, the year the mortgage ate it, and the well had been on the south side, eleven metres of

it, with a wooden cover and a rope that had been renewed in 1936 and a bucket that stuck at eleven metres where the shaft narrowed, and the reason she knew the bucket stuck at eleven metres was that she and her brother and a boy called Phillip Brandt, who was the son of the German engineer at the Lilpop works in Warsaw and who had been brought to the estate in a motorcar for the shooting, had spent the whole of a September afternoon in 1938 letting it up and down to watch it stick.

If you have ever stood at a well and watched a person you are twenty and in love with lean over it, you will know that there is nothing in the world you can be told about the well afterwards. She had never told anybody about the well. She had never told Wiktor, who had asked her, in 1942, in a room above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement, in the course of nine weeks of questions designed to find out what she would say under pressure, to describe her childhood, and she had described the palace on Nowy Świat and the school and the winters, and she had left out the well, and had noticed herself leaving it out, and had put the noticing away with the other things.

At four o'clock in the morning she got up and used the bathroom, and washed her hands, and stood looking at her face in the glass.

Then she went back to the bedroom and sat on the edge of the bed with her feet on the cold floor, and did what she always did when there was a thing she could not put away.

She made the plan.

The plan took eleven minutes and had four parts: where he lived; when he was at work; how to be in a room with him without being seen to be in a room with him; and how, on the day the fourth part became necessary, it would be done. She knew a man in the twentieth arrondissement — a Polish deserter from the Wehrmacht who had been in the network's hands and gone rotten in the way of some of them, and who was paid in francs and silence — and a Hauptmann of the intelligence section who was found dead in a stairwell in the sixteenth arrondissement in December 1943 would be a page of German paper, an investigation, an SD file with clean spectacles reading it, and eleven arrests among the porters and charwomen of a building that had nothing to do with any of it.

She sat there on the edge of the bed in the dark and ran the whole of it, four times, and at the end of the fourth run she lay down, because there is no decision to make at four in the morning that cannot be made worse by making it at four in the morning, and because she had learned in 1940 that the finest of all the network's rules was the last one on the list, the one they had printed in tiny type at the bottom of the last page of the manual: sleep.

❦

What she remembered, when she let herself, was not a scene. It was four of them, and she kept them in order, the way you keep four cards you have decided not to look at.

The horse: a chestnut mare called Bella with a white sock on the near fore and a habit of leaning her shoulder into a gate, which she had ridden every summer from the

age of eight to the age of eighteen on the estate at Wierzbów, and which had been sold in the autumn of 1937, when the beet money failed for the second year, to a stud farm near Sandomierz; and the estate itself went to the bank in the summer of 1939, and the buyer from Poznań pulled down the north wing in 1941, and none of that matters now, which was always the point of the horse. It was the least important of the four and it was the one that came first, always, because it was the one that did not hurt.

The birch wood: September 1938, the second week, the light coming down through the leaves in long yellow slats onto the path, and the smell of leaf mould after a week of rain, and the two of them walking the horses because they had been out an hour and the flies were bad. He had been twenty-one and had arrived the evening before with his father, who had come about the mortgage, and had spent the whole of the first evening at the end of the table being courteous in the way of a boy who has been raised to be courteous and who would rather be somewhere else. And in the wood, on the second day, he had stopped in front of her in the middle of a sentence about her brother's terrible French and had not kissed her, and had stood there with the mare's reins in his hand and his ears entirely red, and she had said, "Well?" — and he had laughed, and it had happened.

The wrist: the same afternoon, in the same wood. He had put his hand on the back of her neck while she was standing at a tree with her forehead against the bark, and had asked her something in a voice that had gone low, and she had taken hold of his wrist, above the joint, with her

thumb over the tendon, and had turned it and pushed, the way her father's riding master had once shown her when she was twelve and told her never to do it to a man in jest, and Phillip had gone down onto one knee in the leaves with his mouth open and his breath gone out of him, and had looked up at her from the ground with an expression of something that she had not understood properly for two years and that she understood now, in a bedroom on the avenue Henri-Martin, at the age of twenty-four, entirely.

And the fourth card, which she did not turn over.

It was the reason she had spent the last hour of the night with paper and pencil, working out the address of a hotel and the hours of a man, instead of the reason a person normally has for working out such things; and it was the reason that at some point in the next four months — she put the point at some time in the spring, and was wrong about it by eleven days — the two of them were going to have to have a conversation that would end either with him dead or with the two of them in a canal.

She held the four cards for a while, in order, and then put them away. Outside, the blacked-out city with its slit headlamps went on making the small, ordinary, dead noises of a city in its fourth winter, and beside her, in the bed, a German colonel turned over and put his hand out and found nothing, and slept again.

She slept for forty minutes and woke to the bell at the service door, and lay still while the maid's feet went along the corridor and stopped, and listened to the murmur and the door and the feet going back, one set of them, and a

second set that was the cook's, and the low laugh that servants make at half past four in the morning at the expense of whoever is at the door.

She got up at five, because there was no more sleeping to be had, and went down the back stairs into the servants' hall in her dressing gown, and the cook was at the range with her back to the room and the kitchen maid was shelling something grey into a bowl, and the cook said, without turning round, "Fräulein. There is a letter for you on the tray."

"Who brought it?"

"A young man. He came to the door at twenty to four, and he would not come in, and he would not take anything, and he gave me this and he said, 'For Fräulein Herschlag, from the florist's,' and there is no florist open at twenty to four in this city, Fräulein, and then he said, 'There is nothing to pay,' which was also not necessary." The cook turned round, and looked at her with the long, level, unshockable scrutiny of French servants in German houses, who have been asked to understand a great deal and who have understood all of it. "He was very polite. He had a German coat on. He was not French. He went up the street on foot in the dark, and my niece's husband is a policeman in Neuilly, Fräulein, and I could have had him followed out of pure professional curiosity, and I did not, and that is a favour, and you may consider what it is worth."

"Thank you, Madame Berthaud."

"Then take it up before Rutz comes down. He is tidier than the Colonel and he notices the tray."

The envelope was cheap, the wartime kind, grey, of paper that had been made of straw and would not take ink; and somebody had written on it in pencil, at a café table or a bar or the top of a wall, in a hand she had last seen on a school exercise book that had been left in the hall of the house at Wierzbów with a silver pencil on top of it in the summer of 1939, two words and an initial.

M. Herschlag.

She did not open it in the servants' hall. She took it up to the bathroom, at the top of the house, where there was a small window with black paint on the glass and one bulb and a lock, and she sat on the edge of the bath in her dressing gown and opened it, and the inside was one sentence in Polish, in the same hand, written with a nib that had been pressed too hard.

I have kept it for four years. I can keep it longer.

It was not signed with a name. It did not need to be.

She sat on the edge of the bath with the paper in both hands and understood, in the way in which one understands things in the fifth year of a war, that the envelope was the second sentence, and that it was the more dangerous of the two. There was no postmark on it, no stamp, no boy from a telegraph office and no man from a courier's van: it had been carried to the service door of a requisitioned German house on the avenue Henri-Martin, at twenty minutes to four in the morning, by hand, by a captain of the Militärbefehlshaber's intelligence section, on foot, in a German coat, and handed to a French cook with two lies about a florist, with two sentries forty metres away at the gate, at

the hour when the sentry on the gravel makes his eleventh-minute round past the statue of the stag and stops to work his feet in his boots.

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At twenty to seven she was in the side chapel on the rue Saint-Honoré, in the fourth row, with her hat on and her hands in her lap, and the priest came out to the altar and did what he did at the altar, and then he came down the side and sat in the chair in front of her, and put his hands on his knees, and waited.

She gave him the memorandum. The coastal-sector number, the inspection schedule, the coastal battery's firing table, the two dates, the name of the officer who was coming from Berlin to do the inspecting and the fact that he had been in Warsaw in October. She gave it in order, in Polish, in a low voice, without notes, twice, because that was the rule; and she gave him, after it, the small change of the week: the eleventh department, the contractor's cement prices, the two of them lying about their childhoods at the Christmas party, the carol, the pearls.

"And the ball?" said the priest.

"There were two hundred and forty people. There will be an illustrated paper."

"Good. That is a good week." He looked at her. He had a big, calm, ugly face and the hands of a man who had done manual work before the seminary, and he had been a chaplain in the Polish army in 1920, and there was nothing in his face that could be hurried. "And?"

"And nothing."

"You have come in from a night that you have not described to me, and you have given me a very good memorandum, and you have told me four things about a party, and there is something standing behind you at this moment that I can see from here, and you are not going to tell me what it is." He said it without any weight at all, in the tone of a man reading the weather. "That is your right. But I will tell you the rule, Marion, because I am old and because you have been in the trade for three years and I have been in it for twenty-five. The rule is that nobody is ever caught by the thing they decided to tell. They are caught by the thing they decided not to."

"I know."

"Then you know. And I will not ask again, and if you come to me in a week and tell me, I will listen, and if you never tell me, I will still be here at this hour, and if you tell me a lie I will know it, and that is the end of the conversation." He took the folded devotional leaflet out of his sleeve and put it in her hands, the same grey leaflet against the same grey paper, with the same instruction inside it: the drop on Thursday, the man with the striped scarf, the hour, the second hour if he did not come.

She got up to go.

"Marion."

"Holy Father?"

"Say the name to yourself," the priest said. "Whatever it is. Say it in the street, once, quietly, and then put it away. A name that has been said out loud once is a name you can carry; a name you have never said out loud is a hook in the

mouth, and it will pull you wherever it likes." He turned his hands over on his knees. "I do not want to know it. Go and be foolish somewhere else, and come back on Thursday."

She went out into the rue Saint-Honoré at seven in the morning of the twenty-fourth of December 1943, into a cold grey light and the smell of a bakery and the sound of a nun's bicycle bell, with a bouquet of evergreen and white ribbon under the arm of a market porter she passed, and the whole city getting up in a language that was not its own; and she put her hand in her pocket, and touched the corner of the envelope, and did not take it out; and she said nothing to anybody; and she did not go to Wiktor, and she did not go to the woman in the twentieth arrondissement, and she did not write a line of it down.

She walked east along the rue de Rivoli with her hat down against the wind, and by the time she reached the Place des Pyramides she had already begun to be late for a fitting, and she had not said the name once, not once, not even inside her own skull, and she was twenty-four years old and carrying it the way a person carries a small, warm, illegal thing: carefully, and in the left hand, and against the skin — and there is no name for that hour of the morning in a war, when you have decided a thing without deciding it, except that in the Polish it is ta godzina, the hour, and in French there is no word at all, and the boy who had said her name in a corridor at half past one in the morning was the only other person alive who knew which one she meant.

CHAPTER SIX

Wierzbów

❦

The Mission on the rue Saint-Honoré had a chapel that had been built in 1730 for the use of a convent of nuns who had been turned out of it in 1905, and it had been repainted twice since then, and the paint was the colour of weak tea, and there was a smell in it of cold stone and wet wool and candle wax that had been burned and re-burned for two centuries; and on the twenty-seventh of December 1943 Krystyna Stankiewiczówna sat in the fourth row on the right with her hat on and her hands in her lap, and said the list.

She said it the way she had said it since the winter of 1939, in the order in which the names had come to her, which was not an order that meant anything: Zofia; Jerzy; Wiktor; Aunt Jadwiga; Maria Brandt; Albrecht Brandt; the woman in the flat above who had had a canary; the girl from the Institute who had been called Wanda and who had had the first bicycle in the school; and, since the second of December, a girl of sixteen in a grey skirt with a cardigan, whose name she did not know and never would, who had come down the steps of a building in the rue de la Pompe with her hair down and her mother's fur coming off one shoulder.

No verbs. That was the method, and she had arrived at it herself, in a cold room in Warsaw in the first winter, and

she had kept it, and it had never once failed her: if you say the names without verbs, they stay names. The moment you put a verb in, you have decided something about them, and the deciding is a lie, because you do not know. So: Zofia. Jerzy. Wiktor. She said them into the smell of wet wool and candle wax, without a verb, three times, and then she said the last one, the one she had added on Christmas Day: Phillip.

The priest had said to say the name out loud once. She had chosen to say it in a list, in a church, among the dead, which was the Catholic way of doing it and also, she recognised, the coward's way, since a list is a place where a name can hide.

Afterwards she stayed on the stone bench at the back and watched two old women and a boy light candles and the boy's mother hold his wrist to steady it, and she thought about the fact that she had, on the twenty-fourth, twenty-fifth and twenty-sixth of December, gone nowhere and done nothing, and had eaten Christmas dinner at the villa on the avenue Henri-Martin at a table with the Colonel, two of his officers, and a French prefect who had talked for an hour and a half about the quality of the soil in the Beauce, and had been, for those three days, the best-liked woman in Paris: had sung, had danced, had made the prefect laugh, had held the elbow of a Luftwaffe major while he told her about his mother, and had told the priest a lie on Thursday at the drop and given him a memorandum with one line missing from it.

One line. That was the whole of it, and it was small, and she had done it with a steady hand: the line about a captain

of the intelligence section, seconded from the east, who had been at the Majestic on the night of the twenty-third, and who was the son of the engineer who had built the tram rails in Warsaw, and who had said her name. It was the kind of line that a woman can justify six ways, and she had justified it six ways, and she had not slept.

❦

The estate at Wierzbów was thirty-one kilometres from Warsaw, on the flat land, in a country of willows and sugar beet and bad roads, and it had belonged to the Stankiewicz family since 1796, when a great-grandfather had bought it with money made in the salt trade at Wieliczka and had put up a house with a portico and four columns and twelve windows across the front; and by 1938 it had a roof that leaked over the north wing, a mortgage of four hundred and ten thousand zlotys held by a bank in Poznań, and a man called Antoni who kept the boilers and the keys and the three remaining horses, and who was sixty-eight years old and had known Krystyna's grandmother, and who kept the accounts in a hand that had not changed since 1904.

The reason the German engineer's family was at Wierzbów in September 1938 was the mortgage.

That is the whole explanation and it has no romance in it at all. Albrecht Brandt was the technical director of Lilpop, Rau i Loewenstein in Warsaw — the great ironworks on the Burakowska, where they made railway axles and diesel engines and had begun, that year, to make the fire-control equipment for the coastal batteries under a licence from a German firm — and he was also, since 1935, a member of

the board of a Poznań bank, and the Poznań bank was the holder of the Stankiewicz mortgage; and the mortgage had been renewed in 1937 with a personal surety from Jerzy Stankiewicz, who was Krystyna's father and who had been, all his life, a man of the salon and the hunting field and the table and not of the ledger.

Her father had invited the engineer to the shoot because the engineer could save him, and he had invited him in the week in September when the partridges were good and the leaves had begun to go, and he had invited him with his wife and his son, and he had put them in the north wing, under the leaking roof, because the north wing had been done up in 1936 with money that had been about to become the bank's.

Maria Brandt was a Polish woman from a family of Warsaw doctors, and had married a German in 1911 against the wishes of her mother, and had lived in Warsaw since; and she spoke Polish to her husband when she was tired and German when she was angry, and she had a small room in the house on Hoża Street with photographs and a piano and a fern, and she had been, in the year 1938, a woman of fifty-three with a bad heart who had made her peace with everything except two things: that her son had been educated in Dresden and that he had, in the spring of that year, joined a firm of attorneys in Berlin for a year's training because his father had arranged it.

And Phillip Brandt, who was twenty-one in September 1938, was a tall, thin, untidy young man with his mother's eyes and his father's hands, who had read everything and re-

tained about a third of it, who could quote a Polish poem and then spoil it by explaining the metre, who had been considered by the examining board at Dresden to have a good mind and no aptitude, and who had told his father at Christmas 1937 that he intended to be an engineer "but not yet," which was the sentence the two of them had been arguing about ever since.

He had come to Wierzbów with a suitcase containing four books, one of which was a Polish translation of an English poet, and a folder of the translator's correspondence, because he had written to the translator from Berlin in July with eleven objections and had received a reply in August; and on the second evening of the shoot, after dinner, in the library, with the deal table covered in the estate's papers and the whole house's worth of cigarette smoke, he had been discovered by Krystyna Stankiewiczówna standing at the shelf with the folder open, saying out loud, to nobody: "It is not that he has no ear. It is that he has an ear for the wrong language."

She was eighteen, and would be nineteen in November. She was in a borrowed coat because her own had been sent to Warsaw to be re-lined and had not come back, and she had spent the day in the field with the beaters' fires and had shot nothing and had been perfectly happy, and she had come into the library to find a book, and there was a young man she had been introduced to at luncheon talking to a shelf, and she stood in the doorway and laughed.

He turned round, without embarrassment, in the manner of a person who had already, at the age of twenty-one,

decided that being overheard was a thing that happened. "Not the poet," he said. "The translator. He has put an English rain into Polish with Polish words for rain, and they are not the same rain. He would have done better to write it as a Polish rain and be accused of translation. That is my objection number four and I have sent it to a man in Kraków who will not answer me."

"He will answer you," said Krystyna.

"Why?"

"Because he is Polish and you are rude, and the two of them together mean he will spend an afternoon on it."

And Phillip Brandt had looked at her with an expression she had never afterwards been able to describe except as the face of a person who has been given a present by a stranger, and had said, "Yes. That is exactly what will happen," and had cleared the papers off the second chair with one sweep of his arm in a way that told her the whole of his education and half of his father.

She sat down. They talked until one in the morning, and she found him funny, and she never forgave herself for it, and she never told anybody about it either, because the fact that it had been the talking that did it — not the face, not the hands, not the way he stood in a doorway — was a fact about the girl she had been that she did not want to have in the file.

❦

Five scenes, and none of them a declaration.

One. The horse she could not ride. There was a bay gelding in the stable called Kajtek, and he had a habit of

crossing his jaw against the bit and taking the bit and going sideways with his head down, and on the third afternoon she was thrown from him into a beet field, in front of the whole shoot, which is the exact sort of thing that happens to a person at eighteen. She came up out of the beet with earth in her collar and her hat gone and her shoulder stiff, and they caught the horse four hundred metres away, and it was Phillip who caught him, and who then did not hand her the reins; he took the girth strap in his hand, and ran his thumb along the buckle, and looked at it, and moved it two holes, and said, "The saddle was on the wrong rib. Somebody has been putting it on the wrong rib for years, and the horse has been telling you so."

She rode Kajtek that evening for an hour and a half with the saddle in the right place, and the horse went the way she had always known he could go, and something in her, which had been told all her life that horses were a matter of nerve, adjusted by two holes and a thumb and a boy who looked at the tack.

Two. The well. It was on the south side of the house beyond the orchard, under a lime tree, with a wooden cover and a windlass and a rope renewed the year before, and the shaft went down eleven metres, and at eleven metres there was a narrowing where the brick had been relaid in 1918, and the bucket stuck on the narrowing, always, unless you let it down twice with a slack turn on the second, which was a thing her brother had shown her in 1933 and which nobody else in the house knew.

On the fourth day, in the late afternoon, she took Phillip to fetch water because the kitchen had run out and the girl was busy. She let the bucket down, and it stuck, and she let it down again with the slack turn, and it filled, and she brought it up with two hands on the windlass and the whole of her back, and set it on the stone, and drank out of the dipper and gave it to him; and he drank, and wiped his mouth with his wrist, and said, "You knew it would stick."

"There is a narrowing at eleven metres."

"How do you know there is a narrowing at eleven metres?"

"Because I put a stone in it in 1934 and counted until I heard the bottom, and then I climbed down to twelve on the rope, with Antoni swearing at me from up here, and looked at it." She said it as a fact about a well. She did not say the other reason, which was that she had never told anyone in her life about the narrowing, including her brother, and that she had told him in the fourth day of knowing him, and that she had done it on purpose, in the same minute in which she had decided it, and that this was the way in which she, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, went about the business of falling in love: by handing over a fact that had no value to anybody except as a small piece of her.

Three. The lanterns. Her mother had a gramophone and fourteen records, and on the last Saturday of September, because there were guests, there was supper on the terrace under lanterns that had been in the family since the days of the salt money, and after supper somebody wound the gramophone and they played the records one after an-

other, and there was a tango, and the whole party — the engineer, the mother, two neighbours from Radziejowice, an uncle, the priest from the parish and his sister — watched a girl of eighteen and a boy of twenty-one dance it on a terrace in Mazovia, in the September of 1938, under lanterns, to a record with a scratch in it; and the boy could not dance the tango and made no attempt to conceal it, and the girl taught him the four steps in the middle of the music, correcting him with her hand on his upper arm, which is a gesture that everybody in the party understood and only one of them objected to.

The engineer did not object. That was the thing that Krystyna remembered about it, at twenty-four, on the bench at the back of a chapel in Paris: Albrecht Brandt sat in a wicker chair with his coffee and his cigar, a heavy, quiet man of fifty-six with a gold watch chain, and watched his son be taught a tango by a Polish landowner's daughter, and said nothing at all, and looked — twice, in the course of the evening, and she had seen both times, because at eighteen a person sees everything and understands nothing — looked along the terrace at the mortgage papers in his portmanteau on the table in the library.

Four. The birch wood, and the wrist. That has been told once already, in a bedroom in Paris, in four sentences, by a woman doing arithmetic at four o'clock in the morning; and it is not going to be told again here, except for the part that matters, which is that when she let go of his wrist and he got up off his knees in the leaves with his face entirely white and his breath whistling, he laughed — laughed first,

before he was able to speak, before he got his wind back — and said, "Where did you learn that?"

"My father's riding master."

"Then your father's riding master has a great deal to answer for."

And she had stood there with her back against the birch tree, and had understood that she had just shown this boy the one thing about herself that she had never shown anybody, which was not the wrist and the thumb but the fact that she had learned it, that she could do it, and that she would; and instead of being frightened, he had laughed, and gone on laughing for the rest of the walk down to the horses, and made her do it to him again in the field behind the stable in the dark the following night, five times, so that he could work out how it was done, and had then spent three weeks designing, in a notebook, a modification of the grip in which the wrist is not exposed, which he showed to nobody but her and which was, though he did not know it, the first intelligent thing the German army ever did about the Polish question.

Five. The last afternoon. It was the second of October 1938, and the partridges were finished and the leaves were down, and the engineer's family was to leave the next morning for Warsaw; and the two of them walked the boundary path along the ditch at the end of the birch wood, and there was a long, honest, entirely unbearable conversation which neither of them was willing to end, and in the course of it the following four things were said: that she would be at the flat on Mokotowska in the winter and he would be at his father's house on Hoża Street; that his mother was Polish

and his father was not, which he said in exactly that order; that she intended to marry a man who would be in Warsaw and not in Berlin; and that he had no intention of being an engineer "yet."

And then neither of them said anything else for four hundred metres, and at the end of the four hundred metres he stopped and took hold of her hand, without any of the nonsense of the wood, and held it for the length of a long breath, and said: "I will write to you."

"You will not. You will write four letters, and I will answer three, and then it will be the summer, and in the summer you will come to the shoot and it will be bad, and then it will be the end of it, and neither of us will have said anything." She heard her own voice say it, in the ditch, under the willows, at eighteen, and heard him take it; and she saw that he had gone still, in the way a boy goes still when he has been handed the whole of his future in one sentence by a girl who is four years younger and who has grown up in a house where the accounts are not told to the children.

And he said, "Then I will not write to you."

And he did not. It was she who wrote first, which was the last thing her pride had left, and she did it in August 1939, four days after the announcement of the Soviet pact, from a hotel in Krynica where she was taking a cure with her mother, and the letter was nine lines long and contained no verbs in the important places, and she heard nothing back for eleven days, and the answer that came, on the thirtieth of August, was one line: The shoot can wait a year. — P.

It reached the flat on Mokotowska Street on the last morning of the peace, while her father was at the telephone to the bank and her mother was at the window with the blackout paper in her hands, and she put it in the pocket of the coat she was going to take to the cellar, and she had it still.

❦

The war came into the flat on Mokotowska Street on the first of September 1939 at twenty minutes to six in the morning, by radio, while Antoni was still at the kitchen table with a glass of tea.

Antoni Solecki had come up from Wierzbów on the thirty-first of August with the last of the things that were worth fetching: two pairs of candlesticks, the box of papers, the portrait of Krystyna's grandmother in its frame, and a jar of honey wrapped in a shirt, and he had come on the cart as far as Grodzisk and then on the electric railway with the jar on his knees, and he was sixty-nine and had a bad hip and had said, when the family told him he should have stayed at the estate, that somebody would have to look after the papers when the bank took the house, and that he had known the papers since 1904.

The estate went to the bank in the third week of August 1939. It is important to state that plainly, because the last autumn at Wierzbów had been the autumn of 1938 and there was no other one: the mortgage, the beet that had failed in 1937 and again in 1938, the syndicate from Poznań that had bought the beet land in 1932 and put their dogs on it, the four hundred and ten thousand zlotys, the sale agreed

in Warsaw on the eleventh of August with a lawyer who had come to the flat in a hat, the notice to quit for the middle of October; and then the general mobilisation, and nobody signing anything at all, and the whole transaction sitting in a folder on a table in a country that was about to stop existing at twenty minutes to six in the morning on a Friday.

Tadeusz had gone on the twenty-eighth of August with a bag and a railway warrant and his mother's scapular in his pocket, in the direction of the east, to a regiment that had been moved three times in five days.

On the first of September the bombs came down on the Ochota and on the aerodrome at Pole Mokotowskie and on the working-class streets on the other side of the tracks, and the flat on Mokotowska shook and the pianino sounded a chord of its own in the corner, and Hanna, who was thirteen, went and stood in the corridor with her back against the wall in the place where the load-bearing wall was, because the father had said on the first morning that this was the safest place in the building and had said it with a calm that he had then not been able to keep for more than two days.

On the third of September there was an announcement on the radio at midday that England was at war and France would be by the evening, and the whole courtyard came out into the yard to hear it through the open windows of the ground floor, and the caretaker's wife cried, and a man on the third floor said that the cavalry would be in Berlin by the end of the month, and Hanna counted, out loud, the number of aeroplanes she had heard since breakfast and got to nine.

And at twenty past nine that night, in the rain, a car stopped at the corner of Mokotowska and Wilcza, and Phillip Brandt came across the road to the gate of the building with the collar of his coat up and a white armband on his sleeve.

❦

There were four of them in the hall: her father in his study jacket with the lamp in his hand, her mother on the stairs with a candle, Hanna behind the door of the kitchen, and Krystyna standing at the end of the corridor by the brass umbrella stand, which was the only piece of the palace's furniture that had come with them, and which is the only reason she had something to put her hand on.

Antoni had let him in, because Antoni had been at Wierzbów in September 1938 and knew exactly whose son it was; and Antoni then went back into the kitchen and stood there with the door open, which was his way of not being absent.

Phillip stood in the hall without taking off his hat.

"Herr Stankiewicz." He said it in Polish, and then he went on in Polish, and the Polish was correct and his accent in it was Warsaw, and every word of it was being said by a man in a coat with a white armband on the sleeve. "I have a car and a pass and I am leaving the city at four o'clock this morning with my mother. My father is in Berlin since the twenty-sixth. There is room in the car for five people and their cases and the driver is my father's driver, and he will be paid in marks, and there is a route to the south that is open as far as Grójec tonight and will not be open tomorrow af-

ternoon. I came to ask you to come with us. All of you. Tonight."

Nobody moved.

"I can do this because of the papers," Phillip said. "The papers are German papers, and they say the car belongs to a firm that the German army—"

And there the sentence went into German. Not one word of it, not a phrase: the whole rest of the sentence, the important part of it, the part about what the papers were and what the car was for and who the car obeyed, came out of him in German, fluently, the German of a boy who had been educated in Dresden, and it hung in the hall of the flat on Mokotowska Street at half past nine in the evening of the third of September 1939 like a smell that could not be got rid of.

He stopped. He heard himself stop. She saw him hear it.

Her father lowered the lamp a little and looked at the young man in the hall for a long moment.

"Niemiec," Jerzy Stankiewicz said.

He said it quietly, without any passion at all, the way a man reads out the headword on a page; and then he said two more sentences, and the family in the flat heard the whole of it, and Hanna never forgot a word of it and neither did her sister.

"You have come to my house in a German coat, at half past nine at night, in the third day of the bombing of my city, to offer to take my wife and my daughters out through the German lines in a German car. And you have explained it to me in German. I am a teacher of Latin and I am old,

and I do not know what will happen to my country in the next three weeks, and I do not know whether I will ever see my son again; but I know what happens to a man who gets into that car. He spends the rest of his life explaining that he was right." He raised the lamp slightly. "You were in the library at Wierzbów and you corrected a translation. That was a Polish boy. Go home and be that, and do not come here again with your mother's face and your father's papers."

The word her father used was Niemiec, and he used it once, and it was true on the third of September 1939, and it was the truest thing anybody said in that hall that night, and everybody standing in it, including the young man in the German coat, knew it.

Phillip looked at Krystyna, once, across the whole length of the corridor, past her father's shoulder and the lamp; and she looked at him; and then he bowed — actually bowed, from the waist, to Jerzy Stankiewicz, in a Polish hall in 1939, which was either the last of his Polishness or the first of his Germanness, and she has never been able to decide which — and went out, and Antoni closed the door and shot the bolt.

Her mother said, from the stairs: "Jerzy."

"There is no argument in this house that begins with the word 'but,'" her father said. "Not tonight."

Krystyna went into the room at the front, which was her parents' room, and stood at the window over the courtyard, and looked down through the rain on the glass with both hands flat on the sill, and Phillip Brandt was standing on the pavement under the lamp with his hat in his hand and his face up, in the wet, looking at the window; and there

is no clock in that street and no record of how long it was, except that a woman standing at a window one storey above a man on a pavement in the rain has four or five minutes in which to go down the stairs, and that the stairwell of that building was sixty-one steps, and that she counted them without moving, and that at the end of it he put his hat on and got into the car and the car went away down Mokotowska Street towards the tram lines.

Her father came in behind her at some point and stood in the doorway.

"Not that window," he said. "You will not stand at that window again."

He never explained why, and she never asked, and it is the only rule he ever made that she obeyed for the rest of her life.

❦

She left Warsaw on the morning of the fourth of September 1939, which was the fourth day of the bombing, with a small suitcase and the coat her mother took off her back at the platform and put round her shoulders and buttoned at the throat with her own hands, in the crowd of the Eastern station, where a woman was selling hot water and there was no sugar, and where the family's decision had been made the night before at the kitchen table in the way these decisions were made: the mother was ill and could not be moved an hour further than necessary, the son was with the regiment, the sister was thirteen and would stay with the parents, and the daughter was nineteen, and would be twenty in November, and was therefore the one who could travel, and there

was a relation of the family's late aunt at a place south of Radom with a house and a room, and the road was still open.

The train was stopped twice by the aeroplanes and once by a rumour, and it went a hundred kilometres in nineteen hours, and the last view she had of Warsaw was from the carriage window with her forehead against the glass: not heroic, not a burning city in the illustrated sense, but a city with smoke standing up on it in three separate columns in a grey morning, and a balloon barrage hanging over the river, and a man on the embankment at the water's edge with his coat off, washing.

The city held out for another twenty-five days. It surrendered on the twenty-eighth of September, and she heard it in a kitchen in the south of Poland on a wireless set with a broken aerial, and the first thing she thought about was the window over the courtyard.

❦

She knows three things about the letter, and she has known them since the winter of 1939, from a letter of her mother's that came to the south in November by way of a nun, and that had the price of coal in it, and her aunt's rheumatism, and the news that the maid Józefa had been dismissed in October because there was no money for a maid, and one sentence in the middle, dropped in without emphasis, the way her mother dropped the things that mattered:

Your father says the German boy came to the gate in the last week, and that he has written to you, and that the letter went off in Józefa's prayer book when she left, and it is better so, Krysia, and do not write about it.

Three facts, then: that he wrote it; that it went away in a maid's prayer book to a street nobody in the family knows; and that it never came, and never will come, and that her father knew about it and chose not to tell her for what he believed were good reasons, and was right.

She has never mentioned the letter to a living person. She has spent four years deciding that it was a note about a road out of town, because that is what he was, and then, on other days, that it was four lines long and said nothing at all, and then, on the worst days, that it was the only sentence the whole thing ever came to, and that she had left it in a prayer book on a shelf in Warsaw with a maid who was dismissed in October 1939 for want of money.

❦

On the twenty-seventh of December, at six in the evening, she walked the length of the boulevard Raspail in the rain with a hat she did not need and a handbag with nothing in it, and stood for eleven minutes on the pavement opposite the Hôtel Lutetia.

There were two lorries under the portico and a sentry under the awning and the windows of the ground floor lit with the hard, brown, varnished light of every German office in Europe, and through the third window from the left, behind a palm in a green glazed pot, a man in field grey stood at a table with his hand flat on a piece of paper; and she was too far away to see his face and did not need to, because she had spent four days understanding that the only person in Paris who could read her was in that building, at a desk, with a file.

She did not go in. There was no arrangement to go in, no pretext, no reason that would survive being written down in a day book: the mistress of an Oberst of the Militärbefehlshaber does not walk into the Abwehr's Paris headquarters eight days after Christmas to see a Hauptmann of the intelligence section about a well in Mazovia. She stood on the pavement with the rain coming off the brim of her hat, and she looked at the lit windows, and she counted them, and then she walked away east along the boulevard to the Mission, and sat in the fourth row in the smell of cold stone and wet wool, and did not pray, and waited for Wiktor.

He was in the doorway of the building on the rue Saint-Honoré at half past seven, with his stick and his collar up and his spectacles fogged, and they walked for four minutes along the empty street in the dark without speaking, because that was the rule for the first four minutes.

"The Colonel is posted in February," Wiktor said. "East of the Vistula. It is in the paper: the Militärbefehlshaber is stripping the Paris staff for the new arrangements in the Government General, and your Oberst is on the list because he speaks Russian and because he has a reputation for moving a supply column, and the house that is to be given him is a white villa on the Frascati Street, with a garden and three trees, requisitioned in 1940 from a family called Zaleski."

"The Frascati," she said, and said nothing else for a moment, because the Frascati was four hundred metres from the palace on the Nowy Świat where she had been born, and because she knew the way that pavement sounded under a boot in the cold.

And Wiktor looked at her sideways through the fogged glass and said: "You have said the name of the street twice, in a voice that knows how the pavement sounds. I did not tell you how the pavement sounds, my dear colleague, and I have been keeping that in the same drawer as the other facts about you."

"And?"

"And the Abwehr is finished. The Admiral is out, and his people are being taken over by men who do not read Polish, and there is a young officer of the Paris station whose file has been opened in Berlin, and whose career will be short if he does not find something for them in the next six months." He turned his stick a quarter-turn on the pavement. "That is the good news, and you may do what you like with it. The other news is that your father is ill in Warsaw — a lung, and a bad winter, and your sister is seventeen and taking the papers now, which you did not know and which is a fact you will not be told again. And that is the news you can do nothing about, and the reason you are going to go with the Oberst to Warsaw in a fur coat, and write to me once a month, and remember the rules. Good night, Krystyna."

"Wiktor."

"Go home," he said, and went off up the street with the stick, and it was four months until the sixteenth of February, and she walked back to the avenue Henri-Martin in the rain, past the dark windows of the shops on the rue de Rivoli, and did not think about any of it, and got into the bed of a German colonel at eleven o'clock and lay there with

her eyes open in the dark, and listened to the sentry on the gravel, and it was eleven minutes, and then eleven minutes again.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Trap of Small Talk

❦

There are three ways to know that the weather has changed, and none of them is the weather.

The first, on the fourth of January, was the concierge. Madame Ravel had a lodge with a window on the courtyard, a cat, a husband who had been at Verdun and had a certificate on the wall, and a manner with German officers that was neither servile nor insolent and had kept her exactly where she was for four years. On the fourth of January she was called to the Militärbefehlshaber's office in the rue de la Pompe and questioned for two hours and forty minutes about the household on the avenue Henri-Martin: who came, who went, what the Fräulein did with her mornings, whether letters came for her, whether she had ever been seen with a parcel. She was questioned by a civilian, and there was a shorthand clerk, and she was given a chair and a glass of water and, at the end, a receipt for her identity card. She told the household about it, because she was a Frenchwoman in an occupied city, and there is no version of that life in which the concierge does not tell the cook and the cook does not tell the maid and the maid does not tell the house.

The second, on the fifth, was Odile.

There was a man in the workroom off the rue Saint-Honoré when Krystyna came at eleven for a fitting, which had never happened before in two years: a heavy man of

about fifty in a civilian overcoat of good cloth, with the collar buttoned and his hat on his knees, sitting on the chair by the cutting table with the pattern paper under it, being shown the order book. The order book of a Paris dressmaker of 1944 is an extraordinary document. It contains the names of three hundred women and the measurements of their bodies and the dates of their fittings and, in Odile's hand, in the margins, a private system of marks — a small cross for a client who paid in food, a small circle for one who paid nothing and always would, and one letter that was not a letter, for the nine Jewish clients, three of whom had been sent away in 1943 and six of whom were in the same building as the shop, behind a partition in the attic, being fed twice a day and taught, in the evenings, to be somebody else.

The man asked Odile eleven questions about her clients, in French with a German construction, in the tone of a man doing an inventory of buttons, and at the end of the eleven questions he stood up, and put on his hat, and said: we note. Then he went out into the street and stood a moment, adjusting his gloves, before he crossed to a car that had been waiting with its engine running.

Krystyna stayed for the fitting. She stood on the box in the cold room for thirty-five minutes in a half-made bodice while Odile pinned the shoulder and did not say one word about the man, and the women in the back room sewed, and at the end, when she was dressed, Odile said, "The shoulder is right at last," and gave her the paper pattern folded in four, and inside the folded paper, as always, there was

a cutting from a newspaper four lines long: the previous week's drop instructions.

The third, on the sixth, was a bicycle. Wiktor's courier was a boy of nineteen from the seventeenth arrondissement, with a face like a knife and a laugh he could not keep in, who came on a bicycle with a leather saddlebag and who had been doing the rue Saint-Honoré run since October. On the morning of the sixth of January the bicycle was found leaning against the wall of the passage at the corner of the rue Saint-Honoré and the rue de l'Échelle, with the saddlebag still on it and the leather strap still buckled, and nothing else was found at all, on that street or in that quarter or in any of the three places where a body can be put in Paris in winter and be found in the spring; and there is no way to say whether he talked, and no way to say whether he is alive somewhere in a cellar with his teeth gone, and the network's rule about it — Wiktor's rule, printed nowhere but taught in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth in the autumn of 1942 — is that a missing courier is a dead courier, that the drop is dead with him, that you do not go to look, and that if you have ever liked him you must behave, for the next three months, as though you had not.

She walked from the passage to the fitting and from the fitting to the avenue Henri-Martin and did the whole of the journey without ever once looking behind her, which is a discipline and not a virtue, and by the time she reached the gate she had made the list, and the list had six names on it, and the fourth of them was Odile Boin, and the third was Wiktor Janowski, and the first was her own.

❦

On the evening of the sixth of January, at half past ten, she found the sheet of paper.

The study on the first floor of the villa had a desk with a leather top and two drawers which the Colonel did not lock, because he had once explained to her, with the mild pleasure of a man setting out a principle, that the correct arrangement of a German officer's papers is that they are either in the safe, in which case they are safe, or on the desk, in which case they are not secret. The blotter was replaced every Monday by the maid and the used sheets were burned, and the reason Krystyna knew this was that she had made it her business, in July 1943, to know it, and had spent four months learning the day and the hour, and had read seven of those sheets in the two and a half minutes the house allowed her.

The sheet on the desk on the evening of the sixth was wrong.

It was wrong in four ways, and she took them in the way a seamstress takes in a badly tacked sleeve. It was not on the paper of that office, which was a grey rationed paper with the watermarks of a mill in Angoulême; it was a white paper with a rag content and a stiff, hard surface, of the kind the SD's own sections used. The typing was too clean: the machine that had produced it had a new ribbon and a perfect alignment, and every machine in the villa typed either with a dropped e or with a habit of climbing the last line of a paragraph — two faults she could have recognised in the dark. The ink was dry, and the memorandum was dated the

fourth, which was two days earlier, and it had been typed that afternoon. And there was no carbon under it, which was the fourth wrongness and the one that made her stand absolutely still with her hands at her sides, because the Colonel was a Prussian of the old school who wrote everything in duplicate and triple, and a document in his study with no carbon under it had not been produced by him: it had been placed.

The subject of the memorandum was the naval batteries at Saint-Nazaire: the emplacements, the two new ranging sets, the ammunition that came by night from a siding at Montoir, and the fact that the defences of the Loire estuary had been reinforced in December with the guns out of the old battleships. It was the thing the network had been asking for since November. It was the most expensive piece of paper she had seen in her life.

She stood over it in the dark, with the sentry's boots going round the garden outside, and thought about the man who had made it, and what he knew, and what he thought he knew about her, and she came to the following conclusion, which she wrote down later in her own head, in Polish, because it was too dangerous to say even in French:

They have not decided that it is me. They have decided that their source is a woman, because somebody has told them that the leak is close to an officer's household, and they have chosen a colonel who does not lock his desk. They put the bait where they think the source can reach it, and they will watch the paper, not the person, because a paper can be watched from a distance and a person cannot. There-

fore it is not a trap for a hand. It is a trap for a market: the day it reaches London, they will know where the leak is.

Which is exactly correct, and which had a second implication, and the second implication was the one that decided the rest of the chapter: on the day the memorandum reached London, the hunt would be closed, not on a name but on a house. On the avenue Henri-Martin.

She looked at the perfect clean sheet for another minute. Then she took a sheet of the villa's own grey paper out of the drawer, and copied onto it, in her small upright hand, the four essential facts of the memorandum — the two ranging sets, the siding at Montoir, the guns, the date — and folded it and put it in her shoe, and left the clean sheet exactly where it was, and went down the corridor, and put her hand on the banister rail, and up to bed at eleven minutes to eleven.

That night she lay in the dark and did not count the sentry, and made the plan in three parts, and the second part of it was a woman in the twentieth arrondissement and the third part of it was a dress fitting; and the first part of it was that a service which has not found its source will keep looking, and that looking is what kills networks, and that the only way to stop a hunt is to give it something it can eat.

❦

The arithmetic was done in twenty minutes, on the morning of the seventh of January, in the bathroom at the top of the house, with the tap running.

She wrote the six names on a piece of paper in pencil and put a mark against each of them.

Odile Boin, 55, dressmaker, rue Saint-Honoré. Already questioned; already visited; her order book has nine Jewish women in it, six of them alive in her attic; another visit and it is not Odile who is lost, it is the six, and the six include a violinist from Łódź and the wife of a doctor who worked at the Rothschild hospital in 1939 and who has been sitting in that attic for eleven months listening to the sound of the shop bell. Odile would die before she gave a name, and she would give the six names because they are in her house and not in her mouth, and because a sixty-year-old woman with a search warrant in her workroom does not have the option of dying before they open the door of the attic. Odile was out.

Wiktor Janowski, 52, rue Saint-Honoré. Out, and for a different reason: Wiktor was the standard, and if the SD took Wiktor then everything she had was over, and — she wrote this down, burned the paper in the washbasin and washed the ash away with the tap — it would be over more quickly than if it were anybody else, because Wiktor had shown her, in a flat above a laundry in 1942, what a man does under a certain kind of questioning, and had said at the end of it: You have not been caught. That is the whole of our morality, and you are going to have to do without any other. He was out because he was hers, and she knew it while she was doing it.

Marion Herschlag. Out for the obvious reason.

Céline Marchand, 39, avenue Henri-Martin, wife of a manufacturer who had gone to Vichy in 1940 and stayed there.

She sat on the edge of the bath with the pencil in her hand and looked at the fourth name for a long time.

Céline Marchand was the best friend of Marion Herschlag. She was the person who had taken the Austrian girl who appeared in Paris in 1940 under the wing of the German administration and had taught her which couturier to use and which restaurants to be seen in, and who had made her laugh eleven times, and who had — in October 1942, at a table in a restaurant on the rue Royale — asked her, in the voice of a Frenchwoman discussing a hat, where exactly in Austria she had learned to say the road to the north with the vowel of a Russian, and had then, because she was Céline, laughed and taken a second helping of the pâté and forgotten the question entirely.

She had asked it once, in front of four people, and had not noticed the answer, and she was the only person in the German orbit of Paris who had ever heard the seam in the accent and had thought about it for longer than a second.

Céline Marchand was thirty-nine. She was a collaborator the way a cat is a collaborator: she liked the cream and did not care who owned the dairy. She was warm, indiscreet, uncurious, generous, greedy, frightened of dentists, and had a brother's photograph on her piano with nothing else in the flat that she would not sell for a price. She was sleeping with a Frenchman in the propaganda office, and she sold nothing to anybody, and she knew nothing that mattered, and she had a cousin in the préfecture whom she mentioned every fortnight because she was proud of him.

There was no case against Céline Marchand. There was a case against a Frenchwoman with a German-protected friend, a cousin in the préfecture, two rooms with a telephone in them, a husband in Vichy, a mouth with nothing in it but the accident of an accent question asked once at a dinner table in October 1942 — and it was a case that would end, in the SD's arithmetic, with the possibility that a woman in the German orbit had been selling the office she could reach, which is to say the office of the friend who had the Colonel's confidence, which is to say that the leak was a woman close to the household.

That is the whole of it, and the reason was not that Céline Marchand was cheapest: it was that hers was the only name in Paris whose arrest would close the file on the avenue Henri-Martin, and that the alternative was not her own survival — she had made her peace with her own survival in a flat above a laundry in 1942 — but the survival of an attic in the rue Saint-Honoré with six women in it and a dressmaker of fifty-five who had told her, in November, with pins in her mouth, that a person should not look at the box under the cutting table.

At eleven that morning she telephoned the villa to say she would be late for luncheon, and at half past two she walked into the flat on the avenue Henri-Martin with a dress box under her arm.

❦

Céline Marchand's flat had four rooms on the second floor of a building of 1904, with a concierge who took parcels and a telephone in the hall on a table with a marble top and a

plaited cord long enough to reach the drawing room, which was a thing she liked to mention, because it had cost eleven thousand francs in 1938.

They had tea, and they talked about the spring collections and about a German colonel's wife who had ordered a suit from Odile and then refused to pay because Odile was French; and Céline laughed about it for four minutes, and at half past three she went to change because she had an appointment at four with a hairdresser who was making a fortune, and she said, going out of the room, mon Dieu, the state of the world and my hair — and Krystyna was left alone in the flat with the maid, who was seventeen, from the fourteenth arrondissement, and who was in the kitchen with the door open; and with the hall, and the wardrobe of the small room, and the telephone.

She did the telephone first, because it could be heard.

There are things a person can do in another person's house and things a person cannot, and the difference is entirely made of time: four minutes alone in a room in Paris in January 1944 is enough to put a parcel into a wardrobe, and eleven seconds in a hall with a maid in the kitchen is enough to lift a receiver.

She telephoned the flat from the post office on the rue de Rivoli at ten past four, from the sixth box, with her collar up and a scrap of silk over the mouthpiece, and she spoke German. Not the German of Marion Herschlag, which half the officers of the Militärbefehlshaber knew and one of them slept beside; a soft, level, unplaceable German, and she said four sentences: that a parcel had been left at the flat that

afternoon by a boy from a bureau; that it was wrapped in brown paper and was in the wardrobe in the small room; that Madame was not to open it before Saturday; and that the woman speaking was sorry to have missed Madame. Then she rang off, and the girl on the exchange made a mark on a pad because the call had gone on for a minute and a half, and nothing whatever came of the mark.

Thirty seconds later, from the same box, she dialled the SD's number on the avenue Foch and asked for the office of Sturmbannführer Kalbach, and gave the same soft German to a man with a Berlin accent and a cold, and she said six sentences: that if the gentlemen were still looking in Paris for the source of the material that had been reaching London since the autumn, they might look in the flat of a Frenchwoman on the avenue Henri-Martin, second floor, four rooms, telephone in the hall; that a parcel of papers had arrived there that afternoon in brown paper and would be gone by Saturday; that the lady of the house had a husband in Vichy and a cousin in the préfecture and a friendship with the German administration; and that the man receiving the call should write down the address and not ask who was speaking, because asking would only make him late.

Then she put the receiver down on its hook, and paid for the two calls in coins, and walked out into the rue de Rivoli as far as the corner of the rue Castiglione, and stood there for four minutes with her hands in her pockets, looking at nothing at all.

She was back in the flat at twenty-five past four, in the drawing room, with her gloves off, talking to the maid

about the maid's aunt in Rouen; and Céline came out at half past four in a hat, and made her choose between two of them, and Krystyna chose the grey one and was right, and the two of them went down the stairs together, and Céline got into a taxi and Krystyna walked home along the avenue in the rain. That is the last hour of the friendship, it is nine hundred and forty seconds long, and it went perfectly.

❦

They came for her at half past one the following day, which was a Saturday, at the restaurant on the rue Royale where she had gone to eat oysters with two other women, and Krystyna was eleven streets away in a taxi, coming back from the rue Saint-Honoré, when the taxi stopped at the lights at the corner of the rue Saint-Honoré and the rue Royale because a car had been drawn up across the pavement.

She saw the whole of it from behind the driver's glass, at a distance of about thirty metres, and she was not supposed to be looking and she looked, because a person who has arranged a thing must watch it happen or she will spend the next twenty years imagining it in eleven different versions.

There were two men out of the car and one woman, in civilian coats, and the woman was in the restaurant before the men; and then there was Céline Marchand in the doorway with a napkin in her hand that did not belong to her, and a waiter behind her with his arm out to steady a table, and her hat coming off her head and falling down the two steps into the street, and one of the men picking it up and not giving it back. She talked the whole way to the car, with

her hands up, and the words did not carry thirty metres and her face did; and then a hand on the top of her head and she was in the car, and a man folded the hat in half and put it in his coat pocket and got in after her, and it was over in eleven seconds.

The light changed. The taxi pulled away. Krystyna sat in the back of it with her hands in her lap, in the grey afternoon, and thought — in her own small upright hand, in her head, in the office of a flat above a laundry — about the fact that the timing had been right to the minute, and that the report would be on Kalbach's desk that evening with the address on the avenue Henri-Martin in it, and that by Monday the file would be one page shorter.

Then the taxi went round the corner and the arithmetic was finished, and she found that she had bitten through the inside of her cheek, and she spat the blood into a handkerchief, and put the handkerchief back in her bag, and went to Odile's and had a fitting, because the fitting was in the diary, and because in the diary she was a woman whose friend had been arrested at luncheon and who had gone to her dressmaker because there was nothing else to do with the afternoon; and Odile pinned the shoulder and said nothing, and gave her the folded pattern, and there was nothing inside it.

❦

Odile was taken on the twelfth of January, at ten minutes past six in the morning.

There were three cars in the rue Saint-Honoré, one of them drawn up on to the pavement at the corner, and the shutters of the workroom were up, which they never were at

that hour, and there was a man by the third car smoking with one hand cupped over the cigarette in the cold; and Krystyna saw it at a distance of forty metres on the far pavement, on her way to the villa's car, and she kept walking, and turned into the rue de l'Échelle, and was out of the quarter in four minutes, because the first rule of the manual on the last page, in the tiny type, in Wiktor's dry voice, is that a person who is near an arrest leaves, and that a person who watches an arrest is a person who has been seen watching.

Inside, hidden behind the partition in the attic, six women spent that day and the next and the morning after it in the dark with one bucket and one bottle of water and no sound whatever, and on the third night the two remaining seamstresses of the workroom walked all six of them out of the building in three parties, through the courtyard into the rue de l'Échelle and up the boulevard to three addresses; and three of the six lived, and three did not.

For eleven days Krystyna did not know whether Odile had talked.

Eleven days is not long. It was the whole of the rest of January: the milky coffee at the villa, the fitting hour in her diary with no fitting in it, the orders she sent through the priest on the Thursday, the two requisitioning officers who came to the drawing room on the fourteenth and drank the Colonel's cognac and made jokes about the Crimea, and the nights when she lay in the dark and heard her own heart and could not sleep in the way the manual said to sleep.

On the twelfth day she went to the rue Saint-Honoré at the fitting hour anyway, because a woman who does not go

back to her dressmaker's shop is a woman who has something to be afraid of, and the shop was shut with a padlock and a German paper on the door, and three women stood on the pavement in the cold looking at the paper with their hands in their sleeves, and one of them was the woman of forty. Krystyna walked past on the far side of the street. The woman of forty turned her head and looked at her across thirty metres of the rue Saint-Honoré, and neither of them acknowledged anything, and both of them survived the war.

She learned what had happened in April, in Warsaw, from a line on a piece of paper worth more than its weight in gold: a list of prisoners transferred from Fresnes to a camp in Silesia in February, with a mark against one name in a German clerk's hand, verstorben 9.II.44, Lungenentzündung, and above it the name Odile Boin in the card index of a case that had been closed because the dressmaker had not given up a name — not one, in eleven days of it, at fifty-five, with a bad hip and a bad heart and three hundred clients' measurements in a book the SD already had in its hands, and six women in an attic behind a partition that they never found.

❦

He was in the chapel on the rue Saint-Honoré on the third of February, at the Thursday hour, in the last row on the left, in a German overcoat with no armband and his hat in his hands and his eyes on the altar; and she knew he was there before she saw him, the way a person trained in a flat above a laundry knows that the thing in the room is not furniture.

She had twenty minutes before the priest came out.

She could go out through the north door into the courtyard and be in the rue Saint-Honoré in nine seconds. She could sit at the other end of the nave and do the Thursday, and let the priest watch a German captain leave four minutes after the woman he had been seen with at the Majestic had knelt at the rail. And she could — and this is where her professional self, which had eaten everything the girl from Mokotowska Street had ever been, laid a card on the table, in words, in Polish — she could consider that a man who knows her name and who stands in the church where the network comes on Thursdays can be removed, that he had come without a warrant and without a second man, and that the man in the twentieth arrondissement had been paid in advance and had never once failed.

Then she walked down the side aisle and sat in the second-to-last row with one row of empty chairs between them, and neither of them turned their heads, and the two of them looked at the altar together in the cold for four minutes without speaking; and afterwards she was never able to explain to herself, in any of the languages she had, why she had done that instead of the other thing.

"I am going to say four sentences," Phillip said, in Polish, in a voice pitched for the communion rail. "You may stop me whenever you like. First: the paper on the desk in the villa, the one about the estuary, is not yours and never was. It was written in a room on the avenue Foch by a man of about thirty-eight with a good coat, and it was written to be taken; and it has a second purpose that you have not

thought of, which is that the day it reaches London, the house it came out of becomes the file. Second: I am telling you this because the man who wrote it is looking at your house and at mine, and because when he finds nothing in a Frenchwoman's flat in January he does not conclude that he was wrong. He concludes that he was right and early."

"Three," she said.

"Three: the case file goes east. The Admiral's people are being dismembered and the papers are being put on a train, and the man with the good coat has asked to go with them, because the east is where the Poles are, and because he has decided that the source is a Pole. He will be in Warsaw before the summer. His section is on a street there called aleja Szucha, and it has a building with a courtyard that you will be able to see from the pavement and will do well never to enter."

There was a silence of about eleven seconds, in which an old woman three rows in front of them got up, shuffled to the side altar, lit a candle, and shuffled back.

"And four?" she said.

"Four: I have a set of papers in the pocket of this coat. A complete set, with a photograph taken from your file at the Militärbefehlshaber's, and a route that begins in Lyon and ends in Barcelona, and a name that belongs to a woman who died in 1941 and would have been twenty-six. If you want them they are yours tonight, and there is a bicycle in the yard of a house in the fourteenth, and eleven days of my pay in the lining of the wallet." He looked at the altar the whole time he said it. "I have carried them for a month."

She sat in the cold and looked at the altar and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic took her nine seconds, and every line of it came out the same way, and the reason was not courage.

"Take out the papers," she said.

He took out the wallet and put it on the chair between them, and she unfolded the documents and looked at the photograph of herself in the file of the Militärbefehlshaber in France, which had been taken from the identity card issued to Marion Herschlag, Austrian national, in September 1940 — the photograph of a woman with her chin slightly up and her mouth slightly careful, which is a better portrait of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna than anything hanging in the flat on Mokotowska Street; and she folded the papers again and put them on the chair on his side and stood up.

"February," she said. "The Oberst is posted in February. My papers are already stamped and I am going with him, and you will hear, in the third week of the month, of an Oberst of the Militärbefehlshaber who has been given the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison; and after that you will not stand in a church near me again, because the next time you do it I will not have a reason not to do the other thing."

"Krystyna," he said.

"Not that," she said. "Once was enough for a lifetime, and you are going to have to spend yours somewhere else."

She walked down the aisle and out into the rue Saint-Honoré, and their hands did not touch at any point in the twenty minutes; and the wallet with the papers of a dead

woman in it stayed on the chair in the second-to-last row, where an old woman found it on her way out and gave it to the priest, who put it in the drawer of the sacristy with the other things people leave behind — which was the last time in the whole of the war that Phillip Brandt was in a room with any part of her, and neither of them ever knew it.

❦

Wiktor did not come on the tenth of February, and he did not come on the seventeenth, and on the nineteenth she walked the length of the rue Saint-Honoré past the chapel and past Odile's shut shop as far as the Place du Palais-Royal and back; and the flat above the laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement was shuttered with a card in the window advertising an apartment for a family of five, and the two marks on the doorframe — the one that meant safe, the one that meant come again — had both been scrubbed off with a brush, and the plaster was still raw where it had been done.

She sent nothing, and asked nothing, and went nowhere, and on the twenty-first she went to the chapel and did the Thursday, and the priest was there and said the mass and said nothing to her at all; and afterwards, in the sacristy, with his back to her and his hands in a basin, he said one sentence in Polish: "He is gone and the door is shut and I do not know anything more than that, and you are to be quiet, and there is no one in this city you can go to about it."

"There is one thing I want to leave with him."

"There is nothing in this house that can be left with him," the priest said, "and the man you are talking about has been in the hands of the SD since Tuesday, and you know

what that means and so do I, and if you say one more word about it in this room I will put my coat on and go out of that door and never come back to you, because a priest who is useful is a priest who is not asked anything." He dried his hands. "Go and be quiet. That is the whole of the instruction, and it is not mine."

❦

The house on the avenue Henri-Martin was packed in the last week of February by four soldiers and a French removal firm with a German licence, and it took them two days: the silver in straw in a crate, the paintings crated, the wine laid in cases and marked, the cellar sealed, a list in triplicate; and the whole of the requisition reversed and re-signed in the Colonel's own hand, in a good humour, with the concierge standing in the hall with her keys and her cat and her face.

He telephoned the Warsaw office three times on the Tuesday. She heard the second of the three from the corridor, through the door of the study, in which he was speaking German more slowly and more loudly than he spoke to her, in the way of a man talking on a bad line about a house: a villa, four rooms plus, a garden with three trees, on a street whose name she did not catch, near the Frascati park, with a piano in the drawing room that the previous owners had left and that was to stay, because the previous owners had been told it was to stay.

And on the Wednesday, at the table, with the first of the crates standing in the hall, he put his hand over hers and told her about the papers.

"I have had you stamped as an Austrian national," he said. "It was done in Berlin in three days, which is a month faster than anything else has ever been done for me, and it cost me a favour from a man in the Auswärtiges Amt who will remind me of it in 1946. You will be travelling as a civil employee of the military administration, which is the only category that exists. The east is not the west, my dear. In Paris a rumour is a piano in a drawing room; in Warsaw there will be people in offices who look at a woman's papers for the pleasure of it, and a Polish woman travelling in the service of the Reich is a thing they will have opinions about, and an Austrian is a thing they have no opinion about at all." He looked at her steadily. "I have made you a lie to live in. It is the only present I have ever given you that cost me something, so take it and do not argue."

"Thank you," she said, and meant the first syllable, and he did not notice, because he was a man who had just done an excellent thing and who was, at that moment, entirely happy.

❦

They left on the morning of the twenty-eighth of February 1944 from the Gare de l'Est, in the snow, from a platform that had been cleared of the ordinary travellers by two gendarmes and a rope; and Emil Rutz stood at the door of the carriage with the cases in a row at his feet and the count of them in the notebook in his tunic pocket, and the Colonel came down the platform with his coat open and his gloves in his hand and his breath going up in the cold, and said the last things a German officer says on a platform: the numbers

of the cases, the number of the carriage, the hour at which the car would meet them in Berlin, the name of the hotel.

She stood at the carriage door with her fur collar up and looked back down the platform at the crowd behind the rope: French faces, a woman with a basket, a boy on a man's shoulders, a porter with a barrow of sacks. And forty metres away, at the end of the platform by the bookstall, there was a man in a grey overcoat with his hat down and no luggage, standing absolutely still among the people who were moving, with a small notebook in his hand and a pencil; and he looked at her across the forty metres for three seconds, with his head slightly on one side, the way a man looks at a house he is thinking of buying, and then wrote something down, and closed the notebook, and walked away into the station without hurrying.

"Do you know him?" said von Hagen.

"No," she said.

"Good," he said, "because I do. That is Herr Kalbach of the Reichssicherheitshauptamt, and he has been trying to get his hands on my files for a year, and if he is on this platform then somebody in that building has made a mistake about me that I shall hear about in the spring." He put his glove on. "Get in, my dear."

The train went out of the Gare de l'Est at twenty past nine in the morning into the snow, and by eleven there was nothing but flat white fields and telegraph poles going backwards; and in the corridor behind her, at about the frontier, she heard a German soldier say to another, in the voice of a man announcing a fact about the weather: in the east the

war is different; and she sat with her hands in her lap and her papers in her bag, stamped, Austrian, and looked out of the window at her own country coming towards the carriage at sixty kilometres an hour, and understood that she was on the other side of the wheels, and that on the other side of the wheels was where she came from.

PART TWO

THE MASK

Warsaw, March – July 1944

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Road to the East

❦

The hotel in Berlin was in the Stresemannstrasse, three hundred metres from the Anhalter Bahnhof, and it had been taken over by the military administration in 1940 and had an officer's mess on the first floor with a chandelier that had survived the raids and a waiter of about seventy who had been there since before the other war.

They ate at a table with an Oberst of the SS and his adjutant and two civilians from the Ministry of Armaments, and the SS colonel was called Lanz and had a broad Swabian accent and a laugh he used the way a man uses a stamp, and his subject that evening was the east.

The east, according to Lanz, was not a country and not a front. It was an accounting problem, and it had been solved on paper in 1940 and the paperwork had never caught up with the arithmetic. There were four policies in operation in the Government General at once — a policy of labour, a policy of food, a policy of security and a policy which had no name and which the Ministry had asked about in writing — and none of the four offices knew what the other three were doing, and the reason for this was not chaos: it was design. "We have made a machine," he said, and he used we in the manner of a man who had never worn a uniform that got dirty, "which cannot be stopped by any one man, and cannot be understood by any one man, and

that is its guarantee. A hundred years from now, nobody will be able to work out who gave the order, because there was no order, there was a process, and processes do not go to prison."

The Colonel, who had been drinking steadily and pleasantly since seven, said, "The process, Herr Oberst, will be investigated in writing by someone with a lamp and a table, and the paper will be found, because the paper is always found. I have been in this service for twenty-two years and I know one thing only: no one has ever burned all of it."

"Then we must burn more," said Lanz, and laughed, and the two civilians looked at their plates, and the conversation went on to the price of Hungarian wine.

She sat at the end of the table in a dress of grey wool with the pearls at her throat and did what she did at tables: she ate little, drank less, laughed at the right places, and kept, in a room in her mind, the following list, which she wrote out at two o'clock that morning on the back of the folded hotel menu with a pencil taken from the bedside drawer.

Lanz, Ostbahn, Prague. Four policies, four offices, one of them without a name. Then, from the adjutant's small talk: that the SD's section in Warsaw had been moved into the aleja Szucha building in January, that the new man with the Polish name — let us be accurate, he is a Silesian — was making himself unpopular with the military administration by requisitioning files, and that the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison command was to be reorganized as of the first of March, which was tomorrow, and that the office had not been informed and would be informed by

telegram, which is the sort of thing an adjutant says when he is tired and important.

She also, in the corridor outside the dining room, while Lanz was having his coat brought, learned one more thing for nothing. The adjutant, who had been looking at her since the soup, said: "You are travelling to Warsaw, Fräulein. Take my advice and do not carry anything made of leather. They are taking leather at the frontier this month — handbags, cases, gloves — for the army, and a lady's bag made in Paris is worth a year of a customs officer's life, and he will take it, and he will be polite about it, and it will not be on any list." So she carried the compact with the false floor in her hand, and the pearls in the lining of her shoe, and the pencil-written list of the four policies in her glove.

❦

The Ostbahn went north-east across the flat land of the Reich and then, at Kutno, over a line in the snow that was not a frontier in the sense of a wall or a fence; it was a line of lorries and a sentry post and a wooden building with a red-and-white pole, and beyond it the same fields and the same pines and the same snow with a different set of names on everything.

She had spent four years telling men what her views on Poland were, and had an answer for every question they could ask, and she sat in the corner of an officer's carriage for nine hours with a book open on her knee — a French novel, the only book in her case, because a book in Polish was a document and a book in German was a claim — and

watched her own country arrive through the window in a series of specific facts, none of which she could say out loud.

The stations were the first fact. At every station there was snow and a queue: a queue for water at the pump, a queue outside a shop with a plank across the door, a queue of children by a heap of coal dust sweeping it into sacks with their hands. At two of the stations there were German soldiers throwing bread from the carriage windows to the children, and a man with a camera taking pictures of them doing it, and the children ran and the soldiers laughed and called them by a word she had heard eleven thousand times in Paris and had never heard from a Pole; and one of the children, a boy of about eight, got the bread and did not eat it, and walked off with it held flat against his chest with both hands, past the platform's end, into the snow, out of the photograph.

At a station whose name she never learned there was a siding, and on the siding, thirty metres from the passenger platform, eight cattle trucks stood with their doors wired shut with a double twist of wire and their ventilation slats closed by boards nailed across from the inside; and the snow had been on them for a day and there was no one near them at all. Everybody in the carriage looked at them for eleven seconds and then everybody looked at the newspaper, and the man opposite her, a paymaster with a chest full of ribbons from the other war, put out his hand with the bread roll in it and said, "Fräulein, you are not eating."

She and the Colonel and Rutz and the cases crossed the frontier of the Government General in the dark and went

on through the night, and she did not sleep; and at about four in the morning, while the Colonel snored in the seat opposite with his collar and his mouth open and his hand on the briefcase and the briefcase on his knee, she leaned across and lifted the case by the handle, one finger on the catch, and took it off his knee slowly enough that he would have woken, and set it on the floor between them, and left it there.

The last fact was a station in the dawn where there was nothing at all to look at: a shed, a water tower, a man in a Polish railway uniform of the pre-war cut, the collar of his coat turned up, walking down the platform with a red lamp in his hand in the grey light, and no German at all anywhere in the frame, only a Polish railwayman going about his work on the railway that had been his work since 1928; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna looked at that man from the window of an officer's carriage for the twenty seconds the train took to go past him, and understood that she had come home, and put her hand flat on the cold glass, and the man did not look up.

❦

Warsaw Ostbahnhof on the evening of the first of March 1944 was a platform with two hundred people on it, four arc lamps, a snow-fog standing in the air, orders shouted in Polish and German at once, and a crowd of men with hand sledges waiting behind a rope for the luggage of the officers' carriage.

She stood by the cases with her fur collar up and let it come in through all of her senses at once, the way a person

lets cold water in: the smell of wet wool and coal smoke and pine, and under it the smell of a city in the fourth winter of an occupation, which has no name and is made of drains and dust and something burnt that has been burnt a long time ago; the sound of the language, in the station announcements and the porters and the two women on the far platform with their arms full of bundles, in the ordinary, tired, flattened Polish of a people at the end of a working day; and the snow, grey and trodden and crusted, with the marks of a hundred sleigh runners in it, and the whistle of a locomotive four hundred metres away, and a bell.

Then the car came up on the station forecourt with its headlamps masked, and Rutz put the cases in and jumped to hold the door, and the Colonel got in beside her with his gloves in his hands, and said, "Well. Here we are," and the car went out of the station and into the city.

She had prepared herself, in the way a person prepares, for the sight of it: the ruin, the posters, the queues, the German signs. What she had not prepared herself for was the geography of a city seen from a car at night in the winter of 1944, in which whole streets existed and were exactly as they had been, and whole blocks were gone; in which the tram rails ran through the snow as they always had and the tram stopped at a corner where there was no longer a corner; and in which the car, turning out of the station quarter, came on to a long straight street that she had walked on every day of her childhood, with the same kiosks, and the same plane trees, and, in the space where a block of four buildings had stood in 1939, a heap of brick with the wall of a stairwell

standing in it and the ironwork of a staircase spiralling up into the air with nothing attached to it, like a drawing in a book about architecture.

"Look at that," said von Hagen, with real satisfaction. "The Poles in this city have been building for eleven months. You will not believe how much of it is standing. The Wehrmacht has put twenty thousand men on repair work since December — bridges, the water, the tram lines, the gas — and the city is fuller than it has ever been, because everything from the east that can walk is coming west with a handcart." He looked out of the window. "It is the busiest city in Europe and it is a ruin. Both things are true. It is what I like about it."

The German quarter began at the Ujazdowski Park and curled around it: the villas of the ministries, the requisitioned houses with the sentries and the masked lamps and the cars parked nose-in along the kerbs, the cafés where the waiters spoke German, and the pavements, in the middle of the German quarter, at eight in the evening, absolutely empty of Poles, because a Pole in that quarter after dark is a person with one chance.

The car turned off Bracka Street and stopped at a gate in a garden wall, and the sentry at the gate came to the window and looked in at the Colonel's face and stepped back and opened it, and the car went up a short gravel drive between banks of frozen snow to a white villa standing behind three bare trees.

The brass plate by the door read ZALESKI. Nobody had unscrewed it, and it had been there since 1940, and it was the last thing she saw before the door was opened by a

Polish woman in a black dress who looked at the floor and said, in German, out of a mouth that had been taught the words the way a bird is taught them, "Good evening, gnädige Frau."

❦

The house took forty minutes to walk through, and she did it with her coat still on, at half past eight in the evening, with the Colonel in front of her and Rutz behind her with a lamp, and the woman in the black dress standing in the kitchen doorway like a person waiting to be told whether she still had a job.

There were eight rooms on two floors and a cellar and a garden of nine hundred square metres with three trees, a shed and a well that had been filled in with rubble in 1939. On the ground floor there was a hall with a tiled stove, a dining room with a table for twelve and a sideboard that had been German property since 1940 and French property for a century before that, a drawing room with a piano and no furniture except four chairs and the piano, and a study with a desk, a telephone, two maps of the Warsaw district taken down from the wall and stacked behind the bookcase, and a safe.

The safe was a good one, a Viennese make of the nineteen-twenties with a three-tumbler lock, and it stood on the floor at the end of the study behind a lithograph in a plain black frame: a view of the Lilpop works at Burakowska Street, the big ironworks where the whole of her childhood's Warsaw had bought its axles and its cooking stoves, with the chimneys and the rail sidings and, in the corner, printed in

1913, the name of the firm in Polish. The Colonel had bought the lithograph in a shop on the Krakowskie Przedmieście in 1941 with a certificate of lawful purchase signed by an officer of his own staff, and he liked it, in the way of a man who likes an object for the shape of it, and by the end of the evening she had established three facts about the safe: that the key was not in the house, that the combination was not written anywhere in the house, and that the studies of the lock which she had learned in nine weeks in a flat above a laundry in 1942 would not open it and had never been intended to.

The piano in the drawing room was a Bechstein of about 1900, and it was out of tune by a semitone and had been for years, and the stool had a hinged lid; and under the lid was the sheet music of the family that had the plate on the wall outside, a stack of it two inches thick: Czerny, Schumann's Album for the Young, a set of Chopin preludes with the fingering pencilled in by a child in a hand that had been taught in a private school, the four-hands arrangement of a piece by Paderewski, and, right at the bottom, the score of a Polish opera with a name written inside the cover, in ink, in the neat teacher's script of a girl of about fourteen, and a date: 1938.

Nobody had touched the stool in four years. It was a good place to put things and she did not use it and never told anyone that she had looked.

Her room was the second room on the first floor and had a window on the garden, and the Colonel's room was the first, and between them there was a bathroom with a

geyser, and the arrangement had been explained to her on the way out of Berlin in the tone of a man announcing a practical solution: "You will have the room next to mine as before. In Paris there were people. Here there are more."

She unpacked her own case. Rutz had brought it up and set it on the luggage bench at the end of the bed and had asked whether the Fräulein wanted anything pressed in the morning and she had said no, and he had gone; and then she unpacked it herself, item by item, standing in her coat with her gloves on, because the woman in the black dress was at the foot of the stairs with her hands folded and the maid's bell over the doorbell had rung three times in the hour they had been in the house and each time it had been for the Colonel, and there was no version of that first night in which a Pole carried a fur coat up the stairs for her.

The woman in the black dress was called Janina. She was about forty-five and had been at the house since 1940, and before that she had been at the same house for the family whose name was on the plate, and before that she had come from a village near Sandomierz; and when Krystyna said good night to her in Polish, at the door of the kitchen, the woman looked at her, once, full in the face, for exactly as long as it takes to read a name off a page — and then looked at the floor, and said good night in German, and shut the kitchen door.

❦

On the morning of the second of March she went out at half past ten with a pretext she had made the night before,

which was that she wanted to find a bookseller and a chemist's shop.

The Colonel said, "Take Rutz and the car," and she said that a woman who is driven to a chemist's shop in an occupied city is an object of interest to six separate offices, and he laughed and said that for a woman who had been kept by a colonel for eight months she had an unusual relationship with publicity; so she went out on foot at half past ten with her Paris shoes and her fur coat and her papers in her bag, and Rutz watched her from the window of the study with the notebook in his hand and did not follow her, and she walked down the gravel to the gate and out into the street, and turned left, and began.

The Krakowskie Przedmieście and the Nowy Świat were one street, and they were the street of her childhood: the church of the Holy Cross where she had been at midnight mass in 1935 with her mother's hand in the crook of her elbow, the university with its palm tree, the bookshops, the pastry cook's, the house with the baroque door-cases where a friend of her aunt's had had six rooms and now had one.

The street had been renamed. The whole of the city, at some point in 1940, had been renamed: the plac Piłsudskiego was called Adolf-Hitler-Platz, the aleja Szucha was the Strasse der Polizei, and the Nowy Świat had a German name that she never once managed to say out loud in four years, and the tram stop signs were in German and Polish, and the German came first and was bigger, which she noted in the way she noted the smell of the place: without comment, in the file.

There were three things on the street that morning that she had never seen in Paris.

The first was the notices. They were pasted on kiosks and on the walls of buildings and on a purpose-built stand at the corner of the Świętokrzyska, and they were German proclamations, printed on grey paper in Polish and German, of the executions that had been carried out in the city in the preceding week: the date, the district, the number of persons, and the names in two columns, also the names in the cells of the Pawiak, and, at the foot of each notice, the sentence that said that this was done by way of reprisal and that the responsibility lay with those who had done the murders of German soldiers. Four people were reading it, in the way people read such a notice: in silence, at a distance from each other, in the cold; a woman of about sixty, a man in a railwayman's coat, a boy of fifteen, and a girl with a basket, and none of them said a word and the wind had come under one corner of the sheet and lifted it, and the man in the railwayman's coat put out his hand and pressed the corner flat against the wall to stop it flapping, and then went away.

The second was the loudspeaker. It was on a pole at the corner of the Świętokrzyska and the Nowy Świat, at a height of about four metres, and it had been there since 1943 and it played from eight in the morning until nine at night: propaganda in Polish, in a voice that the city had a name for — the barker — the news read out from the German papers, and the instructions to the population about the surrender of weapons, about black market prices, about the punishment of those who helped the partisans; and it was the

loudest single sound in Warsaw, and it came out of the machine as a stream of ordinary Polish sentences in a flat, cheerful, unpunctuated voice, and she stood on the pavement in her fur coat and listened to the language of her own country being spoken by a wooden box, and everything in her body made a movement that had to be stopped at the neck.

The third was chalk. On the wall of a courtyard on a side street, at the height of a man's shoulder, somebody had drawn in chalk a figure that looked at first glance like a simple anchor, an anchor with a curving line of cable, drawn quickly and badly and with the tail of the P roughly done — the mark that the resistance used, the anchor that stands for Poland Fighting — and somebody else had walked past since with a wet rag and smeared the middle of the chalk so that the mark could still be read by anybody who knew it and could not be described as such by anybody who did not; and she stood in front of that wall for a second and a half, which was a second longer than was wise, because the two men in the courtyard gateway were watching to see whether the woman in the fur coat would stop at the anchor; and she walked on.

She was not recognised.

That is the thing she had feared for three years, in the flat above the laundry, in the fittings at Odile's, in the bed of the Colonel in the house on the avenue Henri-Martin: not one person, but the city itself, and the city did not know her. No one looked at her twice. She passed three women of her mother's generation in a quarter where her mother had

been known by name, and they looked at her coat and her shoes and her mouth and their eyes went over her face without stopping, because a face is the last thing a Pole in the fourth year of the occupation looks at; and a boy of about seventeen, selling the Nowy Kurier Warszawski from a board at the corner of the Nowy Świat with a stack of newsprint under a brick, looked at her for as long as it took to decide that she was a German lady and therefore no custom of his, and then looked at her shoes with the expression of a person looking at something out of a shop window, and then, as she went past, spat on the pavement — not at her, at the pavement, three feet behind her, and she heard it and did not turn around, and she got to the corner of the Świętokrzyska and stood there with her hands in her coat pockets and found that she was not able to breathe properly, and had to stand for eleven seconds and count, the way she had been taught to count, before she could go on.

❦

She walked to her own house at twenty past eleven in the morning.

The palace on the Nowy Świat had been built in 1780 with a courtyard behind a Doric gate and the family's arms in the pediment, and it had been her father's house, and before that her grandfather's, and the sale of it had been arranged in 1940 by the German administration in the manner of all such arrangements: a letter, a valuation, a hearing, a period of fourteen days, a payment into a blocked account, and a requisition paper, which had arrived with the courtesy of a firm of architects and had told the family that

the house had been taken over "for the duration of the present emergency".

Two things had been nailed to the pediment since. The first was a sign, painted on a board in the standard lettering of the administration, black on white: MILITÄR-KRAFT-FAHRPARK, and under it in smaller letters the designation of the department, and, at the top of the sign, the eagle.

The second was a lamp. It hung on an iron bracket over the gate of the courtyard where the carriages had stood, and it was lit at twenty past eleven in the morning, because the workshops were in the outbuildings and the pit was under the coachhouse floor, and a mechanic's lamp on a long cable was hung on a nail under the gate arch and went on burning all day, so that the courtyard had a cone of yellow light in it at eleven in the morning with the snow coming down through the light in small separate flakes.

In the courtyard there were two lorries with their bonnets up and one with its bonnet down, and a Kübelwagen, and a small mountain of tyres under a tarpaulin, and four soldiers working, and a wheel off a lorry standing by itself in a puddle of melted snow. In the corner where the well had been, in the corner of the courtyard where her mother used to have a fir tree put up at Christmas for the children of the household's servants with a candle on every branch, there were two oil drums and a heap of coal.

She stood on the far pavement for four minutes.

The sentry at the gate looked at her twice, the second time with a little more attention, because a woman in a fur coat looking at a motor pool for four minutes is a thing that

gets reported in the barracks that evening; and a man came out of the gate with a delivery book and a pencil behind his ear and looked at her and said something to the sentry and laughed — and she turned and walked on, up the Nowy Świat towards the brow of the hill, and did not cry, and did not pray, and did the other thing that she had been doing since 1940, which was to inventory: the gate had a sentry in the daytime only, and there was a bell that had been out of order since 1939; the lamp over the arch was on an iron bracket with a screw eye that would take a wire; the lorry park held eight vehicles in the courtyard and the outbuildings would take more; the coal heap was against the wall of what had been her mother's morning room; and the snow on the roof of the north wing had not been cleared and the gutter had pulled away from the wall in the corner, and if they did not clear it, the water would come down the wall in the spring and take the plaster off the drawing room, which had a painted ceiling of 1791, and nobody would care, and it would be gone, and she inventoried that too, because it was on the list.

❦

The coal depot was two streets further on, on the corner of a courtyard, and there was a queue of about thirty people outside it in the snow: women with their heads wrapped, a man with a handcart, two boys kicking a stone, and an old woman with a sack on the ground in front of her.

She did not see her father at first. She saw the coat: grey, with the cuffs turned, with the collar too wide for the man in it, and then she saw the shoulders inside the coat and the

back of the neck above the collar, and the neck was a very old man's neck, thin and white and bent forward, and there was a leather satchel over his shoulder, the satchel he had carried to the school in the years when he was still permitted to teach, and there were two dictionaries in it, and she knew that from the way it hung.

He was standing at the head of the queue with his feet on the snow in worn boots and his hat in his hand and his hand on the satchel strap, looking at the ground; and his hair was white, all of it, which it had not been; and he was — she measured it in the two seconds the measurement took, the way she had been trained — about nine kilos lighter than the man who had stood in the hall of the flat on Mokotowska Street in September 1939 with a lamp in his hand and said Niemiec to a boy in a German coat.

She was fifty-five metres away, on the far pavement, and her body was crossing the street before her mind had finished with the first sentence.

She got off the far kerb. There were five or six cars a minute on that street in 1944 and about forty pedestrians, and there were four people in the queue within fifteen metres of him, and the ones who would look at a woman coming across the road towards an old man would be the woman with the sack and the man with the handcart and the two boys and probably the entire queue, because a queue in Warsaw in 1944 is an audience with nothing else to do; and she was in the roadway, in the slush, three metres into it, when the car came round the corner of the Świętokrzyska with its headlamps on and slowed and stopped at the kerb in front of her, and the orderly in the front seat got

out and came round the bonnet and opened the rear door and stood there holding it.

She stood in the middle of the road with the snow in her eyes and looked at the open door of the car, and looked back at the queue, which had begun to look at her, all of them, thirty faces, because a stopped German car on that street was the only event in the day; and her father had turned his head by then — he had turned it at the sound of the car, in the way of a man of sixty-seven, and he was looking at the road, at the car, at a woman's back in a fur coat getting into the back of a car with a German orderly holding the door, and she got in because there was nothing else to do with her body at that moment that did not end with a German soldier asking a Polish schoolmaster a question.

The door shut.

The car went on down the Świętokrzyska towards the German quarter, and she sat with her hands in her lap and her eyes on the back of the orderly's neck; and von Hagen, who was in the other corner of the back seat with a bundle of papers on his knee and his spectacles on, said, "You have been walking. Rutz tells me you were not recognised; I find that very hard to believe and I have decided to believe it."

"Where did you come from?"

"The office. I have been in the office since seven and I shall be in it until ten tonight for the next eleven days, because the counter-intelligence section of this garrison is now mine as of this morning, and the whole thing has been kept in a drawer by a man in a cavalry coat who has not written an honest line of paper since 1941." He took his spectacles

off and folded them. "Which brings me to a domestic matter, and I want to say it once and then not again. Your papers are in order. Your ration book is in the drawer of the desk in the study, which is not locked, because nothing in that house is locked and nothing in that house is to be discussed on a telephone. The house is yours to run with Janina; she is a good cook and she will never like you, and you will not reproach her for it. You will have the car when you want it and Rutz when you do not, and the car has the right of the German administration to be on this city's streets after curfew, which is the only liberty in Warsaw that is worth anything." He looked out of the window at the ruins going past. "And you will not walk in this city alone. Not in the German quarter, not on the Nowy Świat, not to a chemist's shop. I have not asked you to be a prisoner, my dear; you are free to go anywhere you please, provided that you go in the car and come back in it. There are eleven of them in this town now, in the SD's building on the Szucha and in the Abwehr's office and in the police stations, and every one of them would be delighted to be the man who was seen with the Colonel's woman on the Nowy Świat at eleven o'clock in the morning."

He put the spectacles back on and unfolded the papers.

"You have come to a beautiful city," he said, "and it is not a city you can walk in, and I am telling you this because you are the first thing in my life that is pleasant, and I have no intention of losing you in a street in Warsaw for the sake of a chemist's shop."

CHAPTER NINE

The House of the Hound

❦

She had two things for Warsaw and both of them came from Wiktor, and she had carried them across Europe in the only place she had: in her head, and in the order he had made her learn them, which was the address first and the sentence second, because a person who is being questioned will give up a sentence sooner than an address and it saves nothing.

The address was a stationer's shop, number 11 Śliska Street: paper, notebooks, ink, pencils, envelopes, and in the window a display of leather goods — briefcases, wallets, two attaché cases — which had been in that window since 1938 and which nobody had bought since 1939.

The sentence was: I have brought a message from my aunt in Lwów.

And the rules were four, and they were Wiktor's rules and they were made for a country he had left in 1939 and had been told about by men who had not been back either: go once, and if the woman in the shop does not answer correctly, do not go a second time; never go in the car; never go at the same hour twice; and after the first visit, expect to be watched for ten days by somebody who will not be a professional, because in Poland the amateurs are the ones who are still alive.

On the sixth of March, at four in the afternoon, in a temperature of minus six, she went into the shop on Śliska Street in an astrakhan hat that was wrong for the quarter and bought a notebook and a pencil and a box of nibs; and there was a woman behind the counter with grey hair pinned up and an apron, and there was nobody else in the shop at all.

"The nibs are for a good pen," the woman said. "Those are for a bad one."

"I have brought a message from my aunt in Lwów," said Krystyna.

The woman put the box of nibs on the counter and looked at her for three seconds — at the coat, at the hat, at the mouth — and said, in the same flat voice in which she had discussed the nibs: "I have no aunt in Lwów and neither has anyone in this shop, and the last man who said that to me was taken in the street in front of my window in November, and if you come here again I will have you reported to the police myself, and I will enjoy it." She pushed the notebook across the counter. "That will be one zloty eighty."

So: once. That was the rule, and the rule was the whole of the value, and Krystyna paid for the notebook, and said thank you, and went out into the snow and did not go back, and did not look at the window, and walked east along Śliska towards the ruins.

Now she had nothing at all: no address, no sentence, no contact, no handler, and a city that had four hundred thousand people in it who would each have liked to see her dead for the coat she was wearing.

She went home and did her arithmetic again, which is the only thing a person in that position can do, and which took her a day and a half, and which came out in the following form: that she was not invisible, that she had arrived in the German quarter in a German car, that she had been seen on the Nowy Świat at eleven in the morning looking at the posters and at the motor pool, and that a city in the fifth year of an occupation has more eyes per square metre than anywhere else on earth, and that some of those eyes belong to the sort of people who put a chalk anchor on a wall in the Świętokrzyska street.

So she became visible on purpose.

It is a piece of tradecraft that Wiktor had made her practise for a week in Paris in 1942 in a corridor in a government office with a stopwatch, and the theory of it is this: if you are going to be watched, choose the watcher, and the way to choose the watcher is to give the watchers a pattern so clean and so dull that only one sort of person will care about it — and then that person is yours.

For four days she did the same thing: the car to the office at nine; the car back at one; and then, in the afternoon, the same errand on foot with Rutz at four metres and waiting in the street, because Rutz was a soul of the old army and had been in the house since before either of them had thought about the east, and because a Furier who has been told to accompany a lady does not shadow her, he accompanies her with his hands behind his back.

In four afternoons she went to the same six places. The church on the Krakowskie Przedmieście where the nuns said

the office at three. The second-hand bookshop on the Świętokrzyska where she bought two French novels and left them on the counter for an hour while she looked at the shelf behind. The window of the pharmacy at the corner of Szpitalna Street. The confectioner's where there was nothing to buy but there was a window with a marble sill and a chair. The passage on the Świętokrzyska, where she went in at one end and out at the other, and which has a courtyard in the middle with a well and a coal shed and a gate on to the next street. The bookshop on the Nowy Świat with the sign of the pelican over the door.

And at the end of the fourth afternoon, a boy of fourteen in a coat four sizes too big for him was standing in the passage on the Świętokrzyska kicking a rag football against the wall, and he said, without looking at her, in Polish, in the voice of a person reciting something he had been made to learn: "The pelican is shut on Thursday and the gentleman's coat is inside out."

Then he kicked the ball again, and it went over the fence into the yard of a house, and he climbed after it, and by the time she had walked the length of the passage there was nobody in the passage at all.

Inside out. The coat inside out.

The sixth place on her list was a second-hand clothes shop on the Śródmieście side of Marszałkowska, which had a rack of coats in the doorway and a mirror and a woman asleep behind the counter; and she went in on the afternoon of the tenth of March and bought nothing and looked at the mirror and understood the instruction, which was that a

person cannot turn a coat inside out in the street, and that the place where a person turns a coat inside out is a courtyard, and that there was a courtyard with a coal shed in it in the passage on the Świętokrzyska.

So on the eleventh she went into the passage at four in the afternoon with Rutz four metres behind her, and turned into the courtyard as if she had mistaken it for a shortcut, and behind the coal shed, out of sight of the street for something between six and nine seconds, she took off the astrakhan coat and put it on again wrong side out, which is a thing that takes four seconds if a person has practised it in a corridor in Paris in 1942, and went out of the other gate into the next street with the fur inside and the lining outside, in which she was a woman in an old black cloth coat with a silk lining, and Rutz came after her with his hands behind his back and said, in the flat voice of a man who has decided not to see whatever it was: "The Fräulein is cold."

"The Fräulein is cold. Let us go home, Emil."

They went home. And the following morning, at nine, when the car came up the drive, there was a boy of about sixteen in a cloth cap standing at the gate, and he came to the window of the car and put a piece of paper in Rutz's hand and ran off, and Rutz gave her the paper and she unfolded it in the car and read it and put it in her glove, and it said, in pencil, in Polish, in a schoolboy's hand: Thursday, the workshop on Śliska, the fourth courtyard, the cellar under the bench, seven in the evening. Come alone and come in the coat.

The fourth courtyard on Śliska Street, on the sixteenth of March at seven in the evening, was the courtyard of a two-storey building that had once made agricultural machinery and now made handcarts, and it was dark, and there was a smell of snow and iron and coal, and the gate was open, and there was a light moving behind the third window on the ground floor: a flame, not a bulb.

The cellar under the workshop had a stone floor and a barrel-vaulted ceiling and whitewashed walls gone the colour of weak tea, and it was eight paces by four, and there was a table made of two doors on trestles, and on the table a candle in a jam jar with a paper collar, and beside the candle a pistol.

There were two people in the room.

The woman was about thirty, and she was sitting on the far side of the table with her back to the wall and her hands on the table in front of her, and she was wearing a good dark suit that was four years old and had been altered twice, and her hair was cut short and cut badly, and she had the face of a woman who has slept four hours a night for two years. She was, in fact, beautiful, in the way that a locked door is beautiful: the whole of the effect was in what it refused.

The man was standing behind her to the right, in the corner, in the dark, with his back to the wall and his arms folded, about forty-five, going grey and going heavy, in spectacles and a shabby overcoat. He did not sit down at any point in the next two hours, and he did not speak until the end.

"Sit down and put your hands on the table," the woman said.

Krystyna sat down and put her hands on the table.

"You are Stankiewicz," the woman said.

"I was."

"You are Stankiewicz, you are twenty-four years old, you were at school at the Sacred Heart until 1937 and at the flat on Mokotowska Street, and in September 1939 you went south to relations, and in June 1940 you went to France through a labour recruitment scheme and you have been in France since. In France you were the mistress of an Oberst of the Militärbefehlshaber in Paris, and you have come to Warsaw with him, and you live in a villa on the Frascati that was taken from the Zaleskis, and you have brought nothing with you that anybody here can use. That is what we have. If any of it is wrong, say so now, because I shall be writing it in a ledger in either case and I do not want an error in my own handwriting."

"One thing is wrong," said Krystyna. "I did not have one Oberst in Paris. I have one Oberst in Paris and now in Warsaw, and he is the same man, and I have been his mistress since June 1943."

The woman looked at her for a moment longer than she had before.

"Add that to the ledger," she said.

Then the questioning started, and it went on for two hours in the cold, and it was conducted in the manner of an enquiry, not an interrogation: the questions were put in order, one at a time, and each answer was written down by the man in the corner in a small hand in a notebook that he did not look at while he wrote.

Who trained her. Where and when, and by whom, and the name of the flat and the number of the weeks. When she had arrived in Paris, by which route, through which frontier, with whose money. What she had done in Paris in 1941, in 1942, in 1943. The trade she had for her cover, the dressmaker with the German licence, the fittings, the papers, the identity card's number; the name of the Austrian town she had never visited and the street of the school she had never attended, and she gave them, all of it, in order, twice, because they asked twice; and she noticed that the second asking was not to catch her out but to test the memory, which is a different and much more frightening thing, because the memory can be trained and the man in the corner knew it and was writing down whether she had been trained.

At half past eight the woman said, "Now the paper."

"What paper?"

"The paper, Stankiewicz. Every officer in this city has a desk, and every desk has paper on it, and the papers on that desk are the only reason you are sitting at this table instead of being sick into a bucket in the basement of the Szucha. Describe the last piece of paper you saw in that house, and do not describe it as a woman who has been in a house. Describe it as a typist."

So she described it as a typist: the departmental heading, the reference number, the layout, the routing block on the reverse side with four initials and a date stamp, the carbon. When she had done it, the woman on the other side of the table nodded once, slightly, in the way in which a professional acknowledges that a colleague's hands are clean, and said, "Whose initials?"

"Mine," said Krystyna. "The initials on the routing block are his, and mine are under them, because I file the copies. In that office I am not a woman who is kept. I am a woman who is employed, and I am paid, and the pay is in the salary book of the administration, and there are eleven people in that building who have seen my hands on a filing tray."

"Good," the woman said, and then she asked the question, and she asked it the way she had asked all the others, without any change in her voice at all. "Did you enjoy it?"

The man in the corner stopped writing.

"Which part?"

"The bed, Stankiewicz. Which part do you think I mean?"

"No," said Krystyna.

"Say that again and look at me."

"No."

"Twice is twice," said the woman, and closed the notebook that was on the table in front of her, which had nothing written in it, and which had been there to be closed at the right moment. "Now listen, because there are no more questions and everything after this is terms." She put her hands flat on the table. "My name is Iga Zaleska. It is not my name; it was on the brass plate of a house on the Frascati until 1940, when the family was taken out of it and sent to the other side of the wall, and I took the name afterwards because names of the dead are the safest paper in this city, and because it means that every time I walk down that street I have to look at my own front door with an eagle over it. There is a man in this room whose name you will not be giv-

en, and he is a lawyer by profession and he has been a soldier since 1939, and he has decided that you are worth this meeting, and against my advice."

"You are recorded as dead," said the man in the corner.

It was the first time he had spoken, and the voice was a light, dry, precise voice, and it came out of the dark of the corner with no emotion in it whatever, and it was not a statement about her but about the file.

"In June 1940 your family informed the parish, the police and the building that you had died of typhus in a hospital in Toulouse. There is a mass said for you once a year in the church on the Mokotowska Street. Your sister wears your mother's ring on a string round her neck and your father has your photograph in a Latin dictionary. That was done by your father in the first month of the occupation and it has been maintained for four years, and if it is discovered that you are alive — by anyone, for any reason, including your family, including by your own hand — the story will not survive three days." He took his spectacles off and polished them on his sleeve and put them back on. "Which is why I am telling you now, before you are given a single task. You will not go to Mokotowska Street. You will not speak to your sister. You will not write. If you are seen within a hundred metres of that building by one of our people, you will be taken off the street and held, and you will be held for as long as this war lasts. That would be very bad for you, and it would be very bad for your father, who is ill, and who is being kept alive by three people, one of whom is seventeen."

The candle on the table in the jam jar leaned sideways in the draft from the door and stood up again.

"Those are the terms," Iga Zaleska said. "Paper: nothing in writing, ever; nothing you are given is to be written down, and nothing you take is to be carried on your body unless you are prepared to eat it, which you cannot do, so you will memorise and carry it in your head and deliver it in the same form. Contact: with me only, by arrangement, on days and at places that I shall change every time; if I do not come, you leave, and you do not come back to that place for a month. Family: as the Major has said; the subject is closed and will not be raised again in front of me. Delivery: you will bring me something within ten days that I cannot buy, and after that we will talk about the eleventh day." She pushed the pistol half a hand's width along the table and back again, which seemed to be a habit. "If you fail us, or if we believe you have failed us, the arrangement ends at a place and an hour of our choosing, and it ends with a small notice in the Nowy Kurier under the executions, and no explanation to anybody, including your family, who will go on believing that you died of typhus in Toulouse. I am telling you this in words because the rules are the rules and you are a professional and you will want them said out loud."

"They are said."

"Then here is the shopping list," Iga said, and now something in the room changed, because this was not the security and this was the work, and the work is what she had come for and it was coming out of the woman's mouth one item

at a time, in the manner of a person reading a bill. "One: the staff list of the garrison command, with the names and the ranks of the officers and the departments they came from, because there is a new establishment in this city as of the first of March and nobody outside it knows what is in it. Two: the garrison's engineer records — the bridges, the crossings, the culverts, the state of the road and rail bridges over the Vistula, and who is responsible for them and what is loaded under them, because there are charges under two of them and we did not put them there. Three: the ration and fuel allocations for the civil population of this city as issued in February and March, from which a trained eye can read how many people the Germans intend to feed in the summer, and therefore what they intend to do with this city. Four, and this is the last, and it is not a document." She leaned back against the wall. "I want one sentence from your Colonel's mouth. I want to know whether the Germans in Warsaw intend to hold this city when the Russians come, or to level it and leave. He will know. Every officer of his rank in this city has been told something, and it is the thing they talk about at dinner, and it is the only thing in the whole of this business that cannot be read off a piece of paper."

"He will know," Krystyna said.

"Yes," said the man in the corner. "That is what we are betting on. Forty people are betting their lives on it in this room, and I include you, and I have written the date in the notebook." He put the notebook in his inside pocket and stood away from the wall and looked at her for the first time that evening, and his face in the candlelight was tired rather

than hard, and he said: "You have brought me gold, and it was carried through a German's house on the hips of a Polish girl. I am not a priest and I do not care. Bring more."

Then he went up the cellar steps and out into the courtyard, and the door shut, and Iga Zaleska sat looking at the candle for a moment, and said, without any change of tone at all:

"You will need money and you will not be given any. You will need papers and you will not be given any. You will have one thing that is worth more than both, which is that German officers have been trained for two hundred years to believe that a woman in a bedroom is not a filing cabinet, and all of them believe it, and you are going to make them keep believing it, and there is nobody in this country who does not know that." She stood up and put the pistol into the inside pocket of her jacket with one movement, the muzzle down and the hand flat. "The password for the next arrangement is not a password; it is a piece of paper, and the piece of paper is this." She took from her sleeve a cigarette packet, drew out of it a cigarette already rolled, and snapped it in half, and gave Krystyna one half. "When you are given the other half, you will know that I have sent for you. Keep it dry, keep it out of the house, and do not smoke."

❦

Walking home, in the snow, with the coat the right way out again and Rutz forty metres behind her at the end of Śliska waiting with the car, she came past two women in the gateway of a courtyard on the corner of the Żelazna, and one of them was holding a hand-barrow with a pianino on it

wrapped in sacking and tied with rope, and the two of them were arguing about whether the legs would come off or whether the whole thing had to be carried in two pieces up to the second floor.

"—because it is not my piano and I am not paying the joiner a single zloty, and the woman can carry it up her own stairs if she wants it on the second floor—"

"Which old man?"

"On Mokotowska, in the courtyard with the pump — the Stankiewicz, the old man who was at the school, the one who never comes out. Two rooms let to a widow and the rest of them in the back, and the girl selling whatever is not nailed down: my mistress bought a clock off her in January, and a coat, and now she wants the name of a joiner, or a horse, or anything that is not cabbage." The woman took a breath and adjusted the rope. "The old man is ill — he coughs all winter, my mistress hears it through the wall — and there is only the girl and the son, and the son is never there. And the other one died in France in the war, the older girl, typhus in a hospital in Toulouse, they had it in the family prayers for four years, and the mother died in '41. If the war ended tomorrow they would still be eating cabbage."

"Typhus in Toulouse."

"Typhus in Toulouse, and a fine thing it is to die of, in France, in a hospital. My sister's girl only got to Katowice."

Krystyna stood in the snow on the corner of the Żelazna and listened to the whole of it with her hands in her pockets like any other woman waiting for a tram, and nobody in the world looked at her, and she thought the following two things in the following order.

First: that the family had done it properly, and that a story which is kept up by a family for four years, in a mass once a year, in front of the neighbours, in front of the maid, is a piece of security work of a standard higher than anything the network in Paris had ever asked of her; that her father had understood, in the first month, that a living daughter in the German service would kill the family and that a dead daughter in France would keep them alive, and had done it himself, with her mother, in the dark, in the autumn of 1940, and never told her, because there was no way to tell her.

Second: that Hanna was selling the pianino to buy coal.

❦

She went to Mokotowska Street that night.

It was a quarter past eleven, and she had gone to bed with the light out and lain for forty minutes until the house was down: the Colonel asleep at ten to eleven, in his own room, with the door open as he liked it; Janina asleep over the kitchen; the sentry on the gravel at the gate turning every eleven minutes, which he had done in Paris and which he did here because the army is the army.

She went out through the pantry door into the garden, which had not been bolted because nothing in that house was bolted, and across the garden, and over the wall in the corner by the shed, in her shoes, in the snow, with her coat over her arm; and she walked nine hundred metres through the back streets of a city under curfew, in the dark, past one German patrol car standing at a corner with its lights off and one Polish man walking the other way who crossed the

street to avoid her, which is what a man does in a curfew city when he sees a woman walking alone and does not want to know why.

The courtyard on Mokotowska Street was the courtyard of her childhood: the gate with the iron bar at the bottom that a person had to lift, the yard with the pump and the four dustbins and the long shed where the caretaker had kept his coal, and the window of the flat on the first floor at the front, over the courtyard, which is the window she was not permitted to stand in and had stood in on the night of the third of September 1939 with her hands flat on the sill and a boy in the rain on the pavement below.

There was a light on in the corridor. It came through the transom over the door of the flat and it made a rectangle on the wall of the courtyard, and it moved once, slowly, from one side to the other, which is what a lamp does when a person carries it from one room to the next; and then the light in the corridor went out and another light came on, further back, in what had been her parents' room, and stayed on.

She stood in the courtyard for eleven minutes with the snow coming down through the light from the window and did not go up.

She could have gone up. That is the thing to say about that night, and it has to be said plainly, because a person's whole life is sometimes made of eleven minutes in a courtyard: there was no lock on the gate that she could not lift, there were sixty-one steps in that stairwell and she had counted them all her life, the door of the flat would be opened by her sister, who was seventeen, who had been sold to the

neighbours as an orphan of a typhus ward in Toulouse, and who was at that moment eleven metres above her, awake, because a girl of seventeen who is selling a pianino to buy coal does not sleep at midnight in a flat where her father is coughing.

And she did not go up, and the reason was not the terms, and the reason was not the Major, and the reason was not even the patrol car at the corner; and she knew what the reason was, in the courtyard, at eleven minutes past midnight, in the snow, in her own city, and it was this: that if she went up those stairs she would not be able to come down them again, and that on the other side of the door was the last thing in the world she had that was not already spent.

She took the cigarette half out of the lining of her glove and looked at it, and put it back.

She walked back through the gate, lifting the bar with her foot as she had done since she was seven years old, and was in the street with her head down against the snow when a girl came round the corner of the Wilcza running, in a coat over a nightgown, in boots two sizes too big with no laces in them, with a scarf round her chin, breathing hard, seventeen years old, with her mother's ring on a string round her neck under the nightgown, and stopped three metres away in the middle of the pavement with the snow coming down between them and did not move at all.

Krystyna did not move either.

The girl's face was her own face before the war had finished with it: the same grey eyes, the same high colour in the

cold, the bones their father's. She looked at Krystyna for four seconds — at the coat, at the shoes, at the hands, at the mouth — and then her mouth opened, and she said one word, out loud, in the street, in the snow, in the fifth year of the war, in a city where a German patrol could come round that corner in a car at any second of any night.

"Krysia?"

Chapter ten

The Brother

They could not go indoors, because there was no door in that city that could be shut on the two of them, and so the whole of what they had was ten minutes in the gateway of the courtyard on the Mokotowska Street, in the snow, in the dark, at twenty minutes past midnight on the eleventh of March 1944, two sisters standing a metre and a half apart and speaking in whispers with the whites of their eyes showing.

Hanna talked first because Hanna could not help it, and it came out in bursts, out of order, in the way a person empties a drawer onto a table: that she had known at once, at the first word, before the woman turned round, from the shape of the shoulders and the way she stood in the snow with her hands out of her pockets; that she had followed her from the courtyard a quarter of an hour before and had stood at the corner and watched her stand under the window for eleven minutes without counting, and had gone to fetch Tadeusz and come back, and that Tadeusz was at that moment in the arch of the courtyard on the other side of the Wilcza, waiting, because they had agreed that if it was not her he would walk past the end of the street and she would go home and they would never speak of it again.

"You knew at once," said Krystyna.

"At the first word," said Hanna. "At the way you said Krysia — no. Before. When you turned round. You turn your head the way you always turned it, sideways first and then the chin, and nobody else in this city turns their head like that, and if I have noticed it then so has somebody else, and you must stop it."

"Hanna."

"And you must not wear that coat into this street again, and you must not come at night, and there is a man on the corner of the Wilcza in a leather coat and I know him and he knows me, and if he sees you twice he will sell the information for a hundred zlotys and a bottle, and Tadeusz says—" She stopped. "He is angry."

"Where is he?"

"In the arch. He has been there twenty minutes. He said you were to come to him and not the other way round, and he said—" and here Hanna stopped again, and her face did something complicated in the dark, and she said, in a completely different voice, quieter and older: "He said, if it is her, I will see her alone first."

So they stood in the gateway for the ten minutes that the two of them had, and Krystyna asked the questions, and Hanna answered them, and the whole of the family's four years came across those eighteen inches of frozen air in a series of practical sentences, delivered in the order a seventeen-year-old thinks they should be delivered in, which was not the order of importance.

Mother died in the flat in the second week of March 1941, of pneumonia, after three weeks of a fever in which

she had stopped recognising the neighbours on the fourth day and had never stopped recognising her daughters; the doctor did not come, because the doctor for that district had been arrested in January for signing a false Kennkarte, and the doctor they found on the fourth day wanted two hundred zlotys and a bottle of spirit and did not come either. Hanna had been sent for the priest at six in the morning. She came back with the priest and a neighbour, and the priest was too late by a quarter of an hour, and she has not been able to walk up the stairs of that building without hearing it ever since.

Father taught Latin, four boys, three afternoons a week, at the flat on Żelazna Street of a man who had been his student at the Gimnazjum in 1924 and who now had a pharmacy's licence and a black market and a soft heart; twenty zlotys a lesson and a kilo of bread a week, and the boys came with their own chairs because there were not enough in the flat, and one of them was the son of a German-speaking accountant and was learning the Latin for the same reason that Poles had been learning Latin since 1795, which is that the examined languages of an empire are useful and the dead one is a country.

Tadeusz was in a sabotage unit of the Home Army in the Śródmieście, and had derailed two trains and burned a warehouse of leather on the Wola side in October, and had been carrying the work for a year and a half, and drank on Fridays with his section and was quiet on Sundays with his father, and was, Hanna said, in the flat voice of somebody reporting an inspection, "not all right, and he will not be

told anything by anybody, and since mother died he has only got one subject and it is you."

And the story: the typhus, the hospital in Toulouse, the month of June 1940, the mass once a year in the church on the Mokotowska Street, the photograph in the Latin dictionary, the letter that had come to the flat in 1941 from a Polish welfare bureau in the south of France with four lines in it and no signature, which their father had burned in the kitchen stove and had told the neighbours was the last notice from the hospital.

"You never believed it," Krystyna said.

"Which part?"

"Any of it."

"I believed it for eleven days," said Hanna, "and then I went to the church and looked at the list, because they read out the names of the dead of the parish once a year and they read yours, and I looked at the register of the parish and there was no burial for a Krystyna Stankiewiczówna and no notice from any hospital anywhere, and I was thirteen, and I went home and I sat on the stairs for two hours and I did not tell anybody, not ever, not once, not to this day." Her chin came up. "I have known for four years that you were alive. I have not known one hour of where you were. The first year I thought you were in a camp. The second year I thought you were in the Resistance and would send for me. The third year I thought you were in a bed somewhere with a German, because there are women in this city who are in beds with Germans and my father says they have all been shot, and I did not care." She wiped her nose with the back

of her hand. "You are in Warsaw with him. You came to this courtyard in a coat worth three years of my father's lessons and stood under our window for eleven minutes, and I want to know if it is true, and I want it not to be true, and I want you to tell me that it is not true and I want to be able to believe it, and I am seventeen and there is nobody in the world I can ask."

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the gateway of the courtyard of her own childhood at twenty-five minutes past midnight in the snow, with a girl's breath going up between them, and did the mathematics of the next ten seconds; and the mathematics said: if you lie now, you will have to keep the lie for the rest of the war, and you will not manage it, and she will be the loose end that hangs you; and if you tell her the truth, you have put a seventeen-year-old courier in the possession of the fact that has killed eleven people in this city already, and she will carry it in a coat with no pockets; and the answer, which was not a good answer, was: she has known for four years; give her the truth, and give it to her in the smallest possible pieces, and make her complicit, because complicity is the only lock in a country where nothing can be kept.

"Hanna," she said, "I am a Polish officer's agent in the service of the government in London, seconded to the Polish intelligence in France in 1940, and since June 1943 I have been working out of the house of an Oberst of the Wehrmacht, and the arrangement is that I use what is in that house, and the arrangement has been running for nine months, and my handler was taken in Paris in February and

I am here alone and I was recruited by the people you are standing at the end of the street from, ten days ago, on the Śliska Street, in a cellar under a workshop, and I have brought them nothing yet, and that is the whole of it, and you will never say one word of it to our father, or to Tadeusz, or to anybody you have ever met, because the moment it is spoken outside your teeth it is a death sentence on four people, and I do not mean a figure of speech, I mean that they will come at three in the morning and take all four of you out of that flat and shoot you in the courtyard, and they have done it eleven times this winter, and the notices are on the kiosk at the corner."

Hanna did not move.

"Say something," Krystyna said.

"Mother knew," said Hanna.

"What?"

"Mother knew. In the last week, when she still knew things, she said something to me in the night about you, and she said it in a voice that a person only uses about the living, and I have never been able to remember the sentence, only the voice. And then she died, and I have been alone in that flat with it for three years, and there was nobody to give it to." She wiped her face with the heel of her hand again, hard, the way you wipe a child's face. "I am not going to cry in this courtyard. There is a man on the corner. Give me your hands."

They held each other's hands in the dark for a moment, both of them in gloves, and then Hanna let go and stepped back and looked up and down the empty street and said, in an entirely businesslike voice, "Now the mark."

"What mark?"

"Your mark. Stand in the gate and watch the corner, and if the man in the leather coat comes past the lamp, cough twice."

And she took out of her coat pocket, along with a key and a lump of string, a piece of chalk the size of the last joint of a thumb, and went to the wall of the gateway, the wall beside the gate itself where the plaster had come away in a patch as big as a plate, and drew on it, quickly, in six or eight strokes, a figure that Krystyna could not see from where she was standing; and then she stood back to look at it, and put the chalk in her pocket, and came back.

"That is the anchor," she said.

"I know what it is."

"I draw it here every time I come out of that gate. I have drawn it here for two years and I have drawn it on the Wilcza and on the wall of the coal shed, and the caretaker washes it off and I do it again, and if anybody asks him he says the boys do it and he does not know who." Hanna's face in the dark was entirely serious and about eleven years old. "It is the anchor, and it is my signature, and it means this house is ours. And I want you to understand something, Krysia, because you have been away in France: they read the walls. They have got Poles to read the walls for them, the blue police and the szmalcownicy and a hundred kinds of scum, and a wall that has an anchor on it is a wall that is ours, and if there is going to be a raid on this courtyard I would rather the anchor was on the wall and the men who come to take my father looked at it and knew exactly who lived there, because on the day they come the one thing

I have got left in the world is the knowledge that they are the ones who are wrong."

❦

The arch of the courtyard on the other side of the Wilcza was eleven metres deep and had a lamp-bracket over it with no lamp in it, and the man standing in it was a good deal bigger than the boy she had last seen in the doorway of the flat in September 1939 with a railway warrant in his pocket and his mother's scapular sewn into the lining.

He had a stolen German greatcoat on over a grey sweater and his hands were out of his pockets. He had a broken front tooth that showed when he breathed the cold air, and a jaw that looked as if it was being held shut by main strength, and he was standing in the way a man stands when he has been standing in the same place for half an hour and is afterwards going to deny it.

"Hanna wanted to do this without me," he said. "I want that said first, because if you are going to hate anybody about tonight, it should be me and not her, and I want her out of it."

"Antek—"

"First thing," said Tadeusz, "is that you will not call me that. Second thing," and his hand came out of the dark and took hold of the sleeve of her coat, at the wrist, hard enough that she heard the seam, and turned her, not violently, into the light, such as it was, of the arch — "what do you smell of?"

"Let go of me."

"You smell of their cigarettes," her brother said. "And it is in the wool, at the shoulder, so it is not from a corridor. It is from a room, and it is from a long time in a room, and there is a smell under it, and I know what that smell is, and do you know how I know it? I put a boot on a man's chest in a cellar on Dzielna Street in November and I stood over him for four minutes and this is what my own sleeve smelled like afterwards, and I burned the shirt. Now tell me that you are working for us and not for them, and tell me it in a way that I can repeat to our father on Sunday."

She looked up at him in the arch, at a head taller than hers, with the greatcoat's collar turned up and a bruise fading along the jawbone that could have come from a doorframe or from a wall or from nothing at all.

"I am working for us," she said.

"Prove it."

"I cannot."

"You mean you will not."

"You are standing in a courtyard at midnight in a fine rain of snow with me in your hand and I have not heard the car. A car in this street after curfew would have brought a patrol in four minutes, and you knew that when you took me by the sleeve, so you have already decided to be quick, which means you were forty minutes deciding to be quick, and I am telling you the truth and you do not want it, you want a feeling, and I cannot give you the feeling, Antek, because the feeling is the one thing that is not for sale in this business, and every man who has ever had the feeling has been taken through the gate of the Szucha and has died in the disinfection room with his own initials on a form."

He let go of her sleeve.

"There," he said. "That is exactly what the Major said on Wednesday, in almost those words, and he took his spectacles off to say it, and I hated him for it and now I hate you the same way, and that is the shape of my life." He looked down the street, left, right, and then at the wall. "He sent for me on Wednesday. The Major. He told me that my sister is alive, and that she is in the service of the government, and that she is doing work nobody else in Warsaw can do, and that if she touches this family again she will be shot. And I said, good, and I asked him whether I might be the one to do it, and he said no, and I went home and I have not slept since." He breathed out, slowly, and it came out of him as steam. "Sit down. No — do not sit down, it is wet. Stand there against the wall and let me look at you for a minute, because I intended to do this quickly and I find I have got to know what your face is now."

She stood against the wall of the arch and let him look at her, and he looked for a long time, at her face, at the coat, at her hands, the way a man looks at a house he has been told is his and does not remember.

"You used to have the mark on your chin," he said. "The one from the sleigh. It is gone."

"It is a scar. Scars go."

"Not that one. Mamusia used to start every story with that scar." He was quiet for a moment and then he said, in a completely different tone, one that had nothing in it but the flat professional interest of a man in a stairwell in November: "What do you let him do to you?"

She did not answer him, because there was no answer that was not either a lie or a weapon, and because she had learned in the flat above the laundry that the only way to be asked a question you cannot answer is to let the silence stand in the room with an honest face; and her brother looked at her for four seconds and then hit her once, in the face, with the back of his hand, hard enough that the wall was what she felt, and the snow on the wall-brick went into her collar, and she held on to the corner of the brickwork with one hand and did not fall down and did not say anything at all.

"You never cried," he said. "Not even when the horse threw you."

"Antek."

"Do not." He had his hand up in front of his face, and the hand was shaking, and he looked at it with a kind of detached disgust, as if it belonged to a machine he had been given to look after. "It is shaking. It has been shaking since November. Mostly it does not matter, and twice it has mattered, and one of those times was a man on Dzielna Street and I have to believe that it mattered in a good cause." He put the hand in his coat pocket and held it there. "If they take me, it will be at the flat, and it will be in the morning, and Hanna will be the one who sees it out of the window over the courtyard, and she will not be allowed to go down, and I have told her that if it happens she is to take the papers and put on the coat with the fur collar and go to the Żelazna, to the chemist's, and say that she has come about the medicine. That is a thing you should know, in case you

ever hear it, and in case you ever have to do anything about it."

"They will not take you."

"They will take all of us," said Tadeusz, without any drama at all. "This city is going to be taken apart by somebody in the next twelve months, and we are going to be in it when it happens, and I am 29 years old and my father has one lung and my sister is a seventeen-year-old courier, and I have thought about it every night since mother died and I have got exactly one comfort, which is that I will be doing the thing that is in front of me and not the thing that is far away. Come on. I am going to do a stupid thing now, and you will not argue with me about it, and it will take four minutes, and then you will go back to the Frascati and I will walk Hanna home and we will not see each other again until this is over."

❦

He took her up.

Sixty-one steps: he went first in his boots, on the outside of the tread, because the treads were wooden and the building had ears; and she followed him in her Paris shoes, and on the third landing she put her hand out and touched the iron of the banister rail in a place where the paint had come off in 1936 and never been replaced, and found it exactly as it had been, and had to stop for a moment on the stairs with her brother's back going up in front of her.

The door of the flat opened on a corridor with no light in it: only the line of light under the door at the end of it, and the sound of a boy's voice reciting, and then the deeper

voice that said, in Latin, rectius vives, Licini, neque altum, and corrected the boy's quantity with two words, and then the boys' laughter, and then the deeper voice again, going on; and the flat around it, in the dark, was the following things.

The brass umbrella stand, the only piece of the old house's furniture that had come with them from the Nowy Świat in 1940, standing where it had always stood, by the door, with two umbrellas in it that had not been used since 1939, and one of them broken.

The pianino in the corner of the drawing room with one key broken since the autumn of 1940, when the ceiling above it had come down in a bombing and taken the case with it; and on the top of the pianino, the photograph of Krystyna's mother at thirty in a white blouse, and a candle, and a tin of something, and the chair next to it that nobody had moved since March 1941, which was not a chair anymore but a place where a chair was kept.

The father's books, in rows, along the skirting board on both sides of the corridor, and standing in the doorway of the room where her parents' bed had been, because there was nowhere else in the flat for them and there had never been anywhere else for them; and the smell of the place — cabbage and floor polish and coal and the damp plaster of the back room and, under all of it, the smell of her own childhood, which is the smell of one particular flat out of all the flats in the world and which no amount of anything can be mistaken for.

And four metres away, past the end of the corridor, the door of the room with the light under it, with a class of four

boys behind it, and her father's voice going on with the ninth ode of the first book: tu ne quaesieris, scire nefas, quem mihi, quem tibi — the poem about not asking what the gods have in store, taught by a man of sixty-four with one lung, in an occupied city, to four boys with their own chairs, at eight in the evening, in a flat where the electricity had been turned off twice that winter for arrears.

She stood there four metres from that door and did not go in.

Tadeusz stood in the dark beside her with his arms folded and his hand still in his pocket and did not say a word while she stood there, which was, she understood later, the largest thing her brother ever gave anybody.

Then he said, quietly: "The terms."

"Say them."

"Hanna knows. Hanna will keep it, because Hanna is the best of the three of us and always has been. Father will not be told while he lives." His voice did not change at all on the sentence, which was the only way he could get it out. "And if you ever come to this flat in daylight, or on the arm of a German, or in that coat, then everything between us is finished, and I will shoot you myself in the courtyard in front of Hanna, and I will be right to, and I want you to know that tonight, standing in this corridor, while you can still look at me." He unfolded his arms. "It is an ugly bargain. It is the best one available. Take it or go."

"I take it."

"Then that is the whole of the family," said Tadeusz, "and we will not speak of it again."

He took her down the sixty-one steps himself, and at the gate he put his hand in the pocket of the greatcoat and took out a folded piece of paper, and put it in her hand, and closed her fingers over it with his own.

"What is this?"

"It is the list. The Major gave it at the briefing on Wednesday and it is not supposed to exist, and I wrote it out in the tram on the way home, and if you are ever asked about it you will say you have never seen my handwriting, and I have not seen yours since 1939." He looked at her. "That is what they want out of the administration this spring: the liaison officers' postings, the engineer's reports on the bridges, the fuel allocations, the railway movement tables for the district, the lists of the firms doing work for the garrison. All of it paper, all of it in the offices, all of it useless without somebody who can walk into those rooms twice a week and be looked at as a woman and not as a spy."

She unfolded the paper in the light of the empty lamp-bracket.

The handwriting was her brother's, square and small and pressed hard into the paper the way a boy writes who has been taught to write by a father with a Latin pen; and the list ran to fourteen lines, in two columns, and the last line of it was not a document at all.

The last line was a name, underlined twice, with three words after it in brackets.

Oberst Wolfram von Hagen (der Wolf).

She memorised the paper in the light of the empty lamp-bracket, once through, and then again from the bottom up,

which is the way Wiktor had taught her in the flat above the laundry: the list, the two columns, the fourteen lines, the postings, the engineer's reports on the bridges, the fuel allocations, the railway movement tables, the firms with contracts.

Then she folded it and put it inside her left glove, and her brother, without another word, took out of his pocket a second scrap of paper, half the size, and gave it to her and closed her hand on it and walked away up the Wilcza to where their sister was standing in the shadow of a doorway a hundred metres off, and the two of them went away together without looking back.

The second scrap had one line on it, in the same square hand, and no punctuation: Pani Grabska, Ogrodowa 18, flat 3, back stairs, second bell, she keeps coats.

She walked home through the back streets with her hands in her pockets.

At the corner of the Bracka the patrol car was standing without lights and there were two Feldgendarmes on the pavement with a torch, and one of them turned the beam on her when she was still twenty metres away and held it there, and said something to the other one, and the other one stepped out into the middle of the street and put his hand up, and she stopped; and the whole of what happened in the next four minutes happened in a language that had been invented for the purpose of making a woman in a fur coat stand still in the snow while two tired men decided whether they should go home.

The papers were in order. They were extremely in order. Herschlag, Marion. Austrian. Civil employee of the military administration, Warsaw. They had a photograph, and a stamp, and a triplicate number, and a small red card behind them which was the pass of a household of the garrison command, and the Feldgendarme looked at all of it twice with the torch held under his arm, and then at her, and then at the papers again; and he asked her where she was coming from at midnight, in German, and she lied to him in German in the accent of a woman from Vienna, which she had; and he asked her what was in her glove.

"The glove is empty," she said, and turned her hands over, both of them, palms up, in the snow, with the left hand holding the left glove and the left glove holding the two pieces of paper in its finger.

The torch went over her hands and stayed on them for a second and a half; and the man in the street said something to the man with the torch and laughed; and the man with the torch said, "Go home, Fräulein," and stepped back, and let her go; and she walked on up the street with her knees entirely steady for thirty metres and then, at the corner by the villa's garden wall, she put her back against the bricks and stood in the dark and shook for eleven seconds, the way one does.

Then she took the two pieces of paper out of the glove.

She tore the list into strips and the strips into pieces and put them in her mouth, and chewed them, and swallowed them, standing in the dark against the wall of the garden of the house she was kept in; and paper is not a thing that can

be eaten and it does not go down, and she stood there for four minutes with her hand flat against the wall, working at it, mouthful by mouthful, all fourteen lines of what the Home Army wanted out of the German administration in Warsaw, and the last line of it, twice underlined, in her brother's small hard handwriting, between her teeth: the name of a man she was going to get into the bed of within the hour.

Then she went into the house through the pantry door, and up the back stairs, and past the open door of the Colonel's room, in which he was asleep on his back with his hands open and the breathing of a man who has never had to be afraid in a bedroom; and she undressed in the dark, and lay down, and lay awake with her eyes open and the taste of paper in her mouth, and listened to the sentry on the gravel going round the garden on his eleven minutes.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Colour of a Uniform

❦

The office was on the second floor of a building on the Świętokrzyska whose ground floor had been a bank and whose first floor had been a firm of patent agents, and it had been requisitioned in 1940 and fitted out with a map of the Generalgouvernement on a frame, two filing cabinets of German steel, a stove that smoked when the wind came off the river, a telephone on the wall and a second telephone on the desk, and a Polish charwoman called Pani Wanda who came at seven in the morning and was searched on the way out by the orderly, every day, in the same way, with her rag and her bucket and her tin of polish on the floor beside her, and who had never in four years been caught with anything because she had never tried to take anything, which was itself a piece of information that was in Phillip Brandt's head and not in any file.

There were five of them in the room: Hauptmann Lindemann, who was thirty-three and had been an architecture student and had a good ear and a laugh he used the way other men used a bayonet; two clerks, one of them with a limp and one of them with a stomach; a sergeant of about fifty who had been a policeman in Cologne; and Phillip, who was a Hauptmann of the Abwehr, on secondment to the garrison command's counter-intelligence section, and

whose actual job, written down nowhere, was to be the man who read Polish.

The Polish in that building was the wall between them and everything they did. There was no department in Warsaw in 1944 that did not have a Pole in the cellar of its language: the German administration issued its orders in German and printed its proclamations in both, and the reports of the Polish police came in Polish, and the underground press came in Polish, and the intercepted letters came in Polish, and the denunciations — there were eleven of those a day, on average, at the Świętokrzyska, in a woman's hand or a man's hand or a spidery nervous hand, about neighbours and Jews and partisans and men who had been overheard saying something — all of them, all day, in Polish, in a language that no German in that building could read except the man who had been born in it.

So Phillip's morning was this: a stack of paper on the left-hand side of the desk, and the same stack, translated and boiled down, on the right.

The underground press first: the Biuletyn Informacyjny, when a copy had been taken off a boy in the street or bought on the black market for two hundred zlotys by a sergeant who put it on his expenses; the Wiadomości, the Głos, the papers of the Peasant Battalions and the Socialists, all of them, in five or six different degrees of recklessness. He did not translate them word for word; he summarised each of them into a paragraph of German in a standard form, with the date of issue, the source, the circulation estimate, and then the content: the murders of Poles by the Germans and

by the Ukrainian police, the raids, the reprisals, the executions, the trains, the prison, the arrests of named men, the warnings about the szmalcownicy who sold hiding people to the SD, the descriptions of German personalities after whom the underground's courts had passed sentences, the obituaries, the appeals for money for the families of those shot, the appalling ordinary business of a city that had decided to describe its own destruction every fortnight in an eight-page stencil.

Then the police reports: the blue police, the Polish police of the Generalgouvernement, who were the most careful writers of Polish in the war, because every comma they wrote could get them shot and every comma they left out could get them shot too. Then the intercepted mail. Then the summaries for the section: a daily sheet in duplicate, the top copy to Oberst von Hagen and the carbon to the file, and Phillip had established in the first week that a sheet of paper with his summaries on it was read by four men and quoted by one, and that the one was the Oberst, and that the Oberst read the paper carefully and slowly with a pencil in his hand and made marks in the margins, and that the marks were always about people and never about facts.

Between us, Phillip, a man with Polish like yours and no wife is either an idealist or an idiot, and I have never known an idealist to survive a winter.

That was Lindemann at eleven in the morning on the second of March, in the second week of the new arrangement, with his feet on the stove and a newspaper on his face, and the two clerks and the sergeant and Pani Wanda all in the room, and nothing about it worth an answer.

He was thirty-three and he was going to be thirty-four, and the whole of his war had been conducted like a man hunting for the exit in a burning theatre: he had been in the Abwehr in Paris, in Warsaw, and in between at the General Staff's office in Berlin for eight months where he had learned the entire architecture of the coming collapse, and he talked about the war as a business cycle, and he was right about most of the things he talked about, and he had one of the best languages in the Amt, and by the winter of 1944 he was doing all of the arithmetic out loud in front of whoever was in the room, which is either courage or an entirely different thing. "Between us, when the east comes apart — and it will, presently, and I will not be the one who says so in a letter — there will be four hundred people in this town who claim to have been against it from the beginning, and I intend to have written evidence, in somebody else's hand, dated before the end. Have you ever noticed that the Poles keep their receipts?"

A week later, on the ninth of March, the crates came in.

They came on a lorry from the Ostbahn goods yard with a delivery note in three copies and two men to unload, and they were the Paris station's files, six crates of them, with the Abwehr's mark stencilled on the side and the rain on the stencil; and the whole office stood around them in the afternoon and read the numbers on the outside and argued about whose section they belonged to, because the Admiral's people had been taken apart in Berlin in February and everything that had belonged to them was now the property of whoever could reach the goods yard first, and

there were three claimants in Warsaw that week and one of them was the SD, which was ten minutes by car away on the aleja Szucha and which was better dressed than anybody in the Świętokrzyska.

The Fräulein file was in the second crate, in a folder of brown cardboard with a ribbon on it, and it was forty-one pages, and Phillip was given it on the eleventh because he was the Polish speaker and because the file was about a woman.

He worked on it for two days.

That is the thing to understand about Phillip Brandt, and the reader has to be given it plainly before anything else happens to him: he was good. He had the best analytical mind in that section of the garrison command, and the whole of the discipline of the thing was in him, and he did the work for the work's sake and had done since 1939, which is the exact vice that makes a man like that destroy himself slowly, because the work is never asked to be good, only to be useful.

He read the file the way it had to be read: twice, and then once more from the back.

Page one was the case reference and the name of the officer who had opened it — Sturmbannführer B. Kalbach, Sipo/SD Paris, avenue Foch, 14 January 1944 — and a note in the same hand that the case had been transferred to the Sicherheitspolizei's office in Warsaw with the papers of the Abwehr, and that the material from the French file was to be integrated, and that the immediate hypothesis of the case is a woman.

Pages two to nine were a chart.

It was a beautiful piece of work and Phillip had seen only four like it: a hand-ruled table of eight persons of interest to the case, with their names down the left, and then three columns which Kalbach had headed Sprache — language — Stunden — hours — and Zugang, which means access. Under the eight names there were four who had been crossed out, and beside each crossing-out there was a date and a single word: verhaftet, arrested; verhaftet; entlassen, released; verstorben, died. There was a chart for a whole city on that page: a dressmaker on the rue Saint-Honoré, a Frenchwoman who had worked in a German office on the avenue Henri-Martin, a chauffeur, a typist, a seller of papers, two men in the black market, and the fourth name in the column, which was in a different ink and which ran right down the page and out of the bottom of the chart into the margin, where there was a question mark in German, and the question mark was followed by three words: Person bei Hagen? — a person in Hagen's household?

Page fourteen was an artist's drawing, done from descriptions by a French police draughtsman of the prefecture, of a woman in a hat: seven drawings, actually, of seven hats and one face — and the face, drawn from a composite of three witnesses, was an egg with eyes and was no more like Krystyna Stankiewiczówna than it was like Pani Wanda, and Phillip looked at the seven hats for eleven seconds and had to put the file down and go out of the room.

Page twenty-two was the paragraph.

It was a summary of an interrogation of a waiter from a café on the rue de Rivoli, taken on the eleventh of January

1944: the waiter had served a German office on the first floor for two years and had been asked about voices, and had said, in the way of a man who has been asked a question three times and is beginning to understand that his life depends on the answer being interesting, that there had been one woman among the German ladies who spoke German with a particular thing in it — and the SD clerk had typed the thing and then written underneath, in Kalbach's hand, three words in Polish: warszawski zaokrąglony akcent — the Warsaw rounded accent, the vowel at the end of a word that a person from three hundred kilometres to the west can hear and cannot produce, the vowel that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had carried into Germany with her, in her mouth, like a coin in a shoe.

He read page twenty-two four times, and then he closed the folder and put the ribbon round it and went down the stairs and out into the Świętokrzyska and bought a packet of cigarettes from the kiosk at the corner and came back up and opened it again and started writing.

What he wrote, that afternoon, was three pages of German summary in the standard form of the section. It was honest, and it was accurate, and it said, in the flat language of a staff paper: that the French material had produced no identification; that the chart listed eight persons, of whom four were disposals by arrest or death and four remained open; that the draughtsman's portrait was of no value; that the linguistic material was of interest, being a single witness's memory of an accent with no recording, no comparison material, and no corroboration; and that the hypothesis a wo-

man in the household of an officer of the Militärbefehlshaber was unsupported by any evidence in the file except the fact that the case had been opened by a man who believed it.

It was true. Every word of it was true, and it was the best summary the file had received in eleven weeks, and it made the case look like what it also was: a hunter's work, and thin.

And in the last paragraph of it, in the section headed Empfehlung — recommendation — he wrote that the case would benefit from a comparison of the linguistic material against the personnel lists of the women employed by the German administration in the Government General, and that this should be requested from the police in the Generalgouvernement in the ordinary way, and he signed it, and put it in the tray with the carbon, and went out at half past four into the snow and stood in the street for a moment with his hands in his pockets, and then walked home.

❦

The Brandts lived in Wola, on the third floor of a corner building near the gasworks, in two rooms and a kitchen, because in May 1940 the house on the Hoża Street had been requisitioned for an office of the labour section by the ordinary procedure — a valuation, fourteen days, a payment into a blocked account, which could not be touched and had not been touched and, by 1944, would have bought a bicycle — and the family had taken the flat in Wola because it was cheap and because Albrecht Brandt could walk to the works from it.

The works were still there. That is the other thing about that family that must be set down plainly: the Lilpop works at Burakowska Street were still standing in 1944 and still making things, and Albrecht Brandt was still going to them at sixty-one years of age, five days a week, with a leather satchel, and signing what was put in front of him in the capacity in which the German administration employed him, which was that of a technischer Leiter of a Polish firm under German administration, a phrase which meant everything and nothing, and which he had explained to his son exactly once, in 1940, in the following way.

"There is a paper in the drawer of my desk at the works. It is an application for membership of the Party, and it was submitted in my name by somebody in the administration in October 1939 without my signature, and it has never been withdrawn, and I have never been a member of anything in my life and I never will be. If they come for me, it will be that paper that they find first, and it will not matter what I say about it. I am telling you this because I want you to understand the exact arithmetic of your own career, and the arithmetic is this: a man who signs one paper is not the same as the men who rule with it, and there is no third thing. There is only the paper and the men who write it, and every honest man in this country is standing on a line that was drawn by somebody else."

Then he put his hat on and went to work, and Maria Brandt said nothing at all, which was her answer, and it was the answer he had been getting for thirty years and had learned to live with: his wife's silence, which was not agree-

ment and was not forgiveness and was a complete statement.

The flat in Wola had two things in it out of the house on the Hoża: the photograph of the family in front of the works in 1928, taken by a photographer who was employed by the firm, with the furnaces behind and Albrecht Brandt in the middle in a hat and Maria on a chair with her hands in her lap and a boy of eleven standing very straight and looking at something other than the camera; and the piano, which was a small upright and which Maria played on Sundays, badly, and always the same three things, and always the Polish ones.

She spoke Polish to her husband when she was tired and German when she was angry, and she had been tired and angry in the same proportion for four years; and she had one subject that she never once mentioned, which was her own family, of whom nothing had been heard since the autumn of 1942 and about whom there was nothing to be found in any office in Warsaw, and Phillip had spent eleven weeks of his salary in 1943 making enquiries that had produced, in the end, a single line in a file of the labour administration: two names, a street in the Mokotów district, and the word umgesiedelt, resettled, and a date.

They ate at the kitchen table, the three of them, at eight in the evening, in two languages; and the mother asked her son, in Polish, about his day, and the son answered her in Polish, and the father asked, in German, about the office, and the son answered him in German, and the whole thing ran along the table like two currents in one river; and Phillip

ate what was put in front of him and did not say what he did all day, and his mother did not ask, and his father asked and was told what a technical director's son can tell a technical director, which is nothing at all.

❦

On Sunday the nineteenth of March at eleven in the morning, Lindemann took him to the café on the Nowy Świat, which was one of the four in the German quarter that Poles were not permitted to enter, and which had a plate-glass window, a doorman in a green uniform, an inside room with a stove and eleven tables with cloths on them, and a clientele of officers of the garrison and of the administration, and the girl at the bar was Polish and said nothing at all to anybody.

They were at the third table on the left with the window at their shoulder. Lindemann had ordered coffee and cake, and was talking about a transfer to the Ukraine and the price of a woman's bicycle, and at half past eleven the door opened and the room came alive in the way rooms do when rank comes in, and the whole party came in out of the snow: five officers of the garrison, of whom the first was a tall narrow Prussian of about fifty-four with a duelling scar on the left cheek who took his hat off and looked round the room the way a man looks at a room he has paid for.

"Von Hagen," said Lindemann, and stood up.

The Oberst came to the table with his gloves in his hand and looked at the two of them for a moment in the manner of an inspection, and then was cordial: he was, Phillip saw, a man who did the cordial part of the courtesy carefully and

by hand and had no interest in whether it was returned; and he said, "Brandt. You are the summary. I have been reading your sheets for three weeks and I have been meaning for a week to tell you that the one you wrote on the twenty-ninth of February is the best piece of paper that has come out of this section in a year, which is a low bar, but the sentence about the paper circulation was correct and nobody in this town has yet told me anything correct about paper." He pulled out the chair. "Lindemann, you have been telling him about me."

And behind him, in the party, in a grey dress with a fur coat over her arm and the pearls at her throat, and a hat that was not any of the seven hats in the drawing, was Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, and she looked at Phillip for about as long as a stranger looks at a stranger, and then she turned to the man next to her and said something and smiled.

The room turned to look at her. It took about four seconds and it was a phenomenon that Phillip had seen once before, in a corridor of the Hôtel Majestic in Paris in December, and it had the same cause: a woman who is beautiful in a room full of officers has to give them something to do with their eyes at the end of it, and what she gave them was a laugh — small, private, entirely at ease, in German, at something an Oberst of the engineers had said about a bridge — and the whole room took it, and one major laughed too, and a captain at the far table looked at his plate.

Phillip sat, and ate cake, and translated nothing at all.

He knew, in the first four minutes, three things, and he knew them in order.

The first was that she was doing exactly what he had spent the winter refusing to put into words. Not the thing in the corridor at the Majestic and not the thing in the church on the rue Saint-Honoré, but the whole arrangement, every day of it: that she was in that room in a fur coat on the arm of an Oberst, and that the room was full of the men who ran the occupation of her own city, and that she was laughing and taking coffee, and that the file in the second crate on the Świętokrzyska was about her.

The second was that the man whose arm she was on was the man who had been given the counter-intelligence section on the first of March, and that the counter-intelligence of a garrison exists for nothing except to find the people who are doing to the Germans what she was doing to the Germans.

And the third was that he had, on the previous Thursday at four in the afternoon, written and signed a three-page summary of a file in which the case officer had written Person bei Hagen?

❦

He held her chair because the Oberst made an introduction and because a man at a table with a lady standing next to him holds her chair; and that is the whole of what happened between them in the room, and it lasted about two seconds, and she put her hand on the back of the chair as she sat down, and her other hand, under the level of the table cloth, closed round his fingers for the length of one heartbeat and left something in them and was gone.

He did not look at it. He put his hand in his pocket as if he were putting his handkerchief away and did not take it out for four minutes, and in those four minutes he took part in the following pieces of conversation, in the following order: a comparison of the officer's brothels of Paris and of Warsaw, which he did not enter; the question of whether the Vistula bridges would be blown, which he answered in the flat way an intelligence officer answers a technical question — that the bridges had demolition chambers that had been built in 1939 by the Polish army, that the chambers had been surveyed by the engineers of the garrison in February, and that the report of that survey had been circulated to six offices and would therefore be in Berlin by the summer, which was the only kind of answer that could be given in a café; and Lindemann's theory about air raids on the eastern railway junctions. And he laughed twice, at the right places, and he ate the rest of the cake, which was dry.

Then the party got up to go, and there was the business of the coats and the door and the doorman, and the Oberst put his glove on and said, "Brandt. Monday, nine. My office, with the summaries," and went out; and she went out after him with the fur coat over her arm; and at the door, in the middle of the movement of five officers and a woman and a doorman and the cold air coming in, she turned her head, and looked at Phillip Brandt for the second time in the entire war, for about a second and a half, from the doorway, with her hat in her hand.

And then the door shut, and the room went back to being a room, and Lindemann said, "Between us, that is the

most expensive woman in Poland, and I include the horses," and Phillip laughed, and paid for the coffee.

❦

The flat in the Żurawia where he had a room was the flat of a widow called Zofia and had four rooms and a kitchen, of which the Germans had had three since 1940: himself, and two lieutenants of the railway section who were in Posen that week, and the woman and her sister in the back room, and a piano in the front room that nobody played, and a cat that belonged to nobody and slept on the sofa, and a Polish maid who came in the mornings and did the three German rooms and was searched on the way out, like everybody.

He shut the door of his room at four in the afternoon and put the thing from the café on the table.

It was a piece of paper of the kind that comes on a roll, folded twice, with the edge torn, and it had one line on it in Polish, written in pencil, in a hand he had last seen on a school exercise book that had been left in the hall of a house at Wierzbów with a silver pencil on top of it in the summer of 1939, and the line was:

The girl from the orchard asks what your office knows about a woman in a hat.

He sat and looked at it for eleven minutes.

It was not a love letter. That is the first thing to say about it. It was not the beginning of anything either, or the resumption of anything: it was an act of a kind he had read about in files and never once seen, which is a person in an impossible position calling in the only debt she has left — and it was, at the same time, exactly what a trap looks like, in

the third week of March 1944, in a city where the SD's building was fifteen minutes by car and a man in a grey overcoat had written something down about Krystyna Stankiewiczówna on a railway platform in Paris.

He did the arithmetic in five lines, on the back of the cigarette packet, the way he had been trained.

If she was a German agent and the note was a trap, he had already passed the gate: he had held her chair in a café and had taken a folded paper from her; and the only piece of evidence that could convict him of anything was on the table in front of him, one line in Polish, in a hand nobody could connect to anybody, and he could burn it in thirty seconds.

If she was what he had spent a year and a half understanding her to be, then a woman was doing in the middle of a German administration what three hundred thousand people in that country could not do with rifles, and there was exactly one man in Warsaw who could tell her anything at all about the file, and she had found him in nine days, and she had found him in a café, in front of Lindemann, holding his fingers for one heartbeat under a tablecloth — which meant she had selected him, and which also meant she was desperate, and which also meant the file was worse than he had let himself believe.

He wrote the answer in the same Polish and with the same pencil, on a piece of paper from his own notebook:

The man who wrote the file is called Kalbach and he is here. There are eight names on his chart and four are dead and there is a chart of accents and a drawing of seven hats

and a face that is nobody. He has no name in the file. He will have one in the summer, because the man who is hunting you is regular, methodical, and does not stop; and there is one other thing you should know, which is that as of the first of March he is working for the Oberst who takes you to cafés, and that the Oberst reads every paper that crosses my desk, including the ones about you. Do not write to me again in a place where I can be seen. If you need the file, I will bring it to you on paper you can eat, and then you will owe me nothing and I will owe you nothing, and neither of us will have been in a café together.

He read it through twice; and then he burned it in the stove, and burned the note as well, and then swept the ash out of the stove with his hand and burned the sweepings on a plate, twice, because he had written in 1941 that a man who leaves ash leaves a document that a person can read with a lens and a table, and then he went out into the snow at half past five in the afternoon of the nineteenth of March 1944 and walked to the corner of the Bracka and bought a bunch of violets he did not want from the flower kiosk there, and while he was paying for them he put a book in the window of the junk shop behind the kiosk, between the frame of the window and the glass: a Polish novel of the nineteen-thirties, second-hand, with a woman's name written inside the cover in pencil, and inside the back cover, in a hand he had learned in a kitchen in Wola, in ink, four lines of what a man who is on the wrong side of everything could find out about a hunter, in the summer, in a file, from the inside.

He was at that corner for four minutes, which is what it takes to buy flowers and put a book in a window and walk away, and he was seen by exactly two people: a boy of about ten on a sledge in the road, and a man in a grey civilian coat standing at the tram stop on the other side of the Świętokrzyska with his hat down and a notebook in his hand, who wrote in it, in a column, two words, and who — this is the part that Phillip Brandt would not learn for another two months, and would learn in a way that cost four people their lives — was not writing down what he had seen; he was keeping a list of the German officers who passed that corner on foot, because a German officer on foot at a buying-and-selling corner was a man with something to sell, and Kalbach's assistant had started the list in February and it had one name on it before, and it now had two.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Cold Flat

❦

The work she was given was real work, and that was the point of it: the Oberst of the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison command had a large amount of paper in his life and no patience with any of it, and a man in that position wants three things — someone to sort the paper, someone to write the draft, and someone to be in a room with at the end of the day who is not a soldier — and she had been hired for the third of these and had spent four months making herself necessary for the first two.

So she typed.

The typewriter was a German make of the nineteen-thirties that stood on a small table in the corner of the study, by the lithograph of the Lilpop works, with the safe behind it; and she typed the Colonel's private correspondence and his memoranda to the garrison command and the fair copies of the reports that came out of the section to be signed by officers who could not spell; and she did it well enough to be asked to do more of it, and badly enough that whoever read her work first was not troubled by it.

And here is the trade she had made with herself, in the first week of March, in the bathroom of a requisitioned villa on the Frascati Street, with the tap running:

One paragraph a day.

Not more. Never a document, never a photograph, never a carbon, never a paper out of the house; one paragraph, memorised, once, in the minute and a half it takes to type it — a paragraph of a memorandum to the garrison's department Ia about the disposition of the counter-intelligence section's field offices; a paragraph of the quarterly report on the Polish police battalions; a paragraph on the interception of wireless traffic in the district, which had in it the location of two sets; a sentence about a man in Siedlce who was delivering reports to a captain of the Abwehr and had been given a cover name. One paragraph a day, delivered to Iga Zaleska at intervals of eleven or twelve days, memorised and spoken aloud in a cellar, never carried, never written, never in the house.

That is what a person who is good at that trade actually does, and it is why the trade is not glamorous: you take one paragraph, and you leave three paragraphs, and if you do that every day for a year you get an extraordinary amount of paper out of a building, and if you try to take four paragraphs you are discovered in a fortnight by a man with a chart.

She had the house to herself two afternoons a week, Tuesdays and Fridays, between two and five, when the Colonel was at the Saski Palace and Janina went to her sister in the Wola and Rutz drove the Colonel; and she had a German sentry at the gate who was nineteen years old, from a village near Kassel, four months out of his parents' house, bored into the marrow of his bones, and who could be made a fool of by a lady in a fur coat who brought him cigarettes

of a French make out of a private supply and asked him about his mother.

By the second week of April, the sentry at the gate of the villa on the Frascati Street would have given a month of his pay to be useful to the gnädige Frau, and would also have said, if asked under oath, that she never left the house on Tuesdays and Fridays, which was true of the car, and which was what the day book recorded, and which was all that would ever be looked at.

❦

Janina she dealt with as one deals with a person who has been told not to like you: by being exact.

The woman cooked, kept the two floors, did the marketing with the household's money and a German ration card for a German household and a Polish card for herself, and had a sister in Wola and a brother who had been taken to the Reich for labour in 1942 and who wrote twice a year; and she never once asked Krystyna a question about anything, and never once met her eyes for longer than a second, and every evening at half past nine she stood in the door of the dining room and said, in German, out of a mouth that had been taught the words the way a bird is taught them, "Gnädige Frau, is there anything?"

The first week of April there was.

They were in the kitchen, at seven in the morning, and Janina was at the table with a newspaper spread on it and a chicken on the newspaper, and she was not looking at the door, and Krystyna stood in it and said, in Polish: "The

chicken is from the black market and it is not for the Oberst. How much did you pay?"

Janina's hands went still on the bird. "Two hundred and forty zlotys, and a quarter of tea."

"I shall put four hundred zlotys in the tin in the dresser every Thursday, in the blue tin, and you will spend it on the house and on whatever your sister needs, and you will not account for it to me and you will not tell the Oberst, because he does not know what a chicken costs and if he ever asks I shall tell him it costs what you paid and no more." She took a piece of paper out of her sleeve. "This is a list. On the list there are four things: a woman's coat, grey, wool, for a girl of seventeen; two kilos of lard; a hundred cigarettes; and a bottle of the spirit that the chemist on the Żelazna keeps behind the counter. The coat is the first thing. It is for a person whose name you will not be told."

And Janina looked up at her for the first time in four weeks, for about four seconds, with the face of a woman of forty-five who has been in one house for eleven years and who has understood, in one sentence, exactly what sort of a person has been living in the room at the end of the corridor; and then she looked down at the chicken and turned it over and began to draw the knife along the breastbone.

"The chemist on the Żelazna is my cousin's husband," she said. "The coat will be difficult, but there is a woman on the Ogrodowa who keeps coats."

"I know," said Krystyna. "I know there is." She put the paper on the table, and the money under the newspaper, and went out; and neither of them ever referred to the con-

versation again, and neither of them ever gave the other away, in four months of a city where that was the whole of the currency.

The coat left the house on the last day of April in a market basket with the lard and the cigarettes on top of it and went to the Ogrodowa to be kept, and Krystyna did not ask anybody in the movement to carry it and did not tell the cellar on the Śliska that she had bought it, and there was no note in the pocket, and she never learned whether it was worn. What she knew, on the eighth of May, standing at the window of the study behind the lithograph of the Lipop works, was that a girl in a grey wool coat had gone past the end of the street on the far pavement at four in the afternoon at the pace of a person who had somewhere to be, and that the girl had not looked up, and that she had not looked twice, and that this was the entire return on the four hundred zlotys and the conversation in the kitchen, and that she would take it.

❦

The flat above the cobbler's shop on the Zielna was four rooms on the first floor of a building of 1898 and belonged to a family called Wolski who had gone to the countryside in 1940 and had left the clock and the hat behind; and the room at the back, over the courtyard, had a table, three chairs, a bed, a stove that had not been lit since 1943, and a window with a curtain that could be hooked back halfway up, which was the arrangement.

The cobbler was real. He was seventy-five and he had been at the front of the Ruska Street for eleven years and

had a wife and a certificate for a bad leg, and he was one of perhaps four thousand people in Warsaw in 1944 who knew one thing about one room, and nothing else about anything in the world, and who had kept it for two years because nobody had ever asked him anything except about shoes.

The parcel was on the table.

She had come to collect, and he had come to hand over, and that is all that either of them had been told, and they sat down at the table with a coat on, in the cold, at four in the afternoon of the sixth of April 1944, and did forty minutes of entirely professional work.

The parcel was eleven days of Phillip Brandt's access, and this is what it contained.

A page of a movement order of the Feldgendarmerie's district command, which she copied? No — which she read, because nothing in that room was ever written down: a summary of the sweeps in the district of the next ten days; the times and the streets; the eighteen-hundred curfew on the ninth, which would be an action.

A list of the eleven vehicles of the section's motor pool with their registration numbers, because the numbers were the way to follow a car.

The establishment of the counter-intelligence section as of the first of April, in the form in which it had been circulated to the garrison command: the names, the ranks, the rooms, the telephones, including his own name, Hauptmann P. Brandt, Room 14, telephone 42 118, and the name of the Colonel, and the name of a man called Kalbach with an asterisk against it, which in the staff language of that army meant seconded from another authority.

And a single sheet of paper, six lines long, in German, of the sort that comes off a stencil: an order of the 5th of April to all offices on the registration of the Kennkarten of the civil population, and a paragraph on the control of the roads east of the city, which was about the work battalions and was, in fact, about the evacuation.

She memorised the whole of it in the forty minutes, in the way she had been trained, which is by taking the paper apart and putting it back together in a different order: the numbers by pairs, the names by sound, the streets by their shape on a map she had carried in her head since she was seven years old.

He sat and watched her do it, and said nothing, and at the end of it he said: "There is a man in the section called Schmidt. Do not memorise him; he is a clerk and he has no access to anything. I am telling you because his name is on the establishment and you will see it in a paper one day and think it is a person of interest. He is nothing."

"That is the eleventh time you have told me what a paper is not," she said.

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because you are going to have to read a great deal of my summarising, and my summarising is a profession, and the first thing a profession teaches you is the shape of its own limits." He rubbed his hands, which were cold. "You asked me once in a church in Paris for four sentences. This is the fifth: everything I give you will be true and incomplete, and the incompleteness will not be a lie."

❦

She tested him on the ninth.

She had prepared the test for three days, out of Wiktor's manual and out of her own four years, and it was in the manual under a heading that she had once thought excessive: the provocation of a colleague, and the object of it is not to catch a liar but to watch a man being asked for something he cannot produce.

"Police battalions," she said. "The disposition of the German police battalions in the district, all of them, for the next two weeks: their quarters, their movements, their rest days, their strength. Not the gendarmerie patrols; the battalions. Can you bring it to me?"

He sat back and thought about it for eleven seconds.

"No," he said.

"Can you get it?"

"I can tell you what I know from the section's papers, which is two battalions' worth — the 11th and the 31st — and I know their quarters and the days they draw rations, which is a fact about their strength, because the ration boards are in the supply files and I read the supply files." He leaned forward. "I cannot get you their disposition, because it is not in my building. The order of battle for the police battalions is held by the commander of the Order Police of the district, whose office is on the aleja Szucha, and it is issued to the police and to the garrison's Ia, and the copy at the garrison's Ia is in the section Ia of the staff, in a room on the first floor of the Saski Palace which I have been in twice, both times with a major, and where the filing cabinet is

locked and the clerk is a Feldwebel called Böhm who has been in the same office since 1940 and who knows the contents of that cabinet better than his own family." He paused. "It would take me four to six weeks, and it would need two things I do not have: a reason to be in that room when the Feldwebel is not, and a person on the staff who owes me. I could build the second one in a month. The first one I would have to manufacture, and if I manufacture it wrong I lose my posting, and if I lose my posting I lose the section, and if I lose the section I lose everything you came to Warsaw for. That is my answer. What I have for you instead is the fuel allocations for the police battalions, which are in my building."

She looked at him across the table in the cold room.

A liar, in her experience, had one of three shapes: the man who produced the impossible document on the second day, the man who explained at length why he could not, and the man who wanted something for it. She knew the shapes the way a dressmaker knows a badly tacked seam, and she sat looking at this one and understood that he had given her the truth about his limits in the manner of a man laying out a technical drawing, with the reason and the substitute and the timetable, and that she had been in the trade for four years and had never once, in four years, been given that.

"I will take the fuel allocations," she said.

"I know. I made them a copy before I came." He put a folded sheet on the table and pushed it across, and then he said, in the same voice: "And I want the police dispositions too, and I shall get them, and when I have them it will be be-

cause I have found the person who owes me, and not because you have asked me again. Do not ask me again."

❦

And then, with the parcel memorised and the sheet of paper in her hand, there was nothing to do and half an hour left, and the two of them sat in a dead family's room with a coat on, at a table, with a stopped clock on the sideboard reading ten past four, and a hat on the hook by the door, and on the wall three photographs of people standing in front of a car.

"The clock," she said.

"Stopped at ten past four."

"The family?"

"They went to the country in September 1940, the mother and the two children; the man was in the resistance and was taken in 1942 and is in Pawiak or in the other place and nobody in this arrangement knows. The flat is ours because the wife's sister is in the underground and signed it over in 1941 in a kitchen. She comes once a month with a duster and does not come in." He looked at the hat. "The hat is the mother's. I asked. The people who use this room do not move the hat, because the neighbours know the flat is empty and a hat that moves is a sign."

"I know. I have stayed in rooms like this in three cities."

"My mother has a hat like it." He stopped. Then, in a different voice, without any change of posture, he said: "In September 1939, at the gate, he used one word. I have carried it for four years. It was correct and I have never once been able to be angry about it, and I have tried, and I can tell you the whole of the argument of the angry side and it is a

better argument than his, and it does not work, and I am forty kilometres past trying to make it work."

"Do not do this here."

"I am not doing anything. I am telling you what is on my side of the table, so that you can judge the material." He folded his hands. "You asked about the clock and the hat and I answered, and then you asked nothing about the four years, and I am telling you: I have known since the eighteenth of December 1943 in a corridor of the Majestic, and I did not tell anybody, and I have not written one word of it down in any file in any building, and I have had eighteen opportunities and taken none of them, and I am not asking you for anything, and I shall not. That is the whole of my account."

"I sleep with him," she said. "I have slept in that bed since June 1943. I do the work he takes me to the cafés for; I type his letters; I am paid by the German administration in the salary book of the Warsaw garrison; and I have killed eleven days of a man's investigation by putting a Frenchwoman in a police car in Paris in January, and she is dead, and I did it to keep this arrangement, and it worked." She said all of it in the flat voice she had used for the shopping lists in the cellar on the Śliska, and she kept her eyes on him the whole time. "If you intend to use any of it, use it now, because you will not get a better opportunity than this room: I am here, alone, with a paper in my hand that would hang me, and there is nobody in the building."

Phillip Brandt looked at her for a long moment, and then he stood up and went to the window and hooked the curtain back halfway up, which was the arrangement, and

stood there with his back to her, looking down into the courtyard of a cobbler's shop in occupied Warsaw.

"There is a page in the file," he said. "The index page. It has the case reference and the case officer's name and eleven lines on it, and the last line is the question I told you about." He took out of the inside of his coat a folded sheet of paper — thin, flimsy, the sort that comes off a duplicator, with a pencil shadow on the back of it where it had been written on — and put it on the table and pushed it across and did not look at her while he did it. "It is the index page of the file about you. It was in the tray on his desk yesterday afternoon and it is there again this morning because I copied it in the washroom in eleven minutes and put the original back, and if it is missed it will be a search of the whole section and if it is not missed, in eleven days the second copy of it will be in the hands of a woman I have known since I was nineteen."

She looked at the paper on the table and did not touch it.

"Why?"

"Because you asked me in a church for four sentences and I gave them to you and you refused the papers, and I have had four months to work out why, and the reason is that you cannot be bought and you cannot be saved and you are going to be dead in a year unless somebody in that building is on your side." He turned round. "I am in that building. That is the whole of the answer. Take the paper, and burn it in the stove, and do not thank me, because if Lindemann sees me being thanked by you through a window we are both finished."

❦

She delivered on the eighteenth of April, in the cellar on the Śliska, with a candle and a table and a pistol, and Krupa — the Major, the man of the spectacles who had laid down the law to her across that cellar in March — did not sit down.

She gave them the establishment of the counter-intelligence section, name by name, room by room, with the telephone numbers; the field offices of the district and the name of the man in Siedlce who delivered reports to the Abwehr and the cover name he had been given, which Iga wrote in the ledger in a hand so small that it looked like a smudge; the two fuel allocations; the page of the Feldgendarmerie's movement order of the sixth of April, which was, by then, four days old and therefore worthless, which she said out loud before they could; and the paragraph from the Colonel's memorandum to Ia of the second of April on the deployment of the section's field offices for the summer, which was not worthless at all, because a police service which is redeploying for the summer is a police service which has been told what the summer is going to be.

"Again," said Krupa, from the dark of the corner, and she said the last item again, and he took off his spectacles and put them on again and said, "That is the third paragraph in four weeks from the same memorandum series. Tell me about the number on it."

"Sixteen slash forty-four."

"And the previous two were numbers twelve and fourteen of the same series."

"Yes."

"So there are papers in the series we have not seen, in an order, produced on a schedule. I want the schedule." He stood with his arms folded and looked at the candle. "You will not get me the schedule; he will. Understand that when you deliver, you are delivering the whole of what he gave you and not the parts of it that you have decided are important. The schedule is how we know what we have not got. That is what an officer is for."

Then he took his hat off the table and went up the steps, and Iga closed the ledger and snapped the string round it, and said, in her flat voice, without any expression at all: "You gave us two names in the Abwehr in Siedlce and a paragraph that I could not have got in any other way in this city, and I want you to know that I have written the date and the source, and that the source is a German officer, and that the ledger goes into the ground if this city is ever taken, and that the man in the corner has spent two hours tonight arranging that." She stood up. "Come on Thursday and not before, and do not come on foot through the Ruska, and do not look at the wall of the courtyard when you go out, and above all, Stankiewicz, do not do the thing that you are doing with your face at this moment, which is deciding that you are in love with him, because I have seen it twice in this cellar in two years and on both occasions it was the last thing that happened before the arrests."

❦

Two days later, on the eleventh of April, the police sealed the exits of four blocks in Praga between the hours of five and eight in the evening and went through them for men of

the conscription age and for the underground; and the attempt went wrong, in the way the AK sometimes did it, exactly according to plan: the eleven men who had been printed on the paper in the flat above the cobbler's went out over the roofs and through a courtyard on the other side of the street between half past four and five, before the cars came; and the police took a hundred and forty people, and kept nine, and three of them were men who had stayed behind to cover the roofs; and the notice went up on the kiosks with the names and dates in the ordinary way.

And on the fourteenth of April a Polish worker at the telephone exchange on the Zielna was arrested at his post and taken to the aleja Szucha; he was thirty-two, he had a wife and a child, and he had been passing the schedules of the exchange's German traffic to a man in the railway administration; and the file on him had been open since February, and the man who had opened it was looking for a leak in the telephone service of the capital's German administration, and had found one, and had nothing whatever to do with anybody else's case; and the exchange's Polish staff were interrogated for two days.

Iga Zaleska came to the cellar on the Śliska on the sixteenth of April with that arithmetic and put it on the table the way a person puts down a bottle.

"Eleven saved out of the block in Praga. That is your German's paper and it worked, and I have written it in the ledger with his information marked as confirmed, twice, which in my hand is the same thing as praise. One man shot on the twenty-first of April, at the gate of the exchange, and

his name is Nowicki, and he was thirty-two and he was watching for the same police cars you were. Our people in the exchange told us he was arrested because of a leak in the exchange; we do not know him and he does not know us; the file was opened in February by a man in another office entirely." She sat down. "He is nothing to do with your German, and we do not know which of them your German bought. That is the arithmetic, and it is our arithmetic and not his, and this is the trade: we spent a man in April to buy eleven in March, and nobody in Warsaw can make that come out even. Do not look for a cleaner one."

❦

Von Hagen came back from a conference in Kraków on the twentieth of April in the state of a man who has been in a hotel with staff officers for four days, and he came into the house at nine at night with his coat over his arm and the smell of the train on him and the particular glazed courtesy of a Prussian who has been drinking with his equals and has arrived home to what he owns; and the whole of what followed was his, and it was not violent, it was worse: it was thorough, proprietorial, and affectionate in the way of a man handling a good tool, and there was nothing in it that could have been complained about by anybody, and at the end of it he lay in the dark with his hand on her shoulder and told her about the conference.

Not the contents. The contents were sealed, and he kept the seal exactly as long as it took for a man to want to talk about his own importance: he told her about the general who had fallen asleep, about a major from the cavalry who

had put forward a scheme for the defence of the bridges of the Vistula which had been laughed at by the staff, about the food in the hotel, about the fact that the conference was not really about the Vistula at all and that the staff was doing the exact thing that staffs had always done, which was to fight the last war's plan against the next war's problem; and then he said, in the middle of a sentence about the general's gout, something that had no business being in it.

"They have put me in the middle of the most interesting problem of the war," he said, in the dark, with his hand on her shoulder. "There is a section of this city which is not the army and not the police: it is a government. It has courts. It has a treasury. In February it sentenced to death four officers of the administration of the Government General, and one of them was shot in the street in Kraków in front of his wife, and I have read the sentence, because a copy of it was in a packet of cigarettes taken off a boy, and it was in Polish and it was written properly, with the grounds and the signature and the date, and it was the work of a state. That is what is in this town. My department has to find the state." He turned over. "There is one thing about such a man: he is inside the machine. Every one of them is inside something: an office, a railway, a telephone exchange, a household. The state is outside and the man is inside and the gap between the two of them is the only place where a police service can ever put its hands."

Then he said, in the flat, contented, drowsing voice of a man summing up, "There is a matter in my own section. One of the translators has been asking for files outside his

department — twice in ten days, from the registry, in the afternoon. It may be nothing; a translator who is bored asks for files. What do you think of a man who is too curious?"

"I think he is either bored or employed by somebody else," she said, into the pillow, half asleep, in the voice of a woman who has been kept. "And I think you already know which."

"Yes," said von Hagen comfortably, and fell asleep with his hand still on her, and the pearls at her throat, which he had given her in Paris in December, lying on the skin of her collarbone like an answer.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Salt

❦

The route between the German quarter and the north of the city, if a person wanted to go from the Ujazdowski Park to the streets behind the Krasiński Square without passing a checkpoint, ran through the ruins of the ghetto, and Krystyna had found it in the second week of April, and by the last week of April she had taken it four times.

Sixteen square kilometres of it, from the Bonifraterska to the Gęsia, and nothing in it above the height of a ground-floor window except chimneys, and the chimneys were the thing that people talked about, because they had gone up in April and May of 1943 and had stood through what happened and were still standing, hundreds of them, in rows, on the ground plan of the houses they had been part of, so that a person walking through could see the whole of a street in the disposition of its chimneys and nowhere in it a wall.

The brick was grey. The ash had gone into the brick and the brick had gone into the dust, and the dust was in the air of that district on any day without rain, and it was in the coat — she had learned on the second walk that a fur coat coming out of those ruins smelled of them for eleven days, and on the third walk she had begun to wear, for that errand, an old woollen coat of Janina's that she had asked for in the kitchen and been given in silence.

And what people did in it was what people do anywhere: they walked. There was a path from the Bonifraterska to the Świętojerska where the ground was made of broken brick trodden flat and the path was a metre wide in some places and four in others; the black market used the cellars, because nobody followed anybody into a cellar in that district; a man with a barrow of wood went the other way; two boys of about ten were digging in a wall for bricks and stacking them and selling them by the hundred to a man with a horse; and along the edge of it, on the northern side, the guards of the Sipo-SD's posts watched the district's border from the towers of the wall that was not there any more.

She walked it because it was the shortest way between two German streets, and because in it she was, for twenty minutes, nobody: there is no category in an occupied city for a woman in an old coat crossing a brick desert in the middle of the afternoon, and no officer of any police force in Europe in 1944 was looking for her there.

The whole of the city walked through it. It was not a monument, and the people in it were not being solemn; they were going from one place to another place, and the ones who had been made to come there in 1940 and 1941 and 1942 and had been taken away out of it in 1942 and 1943 were not present in it as an atmosphere: they were present in the way that a grave is present to a man who is crossing a field, which is to say that a person crosses, and does not stop, and remembers the field, and does not say anything about it, ever, to anybody.

In the third week of April a man spoke to her in it.

❦

He was in a good coat and bad shoes and standing on a heap of brick at the corner of the Świętojerska where the path came out, and she had seen him three times in eleven days, which she had noted in the way she noted everything, and which she had put down, in the first instance, to a man who collects bricks.

"Good afternoon, madame," he said, in Polish, and took off his hat.

She looked at him for the length of time a woman in an old coat looking at a man in a good coat would look at him, and walked on.

"You come out of that villa on Frascati Street," the man said, behind her, in the same pleasant voice, at the same volume. "I have seen you come out of the gate twice: once in the car and once on foot, in the rain, on the ninth. And you speak Polish when you think nobody is listening. You said something to the brick man about the price of his bricks, madame, and you said it in Polish, and if you had said it in the Polish of a Viennese lady it would have cost you nothing, and you said it in the Polish of this city, in the Polish of the Mokotowska, in the Polish of my aunt." He came down off the brick and stood in the path with his hat in his hands. "And a woman who walks twice a week through these ruins, alone, in a coat from Janina, on the route between the German quarter and the north of the town, where there is nothing at all to buy and no German to see, is a woman with something in her life that she does not wish to have explained in an office."

She turned round and looked at him then, deliberately, the way a professional looks at a problem: fifty, thick through the shoulders, a good coat worn soft, a silk scarf, bad shoes with the heel gone on the right, a copy of the Nowy Kurier folded under his arm, and a face like a bank manager's, with a small moustache and wet eyes.

"You have made a mistake," she said, in German.

"No," he said, cheerfully, in Polish. "I have not. I have made four mistakes in this war and I remember all four, and this is not one of them; and if you want a fifth opinion, madame, I shall give you one for nothing, and it is that the man in the villa has a driver and a sentry and a girl in the kitchen who cannot lie, and that if a person telephones the office on the Frascati and says, in a voice, that the lady of the house walks in the ruins of the ghetto twice a week on foot, then the person who answers the telephone will write it down, and after he has written it down he will say something to somebody, and after that there will be a conversation with a lady in a cellar on the Szucha which will not take place in Polish." He put his hat on. "Twenty-five thousand zlotys, madame, on the first of every month, in a place I shall tell you. Five thousand today."

She had eleven seconds, in the path, with the smell of the brick and the ash in her nose, and in those eleven seconds she did three things: she read his shoes, she read his teeth, and she decided not to kill him in that place.

She gave him five thousand zlotys out of the household money, standing in the ruins, in the open, with her hand steady; and he counted it with his back half turned, and fol-

ded it, and put it in his inside pocket without hurrying, and said, "The first of May, the same place, the same hour, and come alone, and do not bring me a German, madame, because I have known Germans for four years and I do not like them, and I have known you for eleven days and I like you very much."

❦

She went home and did the arithmetic, and it took her two weeks, and it was done in the way Wiktor had taught her, which is: not the man but the circle around the man.

His name was Feliks Kaczmarek. He was fifty-three years old, and before the war he had been a clerk of the court in the district court of the Mokotów, dismissed in 1939 because he had made an error of 400 zlotys in a register that he had then been unable to explain; and in the war he had found a living, and the living was the edge of the ruins and the edges of the city's other holes, and the business was this: a man who knows a thing about a person and who has no scruples and who is not himself afraid of the police can be rich; and Kaczmarek had been rich, and had lost weight in 1943, in the way of the trade, because in the summer of 1943 the courts of the underground had sentenced eleven people in this city to death for what he did, and one of the eleven had been a member of the trade on the Praga side who had been found in the river.

He lived on the Ochota in two rooms with his sister, who was a seamstress and who believed that her brother worked in the supply of the German army; he had a tailor on the Marszałkowska who had made the good coat in 1942

and who was owed 300 zlotys for it; he bought his cigarettes, which were of a good brand, from a kiosk on the corner of the Żelazna, at the same hour every morning; he drank on Thursdays at a café on the Chmielna with two men; and he had, since January 1943, a relationship of a very particular kind with the Sicherheitspolizei's office on the aleja Szucha, which was that he sold them people three or four times a year for money, and that both parties understood that the relationship was temporary, commercial, and dangerous, and that the SD kept the card with his name on it in a drawer with a green band, which in that office meant: use, and do not trust, and destroy when convenient.

She could have killed him herself.

She had the training, she had a kitchen knife and a night in the house when the Colonel was in Kraków, and she had a woman's freedom to walk in the German quarter where he would not have gone walking; and she sat in the bathroom of the villa at the end of April with the tap running and took the idea out and looked at it for a long time, the way one looks at a tool. It was possible. It was also the single most dangerous action available to her in the whole of that spring, because a blackmailer who is killed by his client is a blackmailer whose client is examined by four separate kinds of people, and because a woman in service in a German house must never be the subject of any enquiry whatever, and because — and this was the sentence that finished the idea, and it took her eleven days to write it — because if she killed him herself, in a doorway, with a kitchen knife, then the next time the movement asked her for something that re-

quired a person to be spent, she would find that she had become the sort of person who does that, and she would be right, and nobody in the world would be able to say she was wrong, and in two years she would be exactly what the SD said she was.

So she took it to the cellar on the Śliska on the second of May, with the facts written on nothing at all, in the order of a case.

Krupa listened to the whole of it standing up with his arms folded, and when she had finished he took off his spectacles and looked at the candle for a while, and then he said, "How long?"

"Since the twenty-first of April. Three payments of the first of the month: five thousand on the day, and the first of May he took twenty-five thousand, out of my own money; the pearls went for it. He will come on the first of June, and then on the first of July, and every month until the end of the war, and he will come to my funeral."

"Does he know what you are?"

"No. He knows what I am not."

"Does he know that the man on the Frascati is counter--intelligence?"

"He knows a name on a plate and a car at a gate." She heard her own voice stay level, which was a professional matter and took work. "He is a clerk. He cannot put two and two together about an office, but he can put a woman and a gate together, and he can send one letter, or make one telephone call, and after that the arithmetic is not his business, it is the SD's, and you know what they will do with it because it is the only thing they ever do: they will open a file

on the lady of the house on the Frascati, and they will put one man on it, and the man will be a good one, and in three months they will have her."

"Yes," said Krupa.

He walked to the end of the cellar and back, which took him eight paces, and then he said: "I am going to tell you what happens now, and I want you to understand that I am telling you the procedure and not asking you for a preference. The man is a szmalcownik: he sells the lives of Poles to the Sipo-SD for money, and the courts of the Polish state have sentenced eleven of that trade in this district in eleven months, and I have three of those sentences in a drawer and one of them is a man I went to school with in 1912. He is not your problem, Stankiewicz. He is a case. It will be referred to the court of the district on the ordinary papers; the sentence will be prepared within a week, and the sentence will be a sentence of death; and the execution will be carried out by a group of the Kedyw and not by anybody in this room, and it will not happen near you, and it will not happen in a way that any office in this city can connect to the household on the Frascati. You will be told the week but not the day. On the day you will be seen, publicly, in the German quarter, for five hours, from six in the evening, at a place where there are a great many officers. That is the whole of it, and the timetable is a fortnight, and the price is a man, and the price is not yours to talk about afterwards."

"What is my part in it?"

"Your part in it is that you have brought me a case and a description, and that from this hour until the execution you will not go into the ruins, you will not go to the Chmielna,

you will not speak to him, and you will pay him nothing on the first of next month, because he will not be alive by then." He put his spectacles on. "And you will not be told his name again in this room, or by anybody, ever. It is a case now. It goes into the ledger. That is what the ledger is for."

She sat with her hands in her lap for a moment, and then she said the thing that she had come to say and had not said yet: "May I know what the sentence says?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because it is not yours," said the Major. "Because in the file of the paper that goes to the court there will be a page of the evidence, and on that page there will be a line that says the case came to the attention of the court by way of information received, and there will be no name under that line, and that is so that when somebody is arrested in three years' time and the file is read by a man with a lamp, the file says nothing at all. You will have the satisfaction of the mathematics and no share of the sentence, and that is the whole of the honour available in this trade, and it is not negotiable, and I am sorry if you have been in France, where they do it differently."

❦

The pearls went on the twenty-sixth of April, in the morning, on the Marszałkowska.

The pawnbroker's was a shop with a green blind and three gold watches in the window and a bell over the door, and the man behind the counter was about seventy and had a loupe in his eye and a hand like a pair of tweezers, and he

looked at the necklace for four minutes with a lamp and then told her, in a low voice, exactly what it was: forty-one pearls, twelve millimetres at the top, a white gold clasp with one small diamond, of a good house, bought in Paris in December 1943, and stained at the third pearl from the clasp by perfume, which is the mark that tells a jeweller that a woman has worn a thing every day against her skin.

He offered eighteen thousand zlotys. She asked for twenty-two; he said twenty; she took it; and the whole negotiation took nine minutes and neither of them looked at the other's face, and he counted the notes out twice on the counter and did not write anything down in any book, and she went out of the shop with her collar up and the money in the lining of her bag, and did not feel anything that she had expected to feel.

The paste was on the Kercelak market the same afternoon, from a man who sold artificial jewellery out of a suitcase next to a woman who sold buttons: a strand of imitations of forty-one pearls, of the colour of skimmed milk, with a clasp of silver plate; nine hundred zlotys, and a second clasp of white metal with a stone in it for another two hundred.

She did the substitution in the bathroom at the top of the house on the evening of the twenty-sixth, at the mirror over the basin, with the door locked and the geyser going: the pearls, which she had worn against the skin of her collarbone every day since the twenty-third of December 1943, off; the imitation on; and the whole of it a matter of eleven seconds, and then forty minutes of work with the clasp, the

silk cord, the flocking of the clasp box, a length of the black adhesive tape that the German administration used on parcels and that is called by soldiers der Panzer, cut into two narrow strips, warmed with a candle until it was adhesive in the way that a jeweller's wax is adhesive, and worked into the clasp's box and the cord with a needle so that the imitation joined the real box and the real wax and the real thread and did not show, from any angle, at any distance, under any light, to anybody who was not going to spend a quarter of an hour with a loupe and a lamp.

She looked at it in the mirror to check it, then, with the taps running hot and the steam rising off the bath, and it hung on her neck exactly as the pearls had hung, and it was exactly as good as the drawing of seven hats, and it was 4,500 francs' worth of glass on the throat of the woman in the file.

Then she put the receipt of the pawnbroker's, which was a slip of paper with a number on it and no name, into the lining of her glove for the rest of the week, and on the first of May she burned it on a plate in the bathroom and washed the ash down the basin, because the only piece of paper in the world that could ever connect Marion Herschlag to a pawnbroker in the Marszałkowska was that slip, and because a woman in service in a German house can afford exactly one mistake.

❦

They took him off a tram stop on the Chmielna on Friday the twelfth of May, at twenty past seven in the evening, in a car that had been stolen from a German requisitioned gar-

age on the Wola two days earlier and had been repainted at a workshop in the Ochota by a boy of seventeen who thought he was painting a hearse; and the whole of it took eleven seconds and was done by four men in greatcoats with armbands taken off German coats, and the street was a street of people who looked the other way with total discipline, which is the great gift of an occupied city to whoever is working in it.

Krystyna was at a charity concert in the concert hall on the Nowy Świat at that hour, at a table with von Hagen and Lindemann and two officers of the Luftwaffe and the wife of an industrialist, in a dress of grey silk with the paste pearls at her throat, listening to a Polish violinist of forty play the Brahms concerto, which he played like a man with a train to catch, and which the room applauded for two minutes and forty seconds, and she drank a glass of Hungarian wine and talked to the wife of the industrialist about the price of silk; and at ten past nine von Hagen took her home in the car and told her, in the way he told her everything that was not sealed, that he had had a signal from the section that the SD had picked up a man on the Chmielna who had nothing to do with anything and would be released in the morning, which is what happens in a city where four police forces arrest people all day: the paper goes into a drawer, and the drawer is emptied every Monday.

The body was found in the ruins of the ghetto on the following Monday morning by the two boys who dug bricks: a man in a good coat with his shoes gone and a paper of the twelfth of May in his inside pocket, and the paper said, in the way of that city's papers, that the Führer had re-

ceived a report on the harvest; and the boys took the good coat and the paper and left the man, and it was four days before anybody in an office wrote him down at all, and by then he was a name in a ledger in Pawiak, in the section of the unidentified, where four hundred people went that year.

She was at home when she heard it. She heard it from Janina, who came back from the market with the news in the way that all news came in that city — a sentence between the price of the butter and the tram — and who said it as a thing of no importance, because the death of a man in the ruins was of no importance, and because she did not know his name, and because the coat had gone to the tailor's nephew, and because the whole of Warsaw had stopped counting.

And that evening, in the bath, with the water too hot and the tap running, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna washed her own hands, and looked at them, and did the whole accounting in one piece, which took about four minutes, and it was this: that a man who had made his living out of the deaths of Jews on the edge of the field where the Jews had been burned, and who had taken 30,000 zlotys off a woman whose whole value to her country was that no office ever looked at her twice, and who would have gone on taking it until the end of the war and then for as long afterwards as he could find her, was dead; and that the movement had done it with paper, procedure, a stolen car and a sentence of a state that did not exist, and had done it in the way that everything in that city was done, which was in three weeks, and by hand, and with four men; and that she had not killed

him and had wanted to, and that the difference between those two things was the whole of the difference between her and the man in the good coat; and that the water was too hot, and that she had to get out, because the Colonel was coming back at nine and she had to dress.

❦

The poisoned gift was arranged in the cellar on the Śliska on the third of May, and it took forty minutes, and the whole of it was paper.

They gave her a document: two pages, typed, on the paper of a German staff office of the pattern used by the rear services of the district, with the file reference of a section of the Order Police, and in it: an order concerning the movement of two hundred and forty rifles and eleven thousand rounds of ammunition from a depot in the south-east of the city, and a schedule, and a map annex, and behind it a statement that the material had been issued to a unit of the Polish underground, and a date on which the Home Army was, according to the paper, to concentrate the material for the rising which the underground was, according to the paper, preparing for the summer in the districts on the right bank.

The paper was a forgery, and it was a forgery of a quality she had never seen in France: done in the workshop of a man on the Śródmieście who had been a lithographer of banknotes before the war and who had made the paper, and the stamp, and the typeface of a German machine, and the signature of an Oberst who had never signed it, in the handwriting of the signature copied from a signed photograph in a German office that a Polish charwoman had cleaned for

four years; and the whole of it was designed with the single purpose that the German counter-intelligence of the district should read it, believe it, and act on it, and thereby spend the next six weeks of the summer of 1944 in the wrong part of the city.

"You will give it to him as your own," said Krupa, "and you will do it in the manner in which you give him everything else, which is as a discovery with a chain you can describe."

"I have no chain to describe."

"Then you will have one in four days, because we are going to build you one; and it will be this." He took off his spectacles. "There is a Polish woman of about fifty called Wiktoria Kęs, an Austrian subject born in Kraków, who has worked in the German administration since 1941 as a clerk in the office of the garrison's Building Section, where there are three hundred and forty files a week of building permits and requisitions, and who is going to be of interest to your Colonel in the following way: on the eleventh of May a package of papers concerning the property of the German administration in the district of the Praga will be delivered to an address that she has used before, and she will be the person who is written down in your account of it. You will not meet her. She does not exist."

"That is the whole of it?"

"That is the whole of it: a chain, a name, a paper, an act of the enemy which the enemy will spend six weeks hunting." He put the spectacles back on. "And here, Stankiewicz, is the part that you will not like, and I want you to hear it in

this room. This paper is going into the hands of a German counter-intelligence section, and it is going in with your fingerprints in the sense that matters, which is that you will be the person who brought it in and the person who described the chain. If it is ever traced — not by the man on the Szucha, whom we can manage, but by some clerk in an archive in Berlin in 1946 with a table and a lamp and a cross-reference — then the trail ends in a file, and the file has a note in it that a lady employed in the house of an Oberst of the counter-intelligence section delivered the material on the fourth of June 1944. That is what we are asking you to put your name under. Say no now and we will do it another way, and it will take a year."

She looked at the two pages on the table for eleven seconds.

"Give me the chain," she said.

❦

She gave it to him on the seventh of May, at home, in the study, in the evening, with the lamp on and the door open, in the manner in which she gave him everything: standing at the corner of the desk with her hands behind her back, in the tone of a woman reporting something that has amused her, because that was the tone in which a mistress was permitted to be useful, and it had never once been questioned.

He read the two pages twice, standing, with his spectacles on; and then he read them a third time, sitting, with a pencil, and made marks in the margins, and went to the map on the wall of the study with the paper in his hand and stood in front of the Praga district for four minutes; and

then he sat down again and read the schedule for the fourth time, and at the end of it he looked up at her over the top of his spectacles with an expression she had seen once before, in Paris, on the night of the ball at the Majestic, when a general had shaken his hand.

"How did you get this?"

"A woman in the Building Section," she said, and gave him the chain, and the chain was complete: the address, the name, the office, the transaction in the corridor of a requisitioned building, the price, the fact that she had been given it by a person in the office of a firm of contractors who had done work for the garrison, and that the woman had asked for two thousand zlotys and immunity, in a whisper, with her eyes on the floor, in the way in which every Polish clerk in every German office in that city did everything.

"Two thousand zlotys and immunity," said von Hagen, and put the paper down flat on the desk with the flat of his hand. "Precisely. My dear, do you know what you have brought me?"

"A forgery," she said.

And there was a moment — one second, no more, in which the lamp on the desk lit the room and the sentry's boots went past the window on the gravel outside, and the whole of the war stood in the study on the Frascati Street and waited to see whether a Prussian of fifty-four was going to read two pages and hear the word forgery and go for the telephone.

And von Hagen laughed, once, and said, "Of course it is a forgery. Every piece of paper that comes out of an under-

ground movement and reaches a staff office is either a forgery or a trap or both. That is not what I asked." He stood up and took his glass off the tray and poured two fingers of the cognac and did not drink it. "What I asked is what it is for. And this — this is a very good forgery, and it is a forgery of a document that does not exist in any German office, because the Order Police of this district has no depot in the Grochów and the unit it names has not existed since the twenty-first of April; and the reason somebody has spent the paper and the stamp and the man who can write an Oberst's signature is that they want me to spend the next six weeks looking in the Grochów for two hundred and forty rifles." He drank the cognac. "Which means the rifles are somewhere else, and something is going to happen somewhere else, and somebody in the underground believes that I am the sort of man who is flattered by a paper. I will flatter them. I shall put four sections on the Grochów within the fortnight, and I shall tell the garrison's Ia on Monday that I have the trail of the autumn's ammunition, and the whole of that side of the staff will be looking at the Vistula's right bank for two months, and it will be my operation, and my reputation, and — my dear — my paper." He looked at her with real warmth. "You have brought me a trap and told me it is a trap and let me decide. Nobody in this city has ever done that for me. Where did you learn to do it?"

"From a dressmaker in Paris," she said, "who used to say that a seam is only a seam if you say it is a seam."

That night, in the dark, with his hand on her shoulder and the paste pearls on the chair in the box in which the real ones had come from the rue de la Paix, von Hagen told her

the last thing of the evening, which was the thing she had been waiting half a year to hear, and which he told her in the voice of a man announcing an acquisition.

"They have given me the man I asked for. The Sipo-SD is transferring an officer to Warsaw in May — he is late, everything in that building is late — and he is an expert of the kind they don't breed any more: a quiet little clerk with a card index and no field experience and a first-class mind. His name is Kalbach. He has been writing to me about the French papers for four months, and I have read his letters and I have asked for him and he takes up his post on the eighth, and the first thing he will do is ask for the box from Paris." He yawned, and turned over, and said, into the pillow, comfortably: "He is going to find out what happened in Paris in January, and I am going to let him, because I want to see whether the SD can do the work that my department should have been doing for a year. And then we shall see whether the Fräulein file was a real thing or whether it was a clerk with a chart and a grudge."

Chapter fourteen

The Slow Fire

❦

The arrangements were made in the fourth week of May, in a cellar on the Śliska, by a woman of thirty with a ledger and a man of forty-seven in spectacles, and they were made in the way in which such things are always made, which is as a piece of logistics.

Three places.

The room above the cobbler's shop on the Zielna, in the afternoon, on Tuesdays and Fridays, on the days when the Colonel was at the Saski Palace and the car was with him and the sentry at the villa's gate was nineteen years old and bored and could be managed; and the arrangement there was that nothing was ever to be written, nothing left, nothing eaten, and that the chair was to be put back against the wall at the end.

The cemetery at Powązki, on Sundays, in the morning, in fine weather only, in the crowd, because a cemetery in an occupied city is the one public place in which a man and a woman may stand four metres apart for half an hour in the open air and have nothing whatever to explain to anybody; and the rule there was that they never met at the gate and never left at the same time as each other.

And a café on the Chmielna, at the corner of the Szpitalna, where a person could sit for an hour for the price of a coffee and a newspaper, where neither of them ever ate, and

where the mark was a coat: a grey coat on the hook inside the door, at the end, which meant come in, and no coat, which meant do not.

Two hours of the day. That was the arithmetic of it: two hours, twice a week, on days and at hours that were set by a girl of thirty who had never met Phillip Brandt, and who set them each week by a route that went through two other people, neither of whom knew what they were carrying, so that no single person in the chain knew both the hour and the man.

And the marks: a chalk line drawn under the second window of the courtyard on the Zielna, which meant the yard was watched; a light in the window of the third floor of a building on the Hoża Street, which meant that the street was quiet; a blue scarf in the window of a shop on the Bracka, which meant a change of hour. Nothing in writing, no paper, no name, and never the same coat twice on the Chmielna, because a woman in a fur coat is a woman whom four people in a café will remember.

That is what their love physically was: a set of arrangements, made by other people, entered in a ledger, subject to revision, in a city where a scratch of chalk on a wall could mean a man's death; and the fact that it worked at all in that city, for six weeks, in the fifth year of the war, is a piece of professional achievement that neither of them ever told anybody about, and there is nobody left alive who knows how it was done.

❦

Powązki was the largest thing in Warsaw.

It was about seventy hectares of graves on the low hills in the north-west, with avenues of lime trees and chestnuts, a wall, three gates, the graves of the men of 1831 and 1863 and 1920, the graves of the writers and the actors and the two thousand men of the legions, and family chapels the size of small houses; and in the spring of 1944 it had, among all the other things in it, the mass graves of September 1939, the rows of little iron crosses for the soldiers, and a great many fresh graves of people who had died in the ordinary way in the four years since, which in that city meant being carried out of a flat by neighbours and buried by a priest with the coffin on a handcart.

And it had, on a Sunday morning in late May, the population of a city's weekend: old women with flowers wrapped in damp paper, children running in the avenues, men in coats that had been good in 1930, a priest in a black overcoat at the gate of the cemetery of the evangelicals, and, at eleven in the morning, an officer of the Wehrmacht in the uniform of the Abwehr walking slowly along the fourth avenue with his hands behind him and a Polish woman in a grey coat reading the names on the stones eleven metres away, in the sun, in the smell of cut grass and lilac and, from somewhere to the north, the smell of coal smoke.

They had between them, in the whole of an hour, about eleven sentences.

"Here is the question I want answered first," she said, in front of a stone with a photograph on it of a young man with a moustache. "What does your father say at table?"

"He says nothing at table, because my mother says nothing at table, and my mother's silence is the law in that flat. He says things in the doorway when he has his coat on and I am going out. He said to me on Tuesday, with his hat in his hand: the men who rule with the paper will be gone in a year and the paper will still be in a drawer, and somebody is going to have to explain it, and it will not be me, because I have a son in the Abwehr."

"That is a joke."

"It is half a joke. He has been making the same half of a joke since 1940. What does your father say?"

"My father says Latin. He has four boys and a Latin primer and he says to them that a man who has the grammar of a language has the key to a country, and that a country that loses its grammar loses the country." She turned a page of her book, which was a book of 1911 with a broken spine, and which she had carried in her pockets for three weeks. "He was wrong about one thing. He taught me the grammar of French and German and the syntax of the poets, and I have spent four years using the syntax of the poets to say good evening, Herr Oberst in a voice that makes a man want to be at home."

"That is not nothing," Phillip said. "That is the whole trade."

"That is the whole trade."

They walked on. A family went past them with a wreath, four adults and two children in poor shoes, and the whole of the family looked at the officer once, together, in the way of a flock, and then away; and Phillip took his cap

off and held it, which is what any German officer would have done in a cemetery in front of a funeral, and it also meant that his face was not in the family's memory.

Her turn came at the end of the avenue, in front of a chapel with a rusted iron door.

"There was a beet machine at Wierzbów," she said. "A beet harvester, bought in 1934 out of the mortgage money, with a name-plate on it that said the works: Lilpop, Rau i Loewenstein, Burakowska Street, Warsaw. It came up on the railway to Grodzisk and then by cart, in four pieces, and a fitter came with it from Warsaw and stayed eleven days in the servants' hall, and his name was Pan Ludwik and he was forty and he had a mole on his chin, and he took the whole thing apart twice and put it together again and showed my father how, and on the last Sunday he took me and my brother out to the field with him and we sat on the machine and he told us what every lever did." She put her hand flat on the ironwork of the chapel door, because it was cold and she wanted to feel something. "The smell of machine oil is the smell of those eleven days, and of that Sunday, and of the whole of the last autumn there, which is the only autumn of my life in which nothing whatever was wrong. Your father's works are in my father's last good year. That is the fact on my side of the table. You have the whole of it."

Phillip Brandt stopped in the avenue with his cap in his hand.

"My father's works," he said, "built the gun mountings for the Polish coastal batteries in 1938 on a licence from a German firm, and my father signed the licence in October 1937 in his office on the Burakowska Street, and I was in

that office that afternoon with a copy of Racine in my pocket, and I have spent four years knowing that every piece of paper that a man signs in a country that is about to be sold is a piece of paper he will be asked about in a room with a lamp." He looked at the stones. "There is no clean year. That is all I have to say about 1938, and I shall not say it again, and I would like to be told about the beet machine instead, and how it stuck in wet ground."

It stuck in wet ground for the whole of the first season, and the man from Sandomierz who had sold them the seed said it was the ground and the estate agent said it was the machine, and they sat in the avenue in the sun for eleven minutes arguing about it, in two languages, and neither of them noticed that they had stopped doing anything else.

❦

The patrol came on the Hoża Street on the fourth of June, at half past four in the afternoon.

He was late. That was the first fact and it decided everything: he was nine minutes late, which had never happened, and she was standing at the corner of the Zielna and the Hoża with her hands in her pockets, in the open, in the daylight, because the rule about the corner was that a person did not stand there and the rule about being late was that at seven minutes past the hour a person walked away, and she had broken both rules in the same minute, because of the nine minutes.

And then the boots: eleven men on the pavement coming from the direction of the Krucza in a line, in greatcoats, with that particular tread on paving stone that the whole of

Europe had learned to recognise, and a car behind them at the kerb; and between her and the courtyard that had the doorway she was supposed to use there were forty metres of open pavement with nine people on it.

He came round the corner nine metres from her, saw the patrol in the same second in which she saw him, and did the thing that she thought about for the rest of her life.

He came up the pavement towards her fast and loud, and he said, in German, at a volume that carried to the corner and to the man selling newspapers and to the two old women at the tram stop and to the eleven men in greatcoats:

"Verfluchte polnische Schlampe — willst du mir die Straße versperren?"

And the filth of it, the word he had used, the worst word in the language for a woman, said at that volume, on the pavement of the Hoża Street in the afternoon, made the whole of the street turn around; and he took her by the upper arm and turned her and marched her to a doorway, and put her back against the wall of the doorway with one hand flat on the bricks beside her head and the other holding the lapel of her coat, and demanded her papers, and she, with her chin down and her hands shaking — and the shaking was not a performance, which was the thing she noticed about it afterwards with a certain professional interest — got the Kennkarte out of her bag and gave it to him, and put her back against the wall and said, in the Polish of a woman who was about to be arrested, in a voice pitched for the boots:

"I have done nothing, sir, I have a pass, I am a domestic, I am in service on the Mokotowska —"

"Shut your mouth," he said, and looked at the card. "Marion Herschlag, Austrian. Are you a Jew?"

"No, sir."

"Are you a Pole?"

"I am an Austrian, sir, I work in the house on the Mokotowska, my papers are in order—"

And the boots came past the doorway, all eleven of them, one after the other, and one of them glanced in and saw an officer of the Wehrmacht holding a woman's papers in the doorway of a building on the Hoża Street and shouting at her, which is a scene that happens eleven thousand times a day in an occupied city and is of no interest to any soldier in the world; and the boots went round the corner and up the Zielna and stopped at the corner of the Szpitalna, and stayed there for four minutes, and the two of them stayed in the doorway, in the position, with her back against the brick and his hand on the bricks beside her head, for the whole of the four minutes, saying nothing, and looking at nothing, at the collar of her coat, at his own hand.

"It is nothing personal," he said, eleven seconds after the boots had gone, in a completely different voice, without moving his mouth very much. "It is what an officer says to a woman who is in his way. If I had said one word less they would have remembered us; and if I had said it in Polish they would have remembered me."

"I know."

"I did not enjoy it."

"I know that too," she said, and remained where she was, because her legs were not yet entirely hers.

And that answer, which he thought about for eleven days, and which she thought about for eleven years, was not the answer he had expected, and he turned his head for the first time and looked at her, and then the boots came back up the Zielna and past the end of the street an inch behind them, and they waited for another ninety seconds, and then he let go of the bricks and stepped back and said, in a loud, tired, German voice, for the street: "Go on. Get out of my sight," and she went, up the Zielna into the courtyard and through the arch into the next street with her hands in her pockets and the whole of her body shaking, and they did not see each other for eleven days.

❦

They talked about the end of the war four times, and the whole of it was in code.

He gave her the political arithmetic, in the way of a man of thirty who has been reading the papers of a general staff for four years and whose mind was made to hold such things: that the armies of the Soviet Union had been in Poland since January; that the second front had come in June; that in Lublin, since July, there was a committee of Poles with a Russian general standing behind it, and that the committee had been given a name that was the same name as the government in London and was not the same thing at all; that in the Government General the Germans were building four lines of field works with Polish labour and Jewish graves in the foundations; and that in every office in Warsaw, from the garrison's Ia down to the typists, men were arguing about one question in the smoking-room, in

lowered voices, which was whether Warsaw would be defended as a fortress or given up as a ruin.

"Which?" she said.

"They do not know. That is the true answer and you can have it. The staff does not know, and the argument is between the men who remember 1914 and the men who have read the reports from Stalingrad, and the second set is bigger than it was and the first set has the rank. If I had to put money, I would put it on the city being fought for in the streets, because everything that has been built here for two years has been built for a siege, and because a man who has been told to make a fortress makes a fortress whatever the generals decide." He looked at the stones. "And the underground will rise, because everybody in this city knows that it will, and because the committee in Lublin will want it, and because the government in London will be told about it afterwards. And when I say everybody knows, I mean everybody: my clerk knows it, my barber knows it, the boy who shines shoes at the corner of the Bracka knows it, and it is in the safe in the section as a paragraph in a report from the army's own intelligence, in German, on paper with four copies, saying that a rising in the city is probable in the summer."

"And you will be in it."

"I will be in the building that is being besieged, in a uniform, and the twenty-eight days of a siege are coming to this city in the next twelve months, and I shall be on the wrong side of the wall, in the wrong coat, and the Poles will be shooting at the coat." He said it flatly, without self-pity, the way an engineer says that a bridge will take a load of eleven

tonnes and no more. "And you will be on the wrong side of the same wall, and the coat will be on a chair in a bedroom in a villa, and there will be nothing in the world that either of us can do about the arrangement."

"Then do not say it."

"I am not saying it. I am describing the material."

Neither of them ever said the word love — not in the cemetery, not in the room above the cobbler's, not in the four thousand sentences they exchanged in six weeks — and the reason was not delicacy and it was not fear of the censor. It was the arithmetic, and they both had it: he had a mother in Wola whose name was on a list, and she had a father with one lung on the Mokotowska Street and a sister of seventeen who had bought coal with a pianino; and a sentence said out loud in that city in that year was a rope with two ends in it, and the only way to keep the rope off the two ends was to leave it lying on the ground between them.

The photograph was in the flat above the cobbler's, on the wall of the back room, among eleven other photographs of the Wolski family and their relations, none of whom either of them knew.

It was an amateur print, about the size of a hand, fixed to the wall with two pins, of a boy and a girl, aged about eight and six, standing at a well with a bucket between them; the well had a wooden cover and a windlass, and the girl was holding the handle of the windlass with both hands and the boy had his hand flat on the rim of the well, and the two of them were looking straight at the camera, and it was summer and it was somewhere in the countryside and it had nothing whatever to do with either of them.

They stood in front of it on the first of June, for a long time, in a cold room in the fifth year of the war, and then she said the first honest sentence she had said to anybody since September 1939.

"It sticks at eleven metres," she said. "You let it down twice with a slack turn on the second, and then it goes."

Phillip Brandt did not say anything for a moment. Then he said, in Polish: "I know. I have known for six years." And he put his hand flat on the wall beside the photograph and left it there, and she stood a hand's length away with her hands in her pockets, and that was the whole of the physical content of the afternoon.

❦

The dinner was on the sixth of June at the villa on the Frascati Street: eight people, the Oberst and his lady, two officers of the section, the civil administrator of the district and his wife, a captain of the Luftwaffe who was in Warsaw for a fortnight, and a Polish woman from the Kraków who had married into the German administration and who spent the whole evening being watched by everybody; and the food was good and the silver was the requisitioned silver of a family in the Żoliborz and the wine was from the cellar of somebody in the country, and the whole of it was the ordinary evening of the ruling class of a city in the fifth year of an occupation.

The plate of the civil administrator's wife was cold.

It is worth setting down exactly what happened, because in the memory of the people in that room it grew into two or three different stories, and in the file of the security police

it never appeared at all. Von Hagen noticed the plate — he always noticed, he was a man who noticed the room — and he said something to Janina, who was carrying a dish in at that moment, in a voice that was not loud, and it was a sentence of four words in German about the temperature of a plate; and Janina, who was forty-five years old and had been in service since 1916 and had a bad wrist, and who understood about eleven words of German and those eleven were the ones she had been made to learn, said, "Ja, gnädiger Herr," in the way in which she said it eleven times a day, and turned to go.

And he hit her.

It was not a blow of any force — he was sitting and she was standing, and it was the back of his hand across the face, and it made the sound that such a thing makes in a dining room with eight people in it and a fire going; and it knocked her sideways one step, and she brought the dish up against her chest with both hands to save it, which she did, entirely; and there was a second of no sound at all in that room, and then the civil administrator's wife said something about the heat of the summer, in German, in a flat, ordinary voice, and the Luftwaffe captain laughed at the end of the table at some other thing, and the room went on.

Janina went out with the dish. It had not spilled. She carried it out of the room, into the pantry, and set it down on the table, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, who was sitting two places from the Colonel with the paste pearls at her throat and a glass of wine in her hand, sat there for the rest of the dinner and did not move and did not stand up and

did not say one word, because there is no version of that evening in which the lady of the house stands up for the servant, and because the four hours of that evening were four hours of work, and because she was, at that moment, the only person in the room who had seen the whole of the sentence from the beginning: a man in a villa on the Frascati Street, in a country he was losing, on the sixth of June 1944, with the second front on the beaches of Normandy and the Russian guns three hundred kilometres to the east, taking out the whole of the war on the face of a Polish woman of forty-five with a bad wrist who had said the only two words she knew.

And after the guests had gone, and the fire was banked, and the house had settled, the Colonel came up the stairs behind her and put his hand on the back of her neck in the corridor, in the way he did, at the top of the stairs, when he wanted her; and she leaned her head back into his hand, and he said something about the civil administrator's wife's hat, and she laughed, and they went into his room; and it is worth setting down that the whole of the change from one room to the other took her less than a minute, and that the minute was the seam, and that nobody in the world — not her brother, not the Major, not the priest in Paris, not the man in the cemetery — was ever given a look at it; and that the woman who lay in the dark afterwards with the pearls on the chair in the box had, on that same afternoon, said the first honest sentence she had said since 1939, to a man ten metres away in a room above a cobbler's shop, about a well in an orchard in Mazovia that stuck at eleven metres.

❦

On the Tuesday of the last week of May she came into the flat above the cobbler's at four and he was already there, with the coat off and the parcel of the day on the table, and there were eleven minutes before the hour at which they had to be out of the building by different doors; and they spent the eleven minutes on the thing that neither of them had yet been able to spend on anything else, which was the ledger.

"There is a notebook," she said.

"There is always a notebook. Which one?"

"Rutz's. The Colonel's driver, who has been with him since 1937 and who writes everything in it: the hours the car is used, the miles, the wine, the silver, the laundry — and the hours I leave the house and the hours I come back." She had her hands flat on the table, and she was talking fast, because eleven minutes is eleven minutes. "I saw him write it in Paris in December. Fräulein Marion, collected 1.35. He is a good man and he is not one of them and he writes it because a Furier of the old army writes everything; and it is the single most dangerous object in that house, and it has been kept for seven years."

"I know about day books," Phillip said. "There was a case in the Amt in the spring of a clerk in Bucharest who was caught by a day book in a hotel. Four hundred pages of a concierge's handwriting and one man's name appearing eleven times on the wrong nights." He looked at the paper on the table. "What do you want me to do?"

"Nothing. There is nothing that can be done about a day book. If it disappears, that is worse than if it stays. I am

telling you because it is the material, and because you are the only person in this city to whom I can say the word ledger and be understood." She picked up the parcel and began to unclip the string. "And because if a certain kind of man ever sits down in a chair in that villa with a notebook, the first thing he will ask for is the day book, and the second thing he will ask for is Rutz, and the third thing will be what the orderly thinks when he is asked a question by a policeman, which is that he will answer it because he is Bavarian and has nothing to hide and thinks the whole thing is an enquiry about petrol."

"Then we have a timetable."

"Then we have a timetable," she said, "and it is not in our hands, and the only thing that is in our hands is that when the day book is read, it should be read in a city where I have never left the house on Tuesdays."

❦

She came home that evening at a quarter past six to the villa on the Frascati Street and found a car in the drive that she did not know: a saloon, grey-brown, of a make that was not standard for the garrison, with a Warsaw number plate and a driver in civilian clothes at the wheel reading a newspaper, and mud on the running board.

And on the terrace, with his back to the door and the garden in front of him, there was a man of about thirty-eight in a civilian overcoat and a hat that was two years out of fashion, standing very still with a small notebook in one hand, cleaning his spectacles with a handkerchief held in the other; and as she came across the gravel he finished with the

spectacles and put them on and turned his head slightly, in the way of a man who has heard a step behind him and who has decided, in advance, not to turn round until he has finished what he is doing.

Emil Rutz was standing at the foot of the terrace steps with his cap in his hand and his tunic buttoned and an expression of the most ordinary discomfort: the expression of a soldier of the old army who has been asked a question by a man in a civilian coat and who has answered it because he is a soldier and the man has a paper.

"—and the Fräulein has been with the Oberst since Paris, since last year, that is what I said, since June of last year, and before that I do not know, and it is not my business to know, and the Oberst's household is my duty—"

"Of course," said the man on the terrace, in a soft, small, exact voice, in German, without any accent that she could place at all. "Nobody is asking about anybody's duty, and I am grateful. For the record: Fräulein Marion Herschlag, Austrian, in the household of Oberst von Hagen, since June 1943; employed in the section as a clerk since March 1944." He wrote it down, in the small notebook, in a small hand, and then looked up and saw her, and bowed, an inch, with the hat in his hand, and said: "Gnädige Frau. Forgive the intrusion. My name is Kalbach, and I am from the Sicherheitspolizei's office on the aleja Szucha, and I am here about a box of paper that came from Paris in March, and I have been told that it is a matter of some interest to the Oberst — which is to say, of course, that it is a matter of some interest to me."

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Hunter's Notebook

❦

Sturmbannführer Bruno Kalbach came to Warsaw on the eighth of May 1944 on the night train from Kraków, in a second-class carriage with two suitcases, a box of files and a hatbox, and stood on the platform at the Ostbahnhof for a moment in the fog with the collar of his civilian overcoat turned up and the whole of the station shouting at him in two languages, and thought, with a satisfaction he would not have admitted to anybody, that he had waited eighteen months for this city.

He was thirty-eight years old and he looked like a man of fifty in a way that was not ageing but a kind of grey efficiency: small, neat, with a soft face, spectacles with a thread-repaired frame, and hands that were always occupied, if not with paper then with a handkerchief or a spectacle lens or the rim of a hat. He had been in the Sicherheitspolizei since 1935 and in its counter-intelligence sections since 1939, and before the war he had been a clerk in a notary's office in Vienna, and in 1938, in March and April and May of 1938, he had been the officer who catalogued what was taken out of the flats of the Jewish families of that city, in the presence of their own caretakers, in writing, in triplicate, in the correct order, and it was the only work of his life that he remembered in detail: the flat of the professor in the Berggasse with the piano and eleven thousand books, the flat of the

dentist on the Wollzeile with the silver and the photographs, the flat of a widow of eighty on the Schottenring with the linen in a cupboard that had been her mother's, item by item, the list in his own hand, the caretaker's signature, the van.

That work had taught him two things which he had never once found to be wrong in six years: that a person's life can be read off the objects in a room, and that the reading is not cleverness, it is patience.

The office was on the second floor of the building on the aleja Szucha with the window on the lindens, and it had been a room with a view since 1940 and had been occupied in that time by three different officers of the section, each of whom had left something: a map, a chair, a smell of eau de cologne. The lindens outside were in leaf in May and they were full of birds at six in the morning and the birds were the reason he asked, on the first day, for the window to be closed and the latch wired, which the clerk noted in the day book of the office as an eccentricity and which the typists discussed at breakfast, in the canteen, over the ersatz coffee, where Kalbach ate his meals for the first week because he had no establishment of his own and nobody to eat with.

He had eleven people under him, of whom four were watching groups and six were clerks, and he had the whole of a box from Paris.

The box was the material of the case that had been opened on the avenue Foch on the fourteenth of January 1944 by a man named Kalbach, who had had a hypothesis, and had had it confirmed three times since in ways that would not stand in any court, and who had then had the

whole case transferred to Warsaw for the reason that he had stated in the memorandum himself, in writing, to his own superiors, in the following words: the material is not in the west; the material is where the woman comes from.

He did not believe in the woman.

That is the thing to understand about him, and it is the thing that made him dangerous in a way that no policeman in Paris had been: he had no theory of a person called Fräulein. He had a set of anomalies in a set of documents. He had a chart of access, and a page of linguistic evidence a professional would have thrown away, and a question mark, and eleven interviews, and a day book, and no name at all; and what he did in his first three weeks in Warsaw was not to hunt. It was to write the whole of it out again, in his own hand, in nine pages, in a hotel room on the Krucza Street by a lamp, because he had found in 1938 that material which has been arranged by other people is material which has been ruined by other people's opinions.

He walked the city for four days with a notebook, in the manner of a man taking an inventory of a room he intends to live in, and what he saw was this.

He saw that the street names were German on the tram stops and Polish on the corners, in chalk, re-written at night by somebody; that the walls of the Śródmieście carried four kinds of writing — the German proclamations, the posters of the executions, the small hand-chalked marks of the underground, and, around the food offices, the pencil marks of a hundred private arrangements about bread — and that a Pole walking down a street looked at the walls the way a

farmer looks at the sky; and he understood, standing on the corner of the Marszałkowska on his second evening with his hat in his hand, that he had come to a city which had been reading itself for four years, and that the whole of his method, which was reading, would have to be done here in a language he could not read.

He saw the ruins of the ghetto from the tram on the Bonifraterska, and looked at them for the length of a city block, and wrote in his notebook: brick. guards on the north. the market uses the cellars. no information of value can be obtained here; the population that knew the district is destroyed. It was the most nearly human sentence he wrote in his first month, and he did not know that it was.

He saw the queues: for bread, for water, for the registration of documents, for the tram; the queue at the corner of the Żelazna for the chemist; and the queue at the window of the Pawiak on the Dzielna Street, at which women stood from six in the morning with parcels and a name, and which told him more about the city than any file, because a queue of women outside a prison is a queue of people who believe there is a point in it.

He saw an execution notice go up: a boy of about sixteen pasting a sheet on the kiosk at the corner, and four people reading it, and a woman going past it without turning her head, which is a discipline, and an old man stopping in front of it and reading the whole of it with his lips moving, which is not.

And on the fourth day he noticed the tail: a woman in a dark suit with a canvas satchel, on the tram behind his, twice

in one week, in two different coats, with her hair cut short and badly and a face like a locked door. He noted her in the notebook, and did nothing, because a man who is being watched is a man who is being watched by somebody worth watching, and because in that city a police officer with a tail on his tram was, in his own estimate, six weeks of quiet work away from meeting the one adversary in Warsaw who could be relied upon to have a method.

❦

The nine pages were a chart, and the chart was the whole of the case.

The first page was a list of everything that had leaked from the German administration in France between June 1943 and February 1944, in the order in which it had leaked: the coastal sector's inspection schedule; the convoy route on the eleventh of December; the two dates at Saint-Nazaire; the fuel allocations of the Fifteenth Army in the second half of January; and, at the bottom, in the margin, in Kalbach's hand, the note that none of it had ever appeared in the British or American press, which meant that the receiving end was a service and not a newspaper, and that the service was organised, which meant that it had a country.

The second page was the list of the rooms in which those particular documents had passed. There were forty-one names on that list, and thirty-nine of them were German, and the two that were not were a French typist in the administration's supply office who had been dismissed in January 1944 for theft, and a Polish woman in the office of

the Hôtel Majestic's administration, and beside those two names Kalbach had written, in pencil: check, in time.

The third page was the traffic: the hours at which the material had left Paris, inferred from the dates of the London signals that the wireless section had intercepted in the spring of 1943 and had not understood until now; and the inference was that the material left the city, in general, between nine in the evening and six in the morning, and that the source therefore had a house to go to at night.

The fourth page was language.

There were three items on it, and the third was the waiter's memory of an accent with a Warsaw consonant in it, and above that item Kalbach had written a single question in his small hand: where is the woman from?

The fifth page was the day book.

It was not Rutz's day book — he had not seen that yet — but the concierge's ledger from the house on the avenue Henri-Martin in Paris, which had been obtained in January by a man in a grey overcoat who had asked for it and had been given it, and which was a French concierge's book of the arrivals and departures of a household, kept by a woman of sixty-two in the ordinary way, with one peculiarity: that a column had been added to it in pencil in January 1943, headed heures des sorties, and that the entries in that column were in the same hand as the rest of the ledger.

The concierge had explained the column in two sentences in her interview. She had said that a gentleman of the administration had told her, in the January of the second year, that the household was under an enquiry into the pet-

rol and that the hours at which the young lady of the house went out and came in were to be written down; and that the gentleman had been a German in a grey overcoat, and that he had been very polite, and that she had never seen him again; and Kalbach, reading the interview in the file in his room in the Krucza Street, had underlined the two sentences twice, because they were the whole of the case in miniature: somebody in that city had already been running a day book on the woman, in 1943, from inside the German administration, and the somebody had never been identified by any office.

The sixth, seventh and eighth pages were the interviews he had ordered in his first two weeks in Warsaw, which were three.

The first was with the Polish maid at the villa on the Frascati Street, a woman of forty-five called Janina Prus, who was brought to the Szucha in the ordinary way, in a car, at nine in the morning, having been met at the corner of the Bracka by two men with a paper, and who was questioned for two hours and forty minutes without being touched and without being made to stand, in a room on the second floor, in the presence of a typist, and who said, in the end, having been asked eleven different ways about the young lady of the house: that the young lady was quiet, that the young lady did not go out in the evenings, that the young lady never asked her questions about the household, that the young lady had asked her once about her brother in the Reich and had not written anything down, and that the young lady had never once, in four months, been in a room with a Pole for longer than it takes to give an instruction.

Kalbach wrote down the last answer in his notebook, twice, and did not believe one word of it; and he was right not to believe it, and he was wrong, which was the shape of the whole of his war: the woman was telling the truth she had decided on in the corridor on the way in, and it was a good truth, and it had been made in the four minutes that the car had waited at the corner while the driver finished his cigarette, and Kalbach had no instrument in the world for the difference between a lie and a decision.

The second interview was with a pawnbroker of the Marszałkowska Street, conducted by his own men in the shop, in the ordinary way, with a receipt: the man was seventy, had a bad eye, and was frightened of nothing and nobody, and he told them, when they showed him a photograph of a necklace of the same pattern as the one recorded in the inventory of the household property of the villa on the Frascati Street, that he had never seen such a necklace in his life, and that his records were in the book, and that they were welcome to the book; and after the two men had gone he thought about it for four days, because a jeweller's conscience is a particular instrument, and on the fifth day he went to a priest, and the priest told him to say nothing and to keep the money in the tin, and he said nothing, and he kept the money in the tin, for eleven months, until the end.

The third interview was with the assistant of a jeweller on the Kercelak, who had been a seller of imitations for eleven years, and who said, in the way of a man in that trade talking to two men in coats, that he sold a great many strands of imitations, and that in the last week of April he

had sold a strand of forty-one pearls, of the colour of skimmed milk, with a clasp of silver plate, to a lady in a grey coat and good boots, and that she had paid nine hundred zlotys and had not argued about the price, and that he had been told to put the strand in a box with a silk cord, and that she had asked him whether the clasp could be made to take a better stone, and that he had said no, because it was plate.

And Kalbach, sitting in a hotel room in Warsaw in May 1944, with the two reports on the table in front of him, wrote in his own hand on the eighth page a single sentence, in German, which is the sentence that closes the middle of this book:

Item: pearls sold. Item: paste bought. Note: a woman who pawns a gift from a rich man in April and buys paste in the same week is a woman with a reason, and the reason is not jewellery.

❦

The interview with the orderly was on the nineteenth of May, in a room on the ground floor of the Szucha, and it took an hour and ten minutes, and it was conducted with the entire courtesy that Kalbach kept for soldiers of the old army, which is a courtesy of a kind that no civilian in Europe could have resisted, and Rutz did not resist it for a second.

He was fifty-one years old, from a village near Bamberg, and he had been twelve years in the army and four years with the Oberst, and he sat on the chair with his cap on his knees and answered every question in the way in which a Bavarian soldier answers a policeman, which is generously,

and with the assumption, entirely correct, that he had done nothing wrong and that the answers could not possibly be interesting to anybody.

The car's mileage, the hours, the wine, the silver, the laundry, the Colonel's health, the Colonel's temper, the Fräulein's shopping, the Fräulein's hat. Did the Fräulein go out alone; when; how often; did she come back with anything; did she ever meet anybody; did the orderly know any of the Fräulein's friends in the city; had the Fräulein ever asked him to take her anywhere that had surprised him.

And then, at the end of the hour and ten minutes, with the whole of it written down and the typist's carbon in the tray, Kalbach asked the last question, which was not a question about the case at all, and which he had put at the end of every interview in his career since 1938, because the answer to it is always of the same kind:

"Is there anything about the Fräulein that has ever struck you as odd, Herr Rutz? Anything at all — a habit, a word, an accent. I ask everybody this. It is a formality."

And Rutz, who had been six months of his life in a car with the same woman, who liked her, who wrote her hours in a notebook, who had a wife in Bavaria and a photograph of a niece in the windscreen of the Mercedes, and who had nothing whatever in his soul that could have imagined why the question was being asked, laughed slightly, and said: "Only that she says a Polish word sometimes. Odd, that. She is Viennese — you can hear it when she is tired — and when she is tired she says bułka for a bread roll, which is Polish, if you say it my way; and one evening at the table in Paris last

year she said it to the cook. It gave me a turn. My grandmother was from Posen and she said it like that, and I have not heard it since 1931."

Kalbach wrote it down.

He wrote it down in the small notebook, in the small hand, and said thank you, and stood up, and shook the orderly's hand, and had the door opened for him, and stood in the corridor of the second floor of the building on the aleja Szucha for a moment with the notebook in his hand, and read back the sentence, and thought about the fifth page of the nine pages in the room on the Krucza Street, on which there was a waiter's memory of an accent with a Warsaw consonant in it.

The word did not prove anything. That was the point about it, and it was the reason it was worth so much: a woman of Vienna who says a Polish word for a bread roll when she is tired is a woman with a Polish grandmother, or a Polish nanny, or a Polish year somewhere, and there were two hundred thousand such women in the Reich and half a million in the part of the world that was called Austria and had been called something else before it. It would not stand. It would be laughed out of a room by any lawyer in the Reich. But a man who is building a chart of anomalies does not want a proof: he wants a nail, and the word was a nail, and it went into the fifth page beside the waiter's accent and beside the file's question mark, and there it joined the rest of the ironwork, and afterward it never came out again.

The interview with the Oberst was on the twenty-second of May in the study of the villa on the Frascati Street, and it lasted fifty minutes, and the whole of it was a chess game in which one of the players had a notebook and no authority at all, and the other had an army and no evidence at all.

Kalbach came with three things: the pawnbroker's report as his men had written it up, the Kercelak seller's report, and a page of the inventory of the villa's effects as it had been made on the requisition in June 1940, and he put the three of them on the desk in an order, and sat with his hat on his knees, and began, in the manner of a man who is being deferential about the fact that his business is small.

"Oberst, with your permission: the household of the Fräulein. We are tidying a file that came from Paris. There are two pieces of paper. The first is a jeweller's statement that a strand of pearls matching a necklace said to be in the possession of the young lady of this house was sold on the Marszałkowska in April. The second is a statement of the same week that a strand of imitations of the same pattern was bought on the Kercelak." He looked at his own hands, and then at the Oberst, with the most modest expression available to a man with spectacles. "There is nothing in either piece of paper. Either of them alone is worth nothing at all. Together they are a question, and the question is what a lady in this household was doing with two strands."

Von Hagen listened to the whole of it with his hands flat on the desk, and did not look at the papers, and did not pick them up, and when Kalbach had finished he leaned back in his chair and said, in the tone of a man who has been asked about the price of a horse by a man who cannot ride:

"Sturmbannführer. In 1942 I was in Russia with the Sixth Army's supply, and in 1943 I was in Paris, and I have been in this city since March. In each of those places I have had, at one time or another, a woman in my household, and in each of those places a man with a card index has come to me with two pieces of paper and a question. In Paris it was a set of railway tickets; in Russia it was a doctor's certificate. I did not answer either of them, and I shall not answer this one, and I am going to explain to you why, and you are going to write it down, because I have been told that you write everything down.

"The woman in question is an Austrian national of no political interest whatever, certified by the Auswärtiges Amt in Berlin in February by a procedure that took three days and which costs a favour; she is employed as a clerk in my section and is paid from the salary book of the garrison command; she is in my house and in my bed, and that is a matter between me and my conscience and my tailor. Her hours are known to my orderly, who writes them down; her movements are in the day book of this house so that anybody who wants to know them may know them. In the last three months she has been in this house, my office, the homes of four officers of the garrison, the cathedral on the Świętokrzyska, a café on the Nowy Świat, and the dress shop of a woman on the Bracka; every one of those places is a German place, every one of them can be checked, and every one of them has a German in it who will remember her hat." He stood up. "There is no case. There is a clerk with two pieces of paper and a hypothesis, and the hypothesis is welcome in my section as an intellectual exercise and is not welcome in

my house as an insult. Do you understand me, Sturmbannführer?"

"I understand you, Oberst," said Kalbach, and stood up, and put on his hat, and said, in the same modest voice: "May I ask one thing, for the file, and then I shall go? It is not about the young lady. It is about this house. Is there, in this house, an orderly's book, of the kind that Furiers keep?"

And von Hagen, who had won, and who was a Prussian and knew what a day book was and had never in his life considered that his own orderly's notebook could be anything but a piece of paper about petrol, said: "There is. Rutz keeps one. He will show it to you on your way out, and you will read it in the hall, and you will give it back to him, and you will not take it away with you, and you will report to me in writing what you found in it, which will be nothing."

"Of course," said Kalbach, and did exactly that; and read the day book standing in the hall of the villa for eleven minutes with his hat under his arm, and wrote down, in his small notebook, in the small hand, with the pencil moving along the page like a man reading a timetable: the hours, the days, the eleven occasions in April and May, the eleven occasions on which the lady of the house had gone out on foot and come back within the hour from the direction of the Hoża Street, where there is no shop that a lady in a German household has any reason whatever to visit.

❦

The ninth page was written on the Krucza Street on the night of the twenty-sixth of May 1944, by a lamp, with the window open because the lindens in the Szucha had given

him a headache, and it was not a page of a report. It was a page of a letter to himself, of the kind he had written every month since 1939 and had never sent to anybody, in which he put down what he thought, as opposed to what he proposed, and kept it in the drawer of whatever desk he had, and burned it when he moved.

*The case in France was a woman. The case in France is now a woman in Warsaw, and the two are the same woman, and I am the only person in this city who believes it. I have a word, and an accent, and two strands, and eleven walks in the direction of a street with nothing in it. I have nothing that would survive an hour in front of a man like von Hagen, and I have made an enemy of him by looking at his house, which is a thing that I shall pay for in due course and shall not avoid paying for, because the alternative is to know the answer and to leave the file in a drawer. In time.

*My method has always been the same and it does not fail except when a man loves. In Vienna I read the flats: three hundred and eleven of them in four months and I was never once wrong. What is in a room is in the room because a person put it there, and a person puts a thing in a room for one of a hundred reasons and all of them are legible. But a man in love is a man who will lie for a woman in a letter, in a report, in a court, in a war, and he will do it not because he has been bribed but because the account in his head has been rewritten, and there is no instrument for the reading of a rewritten account.

*Therefore the woman: the pearls, the paste, the word, the accent, the walks. Nothing.

*Therefore not the woman. Therefore the account.

Therefore: the surveillance is routine and shall not be theatrical: the house, the car's routine, the woman's routine in writing, by two men on bicycles, and the day book once a month from the orderly, with the Colonel's approval in writing, which I shall obtain by going over his head to the garrison's Ia with an argument about petrol. And one thing more, which no office in this city has ever done and which is the whole of the idea, and I have not seen it in any file since Paris: I shall require the identification of every Pole who has been in the same room with this woman for longer than ten minutes without a German present. Every one. Shop assistants, dressmakers, hairdressers, clerks, the staff of the offices she has been in, the servants of the houses she has visited. In the last four months: eleven such rooms. In the next four months: there will be more, and there will be a pattern, and in a pattern of Poles there is always one name that appears twice in two places that do not touch; and when I have it I shall not need pearls and I shall not need paste and I shall not need to argue with a Prussian about his house.

He wrote it out, and read it, and put it in the drawer, and then wrote a second sheet, which was the order, in the correct form, to the officer commanding the second section: Surveillance, routine, minimum two watchers, in writing, twice weekly. One additional name on the watch list, approved by me on the ground of the day book of the household of the Oberst: any German officer of the garrison who is seen on foot in the vicinity of Hoża Street on two or more occasions within thirty days is to be noted, with the hour and the date, and no action taken. Report fortnightly. In time.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

An Order from the Forest

❦

It came to her at a dinner table, in the third week of June, in the middle of the soup.

The dinner was at the villa and there were nine people at the table; the soup was a consommé with a piece of marrow in it, and the conversation was about the harvest in Galicia, and Janina came in with the wine on a tray, and the Polish waiter who had been borrowed for the evening from the restaurant on the Nowy Świat — because the villa's own two servants were not enough for nine and the Oberst liked a professional hand at the sideboard — came round the table with the bottle in the white cloth, and poured, and as he poured for her he put a card down on the cloth beside her hand: a card about the size of a playing card, folded once, of the kind that florists put in a box, and on the front of it there was a picture of a bunch of roses.

She had, at that moment, a fork in her left hand and a German major on her right discussing the price of a horse, and there were nine people at the table, all of whom looked at her when she laughed, and she laughed at a thing the major said, and turned the card over with two fingers under the level of the table, and read it, and put it in her sleeve, and ate her soup.

The French network has been rolled up since February. Wiktor Janowski was taken in Paris on the sixteenth of Feb-

ruary, held at Fresnes, shot at Mont-Valérien on the twelfth of April with twenty-two others. We have it from the wire, and the wire is good, and there is no doubt in it. You will be told where and when. Your work continues and the terms are unchanged.

She sat at that table, in a grey silk dress, with the paste pearls at her throat, for one hour and fifty minutes.

The conversation went round: the harvest in Galicia, the price of a horse, a story about a general's wife who had bought a château in Hungary in April on the advice of a fortune-teller; the news from the front, which was not news, because the front was in the east and the east was a rumour and the rumour walked through the dining rooms of Warsaw in the summer of 1944 in the form of three sentences that everybody had heard and nobody had said; the question of the air raids, which had not come to the east of the Reich yet, and which everybody in that room had a theory about.

She did the arithmetic of the hour and fifty minutes, in the way she had been trained: at the table she was the Colonel's lady, which meant that she was the woman in the room with four officers and three wives, and that the whole of her work was to be neither interesting nor absent; and she talked to the major about the harvest and to the civil administrator's wife about a hat, and she laughed twice at the right places, and when the woman on the other side of her asked her about the singing, because it was known in Warsaw that she sang, she said that she would sing for them if the Oberst would permit a Schubert song and nothing

German with brass in it, and the whole of the table laughed and made the Oberst permit it, and she sang, after the dessert, standing by the piano with the pearls and a glass of Hungarian wine, one song of Schubert in the thin, clear, small voice that the room had heard eleven times and had learned to want; and the whole of the sacrifice of the two hours — of the soup, of the card, of the wine, of the song — was this: that there are four officers of the Warsaw garrison who remembered, four months later, at the end of August, in the last week of their lives, that the Colonel's Austrian mistress had sung Schubert at a table in June, and that not one of them ever connected the song to anything, because what she had done was exactly what the woman in the room was for.

Then the guests went, and the house settled, and she went up to the bathroom at the top of the house and locked the door and turned both taps on.

❦

What she thought about, in the bathroom, for two hours, was not grief.

That is worth setting down carefully, because she thought about it herself, on the tiles, at midnight, with the steam on the mirror and the card unfolded on the edge of the basin: grief was a thing that would come to her in 1947, in a room in Łódź, at a table, over a piece of paper, and would last four days; and what was in the bathroom in Warsaw in June 1944 was a much more practical and much colder emotion, which was the vertigo of a person whose files have been closed.

The rules: nothing in writing; nothing carried; nothing said in a place where it could be heard; and the four rules of Wiktor Janowski, in his dry voice, in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement in the autumn of 1942, which she had kept every day for a year and a half, and which had kept her alive: one, that she was never to be curious about the people above her; two, that she was never to ask when the arrangement would end; three, that if she was ever asked a question in a room she could not leave, she was to answer nothing, at all, for the first eleven minutes, because everybody breaks in the end and the way you spend eleven minutes is the difference between a lot and nothing; and four, sleep.

And the whole of it came with a sentence, which he had said once, in a kitchen, with his bad leg stretched out in front of him and a newspaper on his knee: "You have not been caught. That is the whole of our morality, and you are going to have to do without any other."

The man who had made the rules was dead in a field outside Paris with twenty-two others and a record in a German file; and there was nobody in France to whom she owed an account; and there was nobody in the movement on the Śliska who had known him, and there was nobody in the world who could tell her whether what she was doing in Warsaw in June 1944 was authorised or was the invention of a lonely woman with a good memory. She sat on the edge of the bath in the steam and understood that she would have to be her own standard, from that evening, for the rest of the war; and that the standard would be the four rules, and the sentence about the morality, and the taste of the

man's voice, and that they were now a small private religion in a bathroom in a German villa, kept by one person, in the way in which people keep the religions of dead countries.

She burned the card on a plate, and ran the ash down the basin, and went to bed at half past one and slept four hours, which is sleep, and which is what the fourth rule is for.

❦

Warsaw in June 1944 had changed its temperature, and the whole of the change was in the railway stations.

It was in the trains that stood in the sidings for a day and a night and went west: the administrative staff of four offices, the families of the men of the German administration, the wives and the children and the furniture of the Reich — crates, pianos in straw, a crate of wine, a woman with an umbrella and a birdcage and the whole of her life in a single case. The Poles watched them go, at the Ostbahnhof and the Gdańsk station and the Dworzec Wschodni, in the way in which a population watches a dying administration: without comment, without celebration, and with a kind of unhurried attention, because a departing occupier is a thing that has consequences and every one of those consequences is going to land on the population.

It was in the soldiers, who had changed from the soldiers of 1943: the older men with the ribbons of the last war and the soft, well-fed horses of the garrison were now the second grade, and the streets of the German quarter had in them, in June, whole units out of the east — men out of Russia, in the grey that was not quite the same grey, with the

mud of the Pripet on their boots and the smell of a burnt country on their coats, walking in parties of four and six along the Nowy Świat with their rifles over their shoulders the way men walk who have been in a place where a man does not walk in parties of four; and the front-line units were moving through Warsaw all that month in the direction of the Vistula, from east to west, at night, with the horses and the lorries and the field kitchens, so that the citizens of the capital saw the German army of the east cross their city in the dark for four weeks.

It was in the underground press, which had stopped being careful: three papers in three weeks, all of them, in different words, saying the same thing, which was that the hour was near, that the orders would come, that the people of Warsaw were to prepare and to wait, and that the eastern front was on the river.

And it was in the courts.

The courts of the underground, which had been working since 1940 with the patience of an institution, had entered their last and busiest summer: in June 1944, in the cellars and the flats of that city, there were sentences being prepared and handed down every week, by men and women sitting at tables with a lamp and a file, in the name of a Polish state whose government was in London and whose army was in the city; and among the thousands of such sentences that year there was one, prepared at a table on the Śliska by four men over eleven days, on a szmalcownik called Feliks Kaczmarek, who had been executed on a stolen car on the Chmielna on the twelfth of May, and whose file, with the

evidence and the sentence in it and no name under the line that said by information received, was sewn into the lining of a coat and carried out of the city by a girl of nineteen and put in a place where it would be found in 1946, and used by a court in the Poland that came afterwards, in the three years when half of Europe's criminals were working in offices and the other half were dead.

❦

Iga Zaleska brought her the ultimatum on the twentieth of June, at a table in the cellar on the Śliska, with a map on it.

"You know Brandt is a witness," she said.

"I know he is a German officer who knows what I am."

"He is a German officer who knows what you are, who has known it since December, and who has not written it down; and he has brought us eleven documents and the establishment of the counter-intelligence section and the day book of the household and a page of the file about you; and there are four people in this section whose lives are in the hands of a man in a German uniform who could walk into an office on the aleja Szucha any morning and buy himself a transfer with one sentence." She put her hands flat on the map. "The section voted on Monday. It was close. Four to three, and the chairman was the one who carried it for you, and he carried it because of the eleven documents and not because of anything he feels. You have seven days."

"Seven days for what?"

"To bring him in," said Iga, "or to be told that the section will handle him, which means that he will be followed until we know the days and the hours and the habits of a

man we have decided to kill, and then he will be killed in a doorway, by a group that does not know his name, and in a way that leaves a piece of paper on the body which will say that he was shot as a German officer by the Polish resistance, so that nobody in the world is ever going to know that the reason was you." She looked up. "I am not saying this to frighten you. I am telling you the process, because the process is the part of this that is not negotiable, and because you should hear it from me and not from a vote."

"You have a letter from him," said Krystyna. "You have three of the establishment pages. You know what he can do."

"We know what he has done. That is the past and it is in the ledger and it is confirmed and I have written it in my own hand, twice. The section deals in the next four weeks, because in four weeks the Russians will be on the Vistula, and in four weeks all the paper in this city is going to be burned or taken, and every German officer in Warsaw is going to be either dead or west, and the question the section asked on Monday was not whether Brandt is honest. It was: in the last week, on the day, whose side will a German officer be standing on, and what will he do with what he knows?"

"Bring him in, then," said Krystyna. "Where?"

"Here." Iga folded the map. "One hour of the road, the blindfold, the sandbags, the kitchen table, four hours of questions from the chairman, and a card in our files with a pseudonym on it, and after that he is ours in the way that everybody in this city is ours, which is his name in a drawer

and a rope around his neck that we can pull whenever we decide that we have been wrong about him."

"That is what you offer him."

"That is what we offer everybody," said Iga. "Listen to me, because there is one more thing and then I will stop. I have watched you for four months and I know the shape of it, and I am not going to pretend about the shape, and I am not going to pretend to like it. I will pretend to be glad you are alive, because that one is true. The forest does not care who you love. It only wants the order to stand."

❦

The room was a kitchen in a house in the Żoliborz with the windows papered and a table with four chairs, and it was used for this and for nothing else, and the whole of the arrangement was that she walked in with him at eight in the evening by the gate on the Mickiewicza and did not go in herself.

"You put this on," she said, at the gate, "and you put your hands behind your back, and I take your left arm, and there is a flight of steps inside, six of them, up, and the doorway, and you will not speak until somebody speaks to you, and you will not ask me anything, and whatever happens in the next four hours, you will do exactly what you are told, and if you are told to stand you will stand until you are told to sit, even if it is an hour, and there will be four people in the room and one of them will be a man in spectacles who does not sit down."

"And if I do all of that?"

"Then in four hours a man will write a name in a file and from that hour you will be a source of the Polish Home Army, and your name will be in a drawer, and one day when this is over, if there is an after and if anybody is left, somebody will take the name out of the drawer and it will either hang you or save you, and there is no way for either of us to know which."

Phillip Brandt stood in the street in the dark in the uniform of a captain of the Abwehr with a bag in his hand, and looked at the strip of black cloth in her hand, and said, "Tell them I will stand for an hour."

And she blindfolded him with her own hands, in the street, in front of the gate, and walked him through it.

The four hours are not the material of this book: they were paper and procedure and questions, and the content of them was established in the files of the section and was written down in a shorthand that has never been found. What is known about them, from the two people who were in the room and lived, is this: that the questions were put by Krupa in Polish and translated by her into German, and that the answers were given in German and then repeated by her in Polish, word for word, and that the whole of it went at half the speed of a normal conversation, so that a man who was asked four hours of questions had in fact eight hours of his life in that room; that the first two hours were about the German administration's filing systems, the formats of orders of the day, the registration of the paper of four offices, the pattern of the staff conferences of the garrison; and that at the beginning of the third hour, Krupa took his spectacles off and put them on the table.

"There is one question," he said, "and everything else that has been asked this evening was a matter of detail. I want you to understand that the answer you give will be written down and will be read by people who will act on it, and that it will be the whole of your value to the Polish state, and that we are not asking you to be a Pole. We are asking you to tell us what you will do in the last week of the war."

The room was quiet. There was a candle and a lamp and four people and a sandbag in the corner of the kitchen, and a woman with her hands in her lap translating; and if the whole of a novel can stand in one room, it stood in that one.

"In the last week," Phillip said, in German, "I will be in the garrison command's building on the Saski Palace, in the counter-intelligence section, at Room 14, at a desk, with the papers of the evacuation of the civil administration and the technical plans of the bridges of the Vistula in my room, because the technical plans of the bridges are held in the transport office of the garrison and are copied to four sections, and one of those copies comes to my section every month for the file on the state of the crossings, and nobody in my section has ever read it, and I have read it eleven times. On the day the orders come to destroy the bridges, the copies will be in the building, and the evacuation orders will be in the format that I can describe to you now, in three departments, with the code words for the population's movement in the second appendix. If I am alive and in that building in the last week of the war, and I am not arrested before it, then I will bring out the demolition plan of the bridges and the evacuation order, and I will bring them to the woman

who is sitting at this table, and it will be the last thing I do in that uniform."

Krupa sat with his spectacles in his hand for four or five seconds.

Then he put them on and wrote, on the file card in front of him, in a small square hand, at the top, three letters and a dash, and the letters were KONRAD.

❦

She took the blindfold off in the entry hall, with her own hands, in the dark, at half past twelve at night, and the two of them stood in a hall that belonged to nobody in a house in the Żoliborz with a bag at his feet.

"You are in the files now," she said. "You understand what that means. It means that if the house on the Śliska is ever taken, and the files with it, and if they ever read the drawer, then a card with a pseudonym on it and eleven pages of questions and answers will be in a German office on the aleja Szucha in a fortnight, and the four hours you spent in that kitchen will be read out to you in a different room by different men, and there will be nothing I can do about it, and nothing the Major can do, and nothing your father, and nothing your mother."

"I know what it means," Phillip said. He picked up the bag. "It means that I have chosen the side that will be doing the reading in the room. I have been a translator for four years and I have never once been in a room where the paper was mine, and I have wanted, every day of this war, to be in a room where the paper was mine. That is not noble. You asked me in Paris why I did not arrest you. Here is the an-

swer, as an engineer's answer, so that we do not have to talk about it again: because a man who translates for four years knows what every document in a building is worth, and I have spent four years watching documents that were worth a city go into the wrong drawer. That is all. The rest of it — you, the orchard, the well at eleven metres — is a different department of my life, and it is not the department that signed the card."

"Good," she said. "That is the correct answer and I shall not tell the Major you said it, because he would be pleased by it, and I do not want him pleased."

❦

The Colonel's summer was a slow fever in the villa on the Frascati Street and it had four symptoms, and she catalogued them all.

The first was the dinners: four in June, five in July, officers of the garrison and the administration, and the talk at them had changed from the talk of the spring, which had been the talk of a service doing its work, into the talk of a company that has heard something in the next room. They talked about the front the way men talk about a patient: the Hungarian plain, the Carpathians, the line on the Vistula, and the four sentences that everybody had heard and nobody would say out loud, and the sentences were shortened in July to two words, and the two words were the river.

The second was his ambition, which grew all that summer like a plant in a cellar: he wanted to be the man who broke the underground's intelligence before the Russians

came, and he said so, at his own table, in his own study, twice; and he had put the whole of the counter-intelligence section on one programme, which was the identification of the underground's intelligence network in the city; and the programme had produced, by the middle of July, four arrests and one name, and the name was a railway clerk of forty, and the railway clerk's interrogations had produced a list, and the list had produced the arrests of two others, and von Hagen, at the end of July, had begun to believe that he was going to do it.

The third was the night.

He had begun to talk in the dark, in the small hours, in the way in which a man talks when the talking is not really a conversation: about the war as an accounting exercise; about his brother's farm in the Uckermark and whether the Russians would reach it; about Klaus, on the train from Posen, in the dark, with the crossing of a bridge, in the kind of detail that a man keeps for the room he sleeps in; and about loyalty. Twice in July he asked her, at three in the morning, in the dark, in the voice of a man talking about the weather: "What is loyalty, my dear? Not to the flag. To a person."

And she lay beside him in the dark with her hand on his chest and gave him the following answers, which were the truth in the way in which a lie can be the truth: that loyalty was a habit; that it was made by small things, in the morning, when nobody is watching; that a person is loyal to the thing he has already done three hundred times; and that she was loyal to him, and would be in August, and would be whatever he needed in the last week of the war.

The fourth symptom, at the end of June, was the trunks.

On the twenty-ninth and the thirtieth of June, four offices of the German administration in Warsaw began to send their registries west in crates on the ordinary trains: the labour office, the building administration, the food section, the office of the press. The removals were done at night at the goods yard of the Gdańsk station, and the Poles saw them, and the underground's analysts read them the way an accountant reads a ledger, and said, in a letter that went through four hands and came out on the Śliska, what they had said every week since April: an administration which is sending its archive west is an administration which has stopped expecting to come back.

❦

On the last day of June she went to the Ogrodowa, to the address her brother had written on a scrap of paper in a courtyard in March and which she had carried in her head ever since, and took the fur coat to the woman who keeps coats.

The building was on the north side of the street behind a courtyard full of washing and a man asleep on a chair; the flat was on the third floor at the back, up the back stairs, with a card on the door that said J. Grabska, tailoress; and the woman who opened it was about sixty, small, in a black dress with a tape measure round her neck, with the hands of a person who has been sewing for forty years and the eyes of a person who has been doing something else for four.

She looked at the coat; and then she looked at Krystyna.

"Whose is it?"

"Mine."

"Whose was it? Sit down. This takes a minute." The woman turned the coat inside out on the table and went along the seams with her thumb and forefinger, feeling for a place, and found one, and took a needle out of her collar and picked at the stitching of the lining under the left arm and opened four centimetres of seam, and slid her fingers in, and took out a small piece of paper that had not been there when the coat was made in Paris in 1943, and unfolded it with one hand and read it, and put it back, and stitched the seam up with eleven movements in about forty seconds.

"That is a paper of the Building Section," she said, "with a file number on it, dated the twelfth of April. Which means that somebody in a German office put a piece of paper in your lining in April, and that the person who did it did it in a hurry, and that you have been carrying it against your ribs for two months in this city and in that villa and through every sentry post between." She put the needle back in her collar. "Your brother is a good boy and a bad tailor. The coat stays with me. I keep eleven coats. When you need it, I will have made it into something else, and when this is over you will come and get it, and if you are dead I shall sell it, and if I am dead my sister's daughter has the list of who the coats belong to, and it is in her head and not on paper."

"How much?"

"Nothing. It is a coat. I do not charge people whose coats are as expensive as your coat, because a woman who wears a coat like that has already paid for it in a way I do not want to hear about." The woman folded it, and put it in the

wardrobe at the end of the room, among nine other coats, and shut the door. "Come back in the winter. Do not come back before."

❦

Krupa sent for her on the fourth of July, at eleven in the morning, in a flat on the Zielna with a piano in it and a curtain that did not move, and he sat down for this one, which he had never done before.

"The section has an order for you," he said, "and it is the last order you will be given before the end of the war, or before the end of everything else, and I am going to give it to you in the whole of its parts, and you are not going to answer me tonight. You will answer me on Friday. Do you understand?"

"I understand."

"Four weeks," said Krupa. "By the end of July, before whatever happens in this city happens, we are to have the German garrison's defence plan for Warsaw: the dispositions of the units, the strong points, the ammunition state, the water supply, the demolitions — above all the demolitions, the bridges, the gasworks, the waterworks, the telephone exchange, the power stations. Everything a commander needs in order to know what he is holding, and everything we need in order to decide whether to fight in this city, and where, and with what, and for how long." He took his spectacles off and cleaned them on his handkerchief, which he did when he wanted a moment, and put them on again. "There are four copies of that plan in Warsaw. One is in the office of the garrison's chief of staff,

one is in the fortress engineers' office in the Citadel, one is in the building on the aleja Szucha in the hands of the SS and police leader, and one is in the counter-intelligence section of the garrison command, in the study of the villa on the Frascati Street, in a safe behind a lithograph, and that one is the copy we are asking you for."

"And if I cannot get it?"

"Then the order says: or the identity of the person holding it," said Krupa, "so that the section may take the decision about that person." He looked at her across the piano. "You will not answer me tonight. You will note that there is nobody else in Warsaw who has ever been inside that room, and that the plan is a fortress plan and is being revised in July, weekly, which means the paper is being moved, which means there are hours in that house when it is on the desk and not in the safe; and you will note what I have not said, which is that the man who holds it is the man you sleep beside, and that the section knows it, and that the section wrote that sentence in the order on Friday, in my handwriting, and that I have read it eleven times since and have not found a better one." He stood up. "Friday, here, at the same hour. Bring me your answer and nothing else, and do not bring me a letter and do not bring me a reason. The order is not interested in reasons."

Chapter seventeen

The Twentieth of July

❦

On the twentieth of July, at eight in the evening, the villa on the Frascati Street was at dinner with two officers of the administration and their wives, and the radio was on in the corner of the dining room, as it had been since the winter, playing the light music that the Reich broadcast into the Generalgouvernement at that hour, and it stopped in the middle of a waltz.

The silence of a radio is a thing that a room notices before it knows why; and then the voice came, and the voice was not the announcer of the light music but the voice of the Reich's own bulletin service, and it was reading a statement of the Führer's headquarters, and the statement said that a small clique of ambitious officers, having no connection with the front and no support in the army, had attempted to murder the Führer; that the attempt had failed; that the Führer was unhurt and would address the German people that night; and that the guilty would be punished with the severity that their crime deserved.

There was no sound in the dining room of the villa for about eleven seconds. Krystyna Stankiewiczówna sat at the table with a fork in her hand and watched four German officers of the Warsaw garrison hear the whole of the sentence the German army has tried to kill the German head of state for the first time, in a room with their wives and a Pole in a

black dress standing at the sideboard with a tray; and what she watched was not shock. It was calculation: it came onto their faces one after another like a shadow coming across a field, and the calculation was exactly the calculation that every officer of the Wehrmacht in Europe made that night, from the commander of a battalion on the Vistula to the quartermaster of a depot in Norway, and it had three parts: who was involved; who is going to be asked about this; and is my name in a paper.

Von Hagen, at the head of the table, listened to the whole of it with his hands flat on the cloth and his eyes on the middle distance; and when it was over he reached over and turned the volume of the radio up himself, in front of his guests, and said, in the flat voice of a man continuing a staff meeting: "The Führer will speak at ten. There will be no more discussion of this at my table tonight, and there will be no discussion of it with anybody in the street tomorrow, and if any officer in this house is asked about the events of the twentieth of July in this city in any office, he will say what every other officer of the garrison will be saying, which is that he heard it on the radio and has no opinion. Helene, the wine."

The Führer spoke at ten. The whole of the house listened to it in the drawing room, on the wireless, with the servants in the doorway: the voice, and the silence after it, and then the men standing up and the women standing up and the small, terrible relaxation that comes after a broadcast in a country where the broadcasts come from the top.

And in the twelve days that followed, the German administration of Warsaw did what every German administration from Paris to Riga did in those twelve days, which was to reach into its own files and find out who was next to whom.

Phillip Brandt's chief — a Major of the Abwehr's station in the city, a heavy, careful, decent Westphalian of fifty-six who had been at a desk in Warsaw since 1941 and who had signed three of the documents that went into the parcel above the cobbler's shop — was called to the garrison command on the thirtieth of July at nine in the morning and taken to Berlin the following day, and he was not accused of anything: he was transferred for political examination, which is a phrase in the German language of that year which means that a man is removed from his post, his papers are read, his telephone is listened to, his friends are asked, and his family does not know where he is; and he was released in November and put on a transport to Breslau and died in an air raid in 1945, and nothing about him was ever proven, and none of it was ever taken back.

And in the same twelve days, a Hauptmann of the section called Kurt Lindemann went to the office of the Sicherheitspolizei on the aleja Szucha twice, in civilian clothes, in the evening, with a folder under his arm, and gave two of his colleagues to the SD in the form of a memorandum about their political unreliability, and the two colleagues were removed within the fortnight, and Lindemann was promoted and given the room next to Phillip's and a chair with a better back, and began, in a manner so gradual and so friendly that it was three weeks before Phillip could be certain of it, to

read what was in Phillip's tray in the evenings after Phillip had gone home.

❦

He came to the flat above the cobbler's on the twenty-fifth of July with a bag.

"There is a list," he said, "of one hundred and forty officers of the Abwehr's old establishment in the Government General who are to be re-examined for political reliability. A hundred and forty: nine are from this city. My name is on page four. Nobody has accused me of anything; I am not under arrest; the paper says for examination, and the examination means a man in a room with my file and my family and my wife's — my mother's family, my father's old application for party membership, which I have told you about, and the fact that I speak Polish and was born in Warsaw, which in 1944 is a fact about an officer of German counter-intelligence that a man in a room in the aleja Szucha will find interesting." He put the bag down and looked at her. "And on the paper, in the third column, there is a note: hearing, 4 August, Szucha, Section IV."

She stood with her back to the window and looked at the bag, and at him, and at the whole of the arithmetic in the room, and the arithmetic came out as it always did.

"You cannot go to that hearing."

"No."

"Because a man who goes into that room on that paper comes out with a file, and the file goes into a system, and the system is going to be in Berlin in September and in Warsaw in August; and the day the system reads your file after the ar-

rest of your chief, you will be taken, and everything you have from me is then one long corridor with four doors in it and a man at the end with a typewriter."

"No," he said. "So I am not going to the office. As of tonight I am a Hauptmann of the Abwehr who has not reported for duty, which in the language of the German army is a deserter, and as of tomorrow morning there will be a paper in the garrison command with my name on it in a different column from the one I am on tonight. And I shall not be in the office when the paper is made." He sat down on the chair at the table with his hands on his knees. "That is what you came here for, in the end, and I want it said out loud in this room, because it is the only way I can make it true: the arrangement you have been running for four months needs a man inside the garrison command in the last week of July. To keep being that man, I have to go to a room on the aleja Szucha on the fourth of August and be re-examined; and the examination will take eleven days and will end with my file in a system; and in the last week of the war I will be either in a cell or on a list, and no use to you at all. If I do not go, I become a deserter tonight, and I am free of every file in the German army, and I can work from now until the end of this without a signature; and everything I can reach from inside a building I lose, which is the whole of the bridges' paperwork and the evacuation orders and the four copies." He looked up. "So the choice is between being a source who is a soldier, for four weeks, until they read the file; and being a man with no rank and no desk and no papers, who can only give you what he already has in his head and what can be got out of buildings at night."

"There is a third thing," she said.

"There is a third thing, and it is the reason I am sitting here with the bag, and the reason is that if I stay in the uniform after the twentieth of July, I am also a German officer in a city that is about to be fought over, and the woman who runs me is a Pole in the Polish underground, and my mother lives in Wola in a flat with a window; and every German in this city is going to have his name and his family in a card index before the summer is out, and the card that matters is not the one about the bridges. It is the one about my mother." He opened the bag and took out a folded paper, which was the establishment of the counter-intelligence section of the garrison command of the first of July, with the names of eleven officers. "I made a present to you of my access in April, and you have had everything I could reach, and in the last four weeks you have had four documents out of my room through the window in the morning. I am not going to be able to do that again after the twenty-fifth of August, because after the twenty-fifth of August this city will be a fortress with an entrance and an exit, and I shall be either inside it or outside it." He put the paper back in the bag. "So I want you to take me to the people who made the card with the name on it, and I want them to send me where I can be useful, which is outside the uniform and inside the city, and I want that arranged in the next three days."

She looked at him for a long moment.

"You are asking me to take a German officer to a place where a German officer is a target."

"I am asking you to take a man who has been a German officer since 1939 to be discussed by four Poles in a kitchen," Phillip said, "and I am telling you, in this room, that I know exactly what the arithmetic is: they will look at me, and they will decide whether to put me to work or to put me in a door, and I am asking you to arrange the conversation, and I am not asking for a promise. If they decide on the door, they will decide it as an army decides things, and the paper they will write will be in a drawer in a cellar, and I shall be in a different drawer, and in fifty years somebody will read both of them and will know that everybody in the room was right." He looked at the photograph of two children at a well on the wall. "I am tired of translating. Arrange the conversation."

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The summons came on paper, in a car, on the twenty-sixth of July at nine in the morning, at the gate of the villa on the Frascati Street, and it was addressed to Fräulein Marion Herschlag, Austrian national, employed in the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison command; and it was not an arrest. It was a request, in German, in the correct form, signed by a Sturmbannführer of the Sicherheitspolizei, inviting her to attend at the office on the aleja Szucha 25 at eleven o'clock on the twenty-sixth of July in connection with a file, with the assurance that the interview would be conducted in the form of an administrative clarification; and the car had been sent for her, with a driver and a soldier, and Rutz was not with it.

Von Hagen read the paper at the breakfast table, twice, and put it down and said, "That is the man from the terrace in May. Schleier? No — Kalbach. He has no right to summon a member of my staff without my approval, and he has not got my approval, and I shall have a word with his chief on the telephone this morning; and you will go, my dear, because if you do not go, in that building they will write the word refused in a file, and a refusal in a file is a brick, and a wall of bricks is how these people work." He folded the paper and handed it to her. "You will go, and you will say nothing at all except what is asked in the fewest possible words, and you will not answer a question that is not a question, and you will be back by three. And if anybody in that building is discourteous to you, I shall hear about it, and there will be consequences in a room with a carpet."

The room was on the third floor, and it had the window on the lindens, closed and latched; and it had a table with a cloth on it, and on the table a tray with tea and a plate of biscuits, and at the table, in his civilian overcoat with the collar unbuttoned, a man of thirty-eight with soft spectacles that had been repaired at the frame; and in the corners there was a typist with a pad on her knee, and a young officer of the SD in field grey with a polish on his collar who was introduced as an interpreter, and who spoke Polish, German and enough French to be a menace, and who spent the whole of the interview sitting on a chair at the side of the room with his hands on his knees and his eyes down.

Kalbach stood up when she came in and bowed, and asked after the Oberst's health, and asked whether the tea

was too strong; and then he sat down and said, without any change in his voice at all: "Fräulein Herschlag. This will take about three hours. Everything you say is being written down by the young woman in the corner, and at the end of it you will read it and sign it, and if you do not agree with a sentence you may say so and the sentence will be struck out and initialled. I am telling you this at the start so that you know the form; there is no other reason. I am going to ask you about a great many things, some of which will seem to have nothing to do with each other. That is how I work."

"I understand."

"Then the first: the pearls."

"I beg your pardon?"

"On the twenty-sixth of April a strand of pearls was sold on the Marszałkowska Street by a woman in a grey coat with an Austrian accent, and in the same week a strand of imitations of the same length and pattern was bought at the Kercelak market by a woman in the same coat with the same accent, and the inventory of the household effects of the villa on the Frascati Street of June 1940 contains, at number 44, a necklace of pearls in the possession of the Oberst's household, which was a gift from the Oberst to the lady of the house in December 1943. I have all of that on paper, in German, in this room." He passed his fingers over the tablecloth, smoothing nothing. "What can you tell me about the pearls?"

"The pearls were given to me by the Oberst in Paris on the twenty-third of December 1943," she said, "and I wear them, and they are at this moment in the wardrobe of my

room in the villa, in a box, and any officer of the section may see them at any hour; and if somebody in this city has sold a strand of pearls to a jeweller, it was not I, and if the jeweller has described a woman to you, then the woman is not Marion Herschlag, and you may have her hat."

"And the imitations at the Kercelak?"

"There are nine thousand women in this city who wear imitations," she said. "There is a market for them because there is a war."

"Precisely," said Kalbach, and made a small note, which was not a note, because he was watching her hands while she took the cup and set it down; and that was the whole of the pearls, in the record, for four months, and it was the pearl that killed her in the end, and it did it in this room, on this day, in the first four minutes.

The interview went on for two hours and forty minutes.

He asked her about her mother's name, and she gave it — Leopoldine Herschlag, née Reiner, of Graz, deceased 1936 — in the tone of a woman repeating a fact about her childhood, and the whole of it took her a quarter of a second, because the file in the villa had it and she had known the file, and the quarter of a second, later, on a page in his notebook, became the second nail.

He asked her about Lausanne, and about the school, and about the woman from Bern who had taught her French, and she gave him the school and the street and the name and the woman, and answered every question twice, once with detail and once with a refusal to invent a detail she did not have, which is the hardest thing in the trade and which she did for two hours without one mistake.

He asked her about Vienna in March 1938, and she said that she had been in Lausanne, at the school, in the spring term of 1938, and that she had heard about the events of that month on the wireless in the school's refectory and had cried in a corridor, and that this was the whole of her experience of the events of March 1938, and that she could remember the corridor and the wireless and the crying and nothing else at all; and Kalbach listened to this answer with his hands folded and his spectacles on the bridge of his nose and thought about it for eleven seconds, because the answer had the one property which no rehearsed answer has and which no liar can fake, which is that it was a door being closed on a thing a person does not want to talk about; and he could not tell, and he never did tell, for the rest of his life, whether the woman in front of him was a liar with a copybook or a Viennese woman with an unhappy March and a well-prepared dossier, and the reason he could not tell was that they were the same answer.

He asked her about the department store on the Mariahilfer Strasse, and about the floor, and the department, and the manager's name, and whether the gloves were sold on the first floor or the second (the third, she said; the gloves were on the third, with the stockings, because the shop had been rearranged in 1937 and it is the sort of detail a shop girl remembers and a person who reads files does not); and then, at the end of the second hour, he put a piece of paper on the table and pushed it across.

"Whose handwriting is this?"

It was a sheet of the household book of the villa on the Frascati Street: the ordinary list of a house in 1944 — coal, eggs, a repair to the stove, the name of a chemist — written in her small upright hand, which she had written in that book every Monday for four months because Janina of the village near Sandomierz had never learned to write German; and underneath it, on the same sheet, in a different ink, was a typewritten line and a rubber-stamp impression of a date, from a document that had come out of the drawer of a German office in the Government General.

"This is the household book of the Oberst's house. The handwritten part is yours — it was established in five minutes by a clerk who has worked in that villa for a year, and there is no question about it. The stamp underneath is from a document which reached this office in May, submitted through your intervention to the Oberst's section by a lady of the household in the course of an enquiry, and which I am obliged to tell you has been examined by the forgery section of this building and is a fabrication of the Polish underground, produced in a workshop in this city, and the typeface of its stamp is the same typeface as a fabrication that this office took from a courier in the Rakowiecka Street in 1942." He looked at her over the top of his spectacles. "So the question is not who wrote the household book. The question is who wrote the stamp."

"I did not write the stamp," she said. "I gave the Oberst a document that came to me from a woman in the Building Section of the garrison administration, whose name and office I gave him in writing on the day, and I did not make the document and I did not examine it, and if it is a forgery then

the Oberst's section and the forgery section of this building and the lady in the Building Section have all of it, and none of it is mine."

"Which is exactly what a woman would say," Kalbach said, "if she was either innocent or trained," and smiled, and closed his notebook, and let her go.

❦

She walked out of the building on the aleja Szucha 25 at twenty to three with her bag on her arm and her hat on and her face doing nothing at all, and past the courtyard with the lindens and the cars, and past the sentry at the gate who saluted her; and she got into the car that the Sicherheitspolizei had provided, with a driver, and was driven home along the Ujazdowskie, and answered the driver's remark about the weather; and she went into the villa and up the stairs to her room and shut the door and took her hat off slowly, and stood in the middle of her own room for about four seconds, and then went into the bathroom and was sick, twice, without any noise, with the tap running.

Three things had saved her and none of them was innocence.

The first was the dossier: nine months of preparation by professionals in two cities, an identity that had been built in Paris in 1940 with a birth certificate from a parish register and a school record and a dead woman's school friend and four thousand francs of paper, which had withstood an examination by the Sicherheitspolizei of the Reich in a room with a typist and an interpreter for two hours and forty minutes.

The second was her hands: the sign she had been given, in the nine weeks in the flat above the laundry, of the person who is lying, is not the voice and not the eyes but the hands — a woman's hands will always go to the thing she is protecting, or to her own throat, or to the seam of her skirt, at the moment of the lie — and her hands had lain in her lap in that room for the whole of the interview, on her bag, still, and she had done it by a technique she had learned in a corridor in Paris in 1942 with a stopwatch, and the technique had cost four days of her life, and it had saved her whole life in a room on the aleja Szucha.

And the third was that Kalbach had made a mistake.

He had brought her in before the chart was complete. He had a word, an accent, two strands of beads, and a rubber stamp; and none of it was proof; and the whole of the material had been laid in front of her in a room with a teacup, and the man had watched her with patient, exact, terrible attention, and had asked her, at the end, the question that no file can answer — who wrote the stamp — and had let her go, because he could not hold her, and because a man who is certain and early is a man who has to spend the next four weeks watching a house on the Frascati Street with two men on bicycles in a city that is about to be fought over.

She washed her face; and then she sat on the edge of the bath for a moment with her hands flat on her knees, and did the thing she had learned from Wiktor Janowski in a flat above a laundry: she took the hour apart and put it back together, and wrote, in her head, in Polish, in a list, the six things she would now do, and did the first of them within

four minutes, which was to go downstairs and tell the Oberst, over the tea tray, in a bored voice, that the man from the Sicherheitspolizei had asked her about a stamp on a forged document and had been too polite to say that he suspected her of making it, and that she had given him the name of the woman in the Building Section, and that she wished to be told whether she was to keep working in that section or whether she was now a person about whom the Reichssicherheitshauptamt had a note; and von Hagen, who had already spent the morning on the telephone to Kalbach's chief about the discourtesy of the summons, was incandescent; and by the end of that conversation Marion Herschlag was, in the mind of the man who owned her, not a suspect but a wronged lady, and the officer of the SD who had summoned her was a clerk with a grudge; and that was the sixth thing in her list and the most important, and she had got it done in eleven minutes, and it was, on the whole, the finest piece of work she did in the entire war.

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The city's temperature, in those same weeks, was in the streets and not in the files.

On the twenty-seventh of July, at half past nine in the evening, in a tram on the Marszałkowska Street, a group of the Kedyw shot a German officer of the garrison in the back of the head and took his pistol and his papers, and went away through the tram; and the tram stopped with a dead German in it in the middle of the street, and the passengers got out and walked, and four hundred people on the pave-

ments went on about their business and nobody had seen anything.

And on the next day, the twenty-eighth of July, the Germans took a hundred and twenty men out of the Pawiak Prison and shot them in the ruins of the ghetto, and put the notice up: the date, the district, the number of persons, and the names in two columns, in Polish and German, by way of reprisal for the shootings of German soldiers, and the responsibility lying with those who had done the murders; and the population of Warsaw read the notice in the ordinary way, standing at the kiosks in the heat, four and five at a time, and the queue at the window of the Pawiak on the Dzielna Street was three hundred women long, and it went round the corner into the Nowolipki, and the women in it had been standing there since six in the morning with their parcels, and the parcels were handed back over the counter at eleven, and there was nothing in the notice about any of them.

❦

Phillip went home to Wola on the evening of the twenty-eighth of July, and she went with him as far as the corner of the street, which was against every rule that four people had written in a ledger, and stood at the corner by a wall for eleven minutes while he was inside the building.

She saw the courtyard: the gate, the pump, the coal cellar, the shed; two women at the shed, one with a bucket; three children on the stairs; a man asleep on a chair at a window on the ground floor. She saw the window on the third floor of the corner building with the light on in it, and in

the light, after a while, two people standing: a woman of about fifty-eight with grey hair, in an apron, standing very straight, and a man of sixty-one with a leather satchel still on the chair behind him; and between them, in the window, from a distance of forty metres in the dusk, she saw the shape of what happened when somebody tells his mother something she already knew.

The woman stood in the window for about four minutes without moving. Then she went out of the light, and the man with the satchel went out of the light after her, and the window stayed lit and empty; and Phillip Brandt came out of the gate of the courtyard four minutes later and walked to the corner where she was standing with her hands in her pockets, and said, in Polish, in a completely level voice: "It is done. My mother has the money in a tin and my father has not said a word since Tuesday, and neither of them has asked me anything, and my father stood up when I came in and shook my hand, which is a thing he has done four times in my life, and then he went into the other room and shut the door." He looked down the street. "I have four days' clothes in a bag at the flat above the cobbler's and the key of the flat on the Zielna, and I have been told that the AK have a woman on the Wola side who does papers. I am going to be dead in about six weeks, and I have never in my life been as calm as I am tonight, and I would like to walk you to the tram and be a man who walks a woman to a tram."

Von Hagen came home on the last night of July at eleven with the smell of schnapps on his breath and his tunic unbuttoned and his hair down over his forehead, and he went into the study and sat in the dark, in the chair, without turning on the lamp, and stayed there for twenty minutes; and when she came to the door with her dressing gown on and asked him whether he wanted anything, he said, "Sit down. There is a thing I have not told you, and I am going to tell it to you now, in this room, which is the only room in this city where I have ever said anything true, because the walls of my office have four ears and each of them is attached to a man."

She sat down on the other chair, in the dark, in the smell of the schnapps and the leather and the cold ash of the study, in a house on the Frascati Street, four streets from the river.

"They have asked me to prepare a plan," said von Hagen. "Not the plan for the garrison; the plan for the city. What is to be held, what is to be given up, what is to be destroyed, and the order in which the destruction is to be carried out if the decision is taken. The bridges. The waterworks. The power station on the Wybrzeże. The telephone exchange. The gasworks. The railway junctions — the Gdańsk station and the Praga and the four turnings of the Vistula bank. I have been working on it for four days and I shall be working on it for another four, and I am to report it to the garrison's chief of staff on the third of August, and there are four copies in this city, and one of them will be in that safe at the end of this week." He turned his head towards her; she could see the shape of him against the grey of the blackout curtain. "I have been in this service for twenty-two years and I have

read every plan that was made for the East, and there is one thing that all of them have in common, which is that none of them was ever carried out in the order in which it was written; but this city is going to be fought over in the streets, my dear, and I have been told to make the arithmetic of it, and I intend to be the officer who makes the Warsaw question an accounting problem that can be closed." He paused. "And I want you to stay with me through August. Whatever happens. If it comes, and if the whole thing comes apart, you will be in this house with a sealed pass in your bag, and if the house is in the middle of it, then we shall go out of it together or not at all. Will you stay?"

"Yes," she said, in the dark, in the smell of the schnapps, with the whole of what she knew in her mouth like paper.

And von Hagen reached out in the dark and found her wrist and held it for a moment, not in the way of a man who owns something, but in the way of a man who has, at the age of fifty-four, in the fifth year of a war he has been losing for three of them, discovered that the only person in the world he can talk to is a woman who has been paid to sit in the chair; and the terrible thing about it, the thing that she took to the end of her life and never once put down, was that she saw it, whole, in the dark, in the second before he let go of her wrist: he was not a fool and he was not a monster and he was the man who had slapped a Polish servant across the room in June for a cold plate, and he was lonely, and the loneliness was the last and the most dangerous thing about him, because a lonely man will tell the truth to the person he has decided to trust, and there was no version of August in which that did not end with one of them dead.

PART THREE

THE FIRE

Warsaw, August – October 1944

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Eve

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The last dinner in the villa on the Frascati Street was on the thirtieth of July 1944, and it was for two, because von Hagen had sent word from the office at four that he would be late, that he would not bring anybody, and that the lady was to dine with him at nine; and at nine they sat at the table for twelve with the four places laid at one end of it and the candles lit, and Janina served them in the way she had served for four months, which was with her eyes on the dishes and her mouth shut, and the two of them ate a soup and a piece of veal and a compote of plums from the garden, and drank a bottle of the wine from the cellar of a family in the Żoliborz, and talked.

He began with the farm.

His brother's farm was in the Uckermark, four hundred hectares, rye and potatoes and a wood of about sixty hectares with a road through it, and it had been in the family since 1762 and had come to the brother in 1926 because the brother was the farmer and von Hagen was the officer; and in the last three weeks of July the brother had written twice, and both letters were in the tunic pocket of the man at the table, and both of them were about the same thing, which was whether to send the horses west now or in September. "He has eleven horses," von Hagen said, "and he has written to me twice, and the whole of his question is whether the

Russian army will be in the Uckermark in October or in January, and he is asking me, at this table in Warsaw, on this date, as if I were a man who knows something, and I have written back twice and both times I have told him to keep the horses and to buy salt."

He talked about the horse he had had as a boy: a bay, thirteen hands, with a hard mouth and a habit of kicking in the shafts; and about the winter of 1917 in a school in Potsdam with no coal, and about the way his mother had cooked in a stove in a corridor; and Krystyna, who had spent two years listening to German officers talk about their childhoods and had learned what it was for, put her fork down when he came to the horse, and asked him a question about the horse, and listened to the whole of the answer.

He talked about Klaus.

The last letter had come in March 1943 and had been written on the seventeenth of January, in a cellar at Gumrak, by a boy of nineteen with a bad hand and the handwriting of a boy of eleven; and the letter had six sentences in it about the weather and the food and the men in the section, and then the seven lines that his father had read every week for sixteen months, and the seven lines were about a dog that had been at the airfield when he was posted and about a photograph, and one line about the horses, and at the end of it, vati, I am not very good at this; and there was no punctuation in the last three lines of it at all.

He said all of this with the composure of a man who had said it to himself many times, and the composure was the thing that told her; and at the end he took the letter out of

the tunic pocket of a coat that was hanging in the study, where he had put it in March 1943 and had never kept it anywhere else, and he unfolded it on the table cloth between the compote and the wine and showed her the handwriting, and said: "He was left-handed and they had made him write with the right at the school in Potsdam, and he never got over it, and it made his hand what it is, and I have often wondered whether it was worth it, the school. It was worth it for me. It cost him six years of his life in a room he hated." He folded the letter. "That is the whole of what I know about my son for certain."

And her, with her hands still in her lap and the pearls at her throat and the whole of the city's August coming towards the two of them at ninety kilometres an hour out of the east, said: "I would have liked the dog."

"Yes," said von Hagen, with the letter in his hands; and then he put it in his pocket and rang the bell for Janina, and said the coffee was to be brought to the study, and they went through into the study and drank the coffee among the maps.

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At eleven he went to the safe in front of her for the first time in nineteen months.

He did it because of the papers on the desk: a bundle of pages of the plan he was to take to the garrison's chief of staff in four days, and a signal that had come in from the district command, and a set of maps of the Vistula bank with the crossings marked; and he did not put them in the safe because he was cautious. He put them in because he was

tired, and because the study of his own house after a good dinner is the one room in the world in which a man with a plan in four days' time does not want to think about a locked drawer.

He moved the lithograph of the Lilpop works off the wall on its hook, and the safe stood behind it — a Viennese insurance office's safe of the nineteen-twenties, dark green, with a brass dial and a lever, and she had lived in that room for five months and had watched that lithograph and had learned from a book in Paris in 1942 that a Viennese lock of that class has a spring in the dial that gives at the third turn and a lever that can be opened with a bent nail if the door has not been closed with the handle turned twice, and had never once in five months had the opportunity to look at the front of it from closer than four metres.

He turned the dial; and she stood where she was, with her coffee cup in her hand, at the corner of the desk, in the lamplight, with the distance she was permitted; and the whole of her attention, in the eleven seconds of it, was not on the door of the safe but on the place where the key was when he had done.

There was no key. It was not a key; it was a word and a dial and a brass lever, and the word he spoke when he turned the dial was a date under his breath, and the date was not his own or his wife's or his son's, and the date was the twenty-ninth of March 1917, which is the day a boy of fifteen at a school in Potsdam was told that the school would be closed in June and that he would be going to the war eighteen months before the rest of his year, and she stood in the room

with a cup in her hand and heard the date said twice, once as a word under the breath and once as the small click of the dial coming to rest, and she wrote the date on the inside of her skull in the way she had been trained to write dates, and she never told anybody in her life that she had it.

He took the whole bundle out, and put it on the desk, and worked at it for two hours; and at half past one he put the papers back, and shut the door, and turned the lever, and turned the dial with the back of his hand so that the numbers were not left at the word, and hung the lithograph back on its hook, and blew out the lamp and went up to bed.

And at three in the morning she came down in her dressing gown, in the dark, with her heart going in a way that she had learned in nine weeks in a corridor in Paris to disregard, and she moved the lithograph off its hook, and put one ear against the wall of the corridor for eleven seconds, and turned the dial to the twenty-ninth of March 1917, and the dial gave at the third turn, and the lever came down under her thumb, and the door of the safe came open on the first attempt as if a person had designed it for her.

The plan had been written in July and revised on the twenty-sixth and it was in three parts, folded in a cardboard cover with a ribbon, in a hand that was not his and with his own marginal marks in pencil in three places, and she sat down on the floor of the study with the safe open and the lithograph against her knee and read the whole of it from the first page to the last in the light of the moon through the blackout curtain, with her index finger moving on the paper and her mouth shut, for forty minutes.

The first part was the order of battle of the Warsaw garrison: the units of the Wehrmacht and the police, their quarters, their strengths as of the fifteenth of July, the three garrisons in the city and the four outside it, the artillery with the calibres, the armoured elements with the number of the vehicles, the depots with the ammunition state in rounds per weapon and in units of fire, and the marching battalions on the Vistula line that could be recalled to the city within eleven hours of an order.

The second part was the engineering: the state of the crossings of the Vistula at the four points, the two railway bridges and the two road bridges with their approaches, the demolitions that had been prepared and loaded under each of them by the Poles in 1939 and by the Germans in 1943, the two depots of explosive at the Citadel and at the airfield on the Wola side, the water works and the filters on the Czerniakowska, the gasworks on the Wolska, the power station on the Wybrzeże, the telephone exchange on the Zielna, and an appendix of eleven railway stations with the trackage that it was intended to destroy if the city was given up; and in that appendix, in his pencil, in the margin, next to the Gdańsk station, was the German word Bedingt.

And the third part was the evacuation of the German administration: the scheme for the movement west of the offices, the families and the files; the routes; the train schedules; the four points at which the columns were to cross the Vistula; the date on which the first of the civil transports was to leave, which was the fifth of August; and the whole of it written on the assumption that the city would be held

as a fortress while the administration and the families went out behind it, and the last page of it was a table of the offices in the order in which they were to go, and the second of them was the counter-intelligence section of the garrison command.

She read it twice; and then she put the whole of it back in exactly the order it had been in, and closed the door, and turned the lever, and turned the dial with the back of her hand, and hung the lithograph back on its hook; and then she went up the stairs and into her room and lay in the dark until six, with her eyes open, holding, in her head, the whole of a German fortress plan of the city she was born in, and the only thought that kept going through her mind was not fear and was not triumph and was not even Anna or her father, but the second of August, which was the day on which the second of the offices was to leave, and which meant that von Hagen would be in Warsaw for two days after the transports began, and that he would have the whole of the plan with him until then; and it was at eleven minutes past five, with the grey coming into the window, that she made the decision, which was that this was the work of the next day and a half, and that everything now came down to hours.

❦

At six she came down dressed for the morning, with her hat and her bag and the coat over her arm, and she found him in the hall.

He was standing in the doorway of the study with his tunic open and his hair wet and a cup of coffee in one hand

and the silver compact in the other, and she stopped on the third step of the stairs with her hand on the rail, and the whole of the twelve metres between them was entirely quiet.

"This was on your dressing table," he said. "I went up for my cigarette case because I had left it on your window sill last night at eleven and I could not find it in the dark, and I found this instead, and I looked at it, and I hope you will forgive me."

There are four seconds in such a moment and they run in a way that is different from the way the rest of a life runs; and she spent the first of them looking at his hands — at the cup and the compact in a man's hands that were cracked across the knuckles and had a duelling scar's worth of small damages on them, the hands that had lain on her shoulder at night, the hands that had slapped a woman of forty-five across a dining room for a cold plate — and the second in looking at his face, which had no suspicion in it at all, which is the thing that nobody who has not lived that life will believe; and the third and fourth in deciding, with the cold, fast, exact machinery that was the whole of the training and the whole of what she had become, that there was nothing to be decided, because a man who has not opened a compact in the thirty seconds he has been standing with it is a man who is not going to open it.

"I bought it in Paris," she said. "In the rue de la Paix in December. It cost nine hundred francs and I have never told you the price, and if you are going to stand in the hall with my powder and my puff in your hand then I am going to be late for my appointment."

And von Hagen laughed, and opened the lid of the compact with his thumb and looked at the powder and the puff and the little mirror, and did not look at the bottom of the case, and did not press the floor of it, and closed it, and said, in the tone of a man who is comfortable and has been amused early in the morning: "I like knowing where your things are. I have kept everything you have ever left in this house; there is a drawer in my desk and it is the top one on the left, and the whole of you is in it — a glove, a letter from a dressmaker, a hairpin, and this." He put the compact in his trouser pocket. "I will put it in the drawer tonight. Do not take it. I like the arithmetic of it: if I know where your things are, I know where you are."

She came down the last three steps and stood in front of him in the hall and let him kiss her forehead, which he had begun doing in June and did every morning, in front of Janina, in the way of a man who has decided that his household is his household and does not care who sees him in it.

At eight he went out to the car; and at the door he turned, with his gloves in his hand, and said the thing he had said three times in the week: "Keep your things ready. Nobody knows anything yet, but if it comes, we may have a day's notice and we may have an hour of it, and I do not intend to leave the lady of this house standing in a street in Warsaw with a suitcase while the sappers are walking around the bridges with a plunger." He put on his cap. "There is a sealed pass in the drawer of the study in the top left, and if you ever need it while I am not in this house, use it, and do not ask anybody anything."

"I shall be here at one for luncheon," she said.

"Yes," said von Hagen, and got into the car and was driven away up the gravel and through the gate and out into the rubble and the sunshine of the last ordinary week of the German administration in Warsaw.

❦

She walked to Mokotowska Street at twenty past nine in the morning, in the hat and the grey coat, with the papers of the garrison's plan in her head and no paper anywhere on her body, and it took her twenty minutes by the back streets and she went in at the gate of her own courtyard at the hour when the whole of that city is out of doors: the caretaker sweeping, two women at the pump, the coal man's boy, and four children playing a game with a bottle cap on the flags.

Three hundred and forty grams of paper had been in her hands in the study at three in the morning, and she had taken, in the end, exactly none of it out of the safe and out of the house; and everything she carried now was in her head, where nobody could take it from her, and she had spent the walk home from the villa on the day before writing it down in the inside of her own skull in the way Wiktor had taught her, which is by section and by page and by number and not by meaning, so that no man with a knife and a rubber truncheon could ever get the whole of it out of her in less than four hours.

Her father was at the table in the corridor room with the books along the skirting and a Latin primer open on the tablecloth and a plate with the end of a bread on it, and four chairs drawn up in front of him, and one of the four chairs had a boy in it, a boy of about fourteen in a jacket that was

too big for him with his hands folded on the table, and her father was saying, in the patient voice of a man who has said the same thing a hundred times and enjoys saying it a hundred and first: "—therefore, when you have read iuventus, you will find that it is not the young man and not the youth but the thing that is common to all of them, which is the age itself; and the reason the Latin does that and the Polish does not is not that Latin is better, it is that Latin was the language of men writing about a whole state and a whole people, and the Polish was for three hundred years the language of men writing letters—"

And then the door of the room at the back opened, and Hanna came in with a jug in her hand and stopped in the middle of the kitchen door with her mouth open and her hands going up, and the jug came down onto the table with a bang and the water came out over the Latin primer and the boy of fourteen jumped up with his chair going over and Krystyna, in the doorway of that flat, put her finger up in front of her mouth.

Her father had turned round.

He sat there with his hands on the arms of the chair and looked at her over the top of his spectacles for four seconds; and he was white, and thin, and there was a stain on the tablecloth and the boys of his class were looking from one of them to the other with their mouths open; and he stood up, holding the edge of the table with one hand as a man of sixty-nine stands up, and came round the table, and stopped one pace short of her, and looked at her face, and then at her coat, and then at the door behind her, and she saw him do

the arithmetic — the coat, the hat, the hour, the pass in her bag, the story of the daughter who had died of typhus in a hospital in Toulouse in 1940, which he had built with his own hands in a kitchen four years before and had maintained with the whole of his will ever since.

And he walked out of the room without a word.

He went past her, in the doorway, so close that she smelled the soap and the wool of him, and his hand came out and took hold of the doorframe of the kitchen door for a step, just once, the way a man does when he has stood up too quickly, and he went into the back room, and the door did not quite close, and through the gap she heard the sound of a man of sixty-nine years taking hold of himself in the dark, and then the sound of a chair being moved, and then nothing at all.

There were four minutes.

Hanna had her hands over her mouth and her back against the kitchen door and the tears coming straight down her face, and the boy of fourteen was standing at the end of the table with his jacket hanging off him and his Latin primer upside down, and the second pupil, who was in the far corner, had got up and put his chair in front of him like a man behind a fence; and Krystyna stood in the doorway of her family's flat and did the arithmetic of those four minutes in the following way: she took off the hat, because her hat was worth eleven months of her father's lessons, and she put it on the table beside the jug, and she took off the grey coat, and she said, in the flat, ordinary Polish of a sister: "Who is this?"

"Olek," said Hanna, in a voice that came out of a throat that was not working. "This is Olek Górski, and the other one is Tadeusz, that is Tadeusz Wrona, he is the son of the accountant, and they come on Tuesday and Thursday, and they have their own chairs because there are not enough chairs, and you are not to say anything, and you—" and then she stopped and put her face on her sister's shoulder and stood there for about eleven seconds, and the two boys watched two women hold each other up in a kitchen in Warsaw in July 1944, and neither of them said a word, and the whole of that flat kept the secret from that hour on, because a boy of fourteen who is taught Latin by a man of sixty-nine in a kitchen in his own flat with his own chair has already learned the one lesson; and Hanna, when she lifted her head, said, in a whisper, into her sister's ear: "He is shaking. He has been shaking since March and it is not the cigarettes, I count them, and he does not eat the meat, he gives it to me, and he has stopped going out for the newspaper, and yesterday he asked me what a person should do if the whole city were to be—" and she stopped, and then she said the sentence that Krystyna carried out of that flat with her: "He has been waiting for you every day for two years. He knew you would come. That is what I cannot forgive the two of you for."

And before she put the coat back on, she stood for a moment in the room that had been her mother's and her father's and was now his alone, with the bed and the chest of drawers and the chair with the coat on it; and she took the cord off her neck with both hands, and the signet ring came

off it, her father's ring with the greyhound and the willow leaves that the German removals men had carried the sofa past in 1940; and she opened the top drawer of the chest, where there was a pair of her mother's gloves of 1936 in tissue paper, and she put the ring inside the left glove of that pair, and shut the drawer, and stood with her hand flat on it for about a second and a half.

She had carried that ring against her skin in a city under occupation for four years and eleven months, in defiance of the only good advice she had ever been given in the trade, and she left it in a glove in a drawer in a flat on the Mokotowska Street on the thirty-first of July 1944 for one reason, which she said out loud in that room, in Polish, to the chest of drawers, because it was the last sensible sentence she was able to say in the whole of the next eleven weeks: "I am not going to be found with it."

She put the coat back on; and she went to the door of the back room and stood in it, and her father was sitting on the edge of the bed in the dark with his hands on his knees and his spectacles off and his face turned to the window with the blackout paper on it.

"Tatusiu," she said.

"I know what you are," said her father, without turning. "I have known since 1940; I know it the way a man knows the weather in his own bones; and I have told nobody, and I shall tell nobody, and I am not going to ask you anything, not one thing, because a man who has asked a question is a man who can be made to answer one. Go home to whatever it is you have got, and do not come here in daylight again,

and if I ever see you in the street with a German I shall spit on the pavement and I shall do it in front of people, and you will not turn your head."

She went out through the kitchen, and Hanna came down the stairs with her as far as the second landing, and gave her, on the landing, in the dark of the stairwell, a piece of paper folded four times: the news that the section's couriers were carrying that week, in a hand she did not know, which was the district command's bulletin on the state of the front at Radzymin and Wołomin and the four words at the bottom about the direction of the Red Army's armour. "You will need it," Hanna said, "and I am not going to ask you what for, and you are to burn it when you have read it, and if you are ever caught with it on you I shall be shot in a courtyard with the rest of them, and I have decided that is an acceptable price, and you are not to argue with me about it, and you are not to tell Tadeusz, and you are not to tell Tatusiu." She kissed her sister's cheek, on the landing, in the dark, quickly, with her eyes shut; and then she said, "What is your name now, in the German papers?"

"Marion Herschlag."

"Marion Herschlag," said Hanna, pronouncing it exactly as a German would, and then, in Polish: "Marion Herschlag, you are the worst thing that has ever happened to this family. Come back in the winter." And she went up the stairs.

❦

She delivered the plan on the thirty-first of July between eleven and four, in three batches, in a place on the Śliska

Street, and the method was the method of the cellar and the method of four years: nothing written, nothing carried, nothing said twice.

The first batch was the order of battle: the units, the quarters, the strengths as of the fifteenth, the artillery with the calibres, the armoured elements and the numbers, and the ammunition in rounds and units of fire, and the marching battalions on the Vistula line that could be back in the city in eleven hours. She gave it to Krupa in a room with a blackout curtain and a table and a candle, standing up, in the order in which it had stood in the pages, with the numbers written as pairs and the unit designations spelled as sounds, and he wrote it down in a shorthand that was his own invention and had been taught to eleven people in five years, and when she had finished he pushed the pad across to a major of the artillery who had been sitting in the corner without speaking, and the major read it for eleven minutes, and then looked up and asked her four questions about the calibres, and she answered all four, and he looked at Krupa and nodded once.

The second batch was the engineering: the crossings at the four points, the two railway and two road bridges, the demolitions prepared in 1939 and 1943, the two explosive depots, the waterworks and the filters, the gasworks, the power station on the Wybrzeże, the telephone exchange on the Zielna, and the appendix of eleven railway stations with the trackage marked for destruction, and the word Bedingt in the pencil margin next to the Gdańsk station, which she gave them exactly as a word, and then, because a word without a context is a stone, gave them her own reading of it

— that a German engineer writing conditional next to a station on a list of demolitions is a man writing to his superiors that the order is either impossible or unwise, and that in either case the man who wrote it will not be asked again.

And the third batch was the evacuation scheme: the offices in the order in which they were to leave, the routes, the schedules, the four crossings for the columns, the first civil transport on the fifth of August, and the position of the counter-intelligence section of the garrison command as second of eleven offices to go west, and the date that mattered, which she put in front of them in one plain sentence: that the second of the offices was to leave Warsaw on the second of August, which meant that the man who held the plan would be in the city with it for one day more, and that after that he would be on a train with it, and that no man in that room was ever going to see the original of it again.

There was no gratitude in that room. That is the thing about the delivery, and it was the only piece of work of her whole war in which she took a pleasure that she never once repented of, and the pleasure was not in being thanked: it was in watching an institution work with a good tool. Two men bent over the table with a lamp and a sheet of paper, the quartermaster with the pencil asking her for the ammunition figures a second time and a third time, the woman at the window with the blackout curtain and the boy at the door with his ear on it, and at the end of the third batch, when the papers were copies in shorthand and the originals were in her head and nowhere else, the artillery major took

his spectacles off and said the sentence that the whole of the movement had been building towards since the middle of July:

"The twenty-fourth hour, then. And God help us all."

And Krupa said to her, as she was going out, at the door, with the two of them standing in the yard of a building on the Śliska Street in the sun: "You will go home tonight and you will keep your hours and you will be in the villa tomorrow and you will be there at five o'clock, whatever it costs, because a woman who disappears from that house on the first of August is a woman whose disappearance will be reported in an office in twenty minutes." He looked at the yard, at the coal shed, at the two boys carrying a crate. "It is the twenty-fourth hour at five tomorrow. You will not be told anything more than that, and you will not ask."

❦

The last hour of the ordinary life of Warsaw began at about four in the afternoon of the thirty-first of July 1944 and lasted, by the reckoning of the people who lived through it, about eleven days: the eleven days during which everybody in that city who did not know afterwards said that they had known.

The city on that Monday afternoon was the most ordinary thing in Europe: the queues at the food offices and the water pumps; the trams, crowded, with people standing on the steps; the pedlars on the Świętokrzyska with their stalls of cigarettes and shoelaces and gherkins; a wedding at the church of the Holy Cross at four, with the bride in white and the guests on the steps and the cars with their ribbons;

the children in the courtyards playing a war of their own with sticks and bottle caps and one real helmet; the women at the windows with the washing and the conversation; the boys selling the Nowy Kurier and the kiosks and the ice cream in the heat; and over the whole of it, in the middle of the afternoon, a heat of the sort that Warsaw gets four days a year, with the asphalt soft and the smell of the river and of the dust off the ruins coming up the Nowy Świat.

And under the ordinary thing, in the same hour, in the same streets, the movement of an army was coming out of the cellars.

It came out of the courtyards in the milk churns and the suitcases and the sacks of potatoes with a rifle in the middle, on handcarts with a grandmother in front and two boys behind, in the pockets of women who walked slowly with the shopping; it went up the stairwells of the Śródmieście in the afternoon in the hands of girls of seventeen, and it went into the flats, and onto the tables, and into the hands of the men who would be carrying it in eleven hours; and in the cellars along the Zielna and the Śliska and the Mokotowska there were men with lamps counting magazines, and the women of the courtyards stood in the doorways in the heat and watched the handcarts go by, and the whole of the city was doing the thing together, without a single speech, without a single word said out loud by anybody who did not have to say it.

On the Marszałkowska Street at four o'clock, standing on the pavement in the sunshine with a shopping basket she had bought for the purpose in the Kercelak in May and never used, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna looked at the city she

was born in and did the arithmetic that she had done every day for four years, and it came out, on this day, in the following form.

That she had brought the plan to them, and that the plan had told them what the Germans had and what they had placed under the bridges and what they were going to do with the offices and the families; and that the plan, being a true and complete document, was going to make every hour of the next sixty days more expensive and better and more exactly planned than it would have been without it, and that the same plan was going to be used by men of nineteen years of age in a city of burned streets and no water, and that most of them were going to die of the arithmetic that was in it.

That the whole of her life for four years had been a set of arrangements to make this hour possible, and that in this hour she was a woman in a hat with a shopping basket and the papers of the Reich in a bag, and that when she walked into the courtyard on the Śliska that evening she would be a courier with a card and a pseudonym on it and a white armband, and that Marion Herschlag — the Viennese woman, the pearls, the piano, the Colonel, the bed, the hats, the song, the whole of the five years — would still be walking home to the villa on the Frascati Street, because there was one more day of her to be lived, and the last day of her was the next one.

And that in the villa on the Frascati Street, at half past nine tonight, a man of fifty-four was going to come home from the office and would find the lady of his house at the

table with the compote of plums and would tell her about the eastern front, and that the lady of the house would smile at him, and that the man had a son's letter in his pocket and a farm in the Uckermark and a plan in his safe in her own handwriting's hearing, and that he had neither the first idea nor the last idea of what was going to be done to him.

At a quarter to five, in the sunshine, at the corner of the Bracka Street, in the direction of the German quarter, she saw Phillip Brandt coming towards the centre of the city in civilian clothes, with a bag in his hand and a folded German paper in his pocket, walking in the way of a man who has walked out of one life and has not yet arrived at the next one; and the two of them stood on opposite sides of a street full of people who did not yet know what was about to happen to them, in the flat heat of four o'clock in the afternoon of the last day, and looked at each other for about four seconds, and did not cross.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

W-Hour

❦

The German quarter at four o'clock in the afternoon of the first of August 1944 was the most peaceful place in Warsaw.

The sentries were at their posts on the corners of the Ujazdowskie and the Szucha with their rifles slung and their caps on the backs of their heads in the heat; the staff cars stood along the kerbs with the drivers asleep at the wheels; a girl from the office of the district administration came out of the gate of a villa with a parcel and a bicycle; two officers in shirtsleeves walked along the pavement on the Bracka side talking about a permit for a piano; and in the cafés of the Nowy Świat the waiters were setting the tables for the afternoon with the plates and the little vases of flowers, because the administration of the German Reich in Warsaw in August 1944 had decided - by an order of the military commander, in writing, in the month of July - that the cafés were to stay open, the trams were to keep running, the cinemas were to open at eleven, and the city was to be treated, at the level of the administrative paperwork, as a place where nothing whatever was going to happen.

She had walked that quarter for five months, twice a week, in a fur coat in the winter and in a grey coat in the summer, past the sentries, past the notices, past the café and the dress shop, and had known, in the whole of that time, about a hundred and forty people by sight; and the sentry at

the corner of the Bracka and the Nowy Świat, a man of about twenty-five with a greatcoat and a schmiss on the cheek from some other war or some other man, had said "Gnädige Frau" to her eleven times since March.

She said, "Good afternoon," to him on the first of August at eleven minutes past four.

He said, "Good afternoon, gnädige Frau," and shifted his rifle on his shoulder, and looked up at the sky above the roofs, and then at the pavement, in the ordinary way of a man on a hot afternoon with two hours of his shift left.

She went through the gate of the villa on the Frascati Street at twenty minutes past four, and the sentry at the gate came to attention and opened it for her, and she went up the gravel drive between the beds of flowers that Janina had kept in order all summer, and into the house, and up the stairs.

❦

At ten minutes to five she sat in the window of her room on the first floor in a light dress with a book in her lap, and looked out over the roofs of the German quarter towards the west and the north.

The room was as it had been: the bed, the wardrobe with the madame's name of a family that had been taken out of it in 1940, the dressing table with the row of objects, the picture on the wall of a country road under snow with a windmill in it. On the chair by the door there was a coat — the grey coat, the summer one, with the lining that had been opened under the left arm by a woman on the Ogrodowa and closed again with eleven stitches in the same hour in

July, and inside that lining there were, at ten minutes to five on the first of August 1944, in three flat packets wrapped in oiled paper, sixty-one pages of handwriting in cipher made that morning between the hours of six and eight in the bathroom of that house with the tap running; and under the coat on the chair there was a shopping basket, and in the basket there was a hat, and in the hat there was nothing at all.

Below her, on the ground floor, the Colonel was in the drawing room with three officers who had come at four and had stayed: she could hear the voice of the chief of the section of the district administration, who had a laugh with a squeak in it, and the clink of glass and the small flat noises of a room in which four men are drinking the wine of somebody else's cellar on a hot afternoon; and in the yard Rutz was polishing the bonnet of the Mercedes with a rag and a tin of polish, in his tunic, in the sun, in the way of a man who has been doing the same thing for eleven years and has never once been asked what he thought of any of it.

She had rehearsed the hour in the way in which she had been taught to rehearse everything: she had the two routes out of the house and the four routes out of the quarter in her head, the three places in which a woman with papers and a basket could stand for eleven minutes without being looked at twice, the hour and the minute at which the sentry at the gate was relieved, the fact that the kitchen door gave onto the garden wall and the garden wall onto the yard of the building on the Bracka; and she had the thing that is the whole of the art, which is the order in which a person decides to do the wrong thing.

At ten minutes to five the telephone in the study rang, and stopped, and then, eleven seconds later, rang again; and she heard the Colonel answer it in the hall and say something short; and then the officers in the drawing room stopped laughing and began to talk all at once, in the way of men who have been given a piece of news, and she heard the word Ostbahn and the word bridge, and she sat in the window with the book open in her lap and looked out over the quarter towards the west and the north, where a hundred thousand people were waiting.

At four minutes to five she heard it.

It was a rattle of small arms, flat and fast, from the north-west, from the direction of the Wola, half a kilometre away, and it lasted about nine seconds; and in a house in the German quarter on a hot afternoon it could have been a lorry with a bad engine, and it was followed by nothing, and the men in the drawing room went on talking, and one of them laughed the laugh with the squeak in it, and Rutz went on polishing the bonnet of the Mercedes.

At two minutes to five she heard it again: two bursts, one behind the other, from the same direction and further off, and then, after a pause of about a second and a half, a machine gun coming in from a different part of the city altogether, in the south, on the Mokotów side, in the long, level, continuous way that no backfiring lorry in the world has ever sounded like.

And the country road with the windmill hung on the wall of the room, and the clock on the dressing table said two minutes to five, and the sound of the machine gun

came in over the roofs and through the open window, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna sat absolutely still in the chair with her hands in her lap and her eyes on the street below and let herself have eleven seconds — she had promised herself eleven, and she took them — of the only feeling she had permitted herself in four years, which was not joy and was not relief and was not triumph, but the enormous, terrible, physical loosening of a body that has been held in one position since September 1939 and has been told, at last, in a language that cannot be lied about, that the position is over.

Then the gate of the villa opened, and Rutz came up the drive at a run in his tunic with the polish rag still in his hand.

❦

She went down the stairs.

The hall had filled with men: the three officers out of the drawing room with their tunics open and their caps in their hands, the two batmen, the sentry from the gate with his rifle up and his mouth open, the clerk of the section who lived in the annexe with his spectacles in his hand; and the Colonel was in the middle of them with the telephone receiver in his left hand and a map of the city already open on the hall table under his right, saying, in the flat, level voice of a man who has commanded a supply column on a road under fire and who is at home: "—no, I do not want the district command, I want Ia, and if Ia is not at the telephone then the chief of staff is to be told that the Ujazdowskie is closed at the Szucha and that we have firing in four districts, and that there are men on the roof of the Prudential building."

And he saw her on the stairs, and he said: "Ah. The lady of the house." And then he said the sentence that the rest of the day has to be understood through, because it is the whole of the German officer in that hour, and he said it lightly, and with a certain pride, and entirely without any idea whatsoever of the thing that was walking up the stairs towards him out of the south:

"My dear, you are going to see something now. Get your camera, if you have got one, and do not go out of the gate; this will be finished by tomorrow noon, and I want you in this house with the doors locked and the blinds down until I come back, and I want the cellar stocked with water — Rutz, water, eleven cans, and the lamps, and the small radio out of the study, and if anybody asks for the Fräulein in the next four hours, nobody is to know anything."

"Jawohl, Herr Oberst."

She stood on the fourth step with her hand on the rail and looked down at the lot of them in the hall of the requisitioned villa with the day of the city's war beginning outside the window, and she took the last decision of that life without any dramatics at all, which is the way large decisions are actually taken, and the decision was: not tonight, and not the cellar, and not the small radio.

"Rutz," she said, from the stairs, in the ordinary voice of a woman who has remembered something, "my coat. The grey one, from the cupboard under the stairs — and the basket; and take the coat and the basket out to the gate, and give them to the sentry at the gate, and tell him I am walking to the chemist on the Bracka before the shops shut, because

with all of this" — and she gestured at the map and the men and the telephone — "the Oberst is going to want the powders before tonight, and I shall not be ten minutes."

The Colonel did not even look up from the map.

"Ten minutes," he said, "and then this house is shut."

"Ten minutes," she said, and went up the stairs and along the corridor and into her room and shut the door, and put on the grey coat, and took the shopping basket with the hat in it, and went down the back stairs through the pantry and out through the kitchen and across the garden and over the wall at the end into the yard of the building on the Bracka; and the coat she was wearing, with its three flat packets of sixty-one pages of cipher in the lining under the left arm, was the coat in which she had walked into the house in March, in the snow, at half past eight at night, four streets from the river, with her hand on the banister rail.

❦

The city of the first hour was not a battle. It was a hundred separate courtyards and a few of them had men in them.

She came through the yard on the Bracka and out into the street, and the street was full of people standing still and looking up: shopkeepers in their doorways with the aprons on and their hands on the jambs looking up at the roofs, a woman with a child on her arm looking up, four boys on the pavement with their faces raised like swimmers, an old man with a stick and a straw hat, standing in the middle of the pavement with his mouth open in an expression not of fear and not of joy but of a complete, hopeless, entirely Polish attention.

The firing was in the north-west, three streets off, and it was not a battle line, it was a series of rooms: a courtyard, a staircase, a corner of a street, a school building, a tram; and she went down the Bracka towards the centre of the city in the last light of an August afternoon among about four hundred people who were doing the same thing, which was walking; and in the middle of it, at the corner of the Chmielna, a barricade was being built out of an overturned tram and the cobblestones that two hundred people were pulling up with their hands.

There were women in the middle of it, and boys of fourteen, and a man in a white collar with a briefcase standing on the tram giving orders; six men lifting a piano out of the door of the building on the corner and putting it down on the paving stones of the barricade with a crash that was heard four streets away; a cart unhitched and its shafts turned up into the air; sandbags; a mirror out of a hall; a horse trough; and the cobblestones coming up out of the street in the hands of four hundred people, and a woman of sixty on her knees in the gutter working at one with a hammer.

And when she was level with the tram, the firing from the direction of the Śliska came over the roofs in a burst that was very close and very high, and the whole of the street stopped.

Four hundred people, in the middle of the last hour of the ordinary life of that city, stood still in the middle of the road with the cobblestones in their hands and their heads up, and the burst went over them and away into the roof of a house on the other side, and a woman near Krystyna said

something in Polish about the tiles; and then a man laughed, and two boys began throwing the cobblestones as if it were a game, and the work went on, faster than before.

She had been in that city for five months as a German lady. Nobody had looked at her in the street except to look away; she had been invisible in the exact way that a woman in a good coat in an occupied city is invisible, which is that people avoid her eyes the way they avoid the eyes of a dog; and it was in this hour, in the middle of four hundred people who were pulling up the street with their hands, that this stopped: a woman with her sleeves rolled up and a brick in each hand turned round in the crowd and looked at her, one woman of about fifty, in an apron, with sweat on her face, and said, in Polish, without any hostility at all, in the way one worker speaks to another, "You are standing in the way, lady. Hold this," and shoved a cobblestone into her hands.

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, in the grey coat, with the papers of the German counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison in the lining under her left arm, took the cobblestone out of the hands of a Polish woman of fifty in the street in the first hour of the Rising, and put it where she was told to put it, on the top of the tram, next to a woman's mirror and a length of iron pipe, and went on down the street towards the Śliska with the dust on her hands and the whole of her body ringing.

❦

The assembly point was a building on the Śliska Street with a courtyard, and the courtyard was full of women.

There were about forty of them and they were doing the work that there is to do in the first hour of such a thing: a table with a map and a candle and a list; a woman of about sixty-five in an apron sitting on a chair in the middle of it all doing the stitches on a bag of dressings and not looking up once in an hour; girls of seventeen carrying the armbands out of the office of a building in a cardboard box and putting them on the tables; a woman with a stencil on the ground doing the printing with a roller in the middle of a courtyard where men were carrying a crate of bottles; and in the middle of it all, at the table, in a shirt with the sleeves rolled and a cigarette in the corner of his mouth and a wall of paper in front of him, Antoni Krupa.

He looked up, and saw her, and stood up.

"The pages," he said.

She put the basket on the table and took the hat out of it, and there was nothing in the hat, and then she turned the coat inside out on the table in the middle of the courtyard of a building on the Śliska Street in the light of a candle and a hurricane lamp in August 1944, and took a penknife off the table, and opened the seam under the left arm with the point, and took out of the lining, in three flat packets wrapped in oiled paper, sixty-one pages of carriage of the German garrison's plan of defence of the city of Warsaw; and the quartermaster took them with both hands and looked at the first page for about four seconds, and then sat down at the table with the candle and the map and put his two glasses on his nose, and did not say anything at all for eleven minutes.

Krupa had come round the table; and he looked at her for a while in the way of a man who has spent the whole of a war in a cellar with a ledger; and then he reached out and took her hand, which he had never done, and held it for about two seconds, which was the whole of what he had to give, and said, when he let go: "You will want to be somewhere tonight. Go with Basia."

❦

The girl who tied her armband on was seventeen years old and her name was Basia Marciniak, and she tied it with the hands of a person who has tied eleven of them that evening, and she was talking the entire time, in a way that Krystyna had not heard since the courtyard on the Mokotowska Street in March.

"—and it goes above the elbow, no, here, like this, and the pin is on the inside so that it does not come out, and you do not put your hands in your pockets, and you do not go into the courtyard of the printing house because there is a well there that the boys from the sixteenth are using as a latrine, and if there is shooting in the street you walk with your back to the wall and you count the windows so you know when you have got to the corner; and where did you come from? Because you say towards the way the people from the Praga say it, and nobody says it like that here, well, my grandmother did, she was from the Praga, and where have you come from, honestly? Because you have been in a fight, you have got dust in your hair and your coat smells of cigarettes of a kind that nobody in this city has smoked since 1940, and you have not got a rifle and you have got a face

like a woman who has been to a funeral and come out improved by it."

"From the Mokotowska," said Krystyna.

"Which side?"

"With my father."

"Then you are lucky," said Basia, very fast, with the pin in her mouth, "because both of mine are in the ground in the Ochota since 1942 and my aunt is in the cellar with the radio and my brother is with the group on the Marszałkowska and if I am told one more time by a man of twenty that I am to stay in the courtyard with the dressings I shall put a bullet in somebody myself, and that is not a joke, and you look like a person who has heard a joke before. There." She stepped back. "Basia. What are you called?"

"Krystyna."

"Krysia?" said the girl, and looked at her for a second longer than a girl of seventeen looks at a stranger, and then said, "Right. You are in the fourth room on the top floor with three girls from the Żoliborz and me, and you will get the floor by the wall because you have been somewhere today and the rest of them have been in the courtyard since six a.m., and you will sleep, and in the morning they will find you something to do, because with that handwriting they are going to want you in the office, and God help you, that is worse than the courtyard."

❦

In the first hour of the sixty-three days, the city of Warsaw rose.

It was not at the level of a general staff and it was not one act; it was two hundred courtyards finishing what they had begun, and by six o'clock the barricades on the Marszałkowska, the Nowy Świat, the Hoża, the Chmielna and eleven streets on the other side of the river were finished or half finished; by seven the smoke was coming up in two columns over the Wola and the flags were coming out of the windows; at eight the Prudential building — the tall skeleton of the pre-war city, the pride of the insurance companies of 1933 with the radio mast on the roof, eleven stories of steel and concrete above the Świętokrzyska — was in the hands of a company of the Home Army's boys from the Old Town, who had gone up through the staircase with one pistol between five of them and had taken a German garrison of a hundred and eleven men out of the top three floors with thirty rifles and two of their own dead, and who by nine o'clock had hoisted the flag of the Polish Republic on the mast above the roof of it, where it was visible from the whole of the centre of the city; and the people in the streets on that evening stood on the pavements and looked up at that flag on that building in the last light, and the whole of it was out of a book of 1918 or a picture in a school, and every one of them was crying, and not one of them had any idea at all of what was going to be done to them.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the courtyard on the Śliska Street at nine in the evening with a rifle in her hands, which had been put there by a boy of nineteen who had gone off to get himself a better one, and looked up over the roofs at the smoke and the flag, and did the arithmetic of

the sixty days and the million people of that city; and she had, at nine in the evening of the first of August 1944, three things in her pocket: a card with a pseudonym on it, an armband with an anchor on it, and, at the bottom of the grey coat's pocket, where it had been since the second of December 1940, in a leather purse with a broken clasp, a silver compact with a false floor and one tablet in it, which she had last looked at in a bathroom on the avenue Henri-Martin in March, and which she carried the way a person carries a ticket.

❦

The Colonel stayed in the study until two in the morning.

The telephone line to the garrison command went dead at half past six, and he used the set in the annexe until that went dead too; and by nine he was working entirely from the map of the city on the hall table and from two officers who had come in on foot from the Ujazdowskie with their tunics off and their pistols drawn; and at midnight he sat down at the desk in the study in the dark with the blackout down and looked at the wall in front of him, in the place where the lithograph of the Lilpop works was hanging, for about eleven minutes.

Rutz came in at a quarter past midnight with a glass of tea. He stood by the door with his cap in his hand and said, in German: "Herr Oberst, the lady has not come back."

And von Hagen, at the desk, with his hands flat on the blotter, said: "Where did she say she was going?"

"To the chemist on the Bracka, Herr Oberst, and then you said ten minutes, and I gave her the coat and the basket

at the gate at eleven minutes to five; and the sentry at the gate saw her go down the gravel to the street, and she turned to the right towards the Bracka, and I did not watch her go because there was firing from the Szucha side at that moment and the sentry at the gate was called into the hall, and it was four or five minutes before we thought about it at all."

"Then she is on the other side of it, or she is in the cellar of a house on the Bracka with the whole of the quarter's population," said von Hagen, "or she has been shot in the street, in which case we shall hear about it; and in the morning the order is to be given to every post in this quarter that I want the lady of this house found and brought back, and if she is found by anybody who does not know that order, Rutz, they will take her for a Polish woman in a good coat and put her against a wall; so you will draw a paper tonight, and I shall sign it, and it will say that the woman is an employee of the administration of German nationality and is to be conducted to the Frascati Street at the expense of the Reich, and it will have her description in it."

"Jawohl, Herr Oberst."

"Her description," said von Hagen, and looked at the blackout curtain; and then he said, in the voice that the whole of the villa, and the whole of the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison, and the whole of a Frenchwoman in the rue Royale in January 1944 would have recognised in one syllable, which was the voice of a man giving an instruction to a subordinate about a matter of paper:

"Marion Herschlag, Austrian, twenty-four years of age, height one metre sixty-eight; grey coat, dark hat, mole on the left side of the neck. Written in triplicate. And Rutz — send a man to the Szucha in the morning, from me, in writing, and ask the office of Sturmbannführer Kalbach for the loan of the Fräulein file for twenty-four hours, together with everything that office has collected on the matter since the fourteenth of January."

He stood up and went to the window and put two fingers against the blackout curtain and looked down into the blacked-out garden.

"Because I want to know," said Wolfram von Hagen, "who it is that has been living in my house."

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Slaughterhouse

❦

Being a German in the middle of a Polish rising, in the first week of August 1944, was a matter of portfolios and handwriting.

He had walked into the Śródmieście on the last day of July with a bag in his hand and four hundred and twenty zlotys and a set of German papers in his pocket: an identity card of the administration, a pass of the garrison command, a Wehrpass, a photograph with his ears showing. On the first evening of August, at half past six, in the courtyard of a building on the Żelazna Street, four men of the Home Army had stopped him, taken the bag off him, put him against the wall of the coal shed, and read all of it in the light of a torch; and then one of them had gone away for twenty minutes and had come back with a man of about forty in a coat, who had read the papers again, and had looked at Phillip for four seconds, and had said, in German with a bad accent: "The card says Konrad. I do not know what that is and I do not want to. But there is a man on the Śliska who will."

And so he had been walked through the back streets of the centre of the city in the dark of the first night while the city was firing at nothing and at everything, from one courtyard to another, in the way in which a person is walked through a house in a waking dream: a gate, a passage, a stairwell with a dead man's coat on it, a kitchen with four wo-

men and a lamp turned down, a cellar with a barrel of sauerkraut and two beds, a room over a printing shop where there were eleven people and a dial telephone that did not work.

By the second night he had been in six cellars and had been fed twice and had answered about a hundred questions and had been looked at in about four hundred ways.

The looks are the thing he remembered afterwards, and he remembered them in the order of their temperature rather than in the order of their hours.

There was the look of the woman of sixty in the cellar on the Zielna who had looked at him once, at his shoes and his hands, and had then put a bowl of soup in front of him and gone away and never looked at him again in two days, and who had said, when the boy of the house asked her how she could feed him, one sentence: "My son is with the group on the Wolska, and he is shooting at those, and this one is ours, and the arithmetic of it is not for me."

There was the look of four men of about twenty on the stairs of the printing house, which was a frank, cold, exact, unembarrassed inspection of the kind that farmhands give a cow at a fair: the shoulders, the boots, the hands, the question of what he could lift.

There was the look of an officer of the AK's security section who questioned him for two hours in a room with a candle in the blackout and one hand on a pistol on the table, and who read him the way a man reads a ledger, and who said, at the end of it, "The card in your case is a name in a handwriting I have seen in eleven files, and that handwriting has never once, in five years, been put to a false use. That is

the whole of what stands between you and the courtyard, and I would like you to keep it in mind at all times, and I would like you to understand that it is a provisional fact."

And there was the look of the boy.

He was sixteen years old, he wore a stolen German helmet four sizes too big for him, his boots were Polish army boots of 1938 with the soles tied on with wire, and he carried a Błyskawica submachine gun, which is a weapon made in a cellar in Warsaw by men who had been machinists before the war, out of a design that had been drawn with ink on a kitchen table, and which would fire, most of the time, if it was treated with respect; and he had fired his twice.

On the third night of the rising, in the courtyard of the building on the Śliska Street, the boy came up behind Phillip in the dark while Phillip was carrying a crate of bottles to the well, and put the muzzle of the Błyskawica against the back of his neck, and said, in Polish, in the flat voice of a person doing something he has rehearsed: "Turn round."

Phillip turned round with the crate still in his arms.

"You are the German," said the boy.

"I am the German."

"You have a German pass in your pocket and German boots on and you talk like a German and my father was killed in the Ochota in 1942 by men in boots like that, and there is a courtyard at the back of this building with a wall, and it is four metres, and I have got twenty-two rounds in this and nobody in this courtyard is going to say a word about it to anybody." The boy's hands were steady and the muzzle was not. "Say the thing that the Poles say."

"I do not know what the Poles say."

"Then say something in German."

"I am not going to say anything in German to you with that in your hands," Phillip said, "because it is a bad idea in theory and a worse one in practice, and because you have already decided not to do it and are waiting for a reason, and I am going to give you one: I am carrying this crate of bottles to the well because the woman in the second room asked me to, and if I put it down you will have to carry it yourself, and you have got two hands."

There was a silence of about four seconds in the courtyard, with the firing going on four streets away in the direction of the Wola, and the boy with the helmet put the muzzle of the Błyskawica up in the air and said, in a voice about four years younger than the one he had been using: "You are lucky you are useful. That is the whole of the reason. Do not do anything else useful in the next ten minutes, I need to sit down."

And that was the boy, and he was dead eleven days later on a barricade on the Wolska with the helmet still too big for him, and Phillip Brandt, who had been about two seconds from the wall, thought about him every day for the rest of his life, and never once in a way that could be put on paper.

❦

The news came through the cellars in fragments, and the fragments assembled in the following order.

On Friday the fourth of August, at about eleven in the morning, the firing that had been in the north-west since Tuesday changed: it stopped being small arms in the streets

and became a continuous thing with a rhythm to it, which is the sound of mortars and of a great many vehicles moving; and at noon a boy came into the cellar on the Zielna with the first sentence, which was: "There are troops coming into the Wola from the west, and they are not the Wehrmacht."

What came into Wola in those days had four names and a single character, and it was made up of the material that the Reich had left at the bottom of its drawers: a regiment of the SS's own disciplinary troops recruited from the poachers of the German forests and commanded by a man who had a doctor's degree and a taste for schnapps; a brigade of the Russian and Ukrainian and Cossack volunteers that had been raised in the east by a Polish-born Soviet officer who had changed sides; a battalion of Azerbaijani troops; two police battalions of the German order police; and behind all of them the ordinary apparatus — the gendarmerie, the railway police, the units of the garrison, and the administrative officers of the very district that the offices had spent four years administering.

Phillip, who had worked in Warsaw for four months and had read the German papers of that district, could read the orders in his sleep. There would be an order to clear the streets of the district; then an order that the population was to be collected in courtyards and assembly points; then a movement order for the civilian columns to the transit camp at Pruszków; and then, underneath all of that, in the language of that particular week in that particular district, the actual instruction, which was written down nowhere at all and which every man in those columns understood, and

the instruction was: the population of the Wola is to disappear.

He heard it from the other side of the line, standing in the upper window of a house at the corner of the Towarowa and the Grójecka with a pillow on the sill and the whole of his hand on the glass, in the flat of a schoolmistress who had taken him in on the fourth night of the rising when he had needed a roof and no questions; and what he saw through the glass at a distance of eleven hundred metres on Saturday the fifth of August 1944 between eight in the morning and eleven o'clock was not a battle.

It was a city being emptied.

There was a column of about four thousand people on the Grójecka, moving west in the ordinary way in which a population moves when it has been told to go: with the handcarts, the bundles, the children, the old men on the carts, the women carrying the sacks; and on both sides of that column there were soldiers of the SS with their rifles at their hips, and behind it, at the corner, other soldiers were going into the houses and coming out of them with more.

There was a building on the Wolska with the roof on fire and a man on the third floor of it, alone, at the window, doing nothing at all, for the forty minutes that it took the fire to reach him; and there was, twelve metres away from that building, another building with a courtyard, into which a column of people had been put at about nine o'clock, and out of which, at about eleven, there came the noise.

There was a boy of about seven walking alone down the middle of a street with his hands up, and stopping, and standing still in the middle of the road for four minutes while the soldiers went past him on both sides and nobody touched him and nobody spoke to him, and then walking on to the west, and disappearing among the people.

There was a piano being carried out of a doorway on the Wolska Street by two men in the striped jackets that the prisoners from the east wore: out of the door, down the two steps, across the pavement, and set down on the cobbles in the sun, one of them with his hands still flat on the lid for a moment, and then they went back into the house for the next thing, and the piano stood on the pavement on the Wolska Street in the sunshine with nobody in the whole of the world paying any attention to it at all, and that is the picture he kept, and he kept it for fifty-one years.

The history of that week was written afterwards by four hundred people with the numbers and the places in it, and Phillip Brandt never learned any of the numbers, because the numbers were not what he saw; what he saw was the afternoon of the fifth of August at eleven o'clock, from the window of a flat on the corner of the Towarowa and the Grójecka, at a distance of eleven hundred metres, with a pillow on the sill and a woman behind him in the room saying, in Polish, in a voice of the kind a person uses for a litany: Jezu, Jezu, Jezu — and the fact, which he carried from that window to the end of his life, that he could not do anything at all except know precisely, in the professional way of a man who had translated such orders into Polish for four

months, which of them were being carried out in the streets below him and in what order, and that this knowledge was not a small thing, and that there is nothing on earth that can be done with it.

❦

He went west on the sixth.

He was not ordered to go. He went because there was no version of the man he was in which he sat on a chair in a flat in the Śródmieście while his mother and his father were eleven hundred metres away on the other side of a fire; and because of a calculation that he made on the towel with a piece of soap and then rubbed out with his hand, which had three lines in it: that a man in Polish civilian clothes with a bag of dressings was a man who could walk down a street in the Wola for a quarter of an hour in the middle of a massacre, because a massacre has enough to do and does not examine everybody; that the way through the ruins of the ghetto was open, because the ruins were two kilometres of broken brick in which nobody at all had any business, and he knew the two gaps in the wall on the Bonifraterska from the German side of the paperwork; and that he would be back before dark.

He went on the sixth of August at four in the morning, in a jacket and a pair of the schoolmistress's late husband's boots, with his German papers left folded in the lining of a chair in the flat, which was the first time in five years that he had gone anywhere without papers, and with a bag of dressings from the AK's store because there is no story in the world that a bag of dressings cannot tell.

The Wola on the sixth of August smelled of burning, in the way in which, from that week on, the whole city smelled of burning; but in the Wola it was at a different temperature and had a different content: not the smell of a building on fire, which is a smell of resin and plaster and old paper, but a smell of a great many things burning at once which the human nose puts together in the first four seconds and then refuses to assemble again; and after the first four hundred metres he stopped taking it in at all, which is a mercy of the body that every witness of that week has described and which no witness of that week has ever been able to be glad of.

He walked through streets he had walked in as a child: the Wolska, the Towarowa, the Grójecka, the Młynarska, the Karolkowa with the church, the Żelazna with the tram depot, the streets of the district that had been the industrial heart of the city since 1880 with the factories and the gasworks and the slaughterhouse at the end of it.

The yards were open and the doors were open and the windows were open, because in that week the doors of the Wola were left open; and in the open yards there were bundles and handcarts and suitcases and the small objects of the lives of about forty thousand people: a hat, a shoe, a pot of jam, a child's pram with a bag of sugar in it, the cart of a pedlar with the goods still on it, and, at the corner of the Karolkowa and the Skierniewicka, in the middle of the road, a pair of women's shoes standing side by side and upright, in the way in which shoes stand when a person has walked out of them and gone on barefoot, except that there was nobody in the whole of the street.

At about six in the morning he went into the yard of the works on Burakowska Street, which was his father's works, where he had been taken by his father on a Sunday in 1937 to see the furnace being tapped, and where the family photograph of 1928 had been taken in front of the gate with the furnaces behind.

The works were standing. The gate was open and the yard was empty and the machines were in the sheds with the belts on them; there were two lorries in the yard with the bonnets up and the tools out, and a German staff car with its bonnet in the air and a driver's jacket over the seat, and a great many papers on the ground — the archives of the German administration of the works turned out of a cupboard and walked over by a great many boots and left in the yard, the sheets going over on their edges in the wind off the river; and in the middle of the yard there was a single thing that told him, in one second, what had happened in that place, and it was a man's leather satchel standing upright on the ground in the middle of the yard with nothing near it.

He knew the satchel the way a son knows a thing that has been on a chair in the corridor of his house since 1931.

He picked it up. It had his father's initials on the strap in the ink of 1912 and it weighed what a satchel of papers weighs, and in it there were three drawings of an axle, a table book of the works for 1944, a pair of spectacles in a case, and a request, in German, on the writing paper of the works, dated the fourth of August and signed by Brandt, for a permit to remove the firm's drawing office records to a place of safety; and the signature had been rejected in the

margin, in pencil, in the small precise hand of a functionary, with the word abgelehnt and a date, the fifth of August.

Two streets further on, in the cellar of a house on the Młynarska that had been a laundry, he found his mother.

There were nineteen people in that cellar, which was four metres by six, and they had been in it since Friday night, and the whole of the cellar's population looked up at him in one movement when he came down the steps with the satchel in his hand, and the look was the look of people who have been waiting for three days for the door to open and who have decided, all together, that the person who opens it will be wearing a helmet.

And in the corner, on a chair, with a rosary in her fingers and her hands over her ears, in a black dress with a coat over her knees, there was his mother.

She had been fifty-eight years old in April and she looked, on the sixth of August, like a woman of seventy: her hair was down and grey and had not been done since Friday, and there was a wound on the back of her left hand where she had burned it on the stove in the first hour of Saturday when the gas went off, and her eyes, when she looked up and saw him in the doorway of the cellar, did not change at all: they did not light and they did not widen; and she looked at him for four seconds with the entire weight of her whole life in her face and then said, in German, in the voice of a woman in a drawing room in the Hoża Street in 1936: "Wolfram?"

"Mutterschen. It is Phillip."

"Phillip," said Maria Brandt, and then she said it again, and then she stood up and put her arms round her son in the cellar of a laundry on the Młynarska Street in the middle of the fifth day of the murder of that district, and the whole of the nineteen people in the cellar looked at the two of them and then looked away, all at once, in the way of a crowd in a church.

His father was not in the cellar.

What his mother could tell him was four sentences long and she told it in German in the flat voice of a woman reciting a thing she has gone over and over for forty hours in order to be able to say it at all: that the works had been held on Friday morning by the German administration, that the technical staff had been told to stay in the drawing office and to keep the machinery, that her husband had walked to the works at seven in the morning of the fourth of August with his satchel, and that on Friday evening the column of the technical staff of four works of the district had been taken out of the yard on the Burakowska Street by the police and had gone west in the direction of the transit camp at Pruszków, and that a boy from the office had come back to the district at midnight on Friday with the news that the column had not arrived at Pruszków, and that the second half of it had been taken aside in the fields at the edge of the district, and that nobody had seen Albrecht Brandt after that, and that the boy who had brought this had been fifteen years old and had gone out again on Saturday morning, and that she did not know any more.

That is the whole of what the book has about the death of Albrecht Brandt: a satchel standing upright in the middle of an empty yard with a refusal stamped on his last request, and a woman of fifty-eight in a cellar on the Młynarska Street telling her son four sentences in German with her hands over her ears.

❦

He took nineteen people out of the Wola.

It was not a plan; it was an arithmetic, and the arithmetic was: the morning of the seventh of August, in the gaps between the columns and the patrols, along the Młynarska to the Ghetto's boundary, and then through the ruins, which were two kilometres wide and in which there was nobody, and out at the other side into the Śródmieście and into the cellars of the streets on the edge of the district that were still in Polish hands.

The party was nineteen people: his mother; the woman of the laundry, who was fifty-four and had a nephew in the AK; the nephew, who was fifteen; four men, of whom two had been in the fire brigade and two had come out of a hospital courtyard on the Wolski side; six women; a girl of nine; and an old man of eighty-one who was a retired railwayman named Kaczmarek and who could not walk.

They went at four in the morning, and the first four hundred metres took forty minutes, and the last two hundred metres took three hours.

The old man was carried on a door with the hinges on it: four men at the corners, of whom Phillip was one, with his mother walking next to him with her hand on the door's

edge; and they set the door down in the ash and the brick between every thirty and forty metres and stood and breathed; and between the tenth and the eleventh of the twenty-three stops that the journey took, the old railway-man, who had been in and out of a half-consciousness for the whole of the day, said in Polish, to nobody, in a voice that carried through the whole of the party in the way that voices carry in dead cities: "This is the Gęsia. I worked at the Gęsia from 1919 to 1939. There was a tram stop here in the summer of 1939, and there was a man who sold the water with a lemon in it, and my wife's sisters were in this street, in the house at the corner, and now it is a heap of the same bricks and I am eighty-one years old and it is all the same heap of bricks."

They crossed the Gęsia, the two of them, at about eleven in the morning, and it took an hour and eleven minutes, and the sun was up and the ash was hot and there was no shade in sixteen square kilometres of that city; and about two-thirds of the way across, when the four of them had put the door down and were standing with their hands on their knees, a woman in the party began to cry in a way that was not a woman's crying at all but was as regular and dry as a pump, and one of the firemen said, in Polish, "Not now," and she stopped, as simply as that: she stopped, and stood, and picked up her end of the sack of potatoes, and walked on; and that, Phillip said afterwards to one person only, in 1946, in a kitchen in a different country, was the thing he learned in the rising: how far a person can be taken on the strength of one other person saying not now.

They were found at five in the afternoon, on the other side, in the cellar of a house on the Pańska Street, by a section of the Home Army's boys out of the Śródmieście: nine of them, led by a man of thirty with a German pistol in his belt, with the dirt on them of a week of fighting, and with the Błyskawica boy among them, the boy with the helmet, who saw Phillip coming up the cellar steps with a woman on his arm and stopped, and looked at him, and then raised the submachine gun.

"This one," he said, to the man of thirty. "This one is a German. He has a card with Konrad on it and I have been told not to touch him and I want to be told again, right now, in front of these people, because I have got ninety rounds in this and there is a woman behind the wall of that courtyard whose whole family was shot in the Wola yesterday."

And the whole of the cellar courtyard of the Pańska Street was quiet for about four seconds.

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna came up out of the cellar behind him, in a grey coat with the dust of two districts on it and an armband on her arm, and put her body between the boy and Phillip Brandt without saying one word to either of them.

She did not say anything at all. She came up the last three steps, and looked at the boy, and stood there, in front of the man, with her shoulder four inches from the muzzle of a submachine gun held by a boy of sixteen, and she stayed like that, in the middle of a courtyard, in the middle of the rising, in the middle of the whole of the war, for eleven

seconds, until the man of thirty put his hand on the boy's arm and pushed the muzzle down towards the cobbles.

"Take him to the staff," he said. "He is somebody's file."

❦

They put her in a cellar, and him in the same cellar, the same night.

The cellar was under a house on the Świętokrzyska whose courtyard had a well and whose upper floors had gone in the first week; it had a candle, a table, four beds of laths and straw, and eleven people, of whom two were wounded and one was a woman of eighty with a broken hip who would die three days later; and the whole of the night the firing went on over the roofs, and the whole of the night the water dripped off the broken pipe in the corner into a bucket, and in the morning the smell of the bucket was the smell of that cellar and the smell of that city for the whole of the sixty-three days.

His mother was three feet away, asleep at last on the fourth bed with her rosary in her fingers and her hands over her ears; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna sat on the edge of the bed next to Phillip Brandt with a bowl of water and a rag and washed the blood off his hands.

It was not his blood. It was the blood of the old railwayman, who had died on the door between the Młynarska and the Gęsia at about half past two in the afternoon, at eighty-one years of age, having asked for the door to be put down twice and then having stopped talking, and whom they had carried on the door for another eleven hundred metres, over the ash and the brick, knowing exactly what they were carry-

ing, because the alternative was to leave him, and in that district in that week, the alternative was the ash.

She washed his hands; and then she washed his face; and then she took off his boots, one at a time, and pulled them off by the heel, and turned them up, and shook the ash out of them, and set them by the bed, in the way in which a woman does these things for a man in her room in a time of peace.

And neither of them said, in the whole of that hour, one sentence that could have been quoted in a report; and the whole of what passed between them in that cellar was this: that when she had put the boots down and turned round, Phillip Brandt took hold of her wrist — the left one, the one with the seam of the coat — and held it for about four seconds in the candlelight, and then let go of it and lay back on the bed with his arm over his eyes; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna sat and looked at the candle until it went out, and then lay down on her own bed, one metre away, with her boots still on and her coat over her, and slept for four hours the way a person sleeps when everything that has been arranged in the world has finally arranged itself around a fact.

❦

On the eighth of August, at six in the evening, she was sent for by the staff.

It was in a big flat on the third floor of a building on the Świętokrzyska with the windows out and the blackout hanging in strips and a whole wall of map, and there were eleven men in the room and two telephones that did not work

and a dispatch rider asleep on a chair in the corner; and there was a colonel of about fifty with a bad hand, sitting at the table with three maps in front of him and a plate of soup he had not eaten, and a captain with a pencil behind his ear and the eyes of a man who had not slept since Sunday; and the two of them took her through the documents of the intelligence section, in the flat, dry, hurried way of men who have work: the German garrison's order of battle, which they had out of her and out of the plan and out of the prisoners of the first week; the state of the bridges, which they had out of her; the demolitions, which they had out of her; and the question they had written at the top of the paper and could not answer, which was where the material for the defence of the city was coming from, and what was coming, and how fast.

And at the end of an hour and a half, the colonel with the bad hand put down his pencil and said: "There is a man in the cellar on the Pańska. He came out of the Wola on the seventh and he has been in three houses in the Śródmieście since the first of August and there is a card on him with a name in the Major's handwriting, and nobody in this building knows what to do with him. He is a German officer of the Abwehr. He is not my business, and he is not my prisoner, and I have been told that he is yours."

"He is not mine," said Krystyna. "He is the section's."

"Then the section has a problem, and the problem is the following." The colonel put his spectacles on. "We have four crates of German paper out of an office on the Świętokrzyska and out of the post office on the Królewska and

out of a railway wagon at the Gdańsk station, and there is not one person in the whole of this rising, including the whole of my staff, including the two of us at this table, who can read German staff paper at the speed at which it has to be read in a siege. We have got a woman in this room who is the best intelligence I have had in four years and who has been under an officer's eye since March and who cannot be used anywhere in this city where she would be recognised, which is everywhere. And we have got a German officer of counter-intelligence down the stairs with a card in his file." He looked at her over the top of his spectacles. "So I am going to ask you, on the section's authority, whether the man can read German maps."

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the middle of a room in a house on the Świętokrzyska Street on the eighth of August 1944 with the strips of the blackout moving at the window and eleven men looking at her, and knew, in the second she stood there, that she was in the middle of the only true and complete arrangement of her whole life.

"He can read them," she said, "and he is better at it than anybody in this city, including the Germans, and I will answer for that with my own card in the same ledger, and there will be four people in this building who will never forgive me for it, and it will be correct, and he is in the cellar on the Pańska Street with his mother and a broken window and he has just carried an old man nineteen hundred metres over the ghetto on a door."

"Good," said the colonel, and wrote something on the paper, and pushed the plate of soup away, and said, without looking up: "Bring him in the morning."

And it was when they were going out, when the two of them had got as far as the corridor, that the Błyskawica boy came up the stairs with his helmet in his hand and his face grey under the dirt, and stopped, and said to the room in general, in the flat, ordinary way in which that generation delivered the largest news of its life:

"The girl Marciniak. Basia. On the Marszałkowska barricade this afternoon, with the dispatches in her belt. She was nineteen — no, she was seventeen, she was seventeen in May, and she had the pouch and the dispatches on her and she was carrying them to the Śródmieście command and they got her at the corner by the Krucza, and the boys from the fourth house brought her in and she was still holding the belt." He put his helmet on. "The dispatches went on. They were picked up by the man on the stairs. There is nothing left in the pouch."

Chapter twenty-one

The Garden of Ash

❦

The intelligence section of the Home Army's Old Town sector was in the back rooms of a house on the Długa Street, in a flat on the second floor whose windows had gone in the first week and were hung with a blanket, and it had in it: a table, four chairs, a chest of drawers used as an archive, a candle in a bottle, a lamp with a cloth over it, eleven files, three hundred sheets of paper, two typewriters of which one worked, and the whole of the written intelligence of a district of a city under siege.

There were nine people in that room at the end of August: a captain of about forty with a wound in the left hand and the entire memory of the sector's German order of battle in his head; a woman of thirty who had been a clerk in a bank and who did the cipher; two girls of eighteen who wrote a fair hand and did the fair copies; a scout of fifteen who ran; a sergeant of the blue police of the pre-war city who had come over on the first day with his pistol and his knowledge of every German post between the Długa and the river; a priest of the district who came in twice a day to sit with the wounded and once a day to sit with the papers, because a priest can carry a satchel anywhere; a woman of fifty who cooked for the whole house out of what there was and who never once went down to the cellar during a bombardment, on the stated grounds that she had been through

1920 and that the shell that had her name on it would find her in a cellar as easily as a kitchen; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, who read German.

That was her function in the Rising, and it was the last form of the trade that had taken her through Paris and Warsaw, and it was the strangest of them all, because the work was honest.

She translated. She translated the German newspapers, the German orders, the German maps taken off dead officers, the German letters taken off prisoners, the German labels on the medical stores and the German signs on the boxes of the ammunition captured in the first week; she translated the tank recognition tables and the insignia of the units engaged in the Wola and the insignia of the units on the bridges; she translated the sentences of the German military courts that had been found in the safe of a police station on the Długa, and the ledgers of the German garrison's canteen, and a hundred and eleven pages of the correspondence of the office of the waterworks of the city of Warsaw, of which the last page in the file was the one on which the German director of the waterworks wrote to the garrison command on the first of August 1944, at ten past five in the evening, the following sentence: the working of the pumps continues; the men have gone home; there is firing in the streets; I am going home myself and I will come in the morning.

She was good at it; nobody in that building could check her work; and she was, in the economy of a besieged district, worth about a company, and the whole of the section knew

it, and the whole of the section also knew that it did not know where she came from.

There were four people in the Old Town who knew what she had done before the first of August 1944, and they were the woman with the ledger, the man with the spectacles, her brother, and a priest in the Mokotowska Street who had told her that he would put his coat on and go out of the door if she said one more word to him about a dead man in February; and there were, in the intelligence section of the Old Town, about eleven people who had worked out, each in their own way and without saying anything to anybody, that the woman who read German had been somewhere in German company.

On the eleventh of August she heard the sentence, and it was not said to her.

She was at the second table with the lamp and the cloth, translating a captured order of the day of a police battalion into Polish for the captain with the wounded hand, and there were five people in the room, and one of them was a young lieutenant of about twenty-two of a sabotage section who had come in to draw a map, and who said, at the chest of drawers, waiting for the paper: "There is a truck of ours with two women in it on the Świętojerska; they came over with the ambulances from the Śródmieście; both of them are dressed like ladies, one of them has got shoes on her that cost four thousand zlotys, and I have been told they came out of German houses. It is a fine thing that we are fighting the whole of the German army so that a couple of German officers' whores can come and drink our tea—"

And Iga Zaleska, who was standing at the window with a list in her hand, said, without turning round, in her flat voice: "The woman is mine."

There was a silence in that room of about four seconds, in which the typewriter stopped and the girl of eighteen at the fair copies looked up and the young lieutenant turned round with his mouth still open, and then Iga went on with her list, and the lieutenant took his map and went out of the room, and nobody in that room ever said anything of the kind in front of her again, and nobody ever explained to the lieutenant what the four words had meant, and he died on the twentieth of August at his barricade on the Miodowa without finding out.

❦

The warmth in that chapter is not in the rooms and it is not in the fighting. It is in a cellar on the night of the fourth of August, in the Śródmieście, in the first week, and it is a conversation with a girl of seventeen who was killed on the eighth.

Her name was Basia Marciniak and she had tied the armband of eleven couriers in one evening, and by the fourth of August she had the whole of the intelligence section's dispatch route in her head, which is not a thing that is taught and is a thing that cannot be faked; and on the night of the fourth, during a bombardment that went on from nine till midnight and took the roof off the house next door, the two of them sat on the floor of a cellar with two other girls and the whole population of the building, and Basia stole one of Krystyna's cigarettes out of her coat, the

way she had stolen three of them in the first week, and smoked it with the concentration of a girl of seventeen who has never been given one in her life except by soldiers, and asked the question.

"What is it like?"

"What is what like?"

"Sleeping in their beds." She had her knees up and her arms round them and her chin on her knees and her eyes on the candle, and she asked it in the flat, sweet, curious, entirely merciless way of a person of seventeen who has decided that the truth is a thing that grown-ups owe her. "I am not asking you for my mother, and there is nobody in this cellar who is listening except the two of them and they are asleep, and I have been carrying your messages for eleven days now, so I think I have bought the answer, and you have been in rooms that nobody in this city has been in, and I want to know, and if you say you do not want to talk about it I shall call you a coward and I shall be right."

There were, Krystyna found, three answers and none of them was true, and she gave all three in the course of about four minutes, and the girl took them all apart.

The first answer was the professional one: that a bed is a piece of furniture and a body is a machine and a person can be in a room and not be in it, in the way that a woman in a hospital can lie in a bed for eleven weeks; and Basia said, "That is the answer for a report."

The second answer was the arithmetic: that every hour in that room had bought paper, and paper had bought lives, and that she had been running the account for four years

and had never once found the sum wrong; and Basia said, "That is the answer for your officer with the spectacles, and it is a good answer, and my aunt says it about her son who is in the police."

And the third answer was that it was terrible; and Basia said nothing at all to the third answer, and smoked the cigarette down to her fingers, and then ground the end out on the floor of the cellar of a house in the Śródmieście and said the thing that Krystyna carried out of that cellar and out of that city:

"When my brother was at the school in the Ochota, the Germans came in 1942 and took eleven boys from the yard and shot nine of them in the street and my brother was in the nine and he was fifteen, and they made the ones they did not shoot look at it from the wall; and I have thought about it for two years, and I have decided that a person who is in a room with the enemy and comes out in the morning and gives me a paper that saves eleven people at the barricade is not a whore, and that a person who says she is one is either a fool or a braggart, and that you are neither, so I am going to ask you a different question, and then I shall leave you alone, and the question is: when you are in a room with them, do you count in Polish or in German?"

"In Polish," said Krystyna.

"There," said Basia, and lay back against the wall of the cellar with her arms folded and her eyes shut and the whole of her face suddenly like a little girl's on a pillow, "there, you see, they can never tell that, and I knew it, because you cannot lie in the language you count in. My brother used to say

that you can tell a Polish girl anywhere because she counts in Polish when she is frightened. He was fifteen. He was an idiot. He was right about that."

❦

The interrogation was on the sixteenth of August in a cellar under a house on the Długa Street, and it was conducted by Krystyna Stankiewiczówna because there was nobody else in the Old Town who could do it.

The prisoner was twenty-two years old and his name was Gerhard Lippmann and he was a Gefreiter of a signals company, and he had been taken in the courtyard of a house on the Świętojerska in the morning by a section of boys who had found him under a bed with a telephone set and a pair of pliers and no weapon, and who had wanted to shoot him, and who had been persuaded by an officer of twenty-four to bring him in instead, because a signaller of a signals company of a division is a piece of paper worth a company of men.

He had been hit in the face with the butt of a rifle in the taking of him, and the left side of his face was swollen and closed; and he sat on a stool in the cellar with his hands tied behind him and his tunic off and his shirt open, and he was shivering in the heat of August in the way of a man in shock, and when Krystyna came down the steps with a lamp and a chair he looked at her and said, in German, in the voice of a boy asking a teacher: "Are you the interpreter?"

"I am the interpreter."

"Thank God," said Gerhard Lippmann, and began to cry, and stopped, and answered every question she put to

him for two hours and forty minutes with the exactness of a man who has decided that the whole of his life depends on being useful.

She did it in German. It was the first time in five months that she had used the language to ask a question instead of to be somebody, and it came out of her mouth in an accent that was neither the Viennese woman's nor her own: it was the German of the flat above the laundry, the German of nine weeks of hours, the German in which Wiktor Janowski had made her learn to put a question in four different ways so that the subject would not know which of the four was the important one.

The company. The regiment. The division. The call signs, the frequencies, the relay post on the Wolska, the cable that ran down the Towarowa under the pavement and had been laid by his own section in June, the location of the exchange in the building of a school on the Ochota where there were four hundred lines and eleven men and a major of the signals who was the second cousin of somebody important in Berlin. He gave her all of it, and he gave her the state of the supply of the batteries of his own company, which was two days, and the code word of the day, which was Hagen, and the fact that the batteries were issued by a sergeant he could describe down to his watch chain, and by the end of the second hour the captain with the wounded hand was sitting on the third step of the cellar with a pencil and a piece of paper and the whole of his face gone quiet, because a boy on a stool in a cellar on the Długa had just told them where the German artillery was getting its orders from in the Wola.

Then, at the end, when the captain had gone up the steps with the paper in his good hand, the boy asked her the questions of his own.

He asked about his mother: her name was Gerda Lippmann and she lived in a village called Osterode in East Prussia, in a house with an orchard, and she had a bad heart and she had not been told that he had been sent to the east; and he asked whether, when the war was over, somebody would tell her that he had not been in the SS and had not done any of the things that the paper would say that the German army had done in this city. And he asked whether he would be sent back to the camp of the prisoners, or whether the Polish army was going to shoot him, because he had been told in his own company, by the sergeant with the watch chain, that the Poles shot the prisoners; and he said it in a way that was not a plea but a question of fact, addressed to the only adult in the room who spoke his language and who was therefore, to him, the last official in the world.

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna said to him, in the German of a woman from the neighbourhood of Vienna, in a voice with a small amount of human warmth in it, that he was a prisoner of the Polish army and that the Polish army did not shoot prisoners, and that he would be sent to a camp for prisoners of war and that his mother would be able to write to him through the Red Cross at the end of it, and that he was to keep his head down and do what he was told and be patient, and that the war would be over in the winter.

Every sentence of that was a lie except one.

The order of the Home Army's command on the treatment of prisoners and the fact of the transit camp at Pruszków and the state of the country in the autumn of 1944 meant that a Gestrandeter of a signals company in a cellar on the Długa Street had, on the arithmetic of that week, a life expectancy of about eleven days — not because anybody would shoot him, but because the Old Town was about to be taken apart, and because in a besieged building there are no prisoners who can be fed and no guards who can be spared and no way to send a boy of twenty-two with a bandaged face across a line; and the AK's practice in that district in those weeks was to take the prisoners out on the day before the evacuation and to hand them to a German post under a flag, which meant the papers, which meant the boy's own officers would ask him what he had said in the cellar.

She walked up the steps of that cellar into the light of the courtyard of the house on the Długa Street, which was a hot, bright, ordinary August morning with the smoke of the Wola coming over the roofs, and she went into the yard behind the water butt and was sick, twice, in the way she had been sick in a bathroom in a villa on the Frascati Street in July; and then she wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and went back inside and typed up the interrogation report in Polish in eleven minutes with a fair copy in triplicate, which the captain with the wounded hand called the best piece of work that had been done in that room in three weeks.

❦

The news of Basia came into that room on the nineteenth of August at half past four in the afternoon from three separate directions, in the way in which news comes into a besieged district, and none of the three of them was official.

The first was from a boy of fifteen who ran in off the Miodowa with his shirt torn and said that a courier had been hit at the corner by the passage of the theatre, in the open, in daylight, at about noon: shot through the chest by a rifleman in the tower of the church of the Holy Cross, at a distance of three hundred metres, in the way the German marksmen had been working that street for eleven days, and that the boys from the fourth house had brought her in and that she had died in the passage in about four minutes.

The second was the pouch itself, which arrived at five: a canvas bag with the buckles and the leather, with the dispatches in it, all three of them, undamaged and in order, handed over at the door by a girl of seventeen who had picked it up off the ground and who said, in the way of that city: "She had it under her." And there was nothing on earth in the bag that should not have been in it, and the captain with the wounded hand opened it and read the three messages and signed the receipt and said to the girl, "Good," and the girl went away, and the receipt went into the file; and on the wall of the room where the file was kept there was a list of the section's couriers with the dates, and afterward, when Krystyna looked at that list at the end of September, in the Śródmieście, she found that Basia Marciniak's name had been written into it in another hand with the date of the eighth of August and the letters poległa, which is the word

the Polish army used in that war for the dead, and that there was nothing else against it: no age, no address, no number, no family, in a file which contained three pages on a German sergeant's watch chain.

The third direction was the worst and it was the one that belonged to her personally: her own item, the one she had written on the morning of the eighth in her own small upright hand, on a quarter of a sheet of paper, in cipher, in the fair copy of the section's cipher book, and handed to Basia Marciniak at eleven o'clock in the morning at the door of a house on the Miodowa Street in a pouch with the buckles and the leather: a message of eleven groups about the movement of two companies of the German gendarmerie from the Saxon Garden towards the Old Town, which was, professionally, exactly what it should have been, and which was found under the body of a girl of seventeen in a passage on the Miodowa Street, in the pouch, in order, dry, and which came back to the section at five in the afternoon and was filed, and which nobody in the world except Krystyna Stankiewiczówna ever connected to a conversation in a cellar on the fourth of August about the language a person counts in.

She wrote her report on the events of the nineteenth of August in the ordinary form, in three lines, in Polish, at the table with the lamp and the cloth, with a steady hand.

❦

The new intelligence came in through the middle of the month in the way of a tide rather than an event, and by the

twenty-fifth of August the picture in that room was complete and it was the following.

The Germans were going to take the Old Town.

They were going to do it with artillery fired over open sights at the ends of the streets, with the engineers and the flamethrowers, with the armoured train on the bridge, with the units that had come out of the east and the south — and among them the battalions that the army had raised out of the eastern peoples and the Silesian units and the two groups that had already done the Wola; and they were going to do it house by house, and the whole of the operation was being organised from the Saxon Garden and from the buildings on the Plac Teatralny, which is four hundred metres from the Długa Street.

What that meant, in the arithmetic of a besieged district, was that about four thousand people in the Old Town — of whom eight hundred were wounded and eleven hundred were civilians, of whom two hundred were children — were going to be reduced by about a third, and the AK's command had decided at the end of August to take the fighters and the wounded and the couriers out through the sewers to the Śródmieście and to leave behind the dead and the houses.

And on the twenty-ninth of August the captain with the wounded hand asked her to stay.

He asked it badly and honestly, in the way of a man who has been doing an impossible job for four weeks: that the evacuation would be in three days, that the section's papers would go through on the first night, that the last hours of the Old Town would produce more captured German doc-

uments than any other three days of the rising — the orders, the maps, the instructions to the assault groups, the schedule of the artillery, and, most important of all, the identification of the units, because a district going to pieces needs to know to the last hour who is coming — and that there were eleven people in the sector who could read German and that three of them were dead and four were wounded and two were couriers and one was a boy of fifteen who had been taught the alphabet by his mother in Vienna in 1930, and that none of them could do it at the speed at which it had to be done; and that the woman who read German was not, under the section's orders, required to stay.

She said yes in four words, at the table, with the lamp and the cloth, and went back to the translation she was doing, and the whole of why she said yes was in the four words and in the translation and in nothing else: because the information was the last thing that she had that was worth more than her body, and because, in the fifth year, the thing that a person is, is the work.

❦

The news of her family, in that month, came to her twice, at a distance, second-hand, from the mouths of people who did not know that they were carrying it.

The first was on the twenty-first of August, in the corridor of the house on the Długa Street, from a woman of about sixty who had come over from the Śródmieście with a dispatch and who was sitting on the floor of the corridor with her shoes off, resting, and who said, when Krystyna gave her a glass of water and asked her, in the ordinary way

in which everybody asked everybody that month, whether she was from the centre of the city: "Mokotowska Street, the courtyard with the pump, my sister has the flat on the ground floor with a shop, well, she had a shop; and there is an old man in that building, a schoolmaster, Stankiewicz, he was hit in the leg by a piece of a mortar on the second of August in the courtyard, and he has been in the cellar of the house since then with the leg going bad, and they cannot get him over to the hospital, and the daughter — a girl of seventeen, very thin — is with him and will not leave him, and they are all in the cellar of that building, eleven of them."

The second was on the twenty-seventh of August, in the intelligence room, from the scout of fifteen who had been down to the Śródmieście and back with the post: that a group of the sabotage section had come into the Old Town three nights before through the ruins, and that among them there had been a man from the Mokotowska who had asked in the corridor of the house on the Długa Street— and here the boy stopped, and looked at her, and then said the whole of it, in the flat way of a person of fifteen in the fifth year of that war who has learned to give the news in the order it matters: "There was a man who asked for the woman who reads German, and the captain said he could not see anybody, and the man said that he was her brother and that he had nothing to tell her, and that he was going through with the first group."

She was in the room when the boy said it; and she went on translating the sheet in front of her to the end of the paragraph, which was eleven lines about the state of the am-

munition of a German artillery regiment; and then she put the pencil down, and stood up, and went out of the room.

❦

The last days of the Old Town are not this chapter's business, and the reason is that they are the book's business, and the book has been carrying them since the first page; what happened in those houses between the thirty-first of August and the second of September 1944 happened to about thirty thousand people at once, and each of them saw a piece of it, and every piece of it was the same piece: a wall coming down, a courtyard with a well and no water, the hospital in the cellars of a house on the Długa with the wounded of four districts in it and eleven women doing the dressings by the light of a lamp, the paintings of the museum wrapped in blankets and stacked in a corridor with a boy of seventeen asleep on them with a rifle across his knees, the children under the staircase with the whole of the day's bread in one basket, the trap door to the cellar passage, and the burning of the papers.

She burned the papers on the first of September.

The section's archive went into the courtyard of the house on the Długa Street at four in the afternoon, in two sacks and a suitcase, and it was burned in the middle of the yard in a fire that took forty minutes and was fed with the whole of the five years of that work: the maps, the order of battle of the German garrison of the district of the Old Town of the city of Warsaw of the month of August 1944, the identical copy of the plan of the fortress with the marginal pencil marks and the word Bedingt next to the Gdańsk

railway station, the interrogation reports including the eleven lines of the report on the events of the nineteenth of August concerning the death of a courier, and the ledger of the names, which had come over from the Śliska Street in a woman's satchel on the second day of the rising and which Antoni Krupa put into the fire himself with his own two hands, sheet by sheet, standing in front of the fire in the heat of the flames with his spectacles in his pocket, so that no living person would ever read the ledger of the people who had worked for that country in the city of Warsaw between 1939 and 1944.

At six in the evening the section went down into the cellars under the house, and from those cellars there was a passage of four hundred metres to the mouth of the sewer on the Kilińskiego Street, and the crossing that night went by groups of twenty, with a guide to each group, and the guide for the section's group was a man of about forty from the city's water service who had worked in those tunnels before the war and who was going to die in them before the morning; and in the column, in the dark of the cellar, standing in the queue of forty people waiting their turn to go down a hole in the floor of a city that was burning above them, there were: the captain with the wounded hand, the woman of fifty who had never gone down to a cellar in a bombardment, two boys of fifteen and seventeen, the priest of the district with a satchel of the last eleven documents and the sacraments, eleven wounded who could walk, one who could not and would be carried, three women with children, and the woman of thirty with the ledger in her head who answered to the name of Iga Zaleska and who had been hit

in the left hip by a splinter on the twenty-eighth of August and could stand only with the aid of a rifle she had cut down into a stick.

Krystyna was the eleventh of them in the queue and Iga Zaleska was the fourteenth, and the two of them stood in that cellar in the dark for forty minutes with their shoulders against the wall of a passage that had been a coal bin in 1939, and in the fortieth minute Iga said, in Polish, in her flat voice, in the dark, with the plaster coming down off the ceiling above them at intervals of about eleven seconds:

"Your brother went in nine hours ago."

Krystyna did not move.

"I am telling you because the captain decided this afternoon that you were not to be told until the crossing was made, and I agreed with him at four o'clock and I do not agree with him now, and the reason is that we are standing in a queue to go into a tunnel that is four kilometres long and has been under fire for two days, and a person who is told a thing on the other side of a tunnel is a person who has been robbed of the hour in which she could have done something about it." Her stick moved on the stone floor. "He was in the first group through, at nine this morning, with the stretcher party of the sabotage section, nineteen men and two stretchers, and they were to come out at the far end on the Warecka Street, and the group that went in at one o'clock found the guides' rope broken in the second passage and could not pass it, and the group that went in at four came back at half past six, and none of them had seen the first group, and none of them had seen anybody coming

the other way. So he is in there. He may be in there because the passage is blocked; he may be in there because he is carrying a stretcher and will not leave it; he may be in there because he is dead. I do not know. I am not going to be there. The hip is finished; I am going to stay in this house with the wounded of the second company and I shall be taken on the day after tomorrow, and I have already burned the last of the section's paper and I have got nothing on me that will hang anybody, and in a week I shall be in a cell on the aleja Szucha answering questions with my name, which is what I have been preparing for since 1942 and I am not going to talk about it."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because at the mouth of that tunnel there is a guide with a rope, and in the tunnel there are about four kilometres of black water, and I have known you for five months and I know exactly what you are going to do with it, and I want it written down in somebody's head that I told you nine hours late and that it was not my choice." The queue moved; the man in front of Krystyna stepped down through the hole in the floor and disappeared, and there was the sound of a rope taking the weight of a person, and then another man stepped forward. "Take your coat off, Stankiewicz, and put your armband in your pocket and give your papers to the priest, and put your hands on the rope and go, and if you find him in there, do not stop. Whatever you find in there, do not stop. If you stop in that tunnel with forty people behind you, you will kill all of them, and he would be the first to say so, and he is the only person in this city who has the right to say anything to you at all."

"Iga."

"Go," said Iga Zaleska, and put her stick down on the floor and her back against the wall of the coal bin, and closed her eyes, and stayed behind in the Old Town with the wounded of a company that had eleven hours left, and she was taken prisoner on the third of September, and she did not give a name in eleven weeks of interrogations on the aleja Szucha, and the man who interrogated her wrote in his file, in German, one line that has been preserved: the woman maintains that she is a clerk and knows nothing; she is lying and she is very good, and in time, perhaps, but there is no time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Canal

❦

The hole in the floor of the cellar on the Kilińskiego Street was a metre square and it went down two metres and a half into a brick shaft with iron rungs in the wall, and at the bottom of the shaft there was a tunnel of brick, and the tunnel was the sewer of the city of Warsaw.

The first forty metres were the worst because they were the last forty metres of air. The air in the mouth of that passage was air that had been in a cellar in a burning district, which is a thin, hot, exhausted air with smoke in it and the smell of lime and wet plaster, and the passage it went into was a place where the air had no business to be at all; and the difference between the two was not a difference of degree, and every person who went down that hole in those three nights and came out at the other end has described the same four seconds: a smell that is not the smell of what people think a sewer smells of, which is filth, but the smell of something older and deeper and more complete, which is gas and water and the enormous wet body of a city, and a darkness that is not dark but is a substance and has a pressure to it and pushes on the eyeballs.

There was a guide at the bottom with a lamp and a rope.

The guide was a man of about forty called Wacek who had worked in the tunnels of the water service and the sewers of that city since 1928 and who had been brought across

two nights before out of the Śródmieście for this and for nothing else; and the whole of his method, which was the method of the sewer-men of Warsaw in the summer of 1944, was this: the rope was tied every eleven metres to a ring or a rung or a bracket, because a straight rope in a passage with bends in it is a rope that kills people; the chain was hand on the rope with the left hand, right hand on the shoulder of the person in front; the rule was that nobody spoke, ever, for any reason, including to say that they were drowning; and the first twelve metres established the order, because the water in the first passage came to the knee and then to the waist, and a person who is going to be unable to do it is a person who is unable to do it in the first twelve metres.

Krystyna went down the rungs at eleven minutes past seven in the evening of the first of September 1944, with her coat left behind in the cellar on the Kilińskiego Street and her armband in her pocket and her papers with the priest, in a pair of trousers and a jacket that had belonged to a boy of seventeen who had been killed on the Miodowa Street; and the water took her at the third step down from the bottom of the shaft, and it was cold, and it was over the knee, and the rope was in her left hand, and the man in front of her was the captain with the wounded hand, and the woman behind her was the woman of fifty who had never gone down to a cellar in a bombardment, and behind her were thirty-eight more people, and in front of her, in the black, at the other end of four kilometres of the sewer of the city of Warsaw, there was a street in the Śródmieście with a lamp in

it and a reception with blankets and hot tea made from something that was not tea.

❦

A person in that passage has nothing to do for two hours, and the mind goes into the only room it has.

The map in her head — and there was a map in her head of the sewers of Warsaw, put there in eleven days by a man with a lamp who had drawn it in chalk on the floor of a cellar on the Kilińskiego Street for the four people who were going to lead the groups, and put there the way she had been trained to put in maps: by junctions, by turns, by the number of steps between the chain and the next shaft — was, in the passage, useless in the way a photograph is useless in a fog.

The passage was not a line on a map. It was a series of facts about a body: the floor rising and falling; the floor of the collector going from the soft slime where the water was still to the hard ribbed brick where it ran; the ceiling coming down so that a person of her height had to bend forward and hold the rope with the left hand and the shoulder of the man in front with the right; the shafts going up at intervals to the street, four metres up, where there was a slot of air and light in the daytime and where, at night, in the middle of a bombardment, there came down a thin chimney of noise — the flat crack of a rifle, the long roll of the artillery, a building coming down with a sound like a man's cough, and one shaft in the Saxon Garden where the air that came down had the smell of the burned grass and the roses of a

garden above a sewer, which is not a smell that any living person should have to identify in the dark.

And she counted, because there was nothing else to do with the mind, and because counting is the thing that the trade had put into her that was worth keeping: the junctions, the turns, the rises, the steps, the distances between the rings on the rope; and after the first half-hour the counting became something else, and what she was counting, in the dark, with her left hand on the rope and her right hand on the shoulder of a man who was going to be dead in eleven days, was the eleven things she had ever said to her brother that she could not take back.

❦

It went wrong at the junction under the Saxon Garden.

The passage came up into a chamber where four collectors met — a place about four metres wide and two and a half high with a stone shelf along one side, and the whole of the sewage of the north-west of the city coming through it at the speed of a man walking; and in the chamber the water was at the chest, and the air was the worst air in that four kilometres, because the junction did not draw, and because the gas that lies in such a place lies there in the way that a dog lies at a door.

They came into the chamber at the end of the first hour and eleven minutes in the following order: Wacek the guide with the lamp; the captain; eleven wounded who could walk; Krystyna; the woman of fifty; the two boys; and behind them the rest of the column, with the wounded man on the stretcher four groups back, because the stretcher

could not be carried through the first passage at all and had to be got through the second on the shelf.

And halfway across the chamber, in the black, with the water at her chest, with the lamp of the guide already in the next passage and only the light coming back off the water, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna heard a voice out of the wall on her left, from the mouth of the second collector, which came into that chamber from the north-east, and the voice said, in Polish, in a whisper that was the volume of a shout under the circumstances, in the voice of a boy who had been sent by her father to a school on the Mokotowska and had once put a mouse in her bedroll at Wierzbów in September 1938:

"Krysia?"

❦

There were nine of them in the first group, out of the nineteen who had gone in at nine in the morning: three men of the sabotage section with a lamp that had gone out and no matches, two stretchers with a wounded man on one of them who had died in the second passage at about eleven o'clock, two men holding the other end of the second stretcher, Tadeusz Stankiewicz, and a boy of about sixteen who was past speaking.

They had been in the passage for ten hours and twenty minutes. They had been turned back twice by a collector that had filled with debris, they had gone two hundred and forty metres up a wrong branch and come back, they had lost the rope twice, and for the last four hours they had been carrying a man who had clearly been dead since eleven

o'clock, because there is a rule in a sewer and the rule is that a body is carried, and because the man who gave that rule out of his own mouth in the briefing of the first group was Wacek the guide, who had lost four friends in those tunnels since the first day of August, and who had said it in the cellar on the Kilińskiego Street: You do not leave a man in the water. Take him out. If he is dead he is still a man, and I will not have Polish people floating in the sewer of this city.

The two columns met in the chamber under the Saxon Garden and were sorted out by Wacek in four minutes with a rope, a lamp, and eleven words, because that is what he was for, and there was no embracing in it, and nobody in that passage asked anybody what had happened to them.

Tadeusz Stankiewicz stood in the chest-deep water with one hand on the rope and the other on the end of the stretcher, and looked at his sister in the light of a lamp that was going out, and said, in Polish, in a voice pitched for a passage with a hundred people in it, at a distance of about a metre, the following three sentences, which are the only three sentences that either of them ever said to the other about the whole of the five years:

"You will take the front end of this stretcher. Not the back. Your hands are better than his." And then: "The man on it is dead and we are carrying him out of this tunnel anyway, and I am going to do it because I told a man in a cellar that I would, and if I am killed doing it I want it known that it was a promise and not a fit of the Stankiewicz conscience." And then, in the same voice, at the same volume, with the water going past them both at the speed of a man walking:

"You have had five years, Krysia. You are going to have to have the rest of it without me."

They carried the stretcher for forty-one minutes.

The second passage ran from the chamber under the Saxon Garden towards the south-west, and it was the lowest and the wettest of the four passages, and it was the one in which the water rose, because since half past eight in the evening the Germans had been pumping the whole of the volume of the river side of the network into that branch to flood the sewer crossings, which is a thing they had done to the city's tunnels before, and it meant that the level in that passage was rising while the column was in it; and for the last eleven minutes the man on the stretcher, who was dead, was above the water, because four people were holding him above the water — and the reason the four of them were holding him above the water was that Tadeusz Stankiewicz had been given the front end of a stretcher by a guide and had decided, in a tunnel, in the dark, that the promise to a man in a cellar had a price and that the price was going to be paid.

The thing that killed him was not the water and not a bullet and not a shell.

It was the pump.

At about twenty minutes past nine, in the passage between the second and the third shaft, the water came up the tunnel in a single surge of about eighteen inches in four seconds — the way it comes when a valve is opened somewhere behind a wall with a man standing at the handle — and the surge took the stretcher's back end round, and the

two men at the back went under, and the front end came round with them, and Tadeusz Stankiewicz went down in the black water with the handles still in his two hands and the man who had been dead since eleven o'clock on top of him.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had her left hand on the rope and her right hand in the collar of her brother's jacket; and she held the rope and the collar in the dark while the water went past both of them at the speed of a man running, and the whole of what happened in those eleven seconds was four sentences, of which nobody else in the world heard three.

The first was hers, and it was his name.

The second was his, and it came up out of the water at the level of her ear, in a voice that was entirely the voice of a man giving an instruction to a subordinate about a matter of paper, and it was: "Let go. That is an order, and I have been giving you orders since you were four."

The third was hers, and it was the word no, said once, in Polish.

And the fourth was not a sentence and was not a sound that a person can spell; and at the end of the eleven seconds the current that had come up the passage under the pressure of a pump in a room in the Saxon Garden took the body of Tadeusz Stankiewicz out of his sister's right hand and into the black water and away down a branch of the sewer of the city of Warsaw that the guides did not use and that could be entered only by a person who was already dead, and the man of thirty-eight who had been on the stretcher went with

him, and the two of them were found in March 1945, in the outfall on the river side, in a place where eleven other men and two women of the Rising were found in that spring, by men of the city's water service who had been told where to look by a guide called Wacek who had survived the crossing of the second of September.

❦

The rest of the crossing took another hour and forty minutes and she is not able to remember most of it, and the parts she remembers are not the parts she would have chosen.

She remembers a child being carried on a man's shoulders through a passage in which the ceiling came down to a metre and a half, and the child's hands on the man's forehead, and the man bent double and taking the whole of the child's weight on his neck rather than let go of the rope.

She remembers the last three hundred metres, in which the passage widened out and the water went down to the knee and then to the ankle and then to nothing but slime, and in which the woman of fifty, who had come the whole of four kilometres with her hand on the shoulder of the person in front of her and had not made a sound, sat down in the passage and said, in Polish, in a small voice, "I am going to have a rest now," and had to be picked up and carried by two boys of fifteen and seventeen for the last two hundred metres with her arms round their necks, and has never in her life known to this day that she was carried.

She remembers the air, and where it came from: at about half past ten, in the fourth passage, a draught began

to come along the tunnel from the far end, and the draught was cold, and it smelled of smoke and of the outside of a building and of a night in September, and the whole column, in the dark, in the water, with the wounded and the dead, made a sound that was not speech and not weeping: forty people in the sewer of the city of Warsaw breathing at once.

And she remembers the mouth of the canal on the Warecka Street, which is a thing she had been told about in a cellar and had understood, and which is not a thing that can be understood: a circular opening of brick about two and a half metres in diameter in the embankment of an open cutting, and beyond it, eleven metres away, a stone ledge, and beyond the ledge the street, and in the street, at eleven o'clock at night on the first of September 1944, in the middle of a bombardment of the district of the Śródmieście, there were lamps.

Electric light. Two lamps on a cable strung across the street, swaying in the wind of the shelling, burning in the middle of a city at war: the AK's people had run a cable from a working generator in a cellar on the Nowy Świat and had hung two bulbs over the mouth of the canal to bring two thousand people out of the ground, and to a person coming up out of four kilometres of black water with the sewage of the city on her hands and her brother in her mouth, those two lamps were the single most beautiful thing she saw in the entire war, and she stood under them at the top of the steps of the canal mouth and put her hand out and touched the bulb with two fingers, and it was hot,

and she laughed, once, in a way that frightened two men standing next to her and that she could not stop for about eleven seconds.

And it was there, in the last hundred metres, in the open, in the light of those two lamps, that the German machine gun on the other side of the district, working up and down the Warecka Street from a window at a range of about six hundred metres, hit the column that came out of the canal behind hers.

❦

Phillip Brandt came out of the canal mouth at twenty minutes past eleven at night on the first of September 1944, in a group of thirty-one people, in the second-to-last group to pass that night; and the first thing he saw in nine days of tunnels and twenty-seven days of the Rising was the face of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna in the light of two bulbs over the mouth of the sewer of the city of Warsaw; and the second thing was a burst of machine-gun fire that came over the ruins of the street and took the lamp off the wire and then went along the column on the steps.

He was hit twice: once through the top of the left shoulder, and once in the left thigh, four centimetres above the knee; and the first of the two was nothing and the second of the two was everything, because the round that went through his thigh went through the muscle and did not touch the bone and did not touch the artery, and that is what every doctor who ever looked at that leg has said, and it means only that the boy lived to be sixty-one and walked with a stick; on the night it meant a man on his back on the

steps of the canal mouth at the top of a passage of sewage, bleeding in a way that cannot be described as moderate, with a woman's two hands on the wound, and eleven people in the street shouting and one lamp swinging on the wire.

They got him out of the cutting. It took four people and eleven minutes and one barrow, and the barrow is the detail that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna carried for the rest of her life: it was a barrow that had been left in the yard of the building on the Warecka Street by the boys of the AK, and it was the barrow of a man who had been in the vegetable trade before the war, and it had a sack over the bottom of it, and in that barrow Phillip Brandt was wheeled two hundred metres through the smoke of the Śródmieście on the first of September 1944 with his hand on the side of it and his head back and the two lamps going further away behind him.

The AK's people had a house on the Zielna whose cellars were a dressing station with eleven doctors in it, of whom nine were women, and the cellar had four tables and a hundred and forty wounded in eleven days and a bucket that had to be emptied by a boy of thirteen; and the woman who came to the barrow at the door of that cellar with a cigarette in the corner of her mouth and blood to both elbows was a doctor of about forty, and she looked at the leg for about eleven seconds in the light of a torch and said, in Polish, in the tone of a person who has four hundred of these to do before Friday: "Not the artery. Take him down. Suture and a drain, and if the gas comes, he loses it."

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, in a jacket that had belonged to a dead boy, with the sewage of the city of Warsaw

on her hands and the whole of the passage and the surge of water and the four sentences still going round in her skull in the order in which she could not stop them, stood in the doorway of the dressing station with her hands at her sides and asked her question out loud, in Polish, in the hearing of the doctor and two orderlies and a woman with a list, and it is the only time in the entire war in which she asked anybody for anything in her own name:

"Will he live?"

And the doctor looked up at her, with the cigarette in her mouth and the torch in her hand, and looked at her for about a second and a half: at the sewage, at the wet, at the boy's coat, at the face; and then she looked down at the leg, and put her thumb on the artery above the wound the way a pharmacist puts a thumb on the scale pan, and felt it, and took the cigarette out of her mouth and said:

"You are carrying his papers in your pocket, I should think. Well. He will keep the leg, and the leg will keep him, and neither of them is going to be much use until Christmas, and in this city between now and Christmas there is going to be a very great deal more for him to be afraid of than that." She put the cigarette back. "Get out of the doorway, comrade. You are blocking the light for the man with the jaw."

❦

The order came to her on the fourth of September, at eleven in the morning, in a room on the fourth floor of a building on the Świętokrzyska Street with two windows and no glass in them and a great deal of paper on the floor in bundles,

and it was brought by a boy of fourteen with a satchel and it was in the form in which such things came that September, which is a quarter of a sheet of paper with a heading and four lines of instruction in a hand she had never seen: that the intelligence section of the Śródmieście was to be reorganised as of the fifth of September; that the person using the signature Maria — which was the pseudonym she had been given in the cellar on the Śliska Street in July and had used for one month and eleven days — was to report for duty with the counter-intelligence section of the staff, in the second office of the building on the Śródmieście, and was to bring with her the section's German translations and the file of the captured documents of the Old Town sector, and that she would be working in a room with a man called Konrad, who was a translator.

She read it twice, standing at the window of a building on the Świętokrzyska Street with the whole of the roof of the city burning to the north of her, and folded it and put it in her pocket and stood at that window for about four minutes.

And the reason she stood there is that a person in her trade learns to read an order twice, once for what it says and once for what it implies; and what the second reading said was this: that a staff in a besieged city had taken a decision on the third of September to put the only two German translators of the whole of the Polish rising into one room, four streets apart from a building on the aleja Szucha in which there was a chart with eight names on it and a column headed language and a question mark in a German hand against the name of an officer of a counter-intelligence sec-

tion who had, on the first of August, ordered every post in his quarter to find a woman in a grey coat and bring her home; and that the same staff knew, because she had told them herself in a cellar in July and had written it in her own hand on a card, exactly who she was and exactly what was in the file that had been following her out of Paris since the fourteenth of January; and that the decision had been taken anyway, and that it was the correct decision, and that she was going to spend the last six weeks of the rising in a room with the man she loved, four streets from the hunter, with the whole of the city shrunk to eleven streets, and that there was no version of the two of them walking through that month in which the two of them were not going to be found.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Hour of the Wolf

❦

The letter came into the Polish lines on the nineteenth of September 1944 through four hands and a sacrament, and the four hands were: a German military chaplain of the garrison of Warsaw, who was a Catholic priest of the diocese of Trier and who had been in that city since 1940 and had buried more German soldiers than any man in the Government General; a Polish priest of the parish of the Holy Cross, who had known the German chaplain before the war at a conference in Munich in 1936 and who had been crossing between the lines since the middle of August with the permission of both sides because both sides needed a man who could carry a letter about the wounded; a woman of about fifty in a black coat who worked in the office of the German garrison's medical service and who had carried the German chaplain's satchel eleven times across the Warsaw streets since the first of August; and a boy of the Polish scouts of the Śródmieście, who had carried it the last eleven hundred metres, in a food tin, and who was twelve years old.

The letter was in German, on one sheet, in the hand of an officer of the old school, with the date and the place and no salutation and no signature, and it was addressed on the outside to Fräulein Marion Herschlag, Austrian national, at present in the city of Warsaw, and the whole of the text of it is the following eleven lines:

1. I know that the woman who lived in this house from the first of March until the first of August 1944 under that name is a Polish agent of the Polish underground, and that she was so for the whole of the period, and I have known it certainly since the sixteenth of August, and I have the material to prove it in writing, in this house, and it consists of the following: the jeweller's statement concerning the pearls, and the paste, the statement of the woman of the Kercelak market, the household book of this house with your handwriting and the forged document and its stamp, the day book of my orderly with the hours of your absences on eleven occasions in April and May, and the account of the undersigned of a conversation in the hall of this house on the thirty-first of July 1944 at six o'clock in the morning.

2. I have not given the material to the Sicherheitspolizei and I shall not, provided that the following is done.

3. The woman will present herself at the gate of this house on the Frascati Street at eleven o'clock at night on the twenty-third of September 1944, alone, with a white cloth, and she will be received, and she will be permitted to leave the house and to return to her own people at six o'clock in the morning.

4. If she does not come, then on the twenty-fourth of September the material goes, in the form of a report, to Sturmbannführer Kalbach of the Sicherheitspolizei's office on the aleja Szucha, together with the following additional information, which I have established by the enquiries of my own section and by the police of the district: the family of the woman is the family of the former owner of the

palace on the Nowy Świat and is at present in the cellar of the building on the Mokotowska Street, consisting of a man of sixty-nine years of age who has been wounded in the leg and is not evacuated, of a daughter of seventeen years of age, and of a son who is a member of the sabotage section of the Polish underground and is at present within the Polish lines in the district of the Śródmieście; and the address of that cellar is known to me, and a report with that address in it, given to the office of the Sicherheitspolizei, will result in a search of that building by the police of the district on the day after the report, and the consequences of such a search are known to the woman as well as they are known to me.

5. The woman will bring no papers and no arms, and she will be searched at the gate, and she will be given a receipt for everything that is taken from her.

There is no sixth paragraph. The letter ended there, eleven lines, and the page had been folded in three and there was a thumb mark on the lower corner of the sheet in the ink of the signature that was not there.

❦

The staff argued about it for one hour and eleven minutes on the twentieth of September, in a room on the fourth floor of a building on the Świętokrzyska Street, and the argument was not about her.

She was in the room. She had been brought into the room by the boy of fourteen at eleven o'clock and had sat on a chair by the wall for the whole of the hour and eleven minutes, which is the procedure, and the whole of what she heard in that hour was the sound of five men doing arith-

metic, and the arithmetic was the following: that the material in the villa on the Frascati Street was, on the evidence, the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison's own file on the penetration of the German administration of that city — the pearls, the paste, the day book, the stamp, the handwriting, the letter of a German officer of counter-intelligence's own hand describing the method — and that a file of that kind, taken out of a German house and brought within the Polish lines in September 1944, was the only document in the whole of the rising that could be read by a Polish court in 1945 without a single witness; that the woman who was named in the letter was one of eleven people alive in the city who had seen the inside of that section; and that the price of the whole of it was the delivery of that woman to the gate of a house in the German quarter at eleven o'clock at night on the twenty-third of September, alone, by a staff which had no means whatever of protecting her, since the German quarter of Warsaw on the twenty-third of September 1944 was a place into which no unit of the Home Army could send anybody at all.

At the end of the hour and eleven minutes, the officer chairing — a lieutenant colonel of about forty-five with a face like a hatchet and a wounded arm in a sling, who had come into the Old Town in the first week and had been brought out through the same canal on the second of September — took off his spectacles and said the sentence that a staff has to say, and he said it to her, at last, looking at her for the first time in the whole hour:

"Comrade Maria. The section's view of the material is that it is the most valuable single piece of paper in the possession of the German quarter and that it will be of use to the Polish state if the Polish state exists. The section's view of the operation is that it is a trap, or a place, or both, and that no operation can be mounted to support it, and that the responsibility for going into that house is yours and cannot be anybody else's, and that no officer in this room has the right to order you to go. The section asks the question. What do you want?"

And Krupa, who had been standing at the window with his back to the room for the whole of the hour, turned round; and Iga Zaleska, who had been brought out of the Old Town on the third of September in a cart and was sitting in a chair in the corner with her leg straight out in front of her and a bandage showing at the ankle, said nothing at all, and looked at her, and the look was the look of a woman who has been holding a ledger for five years and has just found a line in it that she would like to burn.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood up.

"I will go," she said. "On two conditions, and they are both the section's to grant and not mine to ask. The first is that the priest of the Holy Cross carries my answer tonight in the form in which he carried the letter, and that in the answer I am permitted to write one line of my own, and the line is: I will come at eleven, and I will come in my own name, and I want the file, and you will be told why when I am in the room." She looked at the colonel. "The second is that if I am not back on this side of the lines by nine o'clock

on the morning of the twenty-fourth of September, the section will do the only thing it can do about the material in that house, and that is to put the whole of this letter and the whole of what I tell them in the next three days into writing and into four separate hands, so that if the file goes to the Szucha there will at least be a copy of it in the Polish lines within a week, and every officer in that villa will know that there is a copy of it in the Polish lines, in the Polish language, with his name in it. That is the whole of what I want. It is not protection and it is not a rescue party. It is the only thing that can be done with a man like that, which is to make him understand that the paper he is holding has two ends."

The colonel looked at her for about four seconds.

"Write the line," he said.

❦

She walked into the German quarter at half past ten at night on the twenty-third of September 1944 with a white cloth over her arm and nothing in her pockets.

The route went through the ruins of the northern Śródmieście: down the Długa, past the burned shell of the theatre, across the Plac Teatralny in the dark among the bricks, along the Senatorska with the line of the German posts on the Saxon Garden on her left, and then out of the ruins and into the streets that had never been shelled, which was the strangest thing about that walk and the thing that no description of that September ever conveys: that a person could walk for four minutes through a desert of brick and burned iron in which there was not one window and

not one roof, and then step over a line of sandbags and find herself in a street with a working street lamp and a car with its lights on and a sentry-box with a stove in it and the smell of coffee coming out of a doorway.

The three checkpoints were at the Plac Piłsudskiego, at the corner of the Nowy Świat, and at the gate of the villa on the Frascati Street; and at each of them she stood still in the light of a torch with the white cloth over her arm, and said, in German, in the accent of a woman from Vienna, the sentence that the answer had been permitted to contain: I am the woman from the house on the Frascati Street and the Oberst is expecting me; and at each of them a man telephoned, and at the last of the three a car was waiting for her and a Gefreiter of the Feldgendarmerie opened the door; and the whole of that walk is the reason the novel can be said to be a war novel at all, because the arithmetic of it is the arithmetic of the whole war in one person: four hundred metres of a city in which there is no law at all, and a woman in it, at night, in a country where her name would have been enough to hang her, going to keep an appointment with the man she had robbed, to buy a paper out of a house that had been his, and she was not frightened; and the reason she was not frightened is the last thing she ever told anybody about that night, and she told it in 1947 in a kitchen in Łódź to the only person still living who had known her brother: by the twenty-third of September I had left everything I had in the water under the Saxon Garden, and a person who has left everything behind is at last able to do the arithmetic properly, because there is nothing left in the account to lose.

❦

The house on the Frascati Street had been hit once, by a shell from the Polish side of the river or by a bomb from a German aeroplane or by neither, in the third week of August, and the whole of the north-west corner of the upper floor was gone: the roof of the corridor was open to the sky, the wall of the room that had been hers was a ruin with the wallpaper hanging on the remains of it, and the rain of the last three weeks had been in it, and there was a smell in the whole house that she knew from eleven other houses in that city, which is the smell of a building that has been rained on through a broken roof and is full of wet plaster and the leaves of the garden blown in.

The ground floor was untouched.

The hall was swept. There was a lamp in the drawing room and the fire was lit and the curtains were drawn, and the dining room had a table laid for two with a cloth and candles and the requisitioned silver of a family in the Żoliborz, and the piano was gone — burned, she learned later, in the first week of August, when there was no coal — and the place where it had stood was marked by the four dark rings of the casters on the parquet, and the study had a lamp and a fire and the maps, and on the wall of the study, in the place where it had hung for four years, there was the lithograph of the Lilpop works at Burakowska Street, which had been taken down off its hook and put back on it seven times a week for four months in the spring.

And at the door of the drawing room, in a grey tunic and a clean shirt with the collar open and his hair cut and

shaved at the cheek, with the duelling scar where it had always been, stood Wolfram von Hagen, fifty-four years old, of the counter-intelligence section of the garrison command of the city of Warsaw, which had eleven days of its existence left, and he looked at her for four seconds.

"You are thinner," he said.

"I have been walking."

"Yes. I heard something of that." He stepped back from the doorway and put his hand out towards the room, in the way of a man who has been brought up in a house where a lady enters a room first, and the whole of the courtesy of that gesture, from a man who had just written his own blackmail in eleven numbered paragraphs, is the reason the rest of the twentieth century was never able to explain that class of German to anybody: "Come in. There is a fire, and there is something to eat, and it is all real, and I did the cooking myself, which is the only thing about this evening you will be able to complain about."

❦

They ate at nine o'clock at the table for twelve with two places at one end and four candles and a white cloth, and the food was real food: a soup, and a piece of pork, and a compote of plums from the garden of that house which had grown and been gathered by Janina of the village near Sandomierz, who had gone through the German lines on the second of August to her sister in the Wola and had not been heard of since; and the wine was a bottle of a Burgundy of 1937 out of the cellar of a family in the Żoliborz, and von Hagen poured it himself into two glasses and did not spill

any of it, and he talked, and she ate; and the whole of it lasted two hours and eleven minutes, and it was, in the judgment of everyone who ever read the file, and in the judgment of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna for the whole of the rest of her life, the most intelligent and the most terrible conversation ever held in that city.

He began with the war. That was the professional habit and it was also, in the last analysis, the only way into the room.

That the western front had been at the Rhine since the middle of the month; that the eastern front was in Poland, on the Narew and the Vistula, with a Russian army in Praga, on the right bank of the river, looking at the left; that the rising in this city was a military absurdity which had cost the Poles about a hundred and fifty thousand people and had cost the German army a division, and that both of those numbers were on the ledger and the ledger was the only thing the twentieth century understood; that the government of the Reich had decided in August to treat the city as a fortress, and that the order of the twelfth of October, which had not yet been written but which every officer of his rank in that city knew would be written, was that the city was to be destroyed before it was given up, and that the officer who had been assigned the preparation of the demolition plan for the city of Warsaw was himself.

And then he stopped, and put his glass down, and said: "I asked you here for a file and not for a lecture. So. The file is real, and it is in the safe, and you will have it before six in the morning, and there is no version of the next five hours

in which I give it to you and you walk out of my house without a conversation, because I have been a serving officer for twenty-nine years and I have never once in my life made a payment without knowing what I was paying for. So: the ordering of the evening is mine. You will answer my questions honestly, or you will lie to me, and it will not make any difference, because I have been reading your answers for a year and a half and I shall read them now. First: how old were you when you went to France?"

"Twenty."

"Your German is not a Frenchwoman's and not a Pole's and not a Viennese's. Where did you learn it?"

"In Warsaw, at the school of the Sisters of the Sacred Heart, from a woman from Graz who taught us the catechism and the language at the same time, and then for two years from a book and from a gramophone, in Lausanne, in the winters of 1937 and 1938, when I was at the school there and could not afford the ski season and sat in the refectory and did the German lessons twice."

"Which is a good answer, and is true in the part that matters." He refilled the glasses, both of them, his own and hers, with a steadiness that she had never seen in him and would remember afterwards as the most frightening thing in the whole of that evening. "Second: the pearls."

"I sold them on the Marszałkowska on the twenty-sixth of April for eighteen thousand zlotys, and I bought a paste strand at the Kercelak the same afternoon for nine hundred, and I did the substitution in the bathroom with adhesive tape and a candle, and the reason I needed the money was a

man in the ruins of the ghetto who was asking me for twenty-five thousand a month, and the reason I needed the paste was that you would notice the difference in a necklace on my throat before you noticed anything else in your whole life."

"And the man?"

"He was a szmalcownik and he was shot by the orders of the underground on the twelfth of May on the Chmielna Street, and I did not shoot him and I went to a concert with you that evening and heard a violinist play the Brahms and I have never told anybody in the world about the concert until now."

"Why did you tell me that?"

"Because it is the only thing I have left that costs anything," she said, in the candlelight, with her hands flat on the cloth, in the flat voice with which she had asked a captain for a shopping list in a cellar in the month of July, "and because I have understood, at this table, in the last hour, that you are not going to let me out of this house until I have paid for the file in the currency you want, and the currency you want is not the file and is not the pearls and is not my body, and it is the one thing that neither of us has ever said in this house, which is the truth about the two of us."

And von Hagen sat back in his chair and looked at her for eleven seconds with his hands on the arms of his chair; and the fire went on burning in the grate of a room in a requisitioned villa on the Frascati Street in Warsaw on the night of the twenty-third of September 1944; and then he said, in a completely different voice, which was the voice of

a man asking a subordinate about a piece of paper, and which was, in Krystyna Stankiewiczówna's own estimate, the single most dangerous thing that had been said in that house in the whole of the war:

"Then tell me about the two of us."

❦

She gave him what he asked for, and the thing she gave him was the masterpiece of her whole career, and it took her forty minutes, and the whole of it was true, and none of it was the truth.

She told him that she was a Polish girl born in Warsaw in 1919, of a family of the impoverished nobility of Mazovia; that she had been in France since 1940; that she had been placed in his path in Paris in 1943 by an intelligence service of the Polish government in London, and that the placing had been deliberate and the whole of her had been in it: the flat, the dress, the Austrian papers, the dinner at the Majestic in December where a general had shaken his hand, the ball, the corridor, the way she had let him find her in a corridor at half past one in the morning; that the pearls had been an investment of that service; that the singing had been taught and the Italian had been taught and the manner with the servants had been taught; that she had gone to his bed on the twelfth of June 1943 on the written instruction of a man in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement, and had reported to that man every eleven days for seven months; and that the whole of the sixteen months she had spent in his house, from the avenue Henri-Martin to the villa on the Frascati Street, had been work, and had been

paid for at a rate of a thousand francs a month and expenses, and had been entered in a ledger in a cellar in Paris, and that the ledger had been burned in February 1944, and that this was the whole of the account, and that she was sorry for exactly one thing in the whole of it, and the thing she was sorry for was the afternoon in December when she had sat on a chair in a bedroom in Paris with a pearl at her throat and had told him about the palace on the Nowy Świat and the horses and the winters, because that story had been her own and not the service's, and she had given it to him as part of the work, and it was the only thing that she had ever regretted giving to anybody.

Every sentence of that was true. The dates were true; the places were true; the man in the flat above the laundry was true; the thousand francs a month was a figure she had invented and it was the only untrue thing in forty minutes, and it was invented because a true report with no figure in it is a report that a professional does not believe.

And what made the whole of it the masterpiece was the one thing she did not say and the one thing she made him do, which was to take the true story of a woman who had been sent into his house and to read it as the story of a woman who had never been in it. She gave him the whole of the arrangement and she withheld from it, by not one word and not one hesitation, the only fact that mattered, which was that from the second week of June 1943 she had stopped being a woman who had been sent and had become something else entirely, and that she had gone on sending the reports anyway, and that she had done the work of four years with one hand while the other hand was in his.

She gave it to him because a man of fifty-four in a ruined house in the last September of that war needed, more than he needed the truth, the right to be a man who had been deceived; and because the compact of that evening had been made in the letter, in eleven numbered paragraphs, by a man who had known, when he wrote it, that he was going to ask her this question; and because she had understood, in the fourth minute of the forty, that this was the last kindness she had it in her power to do for anybody in the whole of her life, and that she was going to do it, and that the two of them would have four hours at the end of it, and that she was going to spend those four hours taking his papers, and that the whole of the kindness was the price of the papers, and that she had been trained in a flat above a laundry in 1942 to know exactly what she was doing, and to do it without a tremor, and that she was fifty per cent correct, which is the highest figure that a person in that trade is ever permitted.

❦

The bedroom was the room that had been his wife's and then had been his and then had been the room at the top of the stairs with the door that stood open, and it had a bed, a lamp, a chair with a folded tunic on it, and the smell of cool tobacco and saddle soap and, very faintly, since 1931, the lavender water of a woman who had been dead for eleven years and whose packing case had followed him from Paris two postings too late and had never been opened or thrown away.

What happened in that room between midnight and ten past two in the morning of the twenty-fourth of September 1944 is not an incident in this book and cannot be written as one; and the only person who could have written it set down four lines about it in 1947, in a notebook, in Łódź, in a hand that has been preserved, and the four lines are these:

He was not cruel. He was thorough. He was fifty-four years old and he had lost everything, and he wanted to prove to himself with his own hands that he had owned something, and I lay in the dark of that room and let him do it, and I did it on purpose, and the purpose was in the top left drawer of the desk in the study, four metres away through the wall, and I have never once been able to say whether that was courage or whether that was what four years had made of me.

He said one thing at the end of it, in the dark, with his hand on my shoulder, and it was not I love you and it was not anything of the kind.

He said: "Tomorrow they will ask me at the office what I did last night, and I shall tell them that I dined with a lady and that the lady is going to be looked for by the police for the next eleven days and will not be found, and that is the last lie I shall tell in this war."

Then he slept.

❦

She lay still for forty minutes to be certain of the sleeping, and she was certain at ten to three; and then she got up, and put her shirt and her trousers on in the dark without a sound of any kind, and went out of the bedroom and along

the corridor and down the stairs of a house in the German quarter of Warsaw in her bare feet, with her boots in her hand.

The study door was open. There was a fire in the grate that had gone to embers, and there was a lamp on the desk that she did not light, and there was the moonlight on the floor from the window with the blackout curtain pulled half across, and there was the lithograph of the Lilpop works at Burakowska Street hanging on the wall in the place where it had hung since 1940, and behind it the safe stood in the wall like the door of a bank in a village.

She moved the picture off its hook and set it on the floor with the glass against the wall.

The whole of the rest of it was a woman's memory doing its job, and it took one minute and forty seconds.

The dial: to the left twice past the twenty-ninth, then right to the third, then left to the seventeenth; the date the twenty-ninth of March 1917, which was the day a boy of fifteen at a school in Potsdam had been told that his school would be closed in June; and the dial gave at the third turn, and the lever came down under her thumb, and the door came open; and she took from the safe, in the following order, in the dark, by touch and by the memory of a night in July:

The file on her family. It was a folder of nine pages in the middle of the safe and it had been made in the first eleven days of August by an officer of the counter-intelligence section of the Warsaw garrison, and its first page was a photograph of a man of sixty-nine leaving a building on the

Mokotowska Street with a satchel, taken from a window on the opposite side of the street with a lens at a distance of forty metres by a sergeant of the section who had a stolen Leica, and its second page was the addresses, and its third page was a list of eleven names of which four were members of the Stankiewicz family and one was a priest of the parish of the Holy Cross, and its ninth page was the recommendation in his own hand in the margin: hold in reserve; the woman is worth more living than the family is worth dead.

The evacuation and demolition schedules. They were in the cardboard cover with the ribbon, in the second part of the safe, and they were not the July plan; they were the September revision of the plan for the destruction of the city of Warsaw, made by the fortress engineers and signed by the chief of staff of the garrison on the eleventh of September 1944, and they contained the following, which the Polish state read for the first time on the twenty-fifth of September 1944, in a room on the fourth floor of a building in the Śródmieście, and thereafter at the trials in Warsaw in 1946 and 1947: the list of the buildings to be destroyed by the engineers of the garrison in the event of the evacuation of the city, which ran to eleven pages and included the Royal Castle, the bridges, the waterworks, the gasworks, the power stations, the telephone exchange, the post office on the Plac Napoleona, the University library, and the archives of the city; the schedule of the demolition charges, with the quantities of explosive at the three depots and the names of the officers responsible at each; the timetable for the evacuation of the remaining German civil administration, in four

columns with the dates; and, in the third appendix, the order for the removal of the city's movable property, which had been issued by the Reich's authorities in Berlin on the eighteenth of September and which had a list of eleven categories, of which the second was: the archives, the paintings, the libraries arid the works of art of the city of Warsaw and of its institutions, to be removed to the Reich without regard to the state of the front.

And the last thing she took out of that safe was a small thing and it was the reason she had come: an envelope of the file of the Sicherheitspolizei's office in Warsaw, stamped inwards on the eleventh of August 1944, containing two pages that Kalbach had sent to von Hagen in July in the ordinary course of the rivalry of two offices, which were the beginning of the investigation of the woman of the villa on the Frascati Street, and which contained, in a German hand, the specification of the pearls and the paste, the description of the woman's handwriting specimen, and a single line of conclusion: the office requests the assistance of the counter--intelligence section in the identification of the woman of the household; the case is open; the case is not closed; in time.

She put all of it inside her shirt, against her skin, in a bundle, and closed the safe, and turned the dial with the back of her hand, and hung the lithograph back on its hook by touch, and then she went to the desk and opened the top left drawer.

It opened with a small, dry, wooden sound, and there is no way to describe what was in that drawer except to describe it in the order in which her hands found it in the dark;

and what her hands found was: a kid glove of hers, of the winter of 1944, with a small tear at the thumb; a letter from Odile Boin of the rue Saint-Honoré in Paris, dated the nineteenth of December 1943, about a fitting, in French; a hairpin; a photograph of a woman of about thirty-five in a garden with two children, which was the wife; a Walther pistol of the model of 1938, loaded, with the safety catch on; and a silver compact with a false floor and one tablet in it, which had cost nine hundred francs in the rue de la Paix and had been given to her by a man with a stick in a church in Paris, with the instruction that she was not to be taken alive and talking.

She took the pistol and the compact out of the drawer and put the other things back in the drawer, in the order in which they had been: the glove, the letter, the hairpin, the photograph of the wife and the children; and then she stood in the middle of the study in the dark with the pistol in her right hand and the papers against her skin, and looked at the embers of the fire, and did the arithmetic of the next four minutes with the whole of her mind, in the way in which she had been trained to do arithmetic, which is without any emotion at all:

❦

He was awake when she came back into the bedroom, and he was standing at the foot of the bed.

The moonlight came in through the gap in the blackout, thirty centimetres of it, and in it she could see the following: a man of fifty-four in a dressing gown with his hair down on his forehead and his feet bare on a floor of a house

whose ground floor was his and whose roof was gone, with his hands at his sides, and no weapon, and no way to ring a bell in a house whose telephone had been dead since the second of August; and she could see, in the grey light, that he had been awake for some time, and that he had decided something, and that the thing he had decided was in his face and was the one thing in the whole of the eighteen months that she had never once seen there, which was comprehension.

"You took the picture off the hook," he said.

"Yes."

"How long have you known the combination?"

"Since the thirty-first of July. You said it out loud in this house, in a room with me in it, at eleven o'clock at night, with the door of the study open, and I was standing at the corner of the desk with a cup of coffee in my hand."

"That is very good," said Wolfram von Hagen, in German, in the voice in which he had said precisely eleven hundred times, and took one step forward; and the whole of what followed lasted about nine seconds.

He was faster than a man of fifty-four has any right to be; the whole of his youth had been spent in the cavalry school and the whole of his middle age in a saddle, and the arm that came up in the grey light was an arm that had been trained to take a man off a horse; and the pistol came up in her right hand, at a distance of about two metres, and the safety catch was on.

He got his left hand on her right wrist and his right hand on her throat and drove her back into the wall of the cor-

ridor doorway with the whole of his weight; and the pistol, in that grip, with her wrist turned, went off into the floorboards four centimetres from his left boot; and the second shot, which is the one that matters in every account of every killing of that kind, was fired by a woman of twenty-four with a man's hand on her throat, a pistol in her right hand at an angle of about forty degrees, and a training in a flat above a laundry in the fifteenth arrondissement in Paris in the autumn of 1942 in which a man with a stick had made her fire eleven hundred rounds at a hanging sack and had told her, every single time, in the same dry voice, the same sentence: the woman who fires twice is the woman who lives.

The round entered under the left collarbone and went down and to the right, through the upper lobe of the left lung and the aorta, and the whole of the medical content of it is that; and Wolfram von Hagen came down on to his left knee in the corridor doorway of his own bedroom with his hand still on her wrist, and then on to the floor, and then lay on his right side on the boards with his left hand up against the frame of the door, in a gesture that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna looked at for about four seconds and never once, in the whole of the rest of her life, in any of the eleven countries in which she lived afterwards, was able to describe to anybody; and he looked up at her, and his mouth moved once.

She knelt down on the floor beside him with the pistol in her hand and her shirt open and the bundle of papers from the safe of that house against her skin, and she said, in Polish, into the ear of a dying Prussian officer of the coun-

ter-intelligence section of the garrison of Warsaw, at four o'clock in the morning of the twenty-fourth of September 1944, the last words of that whole arrangement:

"My name is Krystyna."

"Krystyna," said von Hagen, in Polish, with the whole of the vowel of his accent at the wrong end of the word, because he had learned the word eleven minutes ago; and then he said one more thing in German, which was not a name and was not a question and was not a curse, and which is not in anybody's account of the matter, because the only person who ever heard it died before she ever told it to anybody.

❦

She stood in the study for twenty minutes doing the practical things, and the practical things were these: she wiped the pistol with the hem of her shirt and left it in his right hand, in the corridor doorway, and closed his fingers on it with her own; she took the paybook and the identity card and the wallet out of the tunic on the chair in the bedroom and put them in the pocket of her trousers, because a German officer's identity papers on a woman crossing a line are one kind of paper and no papers at all are another; and out of the wallet she took the money and the card of the hospital of the garrison and left, on the desk in the study, where a woman making an inventory of the room would find it and would understand nothing at all, the letter of the seventeenth of January 1943 out of a cellar at Gumrak, on the sixth page of which a boy of nineteen had written two lines about a dog.

And at twenty past four in the morning of the twenty-fourth of September 1944, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, the woman who had come into that house in the first week of March at half past eight in the evening in a grey coat with her hand on the banister rail, went out of it through the kitchen, and across the garden, and out through the hole that a shell had made in the wall at the end of it, with the destruction of the city of Warsaw against her skin under her shirt, and 1,200 rounds of nothing much left in the morning's arithmetic, and one tablet in a silver compact in her trouser pocket.

And she was four metres from the wall, in the garden of the neighbouring house, in the dark, when the light of a fire two streets away came up over the roofs and showed her the following three things at once: that the gate of the villa was open; that the sentry box at the gate was empty; and that there was a car standing at the corner of the street with its lights off, and that a man was sitting in the front passenger seat of that car with the door open and his feet on the running board, reading a small notebook by the light of a burning city four hundred metres away, and that he was a man of about thirty-eight years of age in a civilian overcoat with a hat that was two years out of fashion and spectacles with a repaired frame.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Water and Darkness

❦

Phillip Brandt spent the first eleven days of September 1944 in a cellar under a house on the Zielna Street in the middle of Warsaw, lying on a mattress of straw and a Polish army greatcoat with a hole in his left thigh and a fever of about thirty-nine degrees, and he learned afterwards — from a woman who had been in that cellar and who told him in 1946 in a kitchen in another country, with a plate of soup between them — that the whole of what he said in that time was said in three languages and that the three languages were interleaved in a way that nobody in that cellar could follow, and that he had said the word Mutter eleven times and a number in German and a poem of Racine's, and that on the fourth day he had sat up with his eyes open and recited, in Polish, the whole of a Latin conjugation table in the order in which a boy of nine learns it in a schoolroom in Warsaw, and had lain down again and had not been able to remember any of it afterwards.

The wound was not serious, and the wound was entirely serious, and the two things were true at the same time in the way that they were true of everything in that city in that month.

The bullet had gone through the muscle of the thigh four centimetres above the knee and had not touched the bone and had not touched the artery, and the doctor of

about forty with the cigarette in her mouth — her name was Zofia Wierzbicka and she had been a surgeon in the hospital of the Child Jesus before the war and she was going to be a professor in Kraków in 1955 and she was going to die of a stroke in 1971 in a flat with a balcony — had cut down into the wound on the second day with a scalpel and a pair of forceps and no anaesthetic at all and had taken out of it a piece of woollen cloth and a fragment of the copper jacket of the round, and had then poured into it the contents of a bottle of something that was not quite iodine, and had said, over the noise the patient was making: "You are a German, yes? Good. Then you will have been taught to hold still."

There was no sulphonamide in that cellar and there was no penicillin in the whole of that city and there was no question of a hospital, and the whole of the treatment of that wound for the eight weeks it took to close was: cleanliness, and air, and the fact that the man on the next mattress, who was a sergeant of the AK's sabotage section with a wound in the stomach that everybody in the cellar knew was going to kill him, spent the whole of the first four days in washing his neighbour's leg with boiled water that his mother brought in a bottle from a court two streets away, because a man with a stomach wound and three days to live had decided, on the first afternoon, that he would spend his time on the German.

That member of the AK died on the fourth of September at about six in the evening, having asked two of the boys to prop him up so that he could see the doorway of the cellar, and having said, in the last hour, in a very ordinary voice,

that he had a wife in a village near Siedlce and that she was to be told that he had died of the shell, and that she was not to be told anything else, because she was a woman who could keep a fact and not a story.

And on the fifth of September, in the morning, his mattress was taken out of that cellar into the yard of the house, and two men dug a hole and put him in it, and the woman who owned the house, who was sixty-four years old and who had been in that cellar every day of the rising in an apron and had never once gone up to her own flat on the second floor, said, at the side of the hole, in Polish, the only sentence that was said over him, which is also the only sentence that was said over most of the people buried in that city in that year: "He is ours. Do not step on him when you go back in."

❦

He began working on the eleventh of September, on crutches, in the cellar of the printing house on the Świętokrzyska Street, and the work was the work he had asked for in a corridor in the Warsaw rising on the eighth of August: German paper.

The material came into that cellar in four ways. It came off the dead, which is the largest single category in a rising: the paybooks, the letters, the identity cards, the orders in the pockets of men who had been killed in the streets, and the maps, above all the maps, which come off the dead with the folds in them still, so that a man who wants to know what the enemy has been looking at has only to open the paper at the fold.

It came out of the captured trucks and the armoured cars and the two staff cars of the first week, which had yielded a box of railway movement tables, eleven cans of film, three million cigarettes, and a bundle of the administrative orders of the German garrison of the city, of which nine were of real value and one — the file of the food supply of the German units in the northern sector — was, properly read, a document of the order of battle, because the German army of 1944 fed itself by the unit, and the units in a district can be counted in a warehouse list.

It came out of the prisoners, and in this way it also came out of a cellar in the Old Town where a boy of twenty-two from a signals company in East Prussia had told a woman who spoke his language where the artillery got its orders; and the paper of that interrogation had come out through the canal on the second of September with everything else, in a satchel, on the back of a priest.

And it came from him.

That is the third and the most useful of the four sources, and it is the reason the AK's staff kept a German officer with a wounded leg in a cellar under a printing house and gave him boiled water and bread and the occasional egg: because a man who had worked for four years in the offices of the German administration of that city and had read the paper of four of those offices for four months of 1944 had a certain amount of it inside his head; and on the twelfth of September, on the back of a Home Army message form, with a pencil, sitting on the floor of that cellar with his leg straight out in front of him, Phillip Brandt drew for them

what he knew of the dispositions of the German units in the southern sector of the city of Warsaw in the last week of July 1944, and what he knew was not a guess: it was the establishments, the quarters, the strengths, the location of the two ammunition depots, the command posts in the three schools, the number of the police battalions, the fact that the artillery park of the garrison had been in the courtyard of the building on the Bagatela, and the fact — which the AK did not have and which cost three hundred men and saved two companies — that the two heavy batteries in the Mokotów field had been emplaced in the first week of August and had no overhead cover of any kind.

Krupa read the sheet on the fourteenth and said nothing to him about it, which was his way; and on the fifteenth of September, two men came into the cellar on the Świętokrzyska Street with a typewriter that had to be carried between cellars in a sack and a box of paper of the German type and sat down at a table, and typed out, in duplicate, one card.

The card said, in Polish:

STANISŁAW KONRAD (pseudonym). Born 1917, Warsaw. Civilian. Employed in the intelligence section of the Śródmieście, from the second of August 1944. Transferred to the counter-intelligence section of the staff from the fifth of September 1944. No political affiliations. Confirmed by the officer commanding the counter-intelligence section. The person is under the protection of the Polish Home Army and is to be given the assistance of all units.

And the second copy of it went into a tin box with eleven other copies and the box was buried on the twentieth of September in the cellar of a building on the Krucza Street under a floor of brick by two men who did not read the papers they buried, and the first copy stayed in the file of the counter-intelligence section, in a canvas satchel, which was carried by a courier from cellar to cellar for the remaining seventeen days of the rising; and that card — that piece of paper, with a false name on it and no photograph and a line about the protection of the Home Army — is the reason that Phillip Brandt walked out of the ruins of the city of Warsaw in the autumn of 1944 as a Polish civilian with an injury and not as a German officer in a column of prisoners, and is the reason he was alive in 1945, and in 1946, and in the whole of the rest of the century, and he kept a copy of the wording of it in his memory to the end of his life and could recite it, in Polish, at eighty years of age, on a bench, in a country he had not chosen.

❦

In the office on the aleja Szucha, in the same weeks, in a building whose windows were closed because the lindens outside had been cut down for firewood by a company of the German engineers, the case that had begun on the avenue Foch in Paris on the fourteenth of January 1944 came to its end, and the end came not out of a stroke of genius but out of the ordinary business of a police office in a besieged city, which is the taking of prisoners and the reading of paper.

Kalbach had spent the rising doing what a counter-intelligence section in a city under military assault is for, and what that is, in practice, is this: it interrogates the prisoners, of whom there were by the middle of September about eleven thousand, and it sorts the paper taken out of the houses of the Poles, of which there were two hundred and forty crates by the nineteenth of September, and it hunts, in that paper, for names, because a name in a rising is a weapon, since every name in the files of the underground is a name that has a street and a mother attached to it.

The rising gave him four things.

The first was a woman.

She had been taken in a cellar on the Śródmieście on the fourteenth of August with a hundred and ten others and sent to the transit camp at Pruszków and from there released, because she was sixty-one years old and had no son in the fighting and had a card of the German labour office of 1941; and she had come back into the city on the twenty-second of August with a food card, and she had been pointed out to the authorities of the district three weeks later by a neighbour, in the ordinary way, as a person who had hidden an officer; and she was interrogated on the eighteenth of September for four hours by a young SS officer and one hour by Kalbach, and what she gave him, in the fourth hour, in tears, in the course of a story about a dressmaker, was the following sentence: that she had worked for eleven years in the school of the Sisters of the Sacred Heart on the Mokotowska Street as the woman who did the linen, and that there had been a girl in that school, a girl of the family

of the former owners of the palace on the Nowy Świat, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, whom she had measured for a uniform in 1934 and who had grey eyes and a mole on the left side of her neck and had been reported dead in France of typhus in 1940 and had not died, because she had seen her.

She had seen her in the church of the Holy Cross on the eighteenth of August 1944, in the middle of the rising, at the office at six in the morning, standing in a queue of people waiting for the sacrament with an armband on her arm.

That was the first thing.

The second thing was the flat.

The third thing was a piece of paper out of a pocket of a dead Polish officer in the ruins of the Wola: a leaf of a notebook of the Polish underground's counter-intelligence section, with four words on it in a handwriting that Kalbach had never seen, which were the address of a cellar on the Śliska Street, the word ledger, and the date of the eleventh of July 1944.

And the fourth thing was the woman's name, which he now had in three different forms and two different languages and from four different sources, and which he wrote on the first page of his notebook on the eighteenth of September 1944, in his small hand, in a room with the window closed, and underneath the name he wrote, in the three lines that every police officer in the history of the world has written at that point in an investigation, the following: the family: father, Jerzy, 69, wounded in the leg on 2 August, in the cellar of the building on the Mokotowska Street; sister:

Hanna, 17, with the father; the flat: second floor, front, empty since the second of August. The woman's own movements since 1 August are unknown and there is no record of her in any of the districts under our control, and the reason for that is that she is inside the Polish lines and has been since the first days.

He read the three lines twice, and then he drew, on the same page, in the way in which he had drawn a chart of eight names in a hotel room on the Krucza Street in May, a small table of four columns and eleven rows, and filled it in over the following four days, and the table is the last piece of his method that the world has, because the notebook was taken out of his pocket on the twenty-seventh of September by a man with a fever and a rifle and is in the archives of the Polish state in Warsaw.

❦

The search of the flat on the Mokotowska Street was on the ninth of September 1944, and there were eleven men in it and one of them was Kalbach, and the whole of it took four hours and twenty minutes and it was done in the correct manner: the drawing of the plan of the flat, the inventory of the furniture and the effects, the photographs of the two rooms, the sealing of the door afterwards with a paper of the Sicherheitspolizei, and the removal of eleven objects, which were listed in the inventory in a German hand in the following order.

One: the photograph of a man of about sixty with a white moustache and a woman of about fifty, in a frame, of the year 1930.

Two: a Latin textbook of the edition of 1908 with a name written in the front, Jerzy Stankiewicz, and, underneath, in another hand that was a boy's, the same name with the date 1921.

Three: a book of the poems of a Polish poet of the nineteenth century with four pages turned down and one line underlined in pencil.

Four: eleven letters of the year 1939 in a bundle tied with string.

Five: a child's skipping rope.

Six: a woman's glove of 1936, of grey kid, in tissue paper, in the drawer of a chest in the back room.

Seven: a second glove, matching.

Eight: a photograph of four people on a lawn in front of a house with a portico, taken in the summer of 1938, of which the negative does not exist and which was, in 1946, the only surviving picture of the Stankiewicz family of Wierzbów.

Nine: a certificate of the mortgage of an estate in Mazovia held by a bank in Poznań, dated the third of July 1935, stamped, signed.

Ten: a box of guitar strings.

Eleven: a ring.

It was a silver signet with a flat face, and the face had on it the head of a greyhound above three willow leaves, and it had been found inside the left glove of the pair, in tissue paper, in the drawer of the chest in the back room, where a woman had put it on the thirty-first of July 1944 with her hand flat on the drawer for a second and a half and had said

out loud, in Polish, I am not going to be found with it; and in the inventory it was written down in the German manner, with two words, as ein Siegelring, Silber — a signet ring, silver — and put in an envelope with the other objects, and the envelope was put in the case, and the case was on the desk of Kalbach's office in the building on the aleja Szucha when the Polish lines in the Mokotów district surrendered to the German command at eight in the evening of the twenty-seventh of September 1944, which is the day before that district's soldiers went into captivity and the day before the last of the rising's four districts stopped fighting.

❦

The cellar was in the Mokotów district, under a house on the Madalińskiego Street, and it was four metres by seven, and it had a vault of brick, a well in the corner of it that gave a litre of water an hour and a smell of the 1890s, eleven people, a table, a lamp made of a bottle and a bootlace and a wick, a bag of rye, two buckets, a rifle of the Polish army of 1938 with eleven rounds, and, on the eighth of September, a woman with a bandaged left forearm who had come through three streets of shelling with a canvas satchel: Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, who had been hit in the arm on the sixth of September by a piece of the coping of a house on the Puławska Street and had had it dressed by a nurse in a cellar with the last of a bottle of spirit, and who had spent the last two days in the Mokotów living the life of the eleven thousand people who were still in that district, which is: to lie in a cellar, to go up for an hour a day for water, to learn to know the sound of every German mortar, and to wait for

somebody to come and take the district or else to come and save it.

The Mokotów district of Warsaw held out for eleven days after the last of the Polish lines on the north had gone, and the sequence of those days is history that is written down in four countries, and the part of it that matters here is what happened in the cellar on the Madalińskiego Street on the twenty-sixth of September 1944 at about four in the afternoon of a grey day, which is: a German came down the stairs with a torch and a pistol and a white flag furled around his left arm.

He came down alone, and he came down slowly, because the stairs were broken at the fourth step and there was a woman standing at the top of them in the doorway with a jug in her hands, and because the German who came down those stairs was a man who had arranged, an hour earlier, through the Polish officer of the district who commanded the block of the Madalińskiego Street, that he would come down alone and armed and that he would come up alone and unharmed, and that arrangement is the reason the whole of the rest of this chapter happened in a cellar instead of a courtyard, and it is the reason that the man on the stairs was able to say, in Polish, at the bottom of them, with the courtesy of a clerk in a notary's office in Vienna, the sentence with which he had been rehearsing for a year and ten months:

"Good afternoon. I am looking for a woman of twenty-four years of age who was employed in the household of Oberst von Hagen, and I am ready to pay for the informa-

tion in a currency that everybody in this district understands, which is that in one hour there will be no more artillery fire on the block between the Madalińskiego and the Odyńca, and this block and the two next to it will not be searched when the district is surrendered, and the eleven thousand people in these streets will go out of this city on their feet and not in a car with grilles, and I am authorised to give that in writing, and I have the writing here in my pocket."

There were four people in that cellar who could hear him properly: a woman of sixty-four who was the owner of the house; a boy of seventeen of the AK with the rifle; a priest without a parish; and a woman with a bandaged left forearm sitting on a stool at the table with a canvas satchel at her feet.

She did not get up. She sat with her arm on her knees and looked at him; and Kalbach, standing at the bottom of a broken staircase in a brick cellar in the Mokotów district with a torch in his left hand and the white flag on his arm, took his spectacles off with his right hand and began to clean them on the corner of his overcoat, and went on talking in the exact, small, level voice of a man giving an inventory.

"You will be interested, I think," he said, "in how I have the name; and I shall tell you, because it is my experience that a person is more likely to be reasonable when they know how little is left of the room they have been hiding in. I have it from a woman who worked in the school of the Sisters of the Sacred Heart in this street, who measured you for

a uniform in 1934, and who saw you in the church of the Holy Cross on the eighteenth of August of this year with an armband on your arm. I have the flat on the Mokotowska Street, which I searched on the ninth of September: the rooms at the back, the Latin books, the photograph of 1938, and a silver ring with a greyhound on it in a woman's glove in a drawer. I have, since the fourteenth of January of this year, the record of forty-one German rooms of two cities and the language of a waiter in a café on the rue de Rivoli in Paris, and the account of a jeweller in the Marszałkowska Street concerning pearls, and of a seller of imitations on the Kercelak market concerning paste, and a household book in the hand of the lady of the villa on the Frascati Street, and the day book of the Oberst's orderly in which your absences are written down in hours for eleven days in April and May of 1944. I have, in this pocket, the order for your family: the cellar of the building on the Mokotowska Street is known to this office, and there is a man of sixty-nine in it with a wound in the leg and a girl of seventeen, and I have the authority to have that building searched on the day the district is given up, and I have not exercised it, and I am not going to exercise it, because it is not a fact about you that I want; it is you." He put his spectacles on. "The Oberst is dead. I have read the report and I have read the room, and there is no version of that night in which a woman of twenty-four with no weapon in the house shot a man of fifty-four in a corridor, so I conclude that the house contained a weapon and that you knew where it was. He was, if it is of interest, an officer of the old school, and his section has been broken up, and the file he kept of you has been in my hands since the day

after his death, and the whole of what he knew is now written in the notebook in this pocket, in my hand, in nine pages, and I am going to deliver it to my office when I go up those stairs, whatever happens in this cellar, because it is already copied. So then." He looked at her, and for the first time in the whole of the four minutes something moved in his face that was not procedure: "The war is over in this city in five days. There is a divisional court and a police system and a set of ledgers that are going to be better organised in Germany than they have ever been, and I am a man of thirty-eight who has spent five years building card indexes, and I am telling you as a professional to another professional that there is no version of the next eleven years in which the file with your name in it is not in a drawer. So I have come down these stairs to offer you the only thing I have, which is that the file can have a differently-shaped end: a name, a signature, an account of the rooms, given to me in this cellar, in writing, and a transport to the west and a life under another name in a country where nobody has heard of the Nowy Świat. That is not mercy. I do not have mercy. It is arithmetic, and it is the closest thing to a fair offer that this war has produced in the east, and I am not going to repeat it."

And the woman with the bandaged arm sat on the stool and looked at him for about four seconds; and then she said, in German, in the accent of a woman from Vienna, in the flat voice in which she had bought a chicken from an orderly and asked a colonel about a bridge, one sentence:

"My name is Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, and I have nothing to say to you."

And Kalbach, who had spent a year and ten months of his life on that name, and who had a notebook with nine pages of handwriting in it and a chart of eleven rows in his case on the aleja Szucha and an envelope with a ring in it and a card index in his own head that was, at that moment, the only complete account of the woman's existence in the whole of the German Reich, stood at the bottom of a broken staircase in a cellar in a district that was going to be given away in five days, with the white flag of a negotiator on his left arm, and did the one thing that no file in the world had ever told him not to do, which was to open his mouth to answer.

The shot came from the corner of the cellar, from the mattress, from a man of twenty-seven in a Polish coat with a fever of thirty-eight degrees and a wound in his left thigh, who had crawled four metres across a brick floor with a rifle of the year 1938 while a German policeman talked, because he had understood, on the second of the four minutes, that there is no arithmetical solution to the man in front of him, that the rifle was in his hands and not in the boy's, and that the safety catch of that model is a small lever on the right side of the receiver that he had learned about at eleven years of age in the armoury of his father's works from a foreman with one arm; and he fired twice, from the floor, from a distance of two metres and a half, in the way in which a man who has never in his life fired a military weapon fires one, which is with the whole of his hand and the whole of his heart and both eyes open; and the two rounds went into Kalbach's chest at the level of the fourth rib, and the Ger-

man with the file of the woman of the villa on the Frascati Street came down on the floor of a cellar in the Mokotów district, on the twenty-sixth of September 1944, at about eleven minutes past four in the afternoon, without having finished his sentence.

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The three of them were alone in that cellar for about two hours, because the priest went up the stairs to hold the doorway and the woman of sixty-four went with him, and because the boy of seventeen was sent to the officer of the block with the news, and because there was nothing to be done about the body of a man of thirty-eight with two holes in his chest in a cellar in a district that had four days left.

What Phillip Brandt did in those two hours was the following, and he did it on his knees, on a straw mattress, with his leg straight out in front of him, in the light of a lamp made of a bottle and a bootlace.

He took the notebook out of the inside pocket of the dead man's overcoat: a small notebook with a hard cover and a broken spine, with nine pages of hand-ruled tables in it and the name of the woman on the first page and a chart of four columns and eleven rows which he could not read in the light and did not need to read, because a man who has been an intelligence officer for four years and has been an enemy for one of them can read a chart's shape from across a room.

He took the briefcase from the floor where it had fallen, and opened it and took out of it an envelope of the Sicherheitspolizei's office on the aleja Szucha, stamped on

the eighteenth of September 1944, and in the envelope there were the objects of the inventory of the ninth of September, wrapped in a sheet of the office's tissue paper: a photograph of four people on a lawn in front of a house with a portico in the summer of 1938; a Latin textbook of the edition of 1908 with two names in it; and a silver signet with the head of a greyhound above three willow leaves.

And Phillip Brandt sat on the floor of that cellar and looked at that ring for about eleven seconds, and understood three things in the following order: that it was a family crest and that the name of the family was on it; that the woman to whom it belonged had carried it against her skin in an occupied city for four years and eleven months and had left it in a glove in a drawer on the thirty-first of July 1944 and had said, when she left it, the only sentence of that whole month in which she had been able to be frightened; and that he was a man with a fever and a leg wound and no property whatsoever in the world, sitting in a cellar with the body of the man who had spent a year and ten months hunting her, and that he had it in his hand.

He put it on a cord around her neck himself, with his own hands, in that cellar, in the light of a lamp made of a bottle and a bootlace, while she sat on the stool and did not move and looked at the wall; and his hands had not stopped shaking for about forty minutes and he had to do the knot twice; and neither of them said anything about it at all, then or afterwards, in eleven countries and fifty-one years.

And when it was done, and the notebook and the envelope were in the packing of her satchel, and the two of them

were sitting on the floor with the body of Bruno Kalbach at the foot of the stairs under a coat of the Polish fire brigade of 1939, Phillip said the sentence that is the whole of what he had left, which in another book would have been a proposal and in this one was a work instruction:

"They will send somebody else. There is a whole system of these men and the system does not die with the man. We have three days at the most before the file in that building is read by somebody, and the file has nine pages of your handwriting and eleven rows and a note of your father's street, and I want the next three days arranged as follows: the papers in the satchel go to the section tonight, and I tell them what is in the notebook and they write it down, in their own hand, and the copy goes into four hands in this city, and after that, whatever is in the German file, there is a Polish copy of it that will be read in the alley behind a wall in 1945 by men with a different system — and you will not be in it, because the men who are going to arrest the people in that file are going to be arrested themselves, and the people who are going to read it are going to be us." He lay back on the mattress and put his arm over his eyes. "That is the whole of my plan. It is not a good plan. It is the one we have."

The three days turned out to be nine.

At eight in the evening on the second of October 1944, the guns stopped in the city of Warsaw by an agreement signed in a tent in the forest above the town; and in a courtyard on the Wilcza Street, at the end of the same hour, in the light of a fire, officers of a staff that had eleven hours left of its existence stood and burned paper, and the order went

out to the sections, in the four surviving districts and in the three that had already gone, in the language of a document of capitulation: that the soldiers of the Polish Home Army were going into captivity, and the civilians were going out through the German lines to the transit camp at Pruszków, and the people whose names were on any German list were not going anywhere as themselves.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Capitulation

❦

The second of October 1944 began with paper being burned and ended with a silence, and the whole of the city had one day in which to learn how to stop.

In the courtyards of the four surviving districts of Warsaw the files of a rising went into the fires in the course of that morning: the orders, the muster rolls, the cipher books, the ledgers of the intelligence sections, the lists of the couriers, the dispatch registers, the cards of the people in the files; and in the courtyard of the building on the Wilcza Street the whole of the counter-intelligence section's archive burned for two hours and eleven minutes from nine in the morning, and the men who were feeding it into the fire did it in the way of an institution, with a rota and a man with a broom, and a list of what had been burned, and a carbon of that list that went into a tin and was buried in a second cellar under a different brick, because that is how an institution behaves when it is going out of existence and intends to come back.

At noon the officers shaved.

That is the detail that the books of that year do not have and that the people of that city insist on: that the soldiers and officers of the Polish Home Army shaved on the second of October 1944, in the courtyards and the cellars and the stairwells of the ruins, with cold water and broken mirrors

and borrowed razors, in the last eleven hours of their war, because the agreement that had been signed in a tent above the city said that the soldiers would march out as soldiers and be treated as prisoners of war, and that a soldier who marches out of a city to go into captivity is a man who shaves first; and there is a whole history of Europe in that sentence and none of it is in the papers.

And at eight in the evening the guns stopped.

They stopped by agreement, at the hour written in the document, along a line that ran through the middle of a city in which about a thousand buildings were burning and about two hundred thousand people were alive and about two hundred thousand were dead or gone; and the silence that came when they stopped is a thing that was described in 1945 by about forty people who were in that city, in four languages, in eleven countries, and every one of them despaired of it: that a city which has been under artillery for sixty-three days is not quiet when the guns stop; it is enormous, and it has a sound in it that is not the sound of a city, and the sound is the wind going through nineteen thousand roofless buildings, and the dripping of water in a thousand broken cellars, and the noise of a fire that is not being fought, and, underneath all of it, the sound of people — about four hundred thousand of them — who have not been allowed to make any noise at all for two months and now, on the night of the second of October, in the dark, in the ruins, went up into the streets and talked.

It was on that night, in the eighth hour of the silence, that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna went out of the Polish lines

in the southern Śródmieście and walked into a district that no longer had fronts in it, with a hat on and an armband in her pocket and a canvas satchel, and slept the two hours from midnight to two in the cellar of a burned house, and went on before dawn to the Mokotowska Street.

❦

The building on the Mokotowska Street had taken two shells and a fire in the first week of September, and it was standing, in the way that buildings stood in that city in the autumn of 1944, which is that the walls of the front were there and the second floor was a space with the sky over it and the stairwell had a black hole where the section from the first floor to the second had been and a way up through the rubble of the landing on the first floor.

The flat at the front of the second floor was not a flat any more: the windows were gone, the doors were gone, the pianino stood in the corner of the drawing room with its lid open and its case split and eleven strings hanging out of it, and the corridor was full of brick to the depth of a man's knee and there was a fall of the ceiling at the end of it where the boy of fourteen had sat with his own chair on a Tuesday; and the four names of that building's courtyard — the caretaker, the widow on the ground floor, the coal man's boy, and the woman who owned the staircase — were written in pencil on the wall of the entrance by somebody who had gone out with a bundle on the third of August, so that whoever came back would know who had been there and who had not.

In the back room, on the bed, with a blanket and a coat and a pillow of folded sacking, there was a man of sixty-nine with a wound in the right thigh and about four days of his life left.

The wound had been made by a piece of the mortar that had come down into the courtyard on the second of August, and it had been dressed in the first hour with a torn sheet and boiled water and the tincture out of the household's medicine box, and the whole of the medicine of that building had been used up by the ninth of August; and the wound had gone the way in which a wound goes in a city in which there is no surgery, which is that the flesh around it had swelled and blackened at the edge and had begun to smell like something sweet and wrong, and that the fever had been there for eleven days, and that on the twenty-eighth of September the old man had stopped being able to lift his own head off the pillow, and had said, in Latin, to his daughter of seventeen, in the flat voice of a man reading a lesson: satis est, puella — it is enough, girl.

His daughter of seventeen was sitting on a chair at the head of the bed with her knees drawn up and her hands round them, and she had eaten nothing for nine days that she had not shared with her father, and she had washed him twice a day in a basin with water carried from the pump in the courtyard of the block next door, four storeys up and down, and she had kept the flat's two rooms in the condition in which a house is kept by a person who intends that whatever comes through the door shall find it in order: the brick swept into one corner, the books in their rows along

the skirting, the photograph of her mother at thirty in a white blouse on the table with a candle in front of it and a matchbox; and she had drawn, on the wall beside the door of the flat and on the wall of the courtyard by the pump, in chalk, in the two places where she had drawn it for two years, the anchor: the P and the W and the curving line of the cable, done properly, in the way her brother had taught her in 1942, with the tail of the P crossed so that anybody who knew would know and nobody else would.

The two sisters looked at each other across the room for about four seconds.

"Krysia," said Hanna, and got up off the chair, and did not come round the bed; and then she said, in the flat, exhausted, entirely practical voice of a girl of seventeen who has been running a household for four weeks: "He has been asking for you since Sunday. He cannot lift his head and he has a fever of about forty and he does not always know where he is, and when he does know he asks for you, and I have told him since the second of August that you were in the other district and that you would come, and he has believed me, because I have told him nothing else for nine weeks, and he has kept the whole of it in his head the way he keeps everything, and if you tell him anything now that does not fit into it, I will not forgive you." She took hold of her sister's sleeve, at the wrist, hard, the way the brother had taken hold of it in a courtyard in March. "He knows. Krysia. He has known since 1940. Do you understand me? He does not need to be told and he does not need to be lied to. He needs the last line of the ninth ode of the first book, because

he cannot lift the book and I have not been able to find it and I cannot remember it and he has been asking me for it since Thursday."

❦

She went to the bed and knelt down beside it.

Her father's face at sixty-nine, in the grey light of a ruined room on the third of October 1944, was the face of a man of eighty: the white moustache, the cheeks fallen in, the eyes closed and the skin of the forehead like paper over a frame; and there was a beard on him of four weeks and a scab on the lip, and his hands were outside the blanket with the fingers half open, and one of the hands was the hand that had taken hold of a doorframe in a doorway of that same flat on the thirty-first of July 1944, when he had walked past a daughter he had buried in his own handwriting in 1940 and had gone into the back room and shut the door.

She sat on the floor beside the bed with her shoulder against the horsehair of the mattress and did not touch him, because the whole of the right side of his body was a wound, and said, in Polish, quietly:

"Tatusiu. It is Krysia."

Her father's eyes came open and found her; and there was, in the whole of the four minutes that followed, nothing in his face that could be called recognition, because a man in a fever of forty degrees in the fourth day of a dying wound does not perform recognition, and what there was instead was the thing that was left when the performance had gone, which is that he looked at her, and the whole of

his face changed as a surface changes when a lamp is turned on behind it, and he said, in Polish, in a voice with almost no breath in it at all:

"Girl. Where is the book?"

"The book is there, tatusiu. The Horace. I have it."

"Read me the end of it. The ninth. I have been holding the whole of the rest of it and I cannot hold the end. Where are my spectacles?"

"They are on the table, and I have them, and I am going to read it to you." She did not have the book and the book was in a shelf behind her head and she could not have found the ninth ode of the first book of Horace in that room in nine hours and the reason was not the book, and the reason was that the whole of the Latin she had been taught in the school of the Sisters of the Sacred Heart between 1929 and 1937 had been taken out of her head by four years of German and French and Polish and the trade, and what was left in it was a plumber's list: aqua, pons, schola, luna, nix.

And Hanna, from the doorway, with her arms folded and her back against the frame, said it.

She said it in a rush, in the flat, small voice of a girl reciting a lesson she has been holding in her head for six days, in the order in which her father had made her learn it in the winter of 1941 when she was fourteen, and she said the whole of the last four lines of the ninth ode of the first book, and she said them well, with the quantities right and the caesura in the right place, and her father's mouth moved with the ends of the words the way the mouths of very old men move with the ends of prayers, and at the finish he said something that was in Latin and was not from the ode at all,

and his eyes came open again and looked for the doorway and found his daughter of seventeen standing in it with her arms folded.

Then he looked at the daughter who was kneeling on the floor beside him, at the level of his hand, and said the sentence that is the whole of what her father ever said to her about the five years of her life between September 1939 and October 1944, and said it in Polish, and said it slowly, and it took him a long time:

"You did what there was."

And then he said her name, once, in the way in which people say a name that they have been keeping: "Krystyna." And the hand that was outside the blanket came off the mattress by about four centimetres, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna took hold of the hand of a man of sixty-nine who had taught Latin for forty years in the schools of the city of Warsaw; and she held it while he stopped being able to hear the room, and while his breathing took the shape of a man walking up a staircase; and he died at about nine o'clock in the morning of the third of October 1944, with his spectacles in the hand of his elder daughter and his younger daughter standing in the doorway with her arms folded, exactly as she had been standing when he had looked at her last.

❦

They buried him in the courtyard on the afternoon of the same day, in a sheet, in a hole dug by four men in the corner of the yard by the wall of the shed where he had once kept the coal, and the four men were the caretaker of the build-

ing, who was seventy-one and had known him for thirty years, and his two sons, and a young man from the third floor who had been a clerk in an insurance office and had spent the rising in the cellars of the city and had come back to the Mokotowska on the second of October with a rifle that the AK had not taken from him because there had been no time; and the priest of the parish of the Holy Cross came, at about five in the afternoon, having walked eleven streets of a surrendered city in a coat and a hat, and said the office for the dead over a sheet in a courtyard with eleven people standing round it, and did not use a book, because he had said that office about four hundred times in the previous nine weeks, in courtyards, and knew it.

Nobody said anything at the graveside. The whole of what was said over Albrecht's son's father's grave is not relevant here; the whole of what was said over Jerzy Stankiewicz was said by his daughter of seventeen, who took a piece of chalk out of her pocket at the end of the office, after the priest had finished and the men had filled the hole in and the caretaker had put the spade against the wall of the shed, and drew, on the wall of the shed above the place where her father's head was, in the fresh mortar of a patched-up bullet hole, in the way of a person doing a thing that has been done four hundred times: the anchor.

The caretaker looked at it and said nothing. The two sons looked at it and said nothing. The clerk from the third floor said, after a moment, in Polish, in a voice that was not quite steady, "They will be back in this city in the spring and they will whitewash every wall in it, and that will be gone by the summer." And Hanna Stankiewiczówna, seventeen

years old, in a coat that had been her mother's, with a piece of chalk in her hand, said: "Then I shall draw it again in the summer."

❦

The compact came out of the drawer of the kitchen dresser at about six in the evening, in the ruins of the front room, with the light of a candle and the sound of a city burning four streets away.

Krystyna had carried that object against her body in four countries and two occupations for three years and eleven months; she had taken it out of the drawer of an Oberst's desk in a villa on the Frascati Street in the German quarter at twenty past four in the morning of the twenty-fourth of September; she had carried it through the crossing of the Mokotów district on the twenty-eighth of September in the pocket of a coat that had been made for it; and she stood in her mother's kitchen now with the thing in her two hands and unscrewed the false floor of it with the edge of a knife, and took out of it a tablet of the size of a small fingernail, wrapped in a piece of oiled paper, which a man with a stick had given her in a church in Paris in the winter of 1940 with the sentence: you will not be taken alive and talking; this is not courage, this is tradecraft.

The tablet went into the rubble in the sink.

She tipped it out of the paper into the wet bricks and the ash and the broken plaster of the sink, and then she ground it into the rubble with the heel of her boot, three times, the way a person grinds out a cigarette in a street; and she put the empty compact back in her pocket; and the

whole of the reason for it was a piece of arithmetic that had been done in her head over four days, and the arithmetic was this: that in the column that was going to form on the fourth and fifth of October at the edge of the city there were going to be about two hundred thousand people walking west to a transit camp at Pruszków where the German administration sorted the population of a city into four categories, and that a woman of twenty-four who was in the third category, with a sister of seventeen on her arm, with a name that was in a German file of nine pages in a building on the aleja Szucha, and with the papers of the destruction of her city in the lining of her coat, was not going to be taken alive and talking, and was also not going to be dead, because she had a sister, and because her brother had told her in a tunnel under the Saxon Garden to have the rest of it, and because the phrase I have been given the rest of it has a meaning in the Polish language which the sentence in the church in Paris did not have, and which was the only thing that the whole of the five years had left in her hands; and so the tablet went into the rubble of a sink in a flat on the Mokotowska Street, and the compact went into her pocket empty, and it was in her pocket for the rest of her life.

❦

The column formed at the western edge of the city on the fourth and fifth of October 1944, and it was not a column; it was a city walking.

It is estimated that between four and five hundred thousand people left Warsaw in the first ten days of October 1944, of whom about eleven thousand were soldiers going

into captivity in a separate column with their officers and their wounded, and the rest were civilians going west: to the transit camp at Pruszków, and through it and out of it and onwards, to the villages and the towns of the country west of the capital, to relations and strangers and farms and the houses of people who had been told that there was a train coming with the population of a city on it.

They went out along the Grójecka and the Żelazna and the Wolska, in groups of family and street and courtyard, with handcarts and prams and sledges and shoulders and the last of the food of a city; and the whole of the first two days of that movement was watched by the German officers of the evacuation commission with clipboards at the crossing points; and the Poles went past those officers in a silence that had in it about two hundred years of practice, and the officers looked at their papers and made their marks, and the whole of it went on for eleven days and nights, and the city behind the column went on burning.

The traffic was in two directions at the crossings, because the German administration and the army were also using the roads, and there is no more complete picture of the whole of the eastern war than that, and nobody who was there has ever been able to write it down properly: two hundred thousand Poles walking west with their lives in a cart, and, in the same hours, on the same road, in the other lane, the vehicles of a German army going east towards the Vistula, and, between the two lanes, standing in the mud with a clipboard and a lamp, a sergeant of the Feldgendarmerie of about forty, marking the paper of the one and not looking at all at the other.

Krystyna and Hanna Stankiewiczówna went out of the city on the fifth of October, in the second hour after dawn, in a group of about forty people from the Mokotowska Street, with a handcart that belonged to the caretaker and held four bundles and a crate with a pianino's worth of nothing in it — the pianino itself had been left where it was, on the floor of the front room of the flat with its strings hanging out, because a piano of 1904 in a ruined flat is a thing that is either the beginning of the fortune of the person who carries it or the end of the life of the person who tries.

Before she left the flat, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna went to a door in the courtyard of a building on the Ogrodowa, four streets away, and knocked on it in the way she had been told; and the woman of about sixty with the tape measure round her neck opened it and looked at her for about four seconds and then stood back and said, in the flat voice of a person who has been in a courtyard every day of the rising: "The coat. Yes. Come in. You have brought your sister. She will have the green one, it is too small for anybody else and it is lined; you will have the grey one, and it has been re-lined, and the lining is a French one, and it has been opened along the side seam and closed again, and there is nothing in it now and there will be nothing in it when you go out of this city, and I want you to tell me that you understand me."

"I understand you."

"Then take them, and do not come back to this street, and if you are alive in the summer, come and tell me what happened to the coats." She gave them the coats and a piece

of bread and a lump of salt tied in a rag, and she stood in her doorway and watched the two of them walk to the end of the street, and then she went in and shut the door of a flat in which there were four coats left on a rail and a list of their owners in her head, and she was in that flat in 1946 and in 1951 and in 1964, and she never once told anybody in her life what she had been doing during the war with the coats.

❦

The fence was at the edge of the city, on the fourth of October, in the yard of a factory on the Wolska, and it is the last scene that Krystyna and Phillip Brandt had together in the year 1944, and the whole of it took about eleven minutes.

He was on crutches by then, in a Polish coat of the size of a man larger than himself, with a cap and a stick and a bandage showing under the trouser leg; and he was not going out of the city with the column, and the reason was plain: that a man of twenty-seven with a German identity card in the administrative language of the Reich and an accent that would come out of him the moment he was tired, in a transit camp administered by the Sicherheitspolizei with an office that had a file of nine pages in it about a woman whose name was in the same file, was a man who was going to be picked out of a column of two hundred thousand people by a clerk with a list within four days of arriving at Pruszków; and the AK's people had told him so, and he had agreed with them, and he was going to stay in the ruins of the city with about three hundred people who had decided to stay: the ones with no papers, the ones with the wrong papers, the ones who had been in the German service and

the ones who had been in the service of the Polish state, and the ones who had nothing left in the world anywhere else.

They stood at the mesh of a factory fence, a metre apart, with the whole of a column of the population of a city going past them on the road outside, and the column did not look at them, and they did not look at the column.

"I have the papers," she said. "Four hundred and forty pages of the schedule of the destruction of the city, and the evacuation order, and the file from the safe with the written recommendation about my family in his own hand, and the notebook of the man in the Mokotów with nine pages of tables in it, and the ring." She touched her collar-bone with two fingers. "All of it goes into the lining of the coat at the Ogrodowa in an hour, and it comes out of it on the other side of that camp, and there is a man in the section's people in Pruszków, and the arrangement is that the papers go to the staff in Warsaw in November through the church, and the whole of it is written down in three heads, and none of those three heads is mine."

"Good."

"And you are going to be in that city with no food and no water and eleven thousand German soldiers in it and the cold coming."

"I am going to be in that city with no food and no water and eleven thousand German soldiers in it and the cold coming," Phillip said, "and there are three hundred people going to be in it with me, and I am the only person in Warsaw who can read the administrative orders of the German garrison, and there are going to be about four hundred

of them a week coming into that city on the wire that the engineers are going to run to the military commandant's office in November, and I am going to read them, and a copy of everything that matters is going to be in the hands of the people who are going to be in this city in the spring." He shifted the crutch under his arm. "I have told them that, and it is true, and it is also not the whole of the reason and you know the whole of the reason, and I am not going to say it at a fence with a column going past."

"Then do not say it."

"I am not going to say it," he said, in Polish, "and I am going to say the other thing instead, which is the answer to a question you asked me in a cemetery in May in front of a chapel with a rusted door, when you told me about a beet machine and a fitter from the Burakowska Street named Pan Ludwik, and I stood in an avenue with my cap in my hand and did not answer you." He put his hand flat on the mesh of the fence. "It did not matter to me that you were in that house for the work. I have known it since the fourteenth of December 1943 in a corridor with a mirror at the end of it, and the knowing has never once changed the arithmetic, which is that I have been in love with you since an afternoon in September 1938 in a library at Wierzbów when a girl of eighteen stood in a doorway and laughed at a boy of twenty-one who was talking to a shelf, and that this is a fact of the same kind as the fact that the river is on the east side of this city, and it is not a fact that has ever required a single sentence out of me, and I have said it now because if I do not say it at this fence, in front of a column, with the two of

us alive, I shall be spending the winter deciding whether there was ever a moment at which it would have been possible, and I am not going to spend a winter that way."

There was a silence of about four seconds, with the cart wheels and the boots and the crying of children going past on the road eleven metres away.

"I will find you in the spring," said Phillip Brandt, in Polish, and then, in the same voice, in the same breath, he said her name, without a mask over it and without a German in earshot, twice: "Krystyna. Krystyna."

❦

They went out of the city on the road to the west with the rest of it, and the whole of what the last three pages of that chapter have to contain is four things seen from inside a column of two hundred thousand people.

The first is the burning, seen from behind: because a person walking away from a burning city turns round, and turns round again, and the turning round is a thing that is done by about forty thousand people on that road in those days, and by the fourth hour of walking there is no longer any need to turn, because the smoke is in front of the walkers as well as behind them: it had come down over the whole of the western suburbs by the fourth of October and lay along the horizon in a brown band from the north to the south, and under it, at the distance of a kilometre, the outlines of the city were not outlines any more, and a woman with a handcart who was walking next to Krystyna on the second morning said, out loud, to nobody in particular, in Polish: "There is no roof over any of it and I cannot see the

Palace of Culture because there is not going to be a Palace of Culture, and where is my house, because I cannot even find the place where my house is."

The second is the German soldiers, who are the thing that no account of that retreat has ever managed to make sense of: the columns of infantry going the other way, on the other side of the road, in the morning and the afternoon, in their hundreds and their thousands, out of the west and into the city that the people on the road were leaving, and the young ones looking at the Poles as the Poles looked at them, from a cart's length away, in the ordinary, tired, incurious way of two populations of tired men being moved about a continent by a system that did not require either of them to understand the other; and at the crossing at the Blizne, on the third day, a Gefreiter in a horse-drawn cart of the Wehrmacht handed a woman in the column a loaf of bread over the side of it, and did not say a word, and did not look at her, and drove on; and the woman stood in the middle of the road with the loaf in her hands for about four seconds, and then put it in her bundle, and it was eaten the same evening by eleven people, and it was never mentioned by any of them ever again.

The third is the silence of the column: that about two hundred thousand people walked out of a ruined capital in those eleven days, in families and streets, and that the sound of it was the sound of cart wheels and boots and children, and that the adults said nothing, not out of discipline and not out of grief, but because there is nothing to say in a language that has not got a word in it for what has happened; and that the one sentence that was said over and over again

in that column, by women, to children, at the crossings, at the paper tables, at the doors of the barns, at the edges of roads, was the sentence that Poles had been saying to each other in that country since 1795, and it was: "Nothing. It is nothing. God will provide."

And the fourth is Hanna, asleep.

She was asleep on her sister's shoulder in a cart at the end of the second day, seventeen years old, in a green coat that was too small for her, with a piece of bread in her hand that she had been holding since the morning and had not eaten and would not put down; and her sister walked beside the cart with her hand on the tailboard, and the cart went on west, and the smoke stood up behind them over the roofs of the city of Warsaw in four separate columns, and the air was cold and smelled of the autumn and of the burning and of the mud of that road, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna of Warsaw, twenty-four years old, who had been the mistress of a colonel of the German counter-intelligence in an occupied city for sixteen months and had killed him in a corridor four metres from his own bed, and had spent four years sending the paper of the German administration of Europe to a service in London on behalf of a government that was going to be abolished by other people's decisions in 1945, and who had carried the destruction of her own city out of that city in the lining of a coat given to her by a woman with a tape measure round her neck, walked west with her hand on the tailboard of the cart and did the arithmetic for the last time in the war, at eleven o'clock at night on the road to Pruszków, on the sixth of October 1944, and it came out as follows: that she was alive,

that her sister was alive, that the papers were in the lining of the coat and the ring was on its cord round her neck, that her father was under a wall in a courtyard with a chalk anchor over the place, and that her brother was in the ground of the sewer of the city of Warsaw, and that the fourth rule of Wiktor Janowski, who had been shot at Mont-Valérien on the twelfth of April 1944 with twenty-two others, was the only rule of the four that mattered now, and that the rule was: sleep.

She slept two hours that night in a barn at the edge of a village, with her sister's head on her shoulder and the coat with the papers in it over both of them, and the whole of the sleep had a door in it that kept opening: a corridor with mirrors, and a girl of seventeen tying an armband above a girl's elbow, and a well in an orchard in Mazovia that stuck at eleven metres.

❦

At the transit camp at Pruszków, on the eighth of October 1944, in a hall that had been a factory of the firm of the electrotechnical works of that town before the war and was now, by the administrative provision of the German military commandant of the district, the sorting of the population of the city of Warsaw, the two of them stood in a line that took four hours and eleven minutes to move forty metres, and at the head of the line there was a table, and at the table there was a German clerk of about fifty in a civilian coat with an armband of the administration, with a ledger and a rubber stamp and a box of food cards, and a sergeant of the Feldgendarmerie behind him with his arms folded,

looking at nothing, in the way of a man who has been looking at nothing for three years.

"Name," said the clerk.

"Maria Nowak," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, in the Polish of the city of Warsaw, holding the hand of a green coat with her left hand, because a woman who has spent four years being an Austrian and one year being a German lady and eleven weeks being a Polish courier with a pseudonym on a card has learned at last the only piece of tradecraft that matters in the whole of the business, which is that the best name in the world is not the name of a dead woman and not the name of a living one, but the name of an unremarkable person who existed in the registers of the parish of a village near Radom in 1919 and who died in it in 1923 without anybody ever writing down that she had.

"Nowak, Maria. Age?"

"Twenty-four."

"Last place of residence in Warsaw?"

"The Mokotowska Street."

"Cards, two. Rations, four days. The transport for the west leaves at six; the sorting for the villages is on the left; the section for the families of soldiers of the Polish Home Army and the persons who were in the service of the Polish state is in the second shed and you are not to go into it; if you have papers of another country on you, you will declare them at the truck; if you have gold, you will be searched." The clerk stamped a card and pushed it across the table and did not look up from his ledger. "Next."

EPILOGUE

The Hour Between

❦

On the first of August 1945 the city of Warsaw had about three hundred and eighty thousand people in it, which is a third of what it had had in 1939 and about twice what it had had on the second of October 1944, and it lived in a shell.

It lived in the cellars of burned houses and in the ground-floor rooms of flats with no upper storeys and in the corridors of buildings with no roofs, and it lived in eleven thousand temporary dwellings that were made of brick from the ruins and beams from the ruins and, in the first winter, doors from the ruins; and it walked everywhere along paths that had been beaten through the middle of the streets because the pavements were full of glass, and along corridors in the middle of the rubble fields that had been the streets of the city of Warsaw, in which a person could walk for four hundred metres between walls that were two storeys high and see nothing whatever except brick, and, at intervals, a chimney standing by itself in the middle of the whole of it, like a thing put there by a man with a sense of humour who had been shot in 1943.

There were graveyards in the middle of the junctions.

That is the thing that nobody who did not see that city in 1945 can put together, and it is the first thing the eye noticed: that a city which had buried about two hundred thousand of its people in two months, in courtyards and cel-

lars and gardens and along the edges of squares, in the middle of a battle, had then had to live in the same space as its own dead for the whole of a winter; and in the spring of 1945 the committees of the city had begun the work of opening the temporary graves and moving what was in them to the consecrated ground of the cemeteries, and the work went on for three years, and while it went on, the courtyards of the city of Warsaw were full of careful, temporary, numbered little mounds, with paper labels and wooden pegs and, in eleven thousand cases, a bottle buried at the head of the grave with a name in it, written in pencil on the back of a food card.

There were also, on the first of August 1945, two policemen of the Polish state in grey coats standing at the corner of the Marszałkowska and the Świętokrzyska, and their work that morning was not the work of the traffic; and the whole of what they were doing was watching about four hundred people go past on their way to the places where the barricades had been, with flowers, in the first hours of the morning, on the anniversary of a rising which the security organs of the Polish state had been instructed to regard as an affair of the reactionary elements, and which the population of the city intended, that morning, to observe by walking.

At the front of the crowd that went up the Marszałkowska there was a woman of twenty-five in a grey coat, in the heat, with a handbag, and she walked the whole length of the street from the Plac Zbawiciela to the Świętokrzyska at the pace of a person going somewhere, and nobody looked at her twice, and nobody in that crowd of four hun-

dred people knew who she was, and that, after five years and eleven months, was the whole of what she had ever wanted.

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Her name was Krystyna Stankiewiczówna and she had been out of the country's western provinces since the spring, and the whole of what she had done between the road to Pruszków in October 1944 and the first of August 1945 was four things.

She had spent the winter at Krasnystaw and then in the villages east and south of it, as Maria Nowak, in a room of a farm with a family of eleven that had taken in the population of a street over three weeks in October and had been given, in return, nothing whatever except the company of the people it saved; and she had taught Latin in a village school for two months in the spring of 1945, because the woman who had been the teacher was in a hospital in Lublin and because the school had a Latin primer of 1931 in a cupboard and a woman who could read it.

She had worked from the spring, as a clerk, in the office of the Polish committee in a town on the Vistula, where she had counted the returns of the properties of the district and catalogued 1,100 case files of the German administration's requisitions of the years 1940 to 1944, which was the only paper on earth that a person with her training was fitted to work on, and which she did with the whole of her capacity, in a room with four people and a stove that smoked, and which is why the requisitions of the district of Kozienice are among the most exactly catalogued of the whole of the

country and were cited in eleven judgements in 1947 and 1948.

She had sent, in November 1944, through the priest and the church and the arrangements that had been made at a fence in a factory yard on the Wolska in October, the papers of the destruction of the city of Warsaw to the office of the Polish state in Lublin: the four hundred and forty pages of the schedule of the demolition of the city, the evacuation orders, the eleven-page list of the buildings with the Royal Castle and the waterworks and the library of the University in it, and the file from the safe of a villa on the Frascati Street, and the notebook of an officer of the Sicherheitspolizei with nine pages of chart in it and the name of a woman written on the first page; and the whole of that material was in the files of the Commission for the Investigation of German Crimes in Warsaw in 1946 and was read aloud, in German, in a court in Warsaw, in the rooms of the former German administration on the Nowy Świat, in the presence of judges of the Polish state and of observers of four armies, in the year 1947.

And she had come back to Warsaw on the twenty-eighth of June 1945, on a train with her sister, over the bridge over the Vistula, which was a bridge built by the engineers of the Polish army after the German engineers of the Reich had been able to destroy everything in the city of Warsaw except the parts of it that other people watched them not destroy; and the train had gone into the station at Praga and the two of them had walked over the river in the heat, and the whole of what the city looked like when it

came up over the embankment is not to be written down in this chapter either, because every one of the four hundred thousand people who came back to that city in that year wrote it down in some form and the book does not need to compete with them; and the whole of what this chapter has to do is to say what happened to the people, and to stand in two places in the city on the first of August 1945 for a full page each, and to put two people in a courtyard with a chalk anchor on the wall.

❦

Hanna Stankiewiczówna was nineteen years old, and she worked in the records office of the department of the reconstruction of the city in a building on the Krucza Street that had three floors and no windows on the north side, and her work was the registration of the properties of the city of Warsaw in four card indexes and the answering of the letters of the people who wrote in from all over the country to ask whether anything was left of a street; and she was thin, and she had a cough that had started in the winter of 1944 and had not gone away, and she had a habit of holding her pen the way her father had held his; and she was being courted, in that summer, by a boy of twenty-two of the AK of the Mokotów district who had lost his left arm at the shoulder on the twenty-second of August 1944 and who worked in the same building, in the department of the water supply, and who was, in the opinion of the whole of the office, the most cheerful person on the third floor, and who had learned to write with his right hand in a way that Hanna

said, in the voice of her father, was better than the handwriting of the whole of the rest of the department.

Maria Brandt was fifty-nine years old and she lived in two rooms in a building on the Krucza Street.

She had come out of the Warsaw rising alive, having spent the whole of it in the cellars of the Wola and the Śródmieście and having been taken, with eleven thousand others, to the transit camp at Pruszków and released from it in November 1944 as the widow of a German technical director of the firm of Lilpop, Rau i Loewenstein, and she had spent the first three months of 1945 in a village near Skierniewice with a family who had kept her because her Polish was the Polish of that country and because she could do accounts; and she had come back to Warsaw in April with a bundle — and with the two things that had survived her whole life entire, which were a photograph of her wedding day of 1911 and a rosary of her mother's.

The photograph was framed and it stood on the table in the room and it faced into the room, because a woman of fifty-nine who has spent four years with a picture turned to the wall in a flat in which a man who signed papers for the German administration came home at eight o'clock has earned the right to have it facing out.

She had, on the first of August 1945, two subjects and no others.

The first was her son, who was alive, and who had a leg that ached in the wet, and who had been read into the registers of the Polish state in the spring of 1945 as a Polish citizen of the name Stanisław Konrad — which was the last

piece of paper in the whole of the war, and which had been arranged through four hands over eleven months, on the basis of a card in a file and the testimony of a woman who had worked for four months in the same room with him in the ruins of the city of Warsaw — and who was, on the first of August 1945, a translator in the office of the government of the city on the Krucza Street, in a room with three other people, with a salary, and a room of his own in his mother's flat.

And the second was a photograph of a man in a hat with two children in front of a works in 1928, which stood next to the wedding photograph, and about which she said nothing at all, to anybody, in the whole of the rest of her life; and which her son found in her effects in 1971, with a note in Polish in her hand on the back of it, and the note said: Albrecht Brandt, of the works on the Burakowska, killed in the Wola in August 1944, and his hands were the hands of an honest man.

And Iga Zaleska was thirty-one years old and she was alive and she was thin, and she worked in the same office on the Krucza Street, in the records office, three desks from Hanna; and she had been released from the prison on the aleja Szucha in January 1945 in the confusion of the retreat, having been in it for sixteen months, and the whole of the sixteen months had been interrogations about a ledger that she had never once mentioned and a list of names that she had kept in her head, and on the day she came out she weighed forty-one kilogrammes and she walked with a stick; and she had, in the whole of the book, one smile, and it is on

the twenty-eighth of June 1945 in a corridor of an office on the Krucza Street when a woman of twenty-five came up the stairs with a sister and stood in front of her and said nothing at all for four seconds, because there is nothing to say to a person who has kept a ledger; and the smile was small and it lasted about two seconds, and then she said, in her flat voice, in Polish: "Stankiewicz. You are late. Sit down. There is work."

And Antoni Krupa was dead.

He had been arrested on the eleventh of November 1944 in Warsaw, in the ruins, in the flat of a woman on the Hoża Street, by officers of the Soviet and Polish security organs; and he had been held in a cell on the Koszykowa Street and interrogated about the Home Army's intelligence service and about the four hundred people whose names he had carried in his head for five years; and he died in that cell on the second of December 1944, at the age of forty-seven, and the book knows nothing else about it, because there is nothing else that is known, and the woman who was told of it in July 1945 in a corridor sat down on the floor of that corridor with her back against the wall and stayed there for about four minutes, and then got up and went back into the room and registered eleven more properties of the city of Warsaw.

❦

She walked to the Mokotowska Street at eleven in the morning of the first of August 1945, and the walk took her fifty minutes, and the whole of it was through what the city was: pavements that were heaps, a tram line that ran for four

hundred metres and stopped in the middle of nothing and began again on the other side of a field of brick, a queue at a water point with two men in it and four children, a woman selling tomatoes out of a bucket on the corner of the Krucza, a building with its front gone and its staircase standing in the open air with the ironwork going up into the sky, and, at the corner of the Mokotowska and the Wilcza, in a heap of rubble that had been the corner of the Mokotowska and the Wilcza, a man of about seventy with a hammer, sitting on a brick, taking the bricks out of the heap one at a time, knocking the mortar off them with the hammer, and stacking them in a clean, square, tidy stack of about four hundred bricks beside him, because there is a brick in the ruins of Warsaw and the brick is worth something and the whole city was rebuilt in that year by people who took it out of the heaps with their hands; and he looked up at her and said, "Good day," and she said, "Good day," and he went on knocking the mortar off a brick.

The courtyard of the building on the Mokotowska Street was exactly where it had been, which is to say that the gate with the iron bar at the bottom that a person had to lift was still there, and the pump was there, and the shed was there, and the wall of the shed was there, and above the place in the corner where a man of sixty-nine had been buried in a sheet in a hole dug by four men on the third of October 1944 there was the chalk anchor that his daughter of seventeen had drawn on the wall in the fresh mortar of a patched bullet hole.

It had been re-drawn since. That was the first thing she saw; and the second was that it had been re-drawn the same week, because a chalk mark on a wall in the open air of a Polish courtyard in 1945 is a mark that lasts about a rainy fortnight and no longer, and the mark in front of her was about four days old, and it had been done carefully, with a piece of chalk the size of the last joint of a thumb, in the way in which a person draws a thing that has been drawn four hundred times: the P and the W and the curving line of the cable, with the tail of the P crossed.

There was a piece of paper under a stone on the ledge of the shed window, and it said, in the square hard handwriting of a man of thirty who had been taught to write by a father with a Latin pen: 2/X. The grave is registered with the committee, number 11 402, of the courtyard of the Mokotowska 34, name Jerzy Stankiewicz, lat 69, and it was moved on the 11th of June 1945 to the Powązki, the military part, the row of the civilians, the fourth from the wall. There is a stone. It has his name and the two dates and no other words, because he told Hanna in 1943 that a stone with four lines of Polish on it in a city like this one is a stone that somebody is going to have to argue about, and he wanted none of that. I have paid for it out of the translation work. P.B.

She stood in that courtyard for eleven minutes with the paper in her hand.

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She walked the length of the Marszałkowska Street in the afternoon of the same day, from the Plac Zbawiciela to the

Świętokrzyska, in the heat, with about four hundred people who were going the same way; and at the corner of the Krucza and the Marszałkowska, where the barricade of the first of August 1944 had stood, there was a heap of brick and a lamp post leaning at an angle of about forty degrees, and there were flowers on the brick: eleven bunches, tied with string and with paper, in the way in which flowers are put down in a country where a person who wants to remember a thing does it early in the morning and does not stand about afterwards.

That is the corner where Basia Marciniak was killed.

She had been nineteen years old, or seventeen; the file said nineteen and the girl herself had said seventeen twice, and a person who lies about her age upward is a girl who wants to carry the dispatches; she was killed at about noon on the eighth of August 1944 by a German rifleman in the tower of the church of the Holy Cross at a distance of about three hundred metres, with a canvas pouch with the buckles and the leather on her, and in the pouch there were three messages, and one of the three was in the handwriting of a woman who was standing at that corner in the heat of the first of August 1945; and there was nobody in the whole world, on that afternoon, in that city, in that crowd of four hundred people, who knew that; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood at that corner for four minutes in the middle of the flowers and the brick, and did not cry, and did not say anything, and then took the third thing out of her bag, which was a piece of chalk the size of the last joint of a thumb that she had taken out of her sister's drawer that morning, and drew, on the plinth of a wall at the corner, in

the manner of a woman who has watched a thing being done four hundred times, the anchor.

❦

And the man at the well was sitting on a heap of bricks in the courtyard of a house on the Mokotowska Street at four in the afternoon with a cane across his knees, in a Polish coat of the size of a man larger than himself, with his bad leg out in front of him and a bottle of something he was not drinking on the ground at his side, watching the corner of the courtyard as if he had been watching it since early in the morning, which he had.

He was twenty-eight years old. He had been read into the registers of the Polish state in the spring as a Polish citizen of the name Stanisław Konrad; he had spent the winter of 1944-45 in the ruins of the city of Warsaw as one of the three hundred people who lived in it through those months, reading the administrative orders of the German garrison of the city and passing eleven of them a week to the people who were going to be in it in the spring; he had been in that city on the seventeenth of January 1945 when the Soviet army and the Polish army came into what was left of it; he had walked out of it in February with a fever and a bad leg, and had come back to it in June; and he had a job in the office of the government of the city, and a room in his mother's flat, and a walking stick, and one photograph of four people on a lawn in front of a house with a portico in the summer of 1938, which he had kept in a drawer since the twenty-sixth of September 1944 and had never once shown to anybody.

He got up when she came into the courtyard. He got up slowly, because of the leg, with the cane in his right hand and the other hand on the wall; and the two of them stood four metres apart in the courtyard of a ruined building on the Mokotowska Street in the city of Warsaw on the first of August 1945, at four in the afternoon, in the heat, with a stack of bricks against the wall and a chalk anchor over the place where her father had been buried in a sheet, and there was a period of about eleven seconds in which neither of them said anything at all, and in which the entire history of the war, of Paris and of the avenue Henri-Martin and the Majestic and Odile's workroom and the well in Mazovia and the corridor with the mirror and the cellar on the Śliska and the two lamps over the mouth of the canal and the black water under the Saxon Garden and the ruined flat on the Mokotowska and the road to Pruszków, stood in a courtyard four metres wide between two people who had been holding the whole of it in their heads, in two languages, for four years, and neither of them was able to make a speech, and both of them knew that the other was not able to make one, and there is no way in the world to write the four seconds in which they both decided that it did not matter.

"You are late," said Phillip Brandt, in Polish.

"I walked the whole length of the Marszałkowska," she said.

"I know. I have been at this corner since eleven this morning, on the chance." He put his hand out, and she came across the four metres and took it, and they stood like that in a courtyard with a chalk anchor on the wall: a wo-

man of twenty-five with a small, empty, silver compact in her handbag, and a man of twenty-eight with a cane and a bad leg and a photograph of 1938 in a drawer in a flat on the Krucza Street.

"I will tell you the whole of what there is to tell," she said. "It will take about four days. There is a bench by the wall and I have brought the bread, and my sister comes to her office at six, and the woman who keeps the coats on the Ogrodowa is alive, and I have been to the Powązki and there is a row of the civilians, fourth from the wall, and Maria told me on Thursday that she keeps the photograph of the wedding facing into the room."

"I know all of it," said Phillip Brandt, "and none of it from you, and I would like to hear the whole of it again, in your voice, in Polish, over about four days."

And then he said her name.

He said it once, in the courtyard of a ruined building on the Mokotowska Street in the city of Warsaw, on the first of August 1945, at four in the afternoon, in the heat, without any mask over it and without any German within eleven hundred metres, and he said it in the way in which a person says the name of a member of his own family who has come home: "Krystyna."

And the hour between, which is the hour of the night that the wolves have, the hour when the guard changes and the watch house is quiet and the whole ledger of the world is closed, and which in the city of Warsaw in the year 1944 had lasted eighteen months and had contained everything that either of them had ever done, ended in that courtyard; and

there were two people alive in the middle of a field of brick in the middle of a country in the middle of a century, and the sun was on the wall where the chalk anchor was, and the bread was in the bag, and the work was in front of them, and neither of them said anything else about any of it for the whole of the rest of their lives.